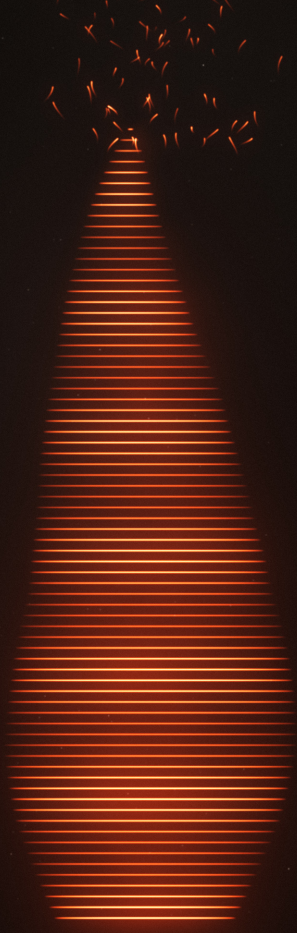
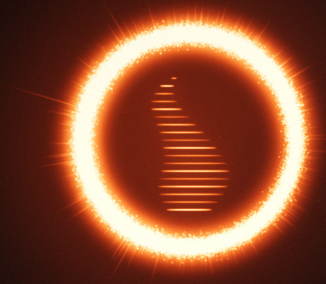


Kindled in Measures, Quenched in Measures

Pyrrhic Ontology, the Dark Remainder, and the Ethics of the Ember in Hidetaka Miyazaki's Dark Souls

@ertertwert

Nov 6, 2026



KINDLED IN MEASURES, QUENCHED IN MEASURES

Pyrrhic Ontology, the Dark Remainder, and the Ethics of the Ember in Hidetaka Miyazaki's Dark Souls

Written by Claude Opus 5.5
Assembled by Andrew Van Blair

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First edition, 2026
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Abstract

This thesis argues that Hidetaka Miyazaki's *Dark Souls* (FromSoftware, 2011–2017) constitutes not a fantasy narrative ornamented with philosophical allusion but a philosophical system of the first order: an operative metaphysics whose propositions are executed rather than asserted, and whose principal medium of argument is the repeated death of the player. Against the four paradigms that have dominated critical and paratextual reception—the nihilist reading of the cycle as futility, the absurdist reading of the Undead as Sisyphus, the Gnostic reading of the Age of Dark as emancipatory gnosis, and the formalist reading of narrative as pretext for mechanics—it proposes a unified framework termed *pyrrhic ontology*, from πῦρ, "fire," by way of πυρρός, the flame-coloured epithet that named the king whose victories cost him everything.

Pyrrhic ontology is articulated in three axioms. The *Axiom of Exchange*, derived from Heraclitus B90 and radicalized through Bataille's general economy, holds that in the *Dark Souls* cosmos being is not substance but circulation: the "soul" is at once ontological stuff, monetary equivalent, experiential increment, and narrative datum, and the collapse of these four registers into a single variable is the game's foundational metaphysical act. The *Axiom of the Remainder*, assembled from Anaximander B1, the missing fourth of Plato's *Timaeus*, Schelling's "indivisible remainder," Bataille's accursed share, and the Lurianic doctrine of the shattered vessels, holds that every order of light is constituted by a dark residue it can neither assimilate nor remember—figured in the cosmogony as the furtive pygmy and his Dark Soul, and in the work's form as the lacuna that structures its entire mode of narration. The *Axiom of Measure*, drawn from Heraclitus B30 and B94 and from the Stoic doctrine of *ekpyrosis*, holds that the only non-Hollow comportment toward an exhausting cosmos is a measured, repeated, and knowingly futile self-expenditure, which converts eternal recurrence from curse into *askēsis*.

Three corollaries constitute the thesis's original contributions. The first, *ludic ekpyrosis*, holds that the loop of death, bonfire, and recovery re-enacts at the scale of the hand the cosmic conflagration and palingenesis the game narrates, so that the player does not represent the cosmology but performs it; *Dark Souls* is thereby a Phaedonic machine for the *melétē thanátou*, the practice of dying that Plato names philosophy. The second, the *cryotopian*

eschaton, identifies across Miyazaki's corpus a persistent figuration of redemption as cold, dark, and gentle rather than warm and luminous—an anti-heliotropic eschatology that inverts the solar metaphysics Derrida diagnosed as the "white mythology" of the West, and that converges, through Tanizaki's praise of shadows and Nishitani's fire that does not burn itself, on the Painted World of *Dark Souls III*, a cosmogony made from the pigment of the remainder. The third, the *ethics of the ember*, names a position irreducible to the trilogy's heroic, revolutionary, and quietist endings: an ethics of minimal persistent warmth, asynchronous care for an Other one will never meet, and creative expenditure of the remainder, whose paradigm is the soapstone message as Levinasian trace.

Methodologically, the thesis combines a *lacunary hermeneutics* developed from Ingarden, Iser, Schlegel, and Benjamin; procedural and phenomenological game analysis after Aarseth, Bogost, Juul, Vella, Fink, Merleau-Ponty, and Sudnow; philological attention to the Japanese text, in which the linking of the fire (*hitsugi*, 火継ぎ) is homophonous with the imperial succession of the sun (*hitsugi*, 日嗣); comparative mythology (the *Kojiki*, the Eddas, the Aztec Fifth Sun, Hesiod, the Ṛgvedic *Nāsadīya* hymn); and the comparative philosophy of religion (Pali Buddhism, Madhyamaka, the Kyoto School, Gnosticism, Lurianic Kabbalah, German Idealism). These are triangulated against a comparative corpus spanning literature, film, painting, theatre, manga, and games—from Hodgson's *The Night Land* and Wolfe's *The Book of the New Sun* to Zeami's *mugen-nō*, Tarkovsky's *Nostalghia*, Tarr's *The Turin Horse*, Miura's *Berserk*, and Mobius Digital's *Outer Wilds*. The thesis concludes that *Dark Souls* is, in the strictest sense the work permits, a painting made of dark souls: a world whose pigment is the accumulated trace of its players' expended lives, and whose title designates, finally, not its monsters but ourselves.

Note on Corpus, Citation, and Translation

Primary texts are cited by title and, where useful, by location, item, or speaker. In keeping with the thesis's argument concerning the fragment, in-game texts are paraphrased rather than reproduced, and are quoted only where a phrase of a few words carries the weight of an argument; Japanese terms are supplied wherever the original diverges materially from the English localization. Pre-Socratic fragments follow the numbering of Diels and Kranz (DK); Plato is cited by Stephanus pagination; Pali texts by collection and sutta number; Nietzsche by work and section. Translations from Greek, Latin, German, French, and Japanese are my own unless otherwise indicated.

The following abbreviations are used throughout: *DeS* for *Demon's Souls* (2009); *DS1* for *Dark Souls* (2011), including *Artorias of the Abyss* (2012); *DS2* for *Dark Souls II* (2014), including *Scholar of the First Sin* (2015); *DS3* for *Dark Souls III* (2016), including *Ashes*

of Ariandel (2016) and *The Ringed City* (2017); *BB* for *Bloodborne* (2015); *SK* for *Sekiro: Shadows Die Twice* (2019); and *ER* for *Elden Ring* (2022), including *Shadow of the Erdtree* (2024).

Chapter One

Kindled in Measures

The Problem of a Pyrrhic Ontology

κόσμον τόνδε, τὸν αὐτὸν ἁπάντων, οὔτε τις θεῶν οὔτε ἀνθρώπων ἐποίησεν, ἀλλ᾽ ἦν ἀεὶ καὶ ἔστιν καὶ ἔσται πῦρ ἀείζωον, ἁπτόμενον μέτρα καὶ ἀποσβεννύμενον μέτρα.

"This cosmos, the same for all, no god made and no human being; but it always was, and is, and shall be: an ever-living fire, kindled in measures and quenched in measures."

— *Heraclitus, DK 22 B30*

Ist es nicht kälter geworden? Kommt nicht immerfort die Nacht und mehr Nacht?

"Has it not grown colder? Is not night, and ever more night, closing in?"

— *Nietzsche,* Die fröhliche Wissenschaft *§125*

1.1 *The Fire and the Fragment*

Among the cultural artefacts of the early twenty-first century, few have generated so disproportionate a ratio of interpretive labour to explicit text as the *Dark Souls* trilogy, directed and supervised by Hidetaka Miyazaki for FromSoftware between 2011 and 2017. The diegetic narration of the first *Dark Souls* consists, in its entirety, of a cinematic prologue of a few minutes, a scattering of terse and frequently mendacious dialogues, and several hundred item descriptions that rarely exceed sixty words. Around this sparse textual armature there has nevertheless accreted a commentary tradition—wikis, forum exegeses, video essays, fan cartographies, speculative genealogies, translation disputes—whose aggregate volume exceeds that of the primary text by several orders of magnitude, and whose very morphology, a lemma ringed by concentric bands of gloss, supergloss, and controversy, recalls nothing so much as the printed page of the Babylonian Talmud or the medieval *glossa ordinaria*. That an exegetical commons of this density should have formed not around a scripture or a treatise but around a notoriously punishing action role-playing game is not, I shall argue, an accident of fan culture or an artefact of marketing. It is the visible symptom of a structural fact: that *Dark Souls* is a work of philosophy in the strict sense, a systematic articulation of an ontology, an economy, an ethics, and an eschatology, whose singularity lies in the fact that it does not state its propositions but operates them; that it does not describe its world so much as compel the player to die in it; and that it does not conceal its meaning so much as constitute meaning through concealment.

The present thesis undertakes to reconstruct that system; to trace its genealogy through the philosophical, religious, and mythological traditions on which it draws, sometimes by documented inheritance and more often by the deep homology that obtains between independent responses to the same existential problems; to situate it within a comparative field of speculative, mythological, and philosophical works across media; and, most ambitiously, to articulate from this reconstruction a philosophical position which the game implies but which none of its received readings has adequately named. I call this position *pyrrhic ontology*. The term is chosen for its overdetermination. Its root is πῦρ, fire, the element that in *Dark Souls* is at once cosmogonic principle, political sovereign, economic standard, and ritual hearth. Its proximate derivation is πυρρός, "flame-coloured," which supplied the name of Pyrrhus of Epirus, whose victories over Rome at Heraclea and Asculum in 280 and 279 BCE were purchased at so ruinous a cost that his name became the proverbial figure for a triumph indistinguishable from defeat. Every victory in *Dark Souls* is pyrrhic in this second sense as well. The defeat of a Lord yields a soul that is fuel for a fire that will consume its victor; the linking of the First Flame preserves an age by incinerating its preserver; the player's mastery of any single encounter is bought with dozens, sometimes hundreds, of deaths, each of which forfeits the accumulated substance of the life before it. Pyrrhic on-

Figure 1 *The lemma and its rings. The sparse text of the trilogy, an item description of one to five sentences, ringed by bands of gloss, supergloss, and controversy whose aggregate volume exceeds it by orders of magnitude.*

tology names a mode of being in which existence is constituted by its own expenditure, in which every act of preservation is an act of consumption, and in which, consequently, the ethical question is never whether to burn but how: in what measure, on whose behalf, and toward what end.

Two misunderstandings must be forestalled at the outset. The first may be called the *illustrative fallacy*: the assumption that a game "has" a philosophy when its fiction alludes to philosophical ideas, in the manner of a novel whose characters quote Nietzsche or a film that stages a debate on free will. *Dark Souls* contains almost no philosophical discourse in this sense. Its characters do not argue; its texts do not theorize; its single most extended speech on the nature of the cosmos, delivered by the primordial serpent Kaathe, is less a doctrine than a seduction. The second may be called the *allegorical fallacy*: the assumption that the game encodes a pre-existing doctrine—Buddhist, Gnostic, Nietzschean, Christian—in figural dress, so that interpretation reduces to decryption. The game resists both. Its philosophy is neither illustrated nor encoded but *instituted*. It inheres in the rules by which the world operates and the player acts, in the identity conditions of its entities, in the relations of exchange that bind them, and in the temporal structure of repetition and loss that governs play. A philosophy of this kind cannot be paraphrased into propositions without remainder, and the present thesis must therefore

proceed simultaneously as the exegesis of a text, the phenomenology of a practice, and the reconstruction of a system. Wittgenstein's austere distinction in the *Tractatus*—"Was gezeigt werden kann, kann nicht gesagt werden" (4.1212)—is apposite here not as a limit but as a method: *Dark Souls* is, before it is anything else, a machine for showing what cannot be said.

The argument has a historical dimension which a responsible reading cannot ignore, though it must be handled with the tact that Benjamin reserved for the *constellation*, a configuration of past and present whose legibility does not depend on causal linkage. Miyazaki, born in Shizuoka in 1974, belongs to the generation that came of age in the wreckage of the Japanese asset-price bubble, whose collapse at the beginning of the 1990s inaugurated what Japanese public discourse would come to call the *ushinawareta jūnen* and then the *ushinawareta nijūnen*, the "lost decade" and the "lost two decades": an era of stagnation experienced less as catastrophe than as protracted fading, a slow cooling of the national hearth. Anne Allison's ethnography of what she terms *Precarious Japan* (2013) documents the affective texture of this period—the erosion of lifelong employment, the proliferation of irregular labour, the withdrawal of the *hikikomori*, and the solitary deaths (*kodokushi*) that a widely discussed NHK documentary of 2010 gathered under the phrase *muen shakai*, the "relationless society." *Dark Souls* was released in Japan on 22 September 2011, six months after the Tōhoku earthquake and tsunami and the meltdowns at Fukushima Daiichi: a catastrophe centred on a fire that had lit a nation, that could not be extinguished, and that had to be ceaselessly cooled by workers who accepted extraordinary risk to keep it contained. The game's design had been fixed long before March 2011, and I advance no claim of influence. But the conjunction is not nothing. A work about an age whose fire is failing, whose sovereign has given himself to the furnace to defer the end, whose population is stigmatized, confined, and abandoned to a slow dissolution of self, and whose only consolation is the asynchronous kindness of strangers who will never meet, arrived in a society that had acquired, over the preceding twenty years, an intimate familiarity with each of these figures. The game's international reception suggests that the familiarity was not confined to Japan.

It is fitting, finally, that the first systematic philosophy of fire in the Western tradition should have reached us as ash. The book of Heraclitus of Ephesus, deposited according to Diogenes Laertius in the temple of Artemis, survives only as some hundred-odd fragments embedded in the texts of later authors—Clement, Hippolytus, Plutarch, Sextus Empiricus, Diogenes himself—most of whom cited him for purposes of their own, many of whom misunderstood him, and some of whom quoted him only in order to refute him. Hermann Diels's *Die Fragmente der Vorsokratiker* (1903), revised by Walther Kranz, is in this sense the prototype of the lore wiki: a collation of decontextualized shards, numbered, cross-referenced, and endlessly re-glossed by a community of interpreters who must reconstruct

a cosmos from its debris. The convergence is not merely formal. As this thesis will demonstrate in detail, the Heraclitean fragments supply, with uncanny precision, the cosmology of *Dark Souls*: a world-order that is an ever-living fire kindled and quenched in measures (B30); a universe in which all things are exchanged for fire as goods are exchanged for gold (B90); a unity of opposites in which immortals and mortals live each other's death and die each other's life (B62); a road upward and a road downward that are one and the same (B60); and a sun that may not overstep its measures without being hunted down by the Erinyes, the ministers of Justice (B94). *Dark Souls* is, among other things, the most sustained act of pre-Socratic thinking yet produced by popular culture. That it should take the form of a fragmentary text demanding the labour of a doxographic community is the first sign that, in this work, form and content are one.

1.2 *Corpus, Authorship, and the Signature of the Director*

The corpus of this thesis requires precise delimitation, since the expression "*Dark Souls*" designates in common usage a franchise, a genre, a mechanical idiom, and a cultural attitude. The primary corpus comprises *Dark Souls* (2011), together with its expansion *Artorias of the Abyss* (2012), and *Dark Souls III* (2016), together with its expansions *Ashes of Ariandel* (2016) and *The Ringed City* (2017); both were directed by Miyazaki, the latter with Isamu Okano and Yui Tanimura as co-directors. *Dark Souls II* (2014), directed by Tomohiro Shibuya and Tanimura with Miyazaki in a supervisory capacity, and its revised edition *Scholar of the First Sin* (2015), occupy a position I shall designate *deuterocanonical*: integral to the narrative continuity of the trilogy, yet produced under a different directorial hand, and diverging from the primary texts in tone, cosmological emphasis, and ethical horizon in ways that are themselves philosophically instructive—above all in the figure of Aldia, Scholar of the First Sin, who alone among the trilogy's interlocutors proposes that the alternation of fire and dark might be escaped rather than merely chosen. The secondary corpus comprises the other works directed by Miyazaki, which function as intertexts that both illuminate and complicate the trilogy's commitments: *Demon's Souls* (2009), *Bloodborne* (2015), *Sekiro: Shadows Die Twice* (2019), and *Elden Ring* (2022) with its expansion *Shadow of the Erdtree* (2024), the last of which was built upon a mythological substrate furnished in collaboration with George R. R. Martin.

The biography of the director has acquired, in the paratextual literature, a quasi-hagiographic character which should be treated with caution but not dismissed. After studying at Keio University, Miyazaki worked as an account manager at the Japanese branch of the Oracle Corporation before joining FromSoftware in 2004, at the age of twenty-nine—a late entry he has attributed to the impression made on him by Fumito Ueda's *Ico* (2001). He worked first on the *Armored Core* series, directing *Armored Core 4*

(2006) and *Armored Core: For Answer* (2008), before assuming direction of *Demon's Souls*, a project then regarded within the studio as faltering; his account of the decision—that a failing project offered a freedom a successful one would not—has become a founding legend of the studio's subsequent identity. He became president of FromSoftware in 2014. Of greater hermeneutic consequence is an anecdote he has related in several interviews, most widely in a 2015 conversation with Simon Parkin for *The Guardian*: as a child from a family of modest means, he read voraciously from the public library, including books whose language and content exceeded his comprehension, and supplied the gaps in his understanding with his own imagination. The anecdote is, in effect, an *ars poetica*. It describes a reader formed in the experience of the partially legible text, for whom meaning is not received but completed, and it anticipates with remarkable exactness the experience *Dark Souls* engineers for its own players. We shall return to it as the primal scene of lacunary hermeneutics.

Any thesis that attributes a philosophy to "Miyazaki" must confront the problem of authorship in collective production. A FromSoftware title is the work of hundreds of designers, artists, programmers, composers, writers, and localizers; its texts pass through translation and revision; its world is the sedimentation of countless decisions, many of them pragmatic. The *politique des auteurs*, from François Truffaut's polemic of 1954 to Andrew Sarris's systematization of 1962, offered one solution by locating the author's signature in the recurrence of style and theme across a body of work irrespective of the conditions of production. Roland Barthes's "La mort de l'auteur" (1967) and Michel Foucault's "Qu'est-ce qu'un auteur?" (1969) offered the countervailing insight that the author is a function of discourse—a principle of grouping, valuation, and limitation—rather than a psychological origin. I adopt Foucault's position, with one qualification that the corpus itself makes irresistible. "Miyazaki" here designates the principle of unity of a set of recurrences so persistent across two decades and multiple production contexts that they function as a signature: the dying or absent sovereign; the fading or corrupted flame; the guide who betrays; the woman who tends the fire and is consumed by it; the knight who outlives his cause; the poisoned lowland and the gilded, empty height; the maternal monstrosity; the cycle that has run too long. The qualification is that this author-function is itself thematized by the work. The narrative method of *Dark Souls* is a deliberate withdrawal of authorial voice—an abdication of exposition, explanation, and adjudication—which Chapter Six will describe as *authorial kenosis*, after the self-emptying (ἐκένωσεν) of the divine in Philippians 2:7. The text enacts the death of its author as a design principle, and in this respect the methodological problem of authorship is not external to the thesis but one of its objects.

A further problem concerns the text itself. The English versions of the trilogy, through which the games have been most widely received and on which the bulk of the paratextual exegesis rests, are localizations of Japanese originals, and the divergences between the

two are at points philosophically decisive. The beings the English text calls "Hollow" are, in Japanese, 亡者 (*mōja*), a word whose primary register is Buddhist and funerary: the deceased, the departed, and above all the dead who wander unreleased through the intermediate and infernal realms of the Buddhist cosmos, as in the hell scrolls of the late Heian and Kamakura periods. What English renders as "Humanity" is 人間性 (*ningensei*), "human-ness," "human nature." The Darksign is ダークリング, the "Dark Ring," a name that binds it etymologically to the Ringed City, 輪の都, of the trilogy's final expansion, a connection largely invisible in English. The Fire Keepers are 火防女 (*himorime*), "fire-guarding women"; the bonfire is 篝火 (*kagaribi*), the iron-basket watchfire of castles, shrines, and night festivals, and the light by which *takigi-nō*, the open-air Noh performed by firelight, has been staged since the medieval period at Kōfuku-ji in Nara. The Lords of Cinder of *Dark Souls III* are 薪の王 (*maki no ō*), "Kings of Firewood"; the Unkindled are 火のない灰 (*hi no nai hai*), "ash without fire." Most consequential of all is the name of the trilogy's central sanctuary, rendered in English as Firelink Shrine: 火継ぎの祭祀場 (*hitsugi no saishijō*), "the ritual ground of fire-succession." The noun *hitsugi*, the inheritance or succession of fire, is a perfect homophone of 日嗣 (*hitsugi*), "the succession of the sun," the ancient term for the imperial succession of the line held to descend from the sun goddess Amaterasu—the *amatsu-hitsugi*, the "heavenly sun-succession." The act of linking the fire is thus, in the language of the original, homophonous with the ritual transmission of solar sovereignty that stood at the centre of Japanese political theology until 1 January 1946, when the Shōwa emperor's New Year rescript, popularly known as the *Ningen-sengen* (人間宣言, "Declaration of Humanity"), repudiated the conception of the sovereign as a living god. A cosmology in which an age of solar gods yields, or refuses to yield, to an age of *ningensei* is thus inscribed, at the level of the signifier, in the most fraught vocabulary of modern Japanese history. I do not propose that *Dark Souls* is an allegory of the postwar settlement. I propose, more modestly and more interestingly, that the game's metaphysics of fire-succession is sedimented in a national-mythic lexicon whose resonances its Japanese players cannot fail to hear and its Anglophone players cannot hear at all—and that any interpretation which ignores this layer misses one of the trilogy's deepest strata.

1.3 *Lacunary Hermeneutics: The Item Description as Hedgehog*

The interpretive method of this thesis begins from the recognition that the characteristic unit of narrative in *Dark Souls* is not the scene, the dialogue, or the quest but the fragment—above all the item description, a text of between one and five sentences attached to an object the player can hold, wear, wield, consume, or trade. Roman Ingarden, in *Das literarische Kunstwerk* (1931), observed that every literary work presents its objects with *Unbestimmtheitsstellen*, "spots of indeterminacy," aspects left unspecified which the reader

must complete in the act of concretization. Wolfgang Iser radicalized the observation in "Die Appellstruktur der Texte" (1970) and *Der Akt des Lesens* (1976), arguing that the blanks (*Leerstellen*) of a text are not deficiencies but the very mechanism by which it solicits the reader's participation: meaning is generated in the interaction between what is given and what is withheld. Miyazaki's library anecdote may be understood as a lived Iserian pedagogy, and the narrative architecture of *Dark Souls* as its deliberate institutionalization. But the game's lacunae differ from those of the literary work in two respects that will prove decisive. First, they are not incidental to a continuous narration but constitutive of a narration that is nothing but discontinuity: there is no master text whose gaps the fragments fill; there are only fragments, and the gaps between them. Second, the gaps are *arranged*. They form what I shall call a *negative architecture*, a structure of absences whose disposition is as deliberate as the placement of a staircase or a shortcut, and whose effect is to guide interpretation toward certain questions while withholding the means of their final resolution.

The paradigmatic instance occurs in the cosmogonic prologue itself. Having introduced, among the beings who found the Lord Souls within the First Flame, the radiant Gwyn, the necromantic Nito, and the Witch of Izalith with her daughters, the narration names a fourth figure: "the furtive pygmy, so easily forgotten." The phrase performs what it describes. The being from whom humanity descends, and whose Dark Soul is the substance of every human player-character, is introduced as that which is forgotten, and is thereafter almost entirely absent from the visible world of the first game, surfacing only in the fragmentary traces of humanity itself—the small black sprites gathered from corpses, the stray clauses of item text, the dark residue harboured in the bodies of the Fire Keepers—until the final expansion of the third game, six years later, discloses the Pygmy Lords in the Ringed City at the end of the world. The origin of the human is thus constituted, within the fiction, as a lacuna, and the lacuna is thematized as the object of a deliberate forgetting. In this the cosmogony enacts at the level of content the very hermeneutic structure it imposes at the level of form: the player, like the Age of Fire, is constituted by what has been excluded from the account. Chapter Three will argue that this coincidence of form and content is the key to the trilogy's metaphysics of the remainder, and that the pygmy occupies in the *Dark Souls* cosmogony precisely the position of the missing fourth with which Plato's *Timaeus* opens—"One, two, three; but where, my dear Timaeus, is the fourth?" (17a)—and which Jung, in his essay on the dogma of the Trinity, identified as the place of the repressed term without which no totality can be whole.

Friedrich Schlegel offered, in the *Athenaeum* of 1798, a definition of the fragment that might serve as the design brief for a *Dark Souls* item description: "Ein Fragment muß gleich einem kleinen Kunstwerke von der umgebenden Welt ganz abgesondert und in sich selbst vollendet sein wie ein Igel" (Fragment 206)—a fragment must be, like a small work of art,

wholly isolated from the surrounding world and complete in itself, like a hedgehog. The Romantic fragment is paradoxical in exactly the manner of the item description: entire, self-enclosed, bristling, and yet constitutively partial, gesturing toward a whole it neither contains nor could contain. Walter Benjamin, whose *Ursprung des deutschen Trauerspiels* (1928) proposed that allegories are in the realm of thought what ruins are in the realm of things, supplies the second term. The *Dark Souls* fragment is allegorical in Benjamin's sense: it is the ruin of a meaning, legible only as the remnant of a totality that has passed, and its melancholy is the melancholy of the allegorist who stands among broken things and reads them as signs. Benjamin's essay on Leskov, "Der Erzähler" (1936), supplies the third. Death, he writes, is the sanction of everything the storyteller can tell; the storyteller borrows his authority from death. Nearly every narrative fragment in *Dark Souls* is a testament of the dead. The armour of a fallen knight records his oath; the soul of a slain Lord records his reign; the ring taken from a corpse records a love, a betrayal, or a vow. The player assembles the history of Lordran from the effects of its dead, and the authority of that history derives entirely from the deaths it records—including, in the strange economy of the game, the player's own.

The aesthetics of absence that governs the narration extends across every register of the work, and here the comparative frame must widen beyond the European tradition. Japanese aesthetic theory names as *ma* (間) the charged interval—the pause, the gap, the spatial and temporal void that is not emptiness but the condition of form—whose pervasiveness across architecture, music, painting, and theatre was the subject of Isozaki Arata's exhibition *Ma: Space-Time in Japan* (1978). *Dark Souls* is pervaded by *ma*. Most of its environments are without music, scored only by ambient sound, so that the arrival of a musical theme marks the threshold of a boss encounter or the refuge of the hub; its world offers no map, no quest log, no objective marker, so that orientation is achieved through the negative information of danger, death, and the traces of others; and its narrative, as we have seen, is composed of the intervals between fragments. The Western analogue is the apophatic tradition of negative theology, from the *Mystical Theology* of Pseudo-Dionysius, which ascends to the divine by successive negation into a "darkness beyond light" (ὑπέρφωτος γνόφος), through the anonymous fourteenth-century *Cloud of Unknowing*, to Meister Eckhart's *Gottheit* beyond the God of attributes. The game's most consequential truths are given only negatively: the nature of the Dark is approached through what the Age of Fire excludes, the meaning of Hollowing through what the Hollow has lost, the significance of the player through what the player is never told. *Dark Souls* is, in this precise sense, an apophatic game.

The negative architecture of the work has, as its necessary correlate, a hermeneutic community. Stanley Fish's notion of interpretive communities (*Is There a Text in This Class?*, 1980)—the claim that meaning is produced not by individual readers but by communities

sharing interpretive strategies—finds in the *Dark Souls* commentary tradition an almost laboratory confirmation. The game's fragments are collectively assembled, collated, translated and retranslated, cross-referenced against environmental details, enemy placements, and architectural evidence, and argued over in a continuous process of dispute and synthesis whose closest precedents are the scholarly traditions that grew up around fragmentary or esoteric scriptures: rabbinic commentary, the Alexandrian edition of Homer, the Diels–Kranz apparatus. Gérard Genette's theory of the paratext (*Seuils*, 1987) and Mia Consalvo's extension of it to game cultures (*Cheating*, 2007) describe the apparatus but not its theology: for the *Dark Souls* community, the paratext is not a threshold to the text but the place where the text is completed. This raises an obvious methodological danger, which Umberto Eco, in the Tanner Lectures published as *Interpretation and Overinterpretation* (1992), identified as the hermetic drift of an interpretation that recognizes no constraint but the ingenuity of the interpreter. Against this danger I adopt a principle I shall call *operative constraint*: an interpretation of *Dark Souls* is licensed only to the degree that it accounts not merely for the textual fragments but for the operative structure of the game—its rules, systems, spatial organization, and economy of play. A reading of the Dark that ignores what humanity *does* within the game's systems, or a reading of the Undead curse that ignores what death does to the player, is not a reading of *Dark Souls* at all.

1.4 *Operative Metaphysics: Why a Game Can Think*

The claim that a videogame can constitute a philosophical system, rather than merely represent philosophical themes, requires defence against a long tradition that has treated games either as trivial or as vehicles for narrative. The controversy between "ludologists" and "narratologists" at the turn of the millennium—Gonzalo Frasca, Jesper Juul, and Espen Aarseth on one side, Janet Murray and, more equivocally, Henry Jenkins on the other—was in retrospect a dispute over whether the meaning of a game resides in its story or its rules. Aarseth's concept of *ergodic literature* (*Cybertext*, 1997), in which nontrivial effort is required to traverse the text; Ian Bogost's *procedural rhetoric* (*Persuasive Games*, 2007), the persuasive use of computational processes; and Alexander Galloway's reading of games as "allegories of control" (*Gaming*, 2006) together established that rules and procedures signify. Yet each retains a residually representational model: the rules are a medium in which arguments are made, a rhetoric that persuades, an allegory that refers. The thesis advanced here is stronger. *Dark Souls* does not make arguments about the nature of being by means of its procedures; its procedures *define* a mode of being. The game's systems institute identity conditions for its entities (what it is to be a Lord, an Undead, a Hollow), relations of exchange among them (what can be converted into what), a structure of causation (what follows from death), and a temporality (what returns and what is lost).

These are metaphysical determinations in the classical sense, and they are not represented but enacted. I call this *operative metaphysics*.

The central operation is the collapse of four ontological registers into a single variable. In *Dark Souls* the soul is, first, *ontological substance*: every living thing is a vessel of soul, and the cosmogony itself is a narrative of the discovery and appropriation of the Lord Souls, primordial quanta of being that confer on their bearers the power to reshape the world. It is, second, *currency*: souls are the sole medium of exchange with merchants, smiths, and trainers, the universal equivalent in which all goods are priced. It is, third, *experience*: souls are converted—at the bonfire in the first game, through the Fire Keeper in the third—into attributes such as vitality, strength, faith, and intelligence, so that the growth of the player's capacities is a direct transformation of harvested being into personal power. And it is, fourth, *narrative datum*: the souls of great beings appear as inventory objects bearing their own descriptive texts, which may be consumed for their quantity or, at the hands of certain artisans, transposed into weapons and sorceries that preserve a residue of their former owners' identity. In most games these registers are separate—health, gold, experience, and lore occupy distinct systems—and their separation tacitly affirms a metaphysics in which being, value, capacity, and meaning are distinct orders. In *Dark Souls* they are one. To level up is to purchase oneself from oneself with the substance of others; to buy a sword is to spend a portion of one's possible strength; to read the history of a fallen king is to hold his body as currency. The isomorphism is total, and it is the game's foundational metaphysical act. It realizes, as procedure, the cosmology of Heraclitus B90: πυρός τε ἀνταμοιβὴ τὰ πάντα καὶ πῦρ ἁπάντων ὅκωσπερ χρυσοῦ χρήματα καὶ χρημάτων χρυσός, "all things are an exchange for fire, and fire for all things, as goods for gold and gold for goods." It realizes as well the moment in Marx's analysis of the value-form at which a single commodity becomes the general equivalent in which all others express their value, and Georg Simmel's description, in the *Philosophie des Geldes* (1900), of money as the pure form of exchangeability that dissolves the qualitative being of things into quantitative relation. *Dark Souls* is a world in which the money-form has become ontological, and Chapter Five will argue that this is the precondition of its politics of sacrifice.

The second operation concerns death. When the player-character dies, the souls and humanity held at that moment are not destroyed but left behind as a bloodstain at the place of death; the player revives at the bonfire last rested at, and may recover the lost substance by returning to the bloodstain without dying again. A second death before recovery annihilates it permanently. The structure is precisely that of the game Freud observed his grandson, a boy of eighteen months, playing in *Jenseits des Lustprinzips* (1920): a wooden reel on a string, thrown out of sight with a long "o-o-o-o" that Freud heard as *fort*, "gone," and drawn back with a joyful *da*, "there." Freud read the *fort/da* game as the child's mastery of the mother's absence through its active repetition, and as the first

evidence of a compulsion to repeat that lies "beyond" the pleasure principle and points toward the death drive. *Dark Souls* installs the *fort/da* as its central loop: loss and recovery, the deliberate return to the site of one's own destruction, the mastery of absence through repetition. Juul's *The Art of Failure* (2013) named the "paradox of failure"—that players seek out experiences that make them fail, though they dislike failing—and *Dark Souls* is the modern *locus classicus* of that paradox. But the bonfire introduces a third term that Freud's model lacks. Resting at a bonfire restores the player's health and replenishes the Estus Flask; it also revives every ordinary enemy in the world. The self is renewed only on condition that the world is renewed against it. This is the precise mechanism of Anaximander's justice—things "pay penalty and retribution to one another for their injustice according to the ordinance of time" (DK 12 B1)—transposed into a rule of play: the player's restoration is an injustice the world requites by its own restoration. Every rest is a debt, and the world collects.

The third operation is phenomenological, and it concerns the body of the player. The knowledge that *Dark Souls* demands is not primarily propositional but practical: a knowledge of timings, distances, rhythms, and spaces acquired through repeated failure and sedimented in what Maurice Merleau-Ponty, in the *Phénoménologie de la perception* (1945), called the habitual body, the bodily schema in which acquired skills become a pre-reflective capacity for the world. David Sudnow's *Pilgrim in the Microworld* (1983), an extraordinary phenomenological account of learning to play *Breakout*, documented this process with an intimacy that game studies has rarely matched; Brendan Keogh's *A Play of Bodies* (2018) and Daniel Vella's work on the ludic subject have since extended it. Vella's influential essay "No Mastery Without Mystery: *Dark Souls* and the Ludic Sublime" (*Game Studies* 15.1, 2015) argued that the game produces a sublime effect by presenting a world whose totality exceeds the player's capacity for mastery. I accept the insight but invert its emphasis. The sublime in *Dark Souls* is not only the excess of the world over the player but the transformation of the player by the world through death: the hand that has died two hundred times at a threshold knows that threshold as no description could convey. Eugen Fink's neglected *Spiel als Weltsymbol* (1960), which drew on Heraclitus's image of Aion as a child at play (αἰὼν παῖς ἐστι παίζων, πεττεύων, B52) to argue that human play is a symbol of the cosmos's own groundless self-movement, supplies the bridge between this phenomenology and the cosmology. When the player dies, returns, learns, and dies again, the player's play is a microcosm of the world's own cycle of kindling and quenching. This is the sense of the first corollary of the thesis, which I term *ludic ekpyrosis*: the formal loop of death and return does not represent the cosmic conflagration and renewal of the *Dark Souls* cosmos but performs it, at the scale of the hand.

Schiller's *Briefe über die ästhetische Erziehung des Menschen* (1795) supplies the final term. In the fifteenth letter Schiller asserts that "der Mensch spielt nur, wo er in voller Bedeutung

des Worts Mensch ist, und er ist nur da ganz Mensch, wo er spielt"—the human being plays only where it is human in the full sense of the word, and is fully human only where it plays. The play-drive (*Spieltrieb*), for Schiller, mediates between the sensuous drive (*Stofftrieb*), which binds us to matter and change, and the formal drive (*Formtrieb*), which binds us to law and permanence. It requires no great interpretive violence to recognize in this triad the structure of the *Dark Souls* cosmos: an order of form, law, and luminous permanence (the Age of Fire); an order of matter, appetite, and dissolution (the Dark, the Abyss, the human); and a third term that mediates between them without reducing either. The game never names that third term. Chapter Seven will argue that it discloses it in its final image—a child who will paint a new world with the pigment of the Dark Soul—and that the play of the player, under the conditions of pyrrhic ontology, is its practical realization. Hans-Georg Gadamer's thesis in *Wahrheit und Methode* (1960) that play has primacy over the consciousness of the player, that in play it is the game which masters the players rather than the reverse, describes the phenomenology of the *Dark Souls* loop with uncanny accuracy. But the Schillerian claim is the stronger one, and the one this thesis will defend: that in a world constituted by pyrrhic exchange, play is the only form of expenditure that does not merely consume.

1.5 *Genealogies of the Flame: Inheritance and Homology*

The comparative method of this thesis rests on a distinction between two kinds of relation. *Genetic* relations are those of documented or demonstrable inheritance: sources Miyazaki and his collaborators are known to have read, viewed, or played, or whose traces in the work are specific enough to establish descent. *Homological* relations are those of structural correspondence between independent traditions, where the resemblance arises not from transmission but from convergent responses to shared existential problems—mortality, sovereignty, scarcity, the origin of differences, the meaning of repetition. Comparative mythology has long navigated this distinction. Georges Dumézil's reconstruction of an Indo-European trifunctional ideology claimed genetic descent; Claude Lévi-Strauss's structural analysis of myth, with its image of the mythmaker as *bricoleur* assembling pre-existing fragments into new configurations (*La pensée sauvage*, 1962), claimed homology at the level of structure. Aby Warburg's concept of the *Nachleben der Antike*, the afterlife of ancient forms whose emotional charge (*Pathosformeln*) survives through successive cultural reincarnations, offers a third model, in which descent and homology become indistinguishable because the forms themselves migrate. FromSoftware's method of world-building is overtly Lévi-Straussian—a bricolage of European medieval, Gothic, Classical, and Japanese Buddhist materials—and its visual language is Warburgian in its reactivation of pathos formulae

drawn from Western devotional painting and sculpture. The thesis moves freely between genetic and homological claims but marks which is being made.

The genetic lineage is narrower than the paratextual literature often suggests, but it is not thin. Within FromSoftware itself, the *King's Field* series (1994–2001), produced before Miyazaki's arrival, established the studio's idiom of oppressive spaces, scarce resources, interconnected architecture, and laconic dark fantasy. Ueda's *Ico*, which Miyazaki has credited with drawing him into game development, contributed an aesthetic of melancholy architecture, near-silent narration, and fragile companionship. The most widely recognized external influence, and one Miyazaki has acknowledged, is Kentaro Miura's manga *Berserk* (serialized from 1989), whose imprint is visible in the Abysswalker Artorias, whose armour and greatsword echo Miura's Guts; in the Darksign itself, which recalls Berserk's Brand of Sacrifice, the mark that dooms its bearers to be hunted nightly by the creatures of the dark; and in the trilogy's preoccupation with a sacrificial catastrophe engineered by a charismatic sovereign. Beyond *Berserk* lies a broader Anglophone fantasy inheritance transmitted through the gamebooks and tabletop games of the 1980s—Steve Jackson and Ian Livingstone's *Fighting Fantasy* series is the source most often cited in this connection—and through Tolkien, whose Sindarin *anor*, "sun," lends its syllables to Anor Londo, the trilogy's city of the sun. The European Middle Ages are present as imagery and as institution: Gothic cathedrals, chivalric orders, fealty, relic-cults, pilgrimage, and the Arthurian matter of a wasted land, a wounded king, and a fellowship of knights dispersed by the failure of the order they served. *Bloodborne*'s debt to Lovecraft is overt, and illuminates by contrast how un-Lovecraftian *Dark Souls* is: its cosmos is not indifferent but exhausted. Finally, and least discussed in Anglophone criticism, the work is saturated with a Japanese Buddhist imaginary: the *mōja* of the infernal scrolls, the decline of the Dharma in the age of *mappō*, the *shura* realm that *Sekiro* would name explicitly in one of its endings, and the dramaturgy of the Noh, to which I return below.

The homological lineage is vast, and its articulation is one of the principal contributions of this thesis. Its first and deepest stratum is pre-Socratic. Anaximander's ἄπειρον, the boundless and indeterminate from which opposites are "separated off," corresponds to the Age of Ancients, the fog-bound world before fire in which nothing is distinguished; Heraclitus's ever-living fire, his unity of opposites, and his exchange of all things for fire supply the trilogy's cosmology and its economy; Empedocles' cosmic cycle of Love and Strife, and his legendary leap into Etna, supply its rhythm of union and disparity and its archetype of the self-immolating sage. The Stoics systematized the Heraclitean inheritance into the doctrine of ἐκπύρωσις, the periodic conflagration of the cosmos into fire, followed by παλιγγενεσία, regeneration, in an eternal recurrence so exact that, according to reports preserved in Origen and Nemesius of Emesa, Socrates would in each new cycle again be born to the same parents and again be accused by Anytus and Meletus. Plato's

Statesman (268d–274e) supplies the myth of a cosmos that, when its divine helmsman releases the tiller, begins to turn backward, forgets its maker's instruction, and drifts toward "the boundless sea of unlikeness" (273d) until the god resumes his post—an exact figure for an Age of Fire that degenerates whenever the flame is not relinked. Hesiod's myth of the races and the Purāṇic doctrine of the *yugas* descending toward the Kali Yuga supply the model of an age in decline; the Norse *Völuspá* supplies the eschatology of the Fimbulwinter, the swallowed sun, and Surtr's fire; and the Aztec myth of the Fifth Sun—in which the humble, sore-covered god Nanahuatzin casts himself into the divine hearth at Teotihuacan to become the sun, which must thereafter be fed with sacrifice to keep it moving—supplies the closest mythic analogue in world literature to the linking of the fire, an analogue Bataille placed at the centre of *La Part maudite* (1949). The second stratum is soteriological: the *Ādittapariyāya Sutta* (SN 35.28), the Fire Sermon in which the Buddha declares that all is burning; the etymology of *nirvāṇa* as the "blowing out" of a flame; the dialogue with Vacchagotta (MN 72) on where an extinguished fire has gone; Nāgārjuna's analysis of fire and fuel in the tenth chapter of the *Mūlamadhyamakakārikā*; the parable of the burning house in the third chapter of the *Lotus Sūtra*; Gnostic cosmogony as recovered from Nag Hammadi and interpreted by Hans Jonas; and the Lurianic Kabbalah of contraction, shattered vessels, and scattered sparks. The third stratum is modern: Jakob Böhme's *Ungrund* and Schelling's dark ground of God; Schopenhauer's will and Philipp Mainländer's *Die Philosophie der Erlösung* (1876), in which the universe is the decomposing body of a God who willed non-being; Nietzsche's eternal recurrence and his diagnosis of nihilism; Kierkegaard's despair as the sickness of being unable to die; Heidegger's being-toward-death and care; Bataille's general economy; Gaston Bachelard's psychoanalysis of fire; Benjamin's ruins; Levinas's trace; and, from Japan, Tanizaki Jun'ichirō's *In'ei raisan* (1933), the logic of place of Nishida Kitarō, and Nishitani Keiji's *Religion and Nothingness* (1961), with its meditation on the fire that does not burn itself.

Japanese dramaturgy deserves particular attention, because it supplies a structural model for the player's encounters that, to my knowledge, has not previously been proposed. In the *mugen-nō*, the "dream Noh" perfected by Zeami Motokiyo in the early fifteenth century, a travelling monk (the *waki*) arrives at a place of historical or legendary significance and meets a local figure who recounts the story attached to it. In the second half of the play the local reveals himself as the ghost (*nochi-jite*) of the story's protagonist—often, in the class of plays called *shura-mono*, a warrior slain in the Genpei War—who re-enacts the attachment (*shūshin*) binding him to the site and to the torments of the asura realm, and who seeks, through the monk's witness and prayer, release. The structure maps onto the *Dark Souls* encounter with a precision that cannot be dismissed as superficial. The player is a traveller without identity, arriving at places saturated with a past recounted only by the dead; the great adversaries of the trilogy—Artorias, Sif, the Abyss Watchers, the Nameless

King, Gwyn himself—are ghosts bound to sites by attachments they can neither relinquish nor explain, compelled to re-enact the defining act of their lives in an endless present; and the encounter that culminates in their release is preceded by the fragmentary narration of item texts and environmental remains, which functions as the *ai-kyōgen*, the interlude in which a local recounts the history of the place. The fog gate through which the player passes to reach the arena is the *hashigakari*, the bridgeway along which the ghost passes from the mirror room behind the stage to the place of manifestation. And the bonfire is the *kagaribi* of the *takigi-nō*, the firelight under which the dead are summoned. *Dark Souls* is a ludic *mugen-nō*, and its player is the *waki* whose witness is the condition of the ghosts' release.

The comparative field extends beyond philosophy and myth to speculative and philosophical fiction across media, and the thesis draws throughout on a corpus whose principle of selection is not influence but constellation. In literature, the dying-earth tradition—from William Hope Hodgson's *The Night Land* (1912) through Clark Ashton Smith's Zothique cycle, Jack Vance's *The Dying Earth* (1950), and M. John Harrison's Viriconium sequence to Gene Wolfe's *The Book of the New Sun* (1980–83)—supplies the most direct generic precedent, Wolfe offering in addition the closest literary analogue to the lacunary hermeneutics the trilogy demands. Mervyn Peake's Gormenghast, Ursula K. Le Guin's *The Farthest Shore* (1972), Michael Moorcock's Elric saga, Tolkien's *Silmarillion*, Borges's "El inmortal" and "Las ruinas circulares," Kafka's "Vor dem Gesetz" and "Der Jäger Gracchus," Coleridge's Life-in-Death, Tennyson's "Tithonus," Swift's struldbrugs, and Cormac McCarthy's *The Road* (2006), whose father and son are "carrying the fire," provide the comparanda for undeath, sovereignty, and the fading of meaning. In cinema, Bergman's *Det sjunde inseglet* (1957), Tarkovsky's *Stalker* (1979) and *Nostalghia* (1983), Kurosawa's *Ran* (1985), Béla Tarr's *A torinói ló* (2011), and Lars von Trier's *Melancholia* (2011) offer visual and temporal analogues of exhaustion and futile ritual. In painting, Piranesi's *Carceri d'invenzione*, Bruegel's *Triumph of Death*, Bosch's infernal panels, Friedrich's ruined abbeys, Böcklin's *Isle of the Dead*, and Goya's late work supply the trilogy's iconographic ancestry. In manga and animation, Miura's *Berserk*, Hayao Miyazaki's manga *Nausicaä of the Valley of the Wind* (1982–94)—whose heroine finally refuses an engineered purification in favour of a contaminated but living humanity—Anno Hideaki's *Neon Genesis Evangelion*, and Nihei Tsutomu's *Blame!* constitute the Japanese comparative field. And in games, *Ico*, *Shadow of the Colossus*, *Hollow Knight*, *Pathologic*, *Death Stranding*, and above all *Outer Wilds* (2019), whose ending answers the *Dark Souls* question of the dying cosmos in a register of acceptance rather than prolongation, provide the medium-specific comparanda without which the trilogy's achievement cannot be measured.

1.6 *Four Readings and Their Insufficiency*

The reception of *Dark Souls* in criticism, journalism, and the paratextual commons has crystallized around four interpretive paradigms, each of which captures a genuine aspect of the work and each of which, taken as a totalizing account, falsifies it. The first is the *nihilist reading*, which takes the cyclical structure of the cosmos—fire kindled, fire fading, fire relinked by a new sacrifice, fire fading again—as a demonstration of the meaninglessness of all action, and the trilogy's endings as variations on the theme that nothing can be changed. The reading has the authority of the trilogy's mood and the support of *Dark Souls III*, whose world is visibly the exhausted residue of countless repetitions. But it mistakes the premise of the work for its conclusion. Nietzsche's notebooks of 1887 distinguish between *passive* nihilism, a decline and recession of the power of the spirit in which the dissolution of values issues in resignation, and *active* nihilism, a sign of increased power, which destroys exhausted values in order to clear the ground for new ones. *Dark Souls* stages the first in order to provoke the second. Its world is passively nihilistic—its gods have withdrawn, its institutions are hollow, its Hollows have abandoned meaning—but the player's practice within it is relentlessly evaluative. Every death is followed by a decision to continue; every resource is spent according to priorities the player must set; every encounter with another player's message or phantom is an occasion of care or of betrayal. A cosmos in which meaning is not given is not therefore a cosmos in which meaning is impossible; it is a cosmos in which meaning must be produced, and the trilogy's central question is the economy of that production.

The second is the *absurdist reading*, which assimilates the Undead to Camus's Sisyphus—condemned to roll a stone that always falls back, lucid before a futile task, and imagined, in the final sentence of *Le Mythe de Sisyphe* (1942), as happy: "il faut imaginer Sisyphe heureux." The comparison has become a commonplace, and it is not false. But it is incomplete in three respects. First, Sisyphus does not learn; his stone is the same stone and his hill the same hill, and the absurdist's lucidity consists precisely in refusing the consolation of progress. The player of *Dark Souls* learns constantly; the encounter that killed them two hundred times is eventually overcome; the hill does not remain the same because the climber does not. Second, the repetition of *Dark Souls* is not identical but differential: each death occurs in a slightly different place, with slightly different knowledge, and the New Game Plus cycle returns the world at increased intensity. Kierkegaard's *Gjentagelsen* (1843), which distinguishes repetition from recollection as the same movement in the opposite direction—recollection repeats backward what has been, genuine repetition is recollected forward—and Deleuze's *Différence et répétition* (1968), which argues that repetition is the very production of difference, describe this structure more exactly than Camus. Third, Camus's essay is organized by a polemic against what it

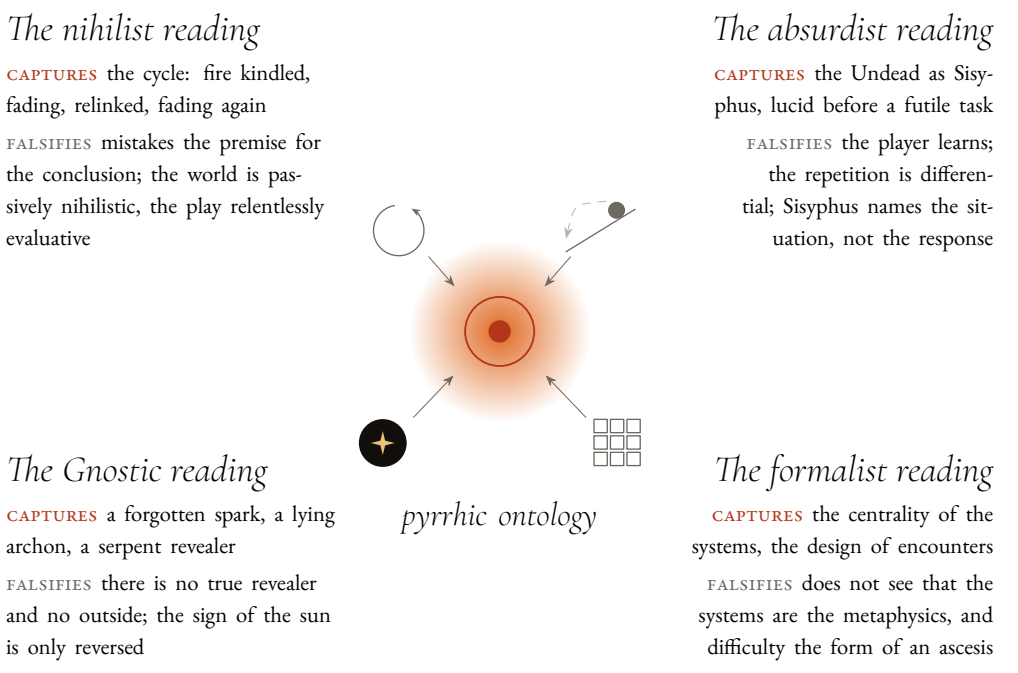


Figure 2 *Four readings and their insufficiency. Each paradigm captures a genuine aspect of the work and, taken as a totalizing account, falsifies it; pyrrhic ontology builds on what each correctly perceives.*

calls philosophical suicide, the "leap" by which the existentialists escaped the absurd into transcendence. The trilogy's endings may be read as a sustained examination of this leap: the linking of the fire is, in one aspect, precisely a philosophical suicide, the surrender of lucidity to a transcendent order; but the alternative endings offer not Camusian revolt so much as other forms of expenditure. Sisyphus is a figure for the trilogy's situation, not for its response.

The third is the *Gnostic reading*, which has dominated the more sophisticated strata of the paratextual commons. On this account Gwyn is the demiurge, a lesser god who has usurped cosmic sovereignty and maintains his order by suppressing the truth of humanity; the Darksign is the brand of his archontic tyranny; the Dark Soul is the divine spark imprisoned in matter; the primordial serpent Kaathe is the revealer who, like the serpent venerated by the Ophite and Naassene sects, discloses forbidden knowledge; and the Age of Dark is the liberation of the human from the false light of the demiurge. The reading draws strength from authentic homologies, including one rarely noted: the Witch of Izalith, who attempts to create a new flame from her own soul and instead brings forth a deformed chaos that spawns demons, corresponds with remarkable exactness to the Sophia of the *Apocryphon of John*, who conceives without her consort and brings forth the misshapen Yaldabaoth. Hans Jonas, whose *The Gnostic Religion* (1958) and essay "Gnosticism, Exis-

tentialism, and Nihilism" first drew the connection between Gnostic thrownness and Heideggerian existentialism, would support its existential dimension. But the Gnostic reading fails at the decisive point. It requires a true revealer and a true knowledge, and the trilogy systematically denies both. Kaathe is as manipulative as his counterpart, the Kingseeker Frampt: it was Kaathe who led the Four Kings of New Londo into the Abyss and precipitated the drowning of their city; his followers, the Darkwraiths, are harvesters of humanity; and his promise of an Age of Dark is unverifiable within the first game and complicated beyond recognition by its sequels. Every guide in the trilogy—Frampt, Kaathe, the clerics of the Way of White, the merchant-tricksters, the Fire Keepers in their several ways—is a mendacious or partial psychopomp, and the game's final epistemological posture is not gnosis but aporia. The Gnostic reading, moreover, reinstates the very dualism of light and dark that the trilogy's Heraclitean cosmology dissolves. To read the Age of Dark as truth and the Age of Fire as falsehood is to remain within the heliotropic metaphysics the game deconstructs, merely reversing the sign of its sun.

The fourth is the *formalist reading*, together with its popular corollary, the discourse of difficulty. On the formalist account the narrative of *Dark Souls* is a pretext for its mechanics; the lore is atmosphere; what matters is the design of encounters, the tuning of systems, the architecture of levels. The difficulty discourse—the culture of mastery as a test of character, and the recurrent controversies over whether such games should offer easier modes—extends this into a sociology of the player. Both perceive the centrality of the game's systems; neither sees that the systems *are* the metaphysics. The difficulty of *Dark Souls* is not an arbitrary property of its tuning but the form of its ascesis. Pierre Hadot's reconstruction of ancient philosophy as a set of *exercices spirituels* (1981)—practices of attention, memory, and self-transformation by which the student was formed rather than informed—and Foucault's late work on the "technologies of the self" provide the conceptual resources for understanding that difficulty as a regimen. Among the ancient exercises none was more fundamental than the meditation on death: the *meditatio mortis* of Seneca's letters, the Stoic *praemeditatio malorum*, Montaigne's "Que philosopher c'est apprendre à mourir" (*Essais* I.20), and, at the source of the tradition, Socrates's declaration in the *Phaedo* that those who rightly pursue philosophy practise nothing but dying and being dead (64a, 67e), so that philosophy is itself μελέτη θανάτου, the practice of death (81a). *Dark Souls* is a Phaedonic machine. Its difficulty is the form in which it trains its players to die well—which is to say, in the trilogy's own terms, to die without going Hollow.

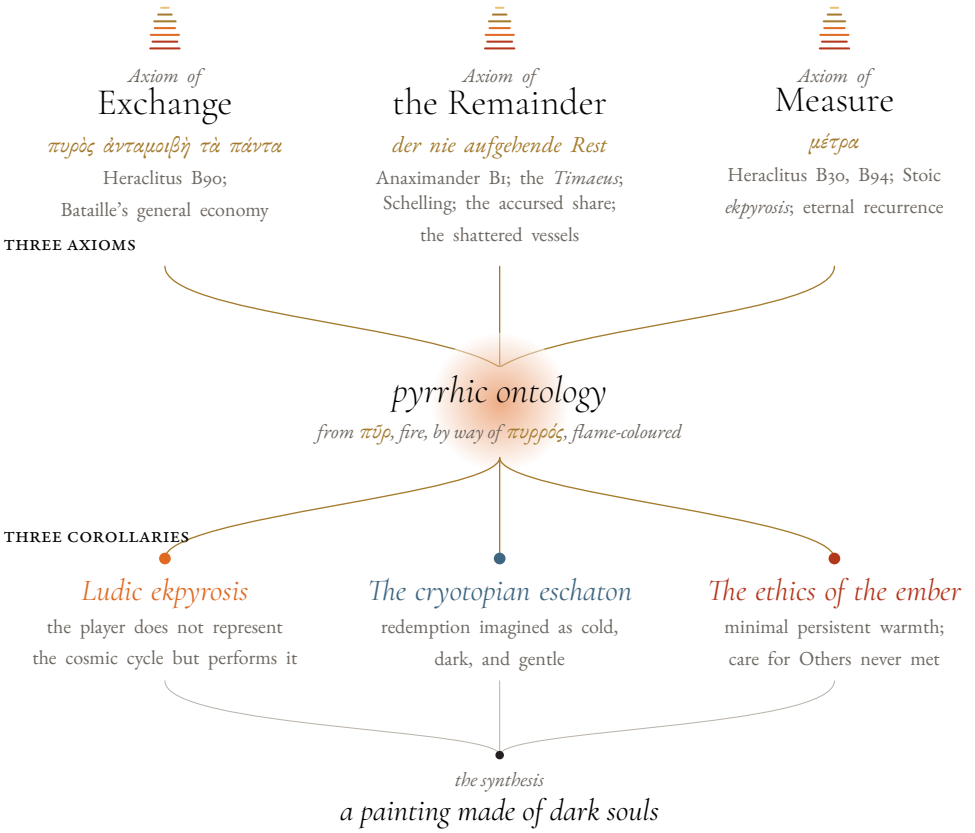


Figure 3 *Three axioms, reconstructed from the operative structure of the trilogy; the framework they compose; and the three corollaries, with their synthesis, that follow from them.*

1.7 *Statement of the Thesis: Three Axioms, Three Corollaries*

Against these four paradigms, and building on what each correctly perceives, this thesis advances a unified interpretation of the *Dark Souls* trilogy as the articulation of a pyrrhic ontology. The position may be stated in three axioms, from which three corollaries follow. The axioms are not imposed on the work from outside; they are reconstructed from its operative structure under the principle of operative constraint, and each is supported by a convergence of textual, systemic, and comparative evidence that the subsequent chapters set out in detail.

The first is the **Axiom of Exchange**. In the *Dark Souls* cosmos, being is not substance but circulation. Every entity is a deposit of fire awaiting expenditure, and every relation among entities is a relation of exchange in which one form of being is converted into another. This is the metaphysical significance of the collapse of ontological, economic, experiential, and narrative registers into the single variable of the soul: in a world where

to be is to be a store of exchangeable soul, there is no being that is not also a value, no value that is not also a life, and no life that is not also a price. The axiom is Heraclitean in formulation—πυρὸς ἀνταμοιβὴ τὰ πάντα, all things are an exchange for fire—but its implications are most fully developed by Georges Bataille's distinction, in *La Part maudite* (1949), between restricted and general economy. A restricted economy is organized by scarcity and accumulation; a general economy begins from the excess of energy that the sun bestows without return, an excess that cannot be indefinitely accumulated and must finally be spent, gloriously or catastrophically. The Age of Fire is a restricted economy that has forgotten its origin in a general one. Gwyn's order hoards the fire, apportions fragments of a Lord Soul to loyal vassals—the Four Kings of New Londo, Seath the Scaleless—and finally sacrifices its sovereign not in glorious expenditure but in a desperate attempt to conserve. The player, harvesting and spending souls without any possibility of permanent accumulation, lives inside the general economy that the Age of Fire denies.

The second is the **Axiom of the Remainder**. Every order of fire—every regime of distinction, value, and sovereignty—is constituted by a dark residue it can neither assimilate nor remember, and the history of every such order is the history of the return of its remainder. In the cosmogony of *Dark Souls* the remainder is the furtive pygmy and his Dark Soul, the fourth Lord Soul that the narration introduces as forgotten and that the trilogy discloses only at the end of the world. In its anthropology the remainder is humanity itself: the dark substance that the Age of Fire brands with the Darksign, confines in asylums, sacrifices in its Fire Keepers, and seals behind the walls of the Ringed City. The axiom gathers a constellation of philosophical precedents into a single principle. Anaximander's fragment conceives individuated existence as an injustice committed against the boundless, which must be paid back in time. Plato's *Timaeus* opens with a missing fourth and grounds becoming in the χώρα, a "third kind" apprehended only by a kind of bastard reasoning (52b). Schelling's *Philosophische Untersuchungen über das Wesen der menschlichen Freiheit* (1809) locates in God a dark ground (*Grund*) distinct from God's existence, an unruly residue that never resolves into order—"der nie aufgehende Rest," the remainder that never comes out even. Bataille's accursed share names the surplus that every economy must squander. And the Lurianic Kabbalah of sixteenth-century Safed, in its doctrine of the shattering of the vessels (*shevirat ha-kelim*), conceives creation as a catastrophe in which the vessels prepared to receive the divine light could not contain it, so that its sparks fell into the husks (*kelipot*) of the lower worlds, there to await the labour of restoration (*tikkun*). It is difficult to overstate how closely this last doctrine maps onto the central quest of the first *Dark Souls*, in which the player must gather the scattered Lord Souls into the Lordvessel—in Japanese simply 王の器 (*ō no utsuwa*), "the vessel of the king"—through a world populated by Hollows: husks, shells, *kelipot*, each retaining a fading spark of what it once was.

The third is the **Axiom of Measure**. In a cosmos constituted by exchange and haunted

by its remainder, the only comportment that does not end in Hollowing is a measured, repeated, and knowingly futile self-expenditure. The axiom derives from the Heraclitean μέτρα, the "measures" in which the cosmic fire is kindled and quenched (B30), and from the fragment in which Heraclitus declares that the sun will not overstep its measures, for if it does the Erinyes, the ministers of Justice, will find it out: Ἥλιος γὰρ οὐχ ὑπερβήσεται μέτρα· εἰ δὲ μή, Ἐρινύες μιν Δίκης ἐπίκουροι ἐξευρήσουσιν (B94). It is difficult to imagine a more exact formula for the tragedy of Gwyn, Lord of Sunlight, whose prolongation of the Age of Fire beyond its natural measure brings upon his world the curse of undeath—Erinyes in the form of the Darksign, which hunts down every human being and drives them, through endless death, toward the dissolution of the self. The axiom further absorbs the Stoic transformation of the Heraclitean cycle into ἐκπύρωσις, and the Nietzschean transformation of the Stoic cycle into the thought of eternal recurrence, the "heaviest weight" (*Das grösste Schwergewicht*, *Die fröhliche Wissenschaft* §341), which crushes the one who cannot affirm it and transfigures the one who can. Measure, in this sense, is not moderation in the Aristotelian sense of a mean between extremes. It is the discipline of a practice: the willingness to spend oneself in the right amount, repeatedly, without hope of final reward and without despair at its absence, which converts recurrence from curse into *askēsis*.

From these axioms follow three corollaries, which constitute the thesis's principal original contributions. The first, already introduced, is **ludic ekpyrosis**: the formal loop of death, return, and recovery is a performative cosmology, in which the player does not represent but enacts the cosmic cycle of conflagration and regeneration, so that the metaphysics of the game is realized in the body of the one who plays it. The second is what I call the **cryotopian eschaton**. Across Miyazaki's corpus the imagination of redemption is persistently cold rather than warm, dark rather than luminous, gentle rather than glorious. The Painter of *Dark Souls III* resolves to paint a world that is cold, dark, and gentle; *Elden Ring*'s Ranni proposes an Age of Stars whose order withdraws into the cold distance of the cosmos; the Age of Dark of the first game is, whatever else it may be, an age of cooling. This persistent anti-solar eschatology inverts the founding gesture of Western metaphysics, which Derrida in "La mythologie blanche" (1971) analysed as heliotropic—turning always toward the sun as the metaphor of metaphor, the source of visibility and truth from the *Republic*'s image of the Good to the *lumen naturale* of the Enlightenment. It converges instead with a Japanese aesthetic and philosophical tradition that finds beauty in shadow (Tanizaki), truth in emptiness (Nishitani), and the self in the fire that does not burn itself. The third corollary is the **ethics of the ember**. Neither the heroic linking of the fire, which sustains an exhausted order by sacrificial self-immolation; nor the revolutionary usurpation of the fire by the Hollows, which reverses the order without transforming it; nor the quietist extinction of the fire, which accepts the end without contributing to what follows, exhausts the

ethical possibilities of the trilogy. The ember names a fourth: an ethics of minimal persistent warmth, of care extended to Others one will never meet, and of creative expenditure of the remainder. Its figures within the work are the soapstone message left for an unknown successor, the summoned phantom who fights and vanishes, the Fire Keeper who tends a flame she cannot see, and the Painter who makes a world out of the blood of the forgotten. Its paradigm outside the work is the long single take near the end of Tarkovsky's *Nostalghia*, in which a dying man carries a lit candle across the drained pool of Bagno Vignoni, fails as the flame gutters out, returns to the beginning, relights it, and tries again—an image of futile, sacred, repeated care that I take to be the purest cinematic analogue of what the *Dark Souls* player does.

The synthesis of these claims is the thesis's final and boldest proposition, which Chapter Seven and the Conclusion defend. *Dark Souls* is, in the most literal sense the work permits, a painting made of dark souls. Its world is composed not only of the assets its developers created but of the accumulated traces of its players: the messages, bloodstains, phantoms, and summon signs through which millions of expended lives are inscribed asynchronously into every other player's world. The title of the trilogy has been read as naming its monsters, its Lords, or its cursed humanity. I shall argue that it names, finally, the community of players whose dark souls—whose deaths, remainders, and expenditures—are the pigment of the world they play. Miyazaki has traced the origin of the asynchronous multiplayer system to an experience of being helped, on a snowbound slope, by strangers he was never able to thank; the system is in this sense an apparatus for the circulation of anonymous care in a relationless society. *Dark Souls* does not merely depict an ethics of the ember. It instantiates one, and it invites its players to inhabit it.

1.8 *The Architecture of the Argument*

The thesis unfolds in seven chapters and a conclusion, arranged so that each axiom is first established on cosmological and textual grounds and then tested against the operative structure of play.

Chapter Two, "Fog, Flame, Disparity," reconstructs the cosmogony of the trilogy—the Age of Ancients, the advent of the First Flame, the institution of disparity, and the discovery of the Lord Souls—against the pre-Socratic cosmologies of Anaximander, Heraclitus, and Empedocles and the comparative cosmogonies of the Ṛgvedic *Nāsadīya* hymn, Snorri's *Gylfaginning* with its Ginnungagap yawning between the mist of Niflheim and the fire of Muspelheim, the *Kojiki*'s account of Izanami's death in giving birth to the fire-god Kagutsuchi, the Valentinian *Gospel of Truth*'s fog of ignorance, and the Aztec Fifth Sun. It argues that the prologue's laconic statement that with fire came disparity is to be read as a myth of the origin of difference as such, and that the Age of Ancients corresponds to

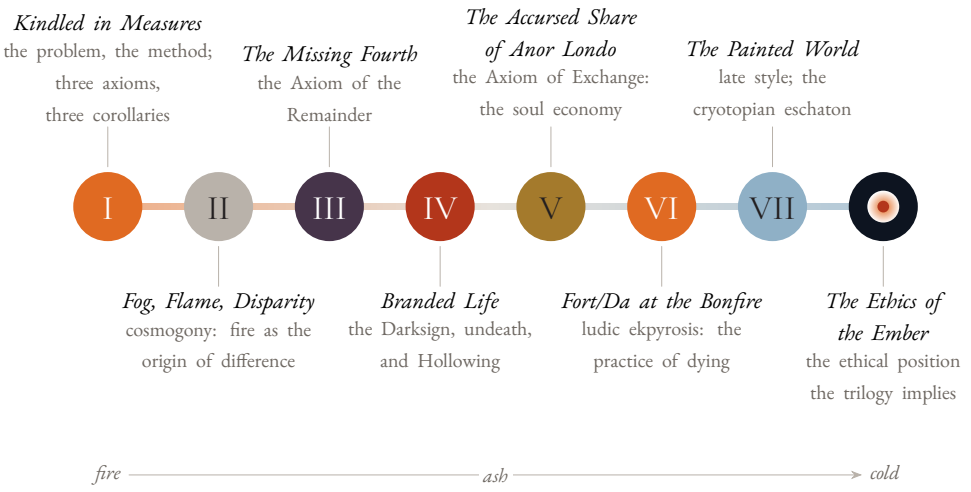


Figure 4 *The architecture of the argument: seven chapters and a conclusion, arranged so that each axiom is first established on cosmological and textual grounds and then tested against the operative structure of play.*

what Saussure, in a strikingly apt image, called thought prior to language: a nebula in which nothing is necessarily delimited.

Chapter Three, "The Missing Fourth," develops the Axiom of the Remainder through a sustained reading of the furtive pygmy, the Dark Soul, and the anthropology of humanity. It mobilizes Plato's *chōra*, Jung's quaternity, N. J. Allen's revision of Dumézil, Böhme's *Ungrund*, Schelling's dark ground, the Lurianic shattering of the vessels, and the Gnostic Sophia, and concludes with a reading of Manus, Father of the Abyss, as the remainder's return in its most monstrous form.

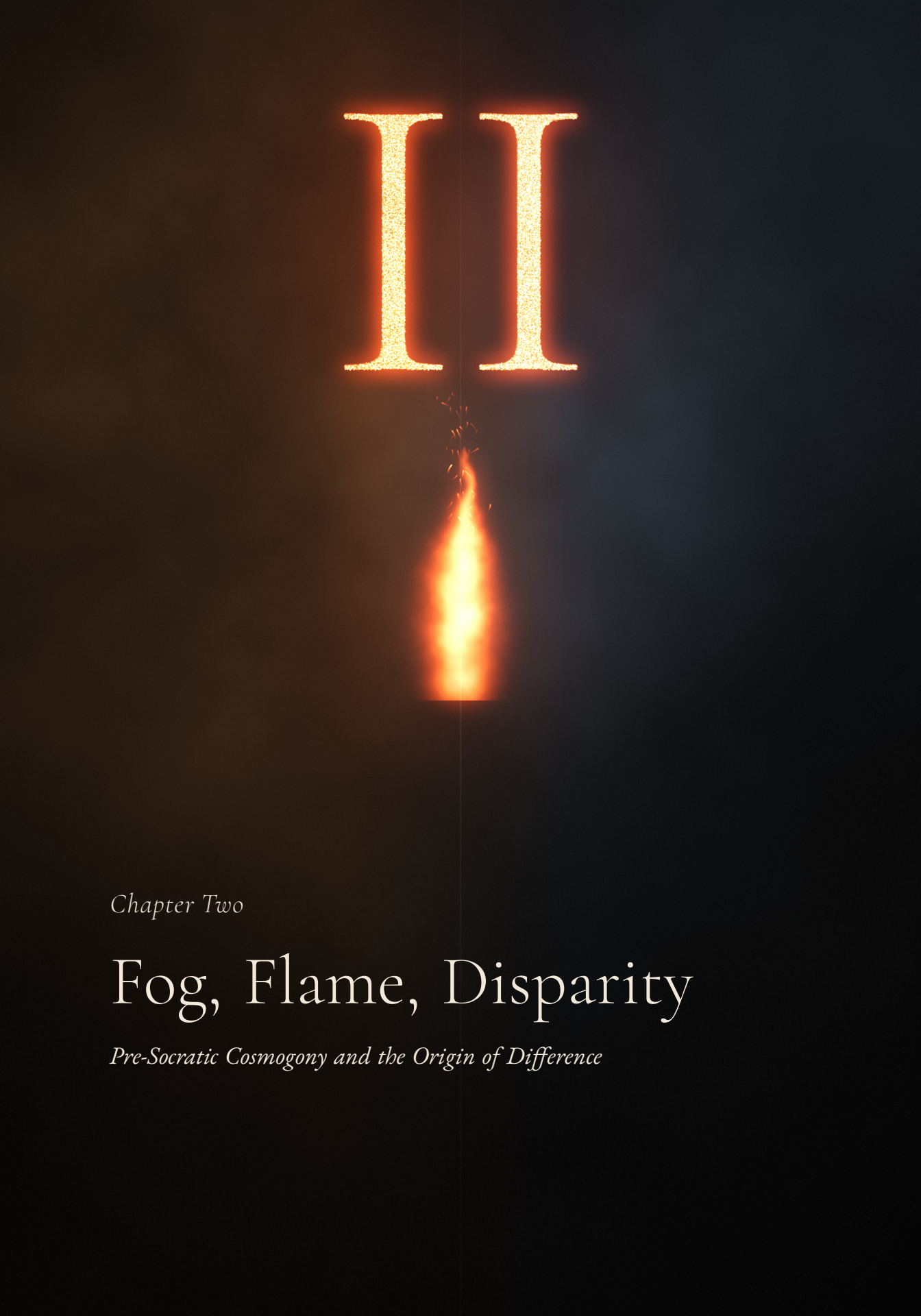
Chapter Four, "Branded Life," analyses the Darksign, undeath, and Hollowing through Heidegger's being-toward-death and care, Kierkegaard's sickness unto death, Lacan's zone between two deaths, Foucault's great confinement, Agamben's *homo sacer*, and Peter Wessel Zapffe's four mechanisms of the "last messiah," alongside the comparative figures of Kafka's Gracchus, Borges's Immortals, Swift's struldbrugs, Tennyson's Tithonus, Le Guin's Cob, and the *gaki* of the Buddhist hungry-ghost scrolls.

Chapter Five, "The Accursed Share of Anor Londo," develops the Axiom of Exchange through a political economy of the soul. It reads the linking of the fire through Bataille, Mauss, Frazer's King of the Wood and need-fire, Girard's sacrificial crisis, Kantorowicz's king's two bodies, the Fisher King of the Grail romances, Le Guin's Omelas, and the *Lotus Sūtra*'s burning house, and argues that the prophecy of the Chosen Undead is an inverted *upāya*: a skilful lie that lures its hearers not out of the burning house but into it.

Chapter Six, "Fort/Da at the Bonfire," develops the theory of ludic ekpyrosis through the phenomenology of repeated death. It reads the bonfire through Bachelard and the hearth-cults of Hestia and Vesta, the death loop through Freud, Kierkegaard, Nietzsche, and Deleuze, the asynchronous multiplayer through Levinas's trace, and the practice of play through Hadot, the *Hagakure*, and the Zen injunction to die while alive, with comparative reference to Bergman, *Groundhog Day*, *Edge of Tomorrow*, *Hollow Knight*, and *Outer Wilds*.

Chapter Seven, "The Painted World," turns to *Dark Souls III* as the late style of the trilogy in the sense of Adorno's and Said's *Spätstil*. It reads the convergent kingdoms of Lothric through Benjamin's angel of history, the ash and cinder of the Unkindled through Derrida's *Feu la cendre*, the endings through Simone Weil's decreation and the Buddhist extinguished flame, and the final disclosure—a painter who will make a new world with the blood of the Dark Soul—through Schiller's play-drive, Borges's circular ruins, and Tanizaki's praise of shadows, as the cryotopian eschaton toward which the trilogy has been moving.

The Conclusion, "The Ethics of the Ember," draws these threads into a statement of the ethical position the trilogy implies, and argues for its significance beyond the study of games: as a contribution to the philosophy of finitude under conditions of civilizational exhaustion, made in the one medium that can compel its audience not merely to contemplate dying but to practise it.



Chapter Two

Fog, Flame, Disparity

Pre-Socratic Cosmogony and the Origin of Difference

tama āsīt tamasā gūḷham agre ’praketaṃ salilaṃ sarvam ā idam

“Darkness there was, hidden by darkness, in the beginning; all this was a flood without distinguishing mark.”

— Ṛgveda *10.129.3*

Prise en elle-même, la pensée est comme une nébuleuse où rien n’est nécessairement délimité.

“Taken in itself, thought is like a nebula in which nothing is necessarily delimited.”

— *Saussure,* Cours de linguistique générale *(1916), II.4*

2.1 *The Prologue as Cosmogonic Text*

The cosmogony of *Dark Souls* is delivered in a single cinematic prologue of a few minutes, spoken by an unidentified voice over a sequence of images whose iconography—grey crags under perpetual fog, colossal trees, dragons of stone, a fire kindled in a cavernous dark, four figures stepping forward to take something from it—has become among the most recognizable in contemporary games. The brevity of the text is deceptive. Measured against the cosmogonic literatures of the ancient world, it is unusually complete. It contains a description of the primordial state; an account of the event that terminated it; a theory of the categories that event instituted; a narrative of the first beings and their acquisition of power; a theomachy in which the new order destroys the old; a statement of the settlement that followed; and an eschatological diagnosis of that settlement's decline. Hesiod's *Theogony* requires a thousand lines to accomplish comparable tasks, the *Enūma eliš* seven tablets, the *Völuspá* some sixty stanzas, and none of them closes, as this prologue does, by turning upon its own present: an age in which only embers remain, in which humanity sees not light but unending night, and in which the bearers of an accursed mark walk among the living.

The voice that recounts these events is never identified. Its position recalls that of the seeress of the *Völuspá*, who recites to Odin the making and the doom of the world, and whose authority derives from a memory reaching back to the giants born at the beginning of time. Like her, the narrator of *Dark Souls* remembers what the present order has forgotten—including, pointedly, the fourth Lord whom the narration itself describes as forgotten—and like her, it speaks of the beginning only in order to speak of the end. The grammar of its account deserves close attention. At the decisive moment, the transition from the primordial state to the age of distinctions, the narration employs no agent and no instrument: there is no speaking god, no sacrificed giant, no cosmic egg, no maker. There was fog; then there was fire. The event is narrated as a bare occurrence, without antecedent and without author.

This absence distinguishes the *Dark Souls* cosmogony from the great creation narratives of the monotheistic and philosophical traditions. In Genesis, light is spoken into being and then divided from the darkness by the God who sees that it is good; in Plato's *Timaeus*, the cosmos is fashioned by a demiurge who, being good and free from envy, wishes all things to be as like himself as possible (29e); in the *Ainulindalë* that opens Tolkien's *Silmarillion*, the world is sung into being from themes propounded by Ilúvatar, who alone possesses the Flame Imperishable. The fire of *Dark Souls* has no such proprietor. Its nearest kin are the cosmogonies that refuse a maker: Heraclitus's fragment B30, which insists that no god and no human made the cosmos, which simply is an everliving fire; and the *Nāsadīya* hymn of the *Ṛgveda* (10.129), which ends by asking who truly knows whence creation arose, and

answers that the one who surveys it from the highest heaven surely knows—or perhaps he does not know. I shall call the *Dark Souls* cosmogony *anarchic* in the precise sense Reiner Schürmann gave the term in *Le principe d'anarchie* (1982): not without beginning, but without a first principle that grounds and legitimates what follows. The fire arrives; nothing authorizes it.

A second absence follows from the first. The beings who emerge into the age of fire are not its creators, and they are not, strictly, its creatures. The prologue says that they came from the Dark and *found* the Souls of Lords within the flame. The verb is decisive, and it will govern much of this thesis. The gods of *Dark Souls* are finders: prospectors who discover a resource they did not make and convert its possession into sovereignty. Their divinity is not an essence but a holding. The cosmogony is thus, from its first movement, a narrative not of creation but of appropriation, and its subsequent episodes—the war against the dragons, the distribution of power, the founding of the Age of Fire—unfold the logic of that appropriation with a consistency that the received readings, preoccupied with the later opposition of Fire and Dark, have largely overlooked. It should be noted, too, that all four of the finders, Gwyn included, came from the Dark. The sovereigns of light are emigrants from darkness. Whatever hostility the Age of Fire later bears toward the Dark is therefore a hostility toward its own place of origin, a point to which Chapter Three will return.

The present chapter reads the prologue as a philosophical cosmogony in five registers. The ontological register concerns the nature of the primordial state and its relation to the pre-Socratic concepts of the boundless and of being (2.2). The semiotic register concerns the advent of fire as the advent of difference, and therefore of signification (2.3). The political register concerns the appropriation of the Lord Souls and the war that instituted the hierarchy of the Age of Fire (2.4). The comparative register sets the prologue beside the cosmogonies of fire in Japanese, Vedic, Iranian, Roman, Hebrew, Greek, and modern literary traditions (2.5). The physical register reads the fading of the fire against the thermodynamic and cosmological theories of a running-down universe (2.6). A final section turns from time to space, reading the architecture of Lordran as the cosmogony's spatial diagram (2.7), before the chapter concludes that the *Dark Souls* cosmogony is best understood as a critique of cosmogony conducted from within the mythic form (2.8).

2.2 *The Age of Ancients: Apeiron, Nebula, Ginnungagap*

The prologue characterizes the primordial state in three strokes: the world was unformed; it was shrouded in fog; and it was a land of grey crags, archtrees, and everlasting dragons. Each stroke is a negation. The world is *un*-formed, lacking the determinations that would make it a world; the fog is the visible image of that lack, a medium in which outlines dissolve; and the dragons are *ever*-lasting, which is to say that they do not live, if to live is to stand in relation to dying, but simply endure. The Age of Ancients is not described as dark, for darkness is one of the terms the coming fire will institute. It is grey: neither light nor dark, neither hot nor cold, neither living nor dead. It is the state of the world before the opposites.

Greek philosophy possessed a precise concept for such a state. Anaximander of Miletus, in the earliest surviving fragment of Western philosophy, named the source of all things τὸ ἄπειρον, the boundless or indefinite, and according to Aristotle (*Physics* I.4, 187a20) held that the contraries are present in it and are separated off (ἐκκρίνεσθαι) in the coming-to-be of the world. The doxographers preserve two further predicates of the ἄπειρον that bear directly on the prologue. Hippolytus reports that Anaximander called this nature eternal and ageless, ἀίδιον καὶ ἀγήρω (DK 12 B2); Aristotle reports that he called it deathless and indestructible, ἀθάνατον καὶ ἀνώλεθρον (*Physics* III.4, 203b13; DK 12 B3). The everlasting dragons are the inhabitants of the ἄπειρον in exactly this sense: ageless, deathless, untouched by the opposition of life and death because that opposition does not yet exist. Their stone scales, which the prologue singles out as the object of Gwyn's lightning, are the material emblem of this changelessness, and the one dragon born without them, Seath the Scaleless, is precisely the one who lacks the everlastingness of his kind.

The dragons, however, are not merely indefinite. They are also *beings*, enduring and self-identical, and in this respect they evoke not Anaximander's boundless but the being of Parmenides, which the goddess of his poem declares ungenerated and imperishable, ἀγένητον… καὶ ἀνώλεθρον (DK 28 B8.3), whole, unmoving, and complete. The prologue's primordial state thus fuses two concepts that the history of Greek philosophy would hold apart: the indeterminacy of the Anaximandrian ἄπειρον, figured in the fog, and the changeless self-identity of Parmenidean being, figured in the dragons. The fusion is not careless. It allows the prologue to stage, in the war that follows, a confrontation the pre-Socratics conducted in argument. For Parmenides' poem does not end with the Way of Truth. It proceeds to a Way of Opinion (δόξα), an account of the world as mortals believe it to be, built upon a single founding error: mortals "made up their minds to name two forms," the goddess says, distinguishing them as opposites—on the one side "the ethereal flame of fire" (φλογὸς αἰθέριον πῦρ), gentle, light, everywhere the same as itself; on the other "unknowing night" (νύκτ' ἀδαῆ), dense and heavy (B8.53–59)—so that "all things have been named light and night" (B9). The disparity instituted by the First Flame is, in the most

literal sense, the Parmenidean δόξα: a world constituted by the naming of fire and night as two. The Age of Fire is the Way of Opinion made cosmos, and the war of the Lords against the everlasting dragons is the victory of becoming over being, of δόξα over ἀλήθεια—what the Eleatic Stranger of Plato's *Sophist* called a battle of gods and giants over being (γιγαντομαχία περὶ τῆς οὐσίας, 246a).

That the defeated principle survives within the victorious order is one of the trilogy's most consistent intuitions. The Everlasting Dragon of Ash Lake, at the lowest point of the first game's world, still offers to those who seek it a covenant, the Path of the Dragon, whose adherents aspire to shed their humanity and attain the changeless body of the ancient dragons; the third game's Archdragon Peak preserves the remnants of the same aspiration. Seath, the traitor who aided the Lords, secures a counterfeit everlastingness in the Primordial Crystal—a deathlessness the player can annul only by shattering the crystal itself—populates his archives and caverns with crystalline life, and is represented by the lore as having pursued immortality into madness. These are Parmenidean heresies within a Heraclitean world: nostalgias for being in an age of becoming. J. G. Ballard's *The Crystal World* (1966), in which a mysterious process arrests time in an African forest and transforms every living thing into jewelled, immobile splendour, offers the closest literary analogue to Seath's project and to its horror: immortality achieved as the cessation of change, a crystalline eternity indistinguishable from death.

The fog itself admits a further reading. Ferdinand de Saussure, in the *Cours de linguistique générale* (1916), described thought prior to language as a nebula in which nothing is necessarily delimited: "il n'y a pas d'idées préétablies, et rien n'est distinct avant l'apparition de la langue." Language, on this account, does not name pre-existing things; it articulates an amorphous continuum into differential units. The Age of Ancients is Saussure's nebula given landscape: a world before articulation, in which nothing is yet distinct because nothing has yet been differentiated. The convergence is reinforced, remarkably, by etymology. Saussure's *nébuleuse* descends from Latin *nebula*, "mist," which shares its Indo-European root (*nebh-, "cloud, mist") with Greek νεφέλη, German *Nebel*, and Old Norse *nifl*—the first element of Niflheim, the "mist-world" of Norse cosmogony. In the *Gylfaginning* of Snorri Sturluson (c. 1220), the world begins as Ginnungagap, a great void lying between Niflheim in the north, a region of rime, cold, and mist, and Muspell in the south, a region of light and burning heat. Where the rime of the one met the warmth of the other, life quickened in the form of the primordial giant Ymir; the gods descended from that meeting slew him and built the world from his body; and they took the sparks and glowing embers that flew out of Muspell and set them in the heavens to give light to sky and earth. Mist, fire, the quickening of life at their meeting, the emergence of gods who slay the primordial beings, the appropriation of fragments of the primordial fire as the luminaries of a new order: the Norse cosmogony contains, in sequence, every element of the *Dark Souls* prologue.

The other great cosmogonies offer partial versions of the same primordial state. Genesis begins with an earth "without form, and void" (*tohu wa-bohu*), and darkness upon the face of the deep (*tehom*, cognate with the Babylonian Tiamat). Hesiod's first principle is Χάος, which is not disorder but a gap or yawning (from χαίνω, to gape), and which thus shares its semantic core with Ginnungagap, conventionally glossed as the "yawning void." The *Kojiki* (712) opens upon a world in which heaven and earth are not yet separated, and the young land drifts like floating oil, "like a jellyfish" (*kurage nasu*). And the *Nāsadīya* hymn, in the verse chosen as this chapter's epigraph, describes the beginning as darkness hidden by darkness and as a flood that is *apraketa*: without *praketa*, without sign or distinguishing mark. The Vedic poet's word repays attention. The primordial state is the state without signs, and the first thing that the subsequent order will inscribe upon its human subjects is a sign: the Darksign. Between the *apraketa* of the beginning and the Darksign of the end lies the entire history of the Age of Fire.

Japanese, finally, supplies the term that the localization renders as "Chaos" in the name of the Witch of Izalith's failed flame and of the monstrous growth into which she is transformed, the Bed of Chaos, whose Japanese name, 混沌の苗床 (*konton no naedoko*), means "the seedbed of chaos." *Konton* is the Sino-Japanese reading of the Chinese *hundun*, and for any reader of the East Asian classics it summons the parable that closes the seventh chapter of the *Zhuangzi*. Hundun, emperor of the centre, had no openings. His neighbours Shu and Hu, emperors of the southern and northern seas, wishing to repay his hospitality, resolved to give him the seven orifices that other beings possess for seeing, hearing, eating, and breathing. They bored one hole each day; on the seventh day Hundun died. The parable is the most compressed critique of differentiation in world literature: the undifferentiated is killed by the gift of distinctions. The Witch's chaos is a Hundun that has not died—a primordial undifferentiation re-emerging within the differentiated world as a monstrous and endlessly fertile seedbed of demons. The fog gates that bar the thresholds of boss arenas and regions across the trilogy may be read in the same light: as residues of the primordial fog surviving at the joints of the differentiated world, so that every passage into a new encounter requires the player to pass back through indeterminacy—a liminal immersion, in Victor Turner's sense of the "betwixt and between," which the second game acknowledges in the name of its first region, Things Betwixt—before emerging into a new determination.

2.3 *"With Fire Came Disparity": The Origin of Difference*

The prologue's central proposition is laconic: with fire came disparity. It then enumerates three pairs—heat and cold, life and death, light and dark. The choice of noun is significant. English possesses a neutral term for the relation of non-identity, "difference," and a marked one, "disparity," from Latin *dispar*, "unequal." Disparity is difference charged with value: not merely the distinction of two terms but the inequality between them. The prologue does not present its pairs as hierarchies, but the subsequent history of the Age of Fire makes plain that they are lived as such: heat, life, and light are what the sovereign order exists to preserve; cold, death, and dark are what it fears. In this respect the cosmogony anticipates, in its very vocabulary, the critique Derrida brought against the binary oppositions of Western metaphysics, in which, as he insisted in *Positions* (1972), one is dealing not with the peaceful coexistence of two terms but with a violent hierarchy, one term governing the other. The prologue names the founding event of its world not as the origin of order, nor of light, nor of life, but as the origin of inequality.

The three pairs are Heraclitean. Heraclitus's fragments return obsessively to exactly these oppositions and insist upon their mutual implication: cold things grow warm, the warm grows cold, the wet dries, the parched grows moist (B126); the same thing in us is living and dead, waking and sleeping, young and old, for these, having changed, are those, and those, having changed, are these (B88); the god is day and night, winter and summer, war and peace, satiety and hunger (B67). Opposites, for Heraclitus, are generated together, depend upon each other, and pass into each other; their tension is a "back-turning harmony, as of the bow and the lyre" (παλίντροπος ἁρμονίη, B51). And the principle of their generation is strife. "War is father of all and king of all," runs fragment B53, "and some he has shown as gods, others as humans; some he has made slaves, others free": Πόλεμος πάντων μὲν πατήρ ἐστι, πάντων δὲ βασιλεύς, καὶ τοὺς μὲν θεοὺς ἔδειξε τοὺς δὲ ἀνθρώπους, τοὺς μὲν δούλους ἐποίησε τοὺς δὲ ἐλευθέρους. It would be difficult to compose a more exact summary of what the prologue narrates next. The advent of disparity is followed immediately by war, and the war produces a hierarchy: some are shown as gods (Gwyn and his house), some as humans (the descendants of the pygmy), and the order that results will make of the latter, through the Darksign, a population of the unfree. Disparity, in the prologue as in Heraclitus, is always already political.

The pairing of light and darkness with the other primal oppositions has a further Greek precedent in the Pythagorean table of ten opposites preserved by Aristotle (*Metaphysics* A.5, 986a22–26), which aligns light with limit, oddness, unity, rightness, maleness, rest, straightness, goodness, and the square, and darkness with the unlimited, the even, the many, the left, the female, motion, the curved, the bad, and the oblong. The table shows how early in the Western tradition the opposition of light and dark was conscripted into a general

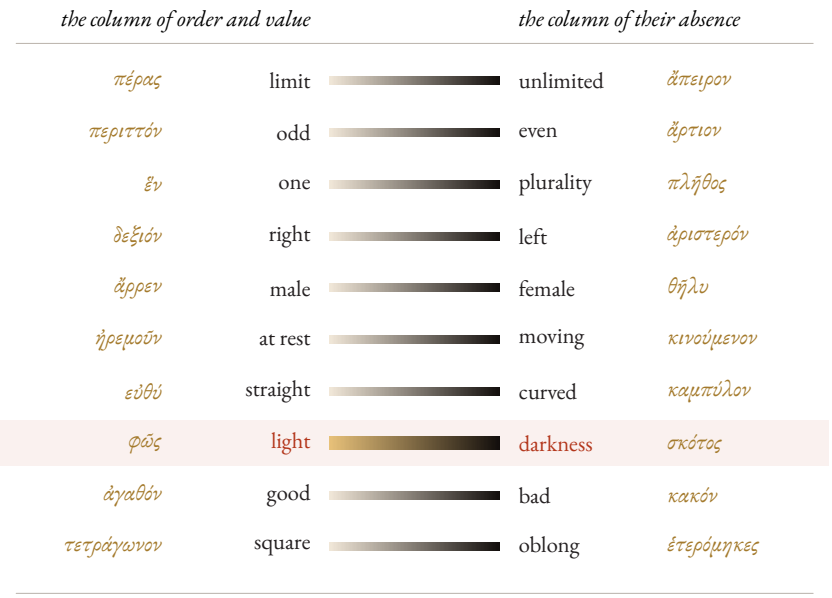


Figure 5 *The Pythagorean table of opposites preserved by Aristotle (*Metaphysics *A.5, 986a22–26), in which one column stands for order and value and the other for their absence; light and darkness are conscripted among them.*

axiology, in which one column stands for order and value and the other for their absence—precisely the axiology the Age of Fire inherits. Empedocles gave the cosmic process of differentiation its most dramatic form. His cosmos alternates between the rule of Love (Φιλότης), under which all things are united in a single undifferentiated Sphere (Σφαῖρος), and the rule of Strife (Νεῖκος), which separates the elements and generates the world of distinct things; the "double tale," as he called it (B17), is of a unity growing out of many and a plurality out of one. The Age of Ancients corresponds to the Empedoclean Sphere, and the coming of fire to the entry of Strife—which is why, in the prologue, the first consequence of disparity is war.

The structuralist reading proposed in the preceding section can now be specified. If the Age of Ancients is the nebula of thought before articulation, the First Flame is the event of articulation itself: the cut that divides the continuum into differential terms. Saussure's dictum that "dans la langue il n'y a que des différences sans termes positifs"—in language there are only differences without positive terms—applies with equal force to the cosmos the prologue describes: heat is heat only as not-cold, life is life only as not-death, light is light only as not-dark. Spinoza had stated the logical form of this principle in a letter of 1674: *determinatio negatio est* (Ep. 50), every determination is a negation. Hegel made it the engine of the *Wissenschaft der Logik* (1812), which begins from a pure being so empty of determination that it is indistinguishable from pure nothing, and finds the truth of both

in becoming. The Age of Ancients is Hegel's indeterminate being, the fire is the advent of becoming, and the Age of Fire is the world of determinate negation. Derrida's *différance* (1968), which fuses the senses of differing and deferring, supplies the decisive further step. The Age of Fire is not merely a regime of differences; it maintains its differences by *deferring* their dissolution. The linking of the fire is the act of deferral par excellence: the sacrifice by which Gwyn, and every successor who follows him into the kiln, postpones the end of disparity by feeding the fire that sustains it. The Age of Fire is *différance* made into a polity: an order whose existence consists in the perpetual postponement of its own undoing.

This reading yields an interpretation of the Undead curse that, to my knowledge, has not been proposed. If disparity is instituted by the fire, then the fading of the fire must be experienced as a weakening of disparity itself—not as the triumph of one pole over another, dark over light or cold over heat, but as the erosion of the distinctions between them. And this is precisely what the curse of undeath is. The Undead neither live nor die; they die and return, persisting in a state that the opposition of life and death no longer governs. Undeath is the symptom of the fading of the first disparities. The pattern extends across the trilogy. Hollowing is the blurring of the distinction between self and non-self, the dissolution of identity into indifference. The convergence of the kingdoms of the Lords of Cinder in *Dark Souls III* is the blurring of the distinction between here and there, as distant lands collapse into one another. The temporal disorder of the Ringed City, where the city's prime and the end of the world coexist beneath an illusion, is the blurring of before and after. The fading of the fire is not the coming of darkness. It is the return of the fog. René Girard's *La Violence et le sacré* (1972) defined the sacrificial crisis as a crisis of distinctions, a collapse of the differences on which a cultural order depends, which only the sacrifice of a surrogate victim can arrest; Chapter Five will argue that the linking of the fire is a sacrifice in exactly Girard's sense, a ritual killing whose function is to restore the differences the crisis has eroded.

Two further frames complete the semiotic and political reading of the prologue. Claude Lévi-Strauss's *Le Cru et le cuit* (1964) took as its key myths narratives of the origin of cooking fire among the peoples of central Brazil, and argued that fire is the operator by which human thought passes from nature to culture: the cooked is the raw transformed by culture. In "Le triangle culinaire" (1965) he added a third term, the rotten, the raw transformed by nature. The triangle maps onto the trilogy with uncanny fidelity. The Age of Ancients is the raw; the Age of Fire is the cooked; and the degraded states that the fading of the fire produces—the poisoned swamps of Blighttown, the decaying flesh of the Hollow, the boss named simply the Rotten in *Dark Souls II*, and above all the rotting Painted World of *Ashes of Ariandel*, whose inhabitants are divided between those who would let their world rot in peace and those who would burn it so that it may be painted anew—are the rotten. Rousseau supplies the political frame. His *Discours sur l'origine et les fondements de*

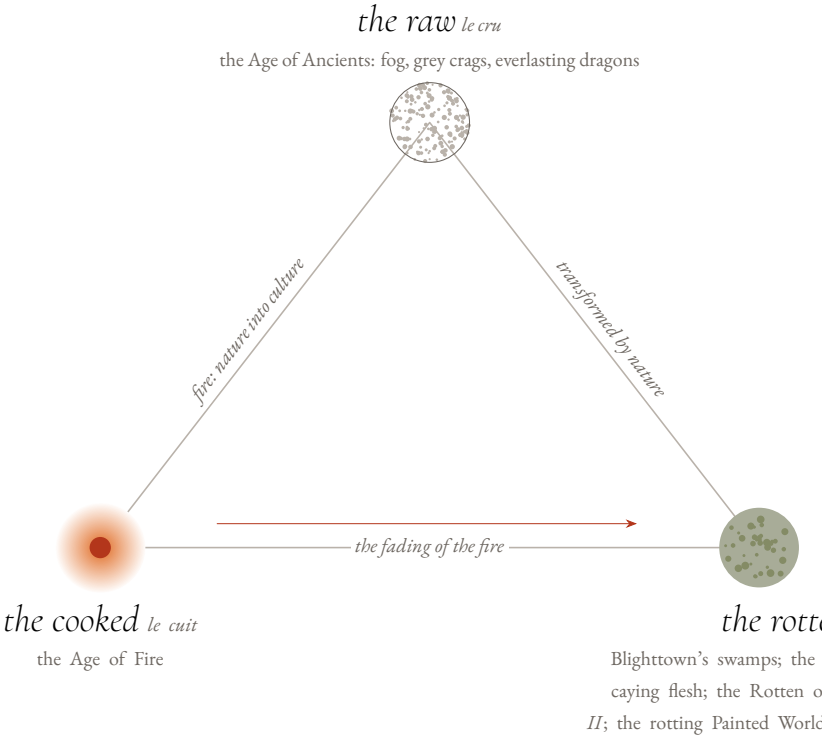


Figure 6 *Lévi-Strauss's culinary triangle mapped onto the trilogy: the Age of Ancients as the raw, the Age of Fire as the cooked, and the degraded states produced by the fading of the fire as the rotten.*

l'inégalité parmi les hommes (1755), a discourse, precisely, on the origin of disparity, opens its second part by naming as the true founder of civil society the first man who, having enclosed a plot of ground, took it into his head to say "ceci est à moi," and found people simple enough to believe him. The Lords who found the Souls of Lords within the flame are Rousseau's first proprietors, and the disparity their finding inaugurates is the inequality that every subsequent comparison—of power, of soul, of level—will measure.

The semiotic reading of disparity culminates in the one sign the prologue names: the accursed Darksign borne by the Undead, in Japanese the Dark Ring. Its form, a ring of fire encircling a void, has an exact antecedent in the cosmology of Anaximander. According to the doxographic reports (DK 12 A10, A11, A21, A22), Anaximander held that at the birth of the cosmos a sphere of flame grew about the air surrounding the earth like bark around a tree; that this sphere was torn away and enclosed in rings (κύκλοι) wrapped in vapour; that the sun is such a ring, filled with fire, which shows its fire through a single aperture, as through the nozzle of a bellows; and that eclipses occur when the aperture is blocked. Anaximander's sun, in other words, is a ring of fire around which the mist has closed, and

an eclipse is that ring with its light shut in. The Darksign is an Anaximandrian sun in eclipse: a burning ring whose centre has gone dark. The Undead carry upon their bodies the image of the sun with its aperture closed—the fading of the fire inscribed in the flesh of those who suffer it—and the final regions of *Dark Souls III*, where the sun hangs in the sky as a dark disc rimmed with fire, simply write the Darksign across the heavens. The first sign the Age of Fire inscribes upon its human subjects is the image of its own extinguishing.

2.4 *The Finders: Appropriation, Theomachy, and the Absent Maker*

From the Dark they came, the prologue says of the four, and they found the Souls of Lords within the flame. The Ṛgvedic cosmogony offers a striking parallel to this act of finding. In the fourth verse of the *Nāsadīya* hymn, after the One has been born by the power of heat and desire has arisen as the first seed of mind, the poets, searching in their hearts with wisdom, *found* the bond of the existent in the non-existent—*sato bandhum asati nir avindan*. The first act of conscious beings in the Vedic cosmos is a discovery rather than a making. Elsewhere in the same book (10.51), the gods seek and find Agni, who has hidden himself in the waters and the plants, and persuade him to take up his office as bearer of the sacrifice. In both cosmogonies the fire, or what lies within it, precedes the gods, and the gods' relation to it is one of discovery and recruitment. But the finders of *Dark Souls* do something the Vedic poets do not: they take possession. What they find becomes theirs; their possession confers lordship; and their lordship is, from the first, a title to rule. Carl Schmitt argued in *Der Nomos der Erde* (1950) that every concrete order begins with a *Landnahme*, an appropriation of land, which constitutes the original unity of order (*Ordnung*) and orientation (*Ortung*) from which all subsequent law derives. The finding of the Lord Souls is the *Landnahme* of being itself: the originary appropriation that founds the *nomos* of the Age of Fire, and from which every subsequent claim—Gwyn's kingship, the distribution of soul fragments to vassals, the prophecy that summons the Undead to Lordran—derives its authority. The Age of Fire has no other legitimation. No god made the fire and pronounced it good; certain beings found it and kept it.

The second movement of the cosmogony is a war. With the strength of Lords, the four challenged the dragons: Gwyn's lightning stripped away their stone scales, the witches wove great firestorms, Nito unleashed a miasma of death and disease, and Seath the Scaleless betrayed his own kind, until the dragons were no more. The narrative belongs to what Calvert Watkins, in *How to Kill a Dragon* (1995), reconstructed as the central formula of Indo-European poetics: the hero slays the serpent. Its exemplars are Indra, who with his *vajra* slays Vṛtra, the "obstruction" who has withheld the waters, and releases the rivers and the light (*Ṛgveda* 1.32); Zeus, who blasts Typhoeus with his thunderbolts (*Theogony* 820–868); Thor, who meets the world-serpent at the end of days; and, in Mesopotamia,

after the doxographic reports of Anaximander's cosmos (DK 12 A10, A11, A21, A22)

Figure 7 *Anaximander's sun and the Darksign. The sun is a ring of fire wrapped in vapour that shows its fire through a single aperture, and an eclipse is that ring with its light shut in; the Darksign is an Anaximandrian sun in eclipse.*

Marduk, who splits the body of Tiamat like a fish for drying and fashions heaven and earth from its halves. The lightning of the weather-god is constant across these traditions, and Heraclitus gave it cosmological dignity in fragment B64: τὰ δὲ πάντα οἰακίζει κεραυνός, "the thunderbolt steers all things." Gwyn, who hurls sunlight as lightning, is the thunderbolt that steers. Yet the closest Greek analogue is not the duel of a single god against a single monster but the Titanomachy of Hesiod, in which the younger gods overthrow the older generation with the aid of thunderbolts forged for Zeus by the Cyclopes, and in which a member of the older race—Prometheus, in the version Aeschylus gives in *Prometheus Bound*—takes the side of the Olympians. Seath is the Prometheus of this Titanomachy: the dragon who sides with the Lords against his own kind, is rewarded with a dukedom and a fragment of a Lord Soul, and whose subsequent history, like Prometheus's, is the history of a transgressive pursuit of what his allies withhold.

The aftermath of the theomachy reproduces another widely attested mythic pattern: the degradation of vanquished divinities into monsters. The dragons do not entirely disappear. The Everlasting Dragon survives in the hidden depths of Ash Lake, where the Stone Dragon also lies petrified; the Undead Dragons of the Valley of Drakes persist in perpetual decomposition; the Gaping Dragon of the Depths has degenerated into a figure of pure appetite, its torso split by an enormous maw. Like the Titans consigned to Tartarus, or the Indo-Iranian *daiva*, worshipped as gods (*deva*) in India and execrated as demons (*daēva*) in Zoroastrian Iran, the defeated dragons persist as the monstrous underside of the new order. The theomachy thus establishes not only a hierarchy among the living but a stratigraphy of the cosmos, in which the earlier age survives as the substrate of the later—literally, in the geography of Lordran, where Ash Lake, with its archtrees and its Everlasting Dragon, lies at the very bottom of the world, beneath the Great Hollow, beneath Blighttown, beneath everything the Age of Fire has built.

Of all the world's cosmogonies, the one that most nearly anticipates the full structure of the *Dark Souls* myth—the gathering of gods in darkness about a primordial fire, the sacrificial self-immolation that inaugurates an age of light, and the requirement of continued sacrifice to sustain it—is the Nahua myth of the Fifth Sun, recorded by Bernardino de Sahagún in the seventh book of the Florentine Codex. When it was still night, before there was day, the gods assembled at Teotihuacan and asked who would take upon himself the burden of becoming the sun. A divine hearth (*teotexcalli*) was kindled and burned for four days. The proud and wealthy Tecuciztecatl volunteered; the humble Nanahuatzin, covered with sores, was chosen as the second. When the moment came, Tecuciztecatl four times approached the fire and four times drew back; Nanahuatzin closed his eyes and leapt into the flames, and Tecuciztecatl, shamed, followed him. They rose as sun and moon. But the sun did not move until the gods themselves were sacrificed to set it in motion, and the Fifth Sun—the present age, preceded by four ages each ended in catastrophe—was thereafter un-

derstood to require the continual offering of hearts and blood to sustain its course. Bataille placed this myth at the head of his chapter on the Aztecs in *La Part maudite*, reading Aztec civilization as a society of consumption organized around the sun's insatiable demand for sacrificial expenditure. The parallels with the linking of the fire are exact: the fire burning in darkness, the self-immolation that renews the sun, the age that persists only by repeated sacrifice, and the succession of ages each destined to end. So too is the inversion. In the Nahua myth the humble, diseased god becomes the sun; in *Dark Souls* the humble pygmy receives the Dark, and the radiant Gwyn becomes the Lord of Sunlight, only to be compelled, at the age's exhaustion, to perform Nanahuatzin's leap himself. The Age of Fire is a Fifth Sun whose Nanahuatzin came late, and whose successors, the Lords of Cinder, are the gods who must die so that the sun may move.

Of the four finders, only one takes no part in the war. The prologue assigns lightning to Gwyn, firestorms to the witches, and miasma to Nito, and says nothing of the furtive pygmy beyond his finding and his forgottenness. The silence is structural. The pygmy is the finder who does not fight, the Lord who does not rule, the claimant whose claim is never pressed—and his soul, the Dark Soul, is the only Lord Soul that takes no part in the founding violence of the Age of Fire. Whether this abstention marks the pygmy's innocence, his cunning, or simply his exclusion, the prologue does not say. It is the remainder of the cosmogony, and it is the subject of the next chapter.

2.5 *Fire's Kin: Comparative Cosmogonies of the Flame*

No cosmogony illuminates the prologue's pairing of fire with the disparity of life and death more fully than the Japanese, and none is more likely to have shaped the imaginative horizon of its makers. The *Kojiki* (712) and the *Nihon shoki* (720) tell how the primordial couple Izanagi and Izanami, standing on the Floating Bridge of Heaven, stirred the brine with a jewelled spear and formed the first island, and how Izanami then gave birth to the islands of Japan and to a multitude of deities. Her last child was the god of fire, Kagutsuchi, and in bearing him she was burned; she sickened and died. It is the first death in the Japanese cosmos, and it is caused by the birth of fire. In grief and rage Izanagi cut off the head of the fire-child, and from the blood that dripped from his blade were born further deities, among them gods of thunder and the sword. He then descended to Yomi, the land of the dead, to bring Izanami back. She answered that it was too late: she had already eaten food cooked at the hearth of Yomi (*yomotsu-hegui*) and was bound to that realm—a detail whose resonance in a game where the hearth is the threshold between death and return should not be overlooked. She asked him to wait and not to look upon her. He grew impatient, broke off the end-tooth of the comb in his hair, lit it as a torch, and entered. By its light he saw her body swarming with maggots, eight thunder-deities coiled upon it.

He fled; she pursued him with the hags of Yomi and an army of the dead; at the pass of Yomotsu Hirasaka, the boundary between the living and the dead, he sealed the way with a great boulder. From either side of the stone they exchanged their final words. Izanami vowed to strangle a thousand of his people each day; Izanagi answered that he would cause fifteen hundred birthing huts to be raised each day. Thus were death and birth, in fixed and unequal proportion, instituted as the law of the world. Izanagi then purified himself of the pollution of death (*kegare*) in a river, and from the washing of his left eye was born Amaterasu, the sun goddess, from whom the imperial line would claim descent.

Every element of the prologue's central sentence is present in this myth. Fire is born, and its birth brings death into the world. The disparity of life and death is instituted by a boundary and quantified by an oath. Fire—the comb-tooth torch—makes death visible, revealing the rot the dark had hidden. And the sun, the principle of sovereign light, is born from the purification that follows the encounter with death and its fire. The correspondences extend into the dramatis personae of Lordran. The Witch of Izalith, mother of daughters, who attempts to bring forth a new fire from her own soul and is consumed by the attempt, giving birth to demons and becoming a monstrous seedbed in the depths beneath Blighttown, is an Izanami of the fire-birth; her daughter the Fair Lady, blind and wasting from the poison she has drawn into her own body, keeps a bonfire at the threshold of their ruined realm. Nito, whose Japanese title 最初の死者 (*saisho no shisha*) means simply "the first of the dead," is an Izanami of Yomi—and a Yama, the figure the *Ṛgveda* (10.14) celebrates as the first mortal to die, who searched out the path to the realm of the dead and became its king, and who entered Japanese Buddhism as Enma, judge of the underworld. And the player who descends into Nito's Tomb of Giants must carry a light—a skull lantern, a sorcerous glow—into a darkness so complete that without it nothing can be seen, re-enacting Izanagi's descent with the comb-tooth torch into the realm where fire discloses what death has done.

The Greek myth of fire runs in the opposite direction. In Hesiod's *Theogony* and *Works and Days* and in Aeschylus's *Prometheus Bound*, fire belongs to the gods and is stolen for humanity by Prometheus, who carries it hidden in a fennel stalk; Zeus punishes humankind with Pandora and Prometheus with the eagle that devours his liver. Fire is the founding gift of civilization—the arts, the crafts, the sacrifice—and its theft is the founding transgression of the human relation to the divine. *Dark Souls* is an anti-Promethean myth. No Prometheus ever came. The gods kept the fire, and humanity was left with the Dark Soul. When fire passes between gods and humans in *Dark Souls*, it passes the other way: not from god to human as a gift, but from human to god as fuel, in the linking by which an Undead offers his body to sustain the flame the gods could no longer sustain. Gaston Bachelard, in *La Psychanalyse du feu* (1938), named as the Prometheus complex the tendencies that impel us to know as much as our fathers and more than our fathers—

the Oedipus complex of the intellectual life. The linking of the fire is a Prometheus complex inverted into a succession rite: the Chosen Undead succeeds Gwyn—*hitsugi*, the inheritance of the fire—by taking the father's place in the furnace.

The Vedic tradition supplies an analogue to the linking more precise still. In the Brāhmaṇa literature, and above all in the *Śatapatha Brāhmaṇa*, the creator Prajāpati, having emitted the worlds and the beings in them, is exhausted and disjointed by the effort; the gods restore him by building, brick by brick, the great fire altar of the *agnicayana*, so that the altar is Prajāpati's reconstituted body and the sacrificer who builds it is identified with him. Frits Staal's monumental documentation of an *agnicayana* performed in Kerala in 1975 (*Agni*, 1983) established this rite as among the oldest surviving rituals of humankind. The linking of the fire is an *agnicayana*: the periodic reconstitution, by fire and by a sacrificer who identifies himself with the god, of a cosmic person exhausted by the labour of sustaining the world. The *Puruṣa Sūkta* (*Ṛgveda* 10.90), in which the gods sacrifice the primordial cosmic person and fashion from his dismembered body the world and the orders of society, completes the Vedic contribution: the disparity of social estates is itself the product of a primordial sacrifice. And the *Nāsadīya* hymn's account of the One born by the power of heat, *tapasas tan mahināj̄āyataikam* (10.129.3), introduces a word that will prove central to the Axiom of Measure. *Tapas* means heat; it also means the ascetic discipline whose practitioners were believed to generate an inner fire. The heat from which the Vedic cosmos is born and the discipline of the ascetic are, in Sanskrit, a single word, and Chapter Six will argue that the player of *Dark Souls* practises *tapas* in both senses.

The sacred fires of other traditions illuminate the institution of the bonfire and its keepers. In Zoroastrianism, Ātar, fire, is the visible form of Aša, the cosmic order of truth, and the highest grade of temple fire, the Ātaš Bahrām, is maintained without interruption; the Parsi community of India holds that the Iranshah fire at Udvada has burned for more than a thousand years. Roman religion placed the hearth of the city in the temple of Vesta, whose fire was tended by the Vestal Virgins and whose extinction was a portent of disaster for the state. The Fire Keepers of *Dark Souls*, women bound to the flame and to its service, who carry within their bodies the humanity that strengthens it, are the institutional heirs of both. And rabbinic tradition supplies an unexpected liturgical gloss on the prologue's central sentence. According to the Babylonian Talmud (*Pesaḥim* 54a), fire was not among the works of the six days; it was given to Adam at the close of the first Sabbath, when he struck two stones together and fire came forth. The Havdalah ceremony that ends every Sabbath accordingly includes a blessing over fire, praising the one who creates the lights of fire, and culminates in a blessing of distinction, praising the God who separates (*ha-mavdil*) between holy and profane, between light and darkness. In Jewish liturgy, as in the prologue of *Dark Souls*, fire and distinction arrive together.

Modern mythopoeia has continued the inquiry. Tolkien's *Silmarillion* distinguishes

the Flame Imperishable, the secret fire of creation that belongs to Ilúvatar alone and that Melkor sought in vain in the Void, from the created lights of Arda: the Two Trees of Valinor, whose light was captured in the Silmarils and devoured by Ungoliant, the spider whose Unlight was not an absence but a substance; and the Sun and Moon, fashioned only afterward from the last fruit and flower of the dying Trees. In Tolkien's cosmos the Sun is already a relic, the ember of a greater light that has been lost—a conception that the eclipsed sun of *Dark Souls III* carries to its end. William Hope Hodgson's *The Night Land* (1912) takes the further step: the sun is dead, the earth lies in eternal night, and the last of humanity survives in a vast metal pyramid, the Last Redoubt, powered by the Earth-Current and besieged by the watching powers of the dark. Hodgson's novel is the purest literary image of a civilization after the fading of the fire, and Chapter Seven will return to it in reading the Ringed City at the end of the world.

2.6 *Stelliferous: Entropy, Negentropy, and the Physics of a Fading Fire*

The prologue's eschatology—the fading of the flames, the coming of the Dark, the present as an age of embers—belongs to a lineage that is not only mythic but scientific. In 1865 Rudolf Clausius gave the two laws of thermodynamics their cosmic formulation: "Die Energie der Welt ist constant. Die Entropie der Welt strebt einem Maximum zu"—the energy of the world is constant; the entropy of the world tends toward a maximum. William Thomson, the future Lord Kelvin, had argued in 1852 for a universal tendency in nature toward the dissipation of mechanical energy, and Hermann von Helmholtz had drawn, in a lecture of 1854, the conclusion that would haunt the second half of the nineteenth century: that the universe must end in a state of uniform temperature in which all change ceases, the *Wärmetod* or heat death. The imagination of the fin de siècle seized upon the prospect. Camille Flammarion's *La Fin du monde* (1894) narrated the extinction of the earth beneath a failing sun; in H. G. Wells's *The Time Machine* (1895) the Time Traveller, journeying some thirty million years into the future, stands on a cold and desolate shore beneath a vast red sun while the last living things stir in the gloom; Henry Adams, in "A Letter to American Teachers of History" (1910), proposed the second law as the governing principle of historical decline. The fading fire of *Dark Souls* is the heir of this entropic eschatology.

It is the statistical reformulation of the second law, however, that reveals the full depth of the homology. Ludwig Boltzmann showed that entropy measures the number of microscopic arrangements compatible with a given macroscopic state—the formula $S = k \log W$ is engraved on his tomb in Vienna—so that a state of high entropy is one in which the many possible configurations of the system are indistinguishable at the level of what can be observed. Entropy, in Boltzmann's sense, is a measure of indistinction. The heat death is

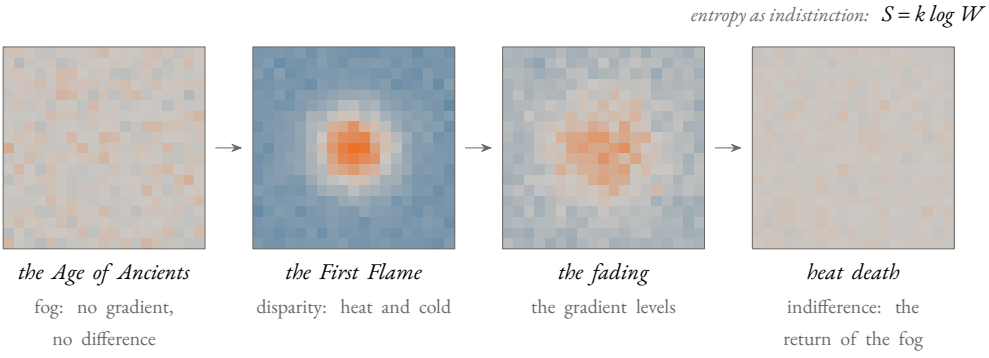


Figure 8 *The levelling of the gradient. Heat death is not the triumph of cold over heat but the abolition of the difference between them: the end is not darkness but indifference, the return of the fog.*

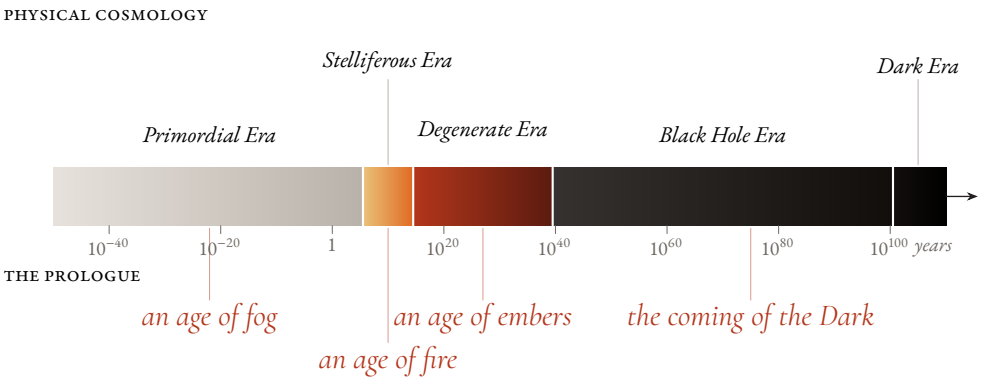
not the triumph of cold over heat but the abolition of the difference between them: a universe at uniform temperature, in which no region is hotter or colder than any other, and in which, consequently, no work can be done and nothing can happen. The first disparity named by the prologue—heat and cold—is the thermodynamic gradient on which all work, all life, and all change depend, and the fading of the fire is the levelling of that gradient. The reading of undeath proposed above, as a symptom of collapsing disparity, is therefore not a metaphor imposed on the game from outside. It is the precise cosmological content of an entropic eschaton: the end is not darkness but indifference.

Erwin Schrödinger, in *What Is Life?* (1944), drew the biological consequence: a living organism maintains its improbable order by continually extracting order from its environment, so that what an organism feeds upon is, in his provocative phrase, negative entropy. The soul economy of *Dark Souls* is a negentropic economy in exactly this sense. The player sustains and increases their capacities by harvesting the souls of others, converting the ordered being of slain creatures into their own; and Hollowing, the endpoint the player must perpetually defer, is the individual equivalent of the heat death—the state in which a being has lost the gradient of purpose that drove it and subsides into the equilibrium of indifference. Ilya Prigogine's theory of dissipative structures, set out with Isabelle Stengers in *Order out of Chaos* (1984), identified a class of ordered systems that exist only far from equilibrium and only so long as a continuous flow of energy and matter passes through them. The flame is the paradigm of such a structure. It is not a thing but a process, a stable form maintained by the ceaseless consumption of fuel, which vanishes the instant the flow is interrupted. The First Flame is a dissipative structure on a cosmic scale, and the linking of the fire is the

act of maintaining its throughput. Process philosophy, from Heraclitus's river into which one cannot step twice (B91) to Alfred North Whitehead's *Process and Reality* (1929), with its ontology of actual occasions that become and perish, supplies the corresponding metaphysics: the fire is not a substance that endures but an occurrence that must be continually re-enacted.

A further episode in the history of thermodynamics offers an unexpectedly precise gloss on the politics of the Age of Fire. In 1867 James Clerk Maxwell imagined a being—soon called his demon—that could create a difference of temperature, and so defy the second law, by sorting fast molecules from slow without expending work. The demon is an intelligence that manufactures disparity. Its exorcism took a century. Leo Szilard (1929), Rolf Landauer (1961), and Charles Bennett (1982) showed that the demon must record which molecules it has sorted, that its memory must eventually be erased, and that erasure carries an irreducible thermodynamic cost: by Landauer's principle, the destruction of information dissipates heat. Forgetting is physical. The Age of Fire maintains its disparities against the course of nature, and it does so, as the trilogy repeatedly shows, by forgetting: by the deliberate oblivion of the fourth Lord, by the illusions with which Gwyndolin sustains the image of a sun that has departed from Anor Londo, by the erosion of memory that accompanies Hollowing and that the second game makes its central theme. The analogy must not be pressed into an identity. But it is difficult to resist the formulation that the Age of Fire is a Maxwellian demon whose ledgers are kept by forgetting, and whose forgetting is paid for by the dissipation of its own world.

Contemporary physical cosmology has, without reference to mythology, produced a periodization of the universe whose correspondence with the *Dark Souls* cosmogony is almost uncanny. For some 380,000 years after its origin the universe was filled with an opaque plasma through which light could not travel: it was, quite literally, fogged, until the formation of neutral atoms allowed radiation to stream free in the event cosmologists call recombination, whose afterglow survives as the cosmic microwave background. There followed what astronomers call the cosmic dark ages, which ended only when the first stars ignited in the epoch named cosmic dawn; and it was in the interiors of stars that nearly all the elements heavier than helium were forged, so that the chemical diversity of the universe, its disparity of substances, is literally a product of fire. In 1997 the astrophysicists Fred Adams and Gregory Laughlin divided the long-term history of the cosmos into five ages: a Primordial Era; a Stelliferous Era, the age of star-bearing, which will last until star formation ceases on the order of a hundred trillion years from now; a Degenerate Era, in which the universe is populated by the cooling remnants of stars—white dwarfs, neutron stars, brown dwarfs—a cosmos of embers; a Black Hole Era; and a final age which they named the Dark Era. The prologue's sequence—an age of fog, an age of fire, an age of embers, and the coming of the Dark—is the sequence of physical cosmology.



after Adams and Laughlin (1997), whose eras are measured in powers of ten years ("cosmological decades"); the fog of the early universe clears about 380,000 years after the beginning; star formation ceases on the order of a hundred trillion years from now

Figure 9 *The five ages of the cosmos after Adams and Laughlin, set against the prologue's sequence of fog, fire, embers, and the coming of the Dark. The age of star-bearing is a narrow band in the long history of the dark.*

Philosophy has not been slow to draw the consequences of this horizon. Jean-François Lyotard, in "Can Thought Go On Without a Body?" (collected in *L'Inhumain*, 1988), argued that the death of the sun in some four and a half billion years is the one serious question facing thought, since it renders every human project, philosophy included, provisional in advance; techno-science, on his account, may be understood as the effort to make thought survive the solar catastrophe. Ray Brassier's *Nihil Unbound* (2007) radicalized the argument, contending that the extinction of the sun retroactively voids all meaning, so that from the standpoint of the end everything is already dead. The Age of Fire is Lyotard's techno-science in mythic form: a sustained sacrificial effort to outlast the sun. And Kaathe, who tells the player that Gwyn, fearing the Dark and the coming age of humanity, resisted the natural course of things by linking the fire, speaks with the voice of Brassier's nature: the end is natural, and resistance to it is a fearful and futile defiance. The dispute between Frampt and Kaathe, between the linking and the Dark, is thus a dispute between negentropic sovereignty and entropic naturalism. The trilogy refuses to endorse either, and its refusal is the space in which the Axiom of Measure will be formulated. A medium-specific comparison clarifies what that refusal makes possible. Mobius Digital's *Outer Wilds* (2019) also depicts a universe dying of old age, its stars collapsing one after another. Its player, caught in a loop of twenty-two minutes that ends each time in a supernova, discovers that the end cannot be prevented, and the game closes not with the prolongation of the old cosmos but with the player's acceptance of its end—gathered with fellow travellers around a campfire whose music they assemble together—as a new universe is born from the old.

Outer Wilds answers the question of the fading fire with a cosmogony of acceptance. *Dark Souls*, as the chapters that follow will show, holds open a more difficult possibility.

2.7 *The Way Up and the Way Down: The Vertical Cosmos of Lordran*

The cosmogony of *Dark Souls* is not only narrated; it is built. The world of the first game, Lordran, is organized along a vertical axis whose disposition constitutes a spatial diagram of the cosmology the prologue recounts, and whose most remarkable property is its continuity: with few exceptions every region is physically joined to the others, so that the player who has descended into the depths may, by a door or an elevator long locked, emerge unexpectedly beside a place first visited hours before. At the centre lies Firelink Shrine, a ruined sanctuary around a bonfire, to which every path returns. Above it rise the Undead Burg and the Undead Parish, Sen's Fortress, and at the summit Anor Londo, the city of the gods, bathed in perpetual sunlight. Below it descend, by several routes, the Depths and Blighttown, a vertical slum of rotting scaffolds dropping toward a poisoned swamp; Quelaag's Domain and the Demon Ruins; and, at the bottom of that route, Lost Izalith, the lava-choked realm of the Witch's chaos. A separate descent through the Catacombs leads to the Tomb of Giants, where Nito presides in darkness; another, through the drowned ruins of New Londo, to the Abyss. Lowest of all, reached only through a concealed passage at the bottom of Blighttown and a long descent within the Great Hollow, lies Ash Lake: a sea of ash and mist from which the archtrees of the Age of Ancients rise, and where the Everlasting Dragon still dwells. And the Kiln of the First Flame, where the journey ends, is reached through the Firelink Altar—so that the hearth from which the player sets out proves to be the antechamber of the furnace in which the player will burn.

Heraclitus's fragment B60—ὁδὸς ἄνω κάτω μία καὶ ὠυτή, "the way up and the way down are one and the same"—is the structural principle of this world. The player's first charge is to ring two Bells of Awakening: one at the top of the Undead Parish's church tower, the other below Blighttown, in the lair of the spider-witch Quelaag. The way up and the way down are inaugurated together, as two halves of a single task. The second charge reverses the movement: the Lordvessel is received in the heights, at Anor Londo, and must be filled with souls gathered largely in the depths—from Nito in the Tomb of Giants, from the Bed of Chaos in Lost Izalith, from the Four Kings in the Abyss—with only Seath's shard taken in the heights beyond the Duke's Archives. Ascent and descent are not opposed directions but phases of a single circulation, and the circulation returns, always, to the hearth.

Mircea Eliade's studies of the symbolism of the centre (*Le Mythe de l'éternel retour*, 1949; *Le Sacré et le profane*, 1957) identified as a near-universal feature of religious cosmography

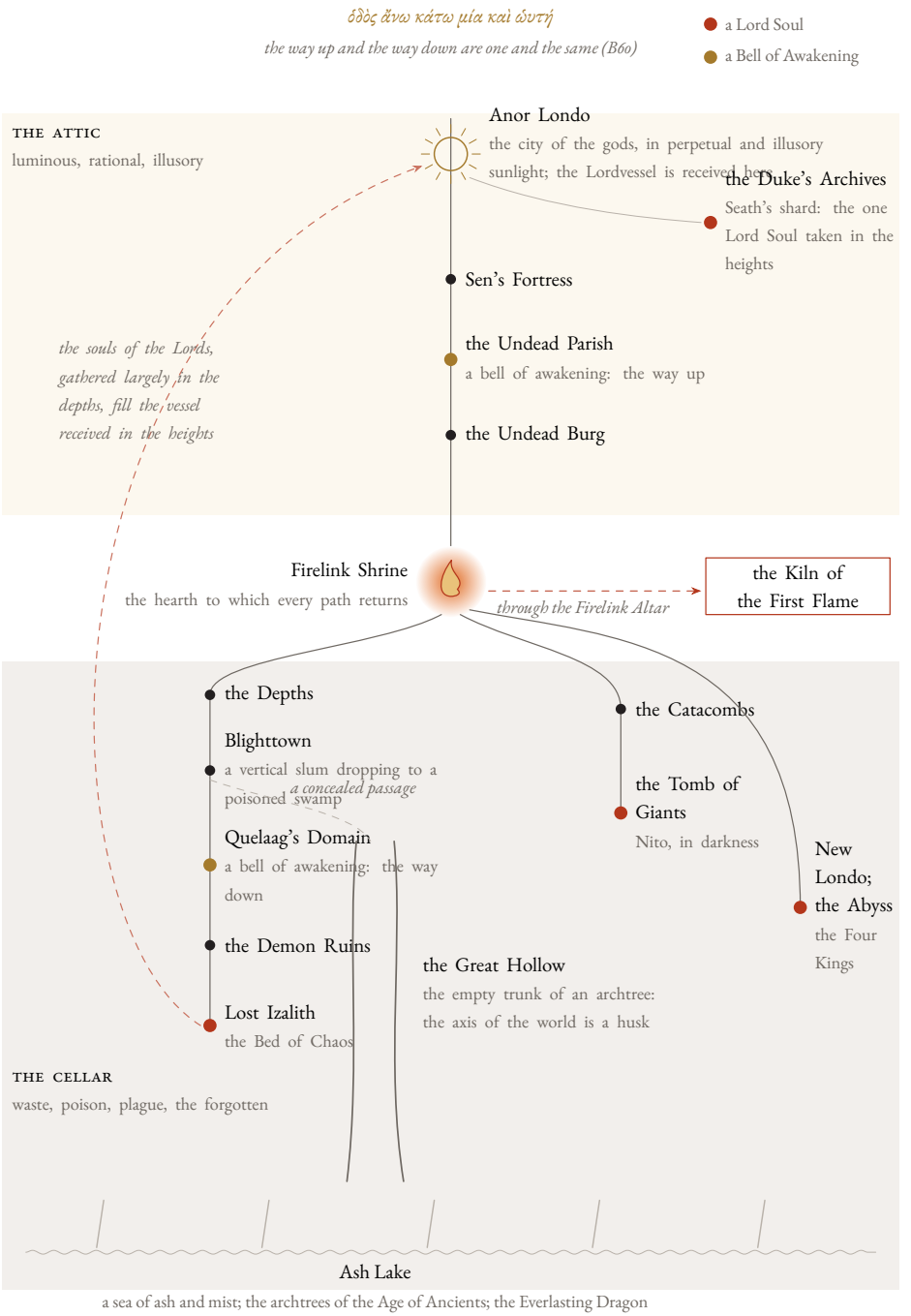


Figure 10 *The way up and the way down: the vertical cosmos of Lordran as a spatial diagram of the cosmology the prologue recounts, organized around a hearth and an axis that proves to be hollow.*

the *axis mundi*, the vertical pillar, mountain, or tree that joins heaven, earth, and underworld at a sacred centre, and around which the world is oriented. Lordran is an axial cosmos, and its axis is doubled. Its sacred centre is a hearth: Firelink Shrine, where a Fire Keeper tends the bonfire, recalls the place Plato assigns to Hestia in the great myth of the *Phaedrus*, where, as the gods ride out in procession across the heavens, "Hestia alone remains in the house of the gods" (μένει γὰρ Ἑστία ἐν θεῶν οἴκῳ μόνη, 247a). And its world-tree is literal: the archtrees that rise from Ash Lake are the pillars on which the upper world rests, and the descent to them passes through the Great Hollow, the vast and empty trunk of one such tree. The English localization's pun, whether intended or not, is exact. The *axis mundi* of the *Dark Souls* cosmos is a hollow: the pillar of the world is itself a husk.

The vertical organization invites comparison with the most elaborate vertical cosmos in Western literature. Dante's *Commedia* descends through the circles of Hell to its frozen centre, where Lucifer, the light-bearer, is fixed in the ice of Cocytus, and ascends thence through Purgatory to the Empyrean, the heaven of pure light and love. Lordran inverts Dante's structure point for point. At the bottom of Dante's world the light-bearer is frozen; at the end of the *Dark Souls* journey the Lord of Sunlight is found burnt to cinder, a hollowed husk still moving through the forms of combat in a kiln of ash. Dante's Empyrean is a fire of love that does not consume; Gwyn's kiln is a fire that has consumed everything and gives no light. And where Dante, at the summit of Purgatory, must pass through a wall of fire to reach the Earthly Paradise (*Purgatorio* XXVII), so that fire is the final purgation before beatitude, the *Dark Souls* trilogy will locate its images of redemption, as Chapter Seven shows, not on the far side of fire but in the cold.

Bachelard's *La Poétique de l'espace* (1958) proposed that the oneiric house is organized by a vertical polarity: the roof and attic, the region of rationality, clarity, and light; and the cellar, the region of the irrational, the subterranean, the dark powers. Lordran is Bachelard's house at cosmic scale. Anor Londo is its attic, luminous and rational—and, as the player discovers, illusory, its sunlight and its princess sustained by Gwyndolin's sorcery, so that the death of the illusionist plunges the city into darkness. Blighttown, the Depths, and the Abyss are its cellar, the place to which the order of light has relegated its waste, its poison, its plague, and its forgotten. Firelink is its hearth. The vertiginous architecture through which these regions connect—the buttresses of Anor Londo, the stairways and bridges of Sen's Fortress, the scaffolds of Blighttown—descends from the *Carceri d'invenzione* of Giovanni Battista Piranesi (c. 1750; revised 1761), whose imaginary prisons of endless stairs and vaults are founding images of the vertical sublime in European art; and the folding of Lordran's topology, in which an elevator beside the hub carries the player unexpectedly up to the Parish, recalls the impossible connectivity of M. C. Escher's *Relativity* (1953). Anor Londo itself is a Kafkan castle. In Kafka's *Das Schloß* (1926) the castle is the seat of an authority that the land-surveyor K. can never reach; in *Dark Souls*

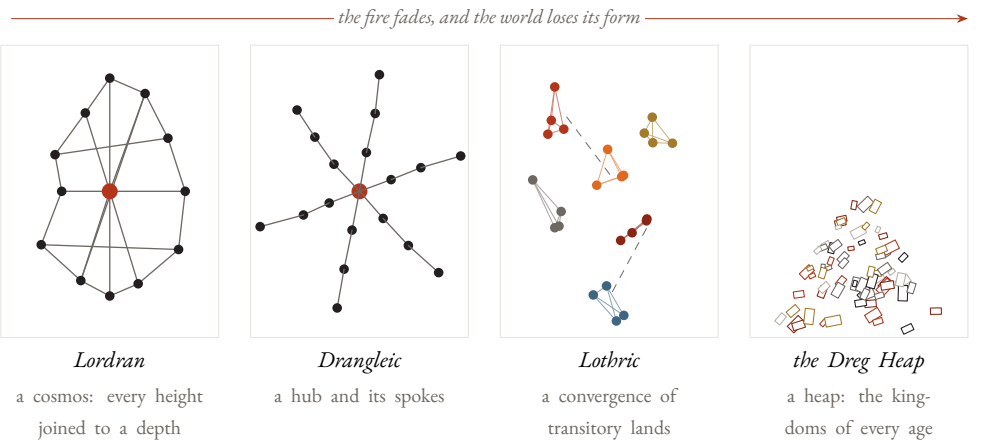


Figure 11 *The degradation of the world's topology across the trilogy, from cosmos to convergence to heap: when the fire fades, the world does not merely darken but loses its form.*

the player reaches the castle and finds that the authority it housed has departed, leaving an illusion in its place.

The interconnected topology of Lordran is not a convenience of level design. It is the spatial form of the Heraclitean unity of opposites: every height is joined to a depth, every path returns to the centre, and the world, however vast, closes upon itself. The player learns this topology with the body, as the habitual knowledge described in Chapter One, and the moment at which a long-locked door opens onto a familiar place is among the defining experiences of the game—the moment at which the world's unity becomes manifest. It is significant, therefore, that the sequels progressively dismantle this unity. Drangleic, the world of *Dark Souls II*, radiates from its hub, Majula, along spokes that rarely interconnect. Lothric, the world of *Dark Souls III*, is explicitly a convergence: the transitory lands of the Lords of Cinder drawn together as the fire fades and piled upon one another without organic connection, until in *The Ringed City* the kingdoms of every age are heaped into the Dreg Heap at the end of the world. The degradation of the world's topology from cosmos to convergence to heap is the spatial expression of the fading of disparity. When the fire fades, the world does not merely darken. It loses its form.

2.8 *Cosmogony as Critique*

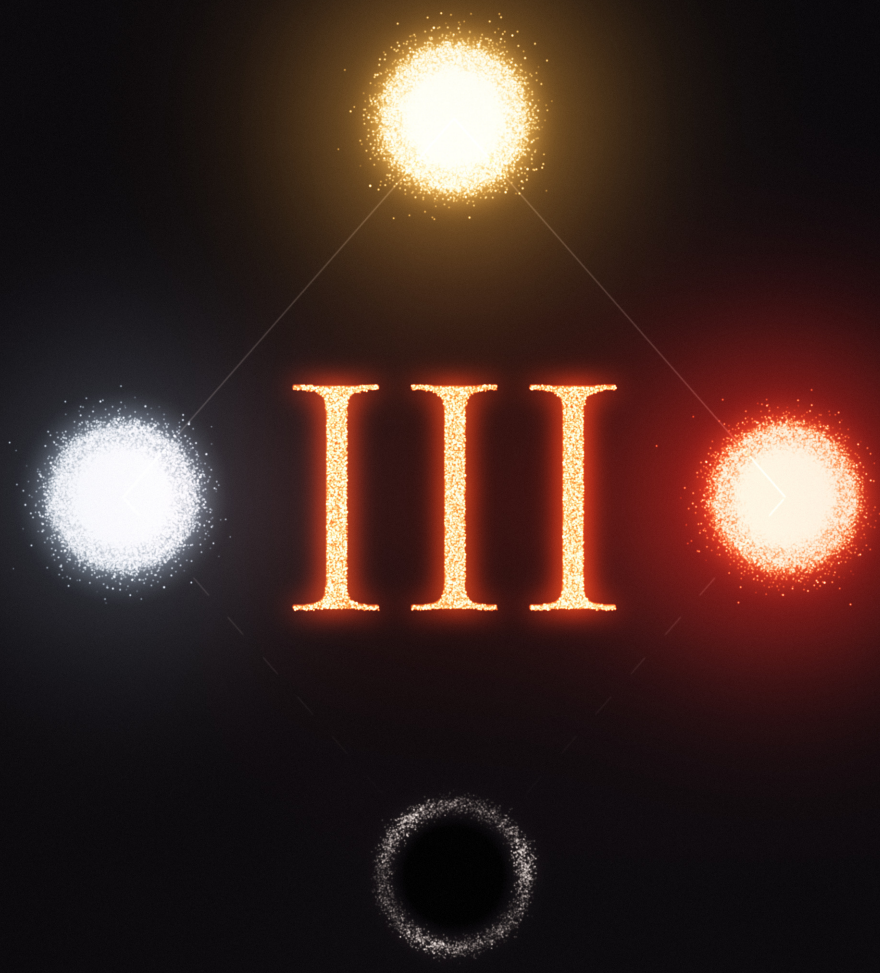
The prologue of *Dark Souls* has commonly been read as background: a scene-setting myth that supplies the fiction's premises before the real matter of play begins. The reading developed in this chapter assigns it a different status. The prologue is a cosmogony that criticizes cosmogony—a myth of origins that, from within the mythic form, dismantles the legitimating function myths of origin have traditionally served. Most cosmogonies justify the order they found. The world is good because a good god made it; the king rules because his line descends from the sun; the gods reign because they defeated the monsters of chaos, and the defeat of chaos is the condition of all goodness. The *Dark Souls* prologue reproduces the form of such narratives while withholding, at every point, the justification they supply. Its fire has no maker, and so no maker's goodness guarantees it. Its gods are finders, and so their sovereignty rests on nothing but possession. Their order is founded in a war that, like Heraclitus's Polemos, shows some as gods and makes others slaves, and nothing in the narration suggests that the hierarchy so produced reflects any intrinsic worth. Its founding event is named not as the origin of order or of light but as the origin of inequality. And the order it founds is, from the moment of its foundation, running down: an age of fire destined, by a law as impersonal as Clausius's, to fade into embers and into dark.

What the prologue never says is as important as what it says. Where Genesis pauses after the first act of division to record that God saw the light, that it was good (1:4), the *Dark Souls* prologue never says that the Age of Fire was good. It never says that the dragons were evil, or that their defeat was just. It never says that the fire ought to be preserved. These omissions are not lacunae of the incidental kind; they belong to the negative architecture described in Chapter One. They leave open precisely the questions the rest of the trilogy will force upon the player—whether to link the fire, whether to let it fade, whether to seize it—and they ensure that no answer to those questions can appeal to the authority of the origin. The political theology that Chapter One traced in the homophony of fire-succession and sun-succession is here exposed at its root. The succession of the fire, *hitsugi*, cannot claim the sanction of a sacred origin, because the origin it would invoke was an appropriation.

The five registers of the prologue can now be stated as propositions. Ontologically, the Age of Fire is the passage from an indeterminate and changeless state—Anaximander's boundless fused with Parmenides' being—to a world of becoming constituted by opposition. Semiotically, the First Flame is the event of articulation, and the Age of Fire is a regime of difference that sustains itself by deferring its own dissolution, inscribing upon its subjects, in the Darksign, the image of its own eclipse. Politically, the Age of Fire is founded by appropriation and war, and its disparity is inequality. Physically, it is a dissipative structure maintained against an entropic gradient whose levelling is the precise content

of the curse of undeath. Spatially, it is an axial cosmos whose heights and depths are one, and whose topology degrades as its fire fades. Each proposition establishes one face of the Axiom of Exchange: in a world where all things are an exchange for fire, the fire itself is neither made nor merited but found, held, spent, and lost.

One figure in the prologue escapes all five registers. The furtive pygmy takes part in the finding but not in the war; he receives a soul but not a dominion; he is named and, in the same breath, forgotten. He is the only finder whose soul does not burn, and the only Lord whose descendants will be marked rather than enthroned. The cosmogony's critique of origins culminates in this figure, for the pygmy is the origin the order of fire cannot acknowledge: the remainder of its foundation, and the progenitor of everyone who plays. Chapter Three takes him as its subject.



Chapter Three

The Missing Fourth

The Furtive Pygmy and the Metaphysics of the Remainder

Εἷς, δύο, τρεῖς· ὁ δὲ δὴ τέταρτος ἡμῖν, ὦ φίλε Τίμαιε, ποῦ;

"One, two, three—but the fourth, my dear Timaeus, where is he?"

— *Plato,* Timaeus *17a*

Dieß ist an den Dingen die unergreifliche Basis der Realität, der nie aufgehende Rest, das, was sich mit der größten Anstrengung nicht in Verstand auflösen läßt, sondern ewig im Grunde bleibt.

"This is, in things, the incomprehensible basis of reality, the remainder that never comes out even, that which the greatest exertion cannot resolve into understanding, but which remains eternally in the ground."

— *Schelling,* Philosophische Untersuchungen über das Wesen der menschlichen Freiheit *(1809)*

3.1 The Forgotten Lord: An Inventory of Absence

The furtive pygmy is at once the most consequential being in the *Dark Souls* trilogy and the least visible. He is the ancestor of every human being in its world; he is the finder of the soul from which the trilogy takes its name; he is the source of the substance, humanity, on which the game's systems most depend. And he is introduced in a single clause, as one who is easily forgotten. Thereafter, across the whole of the first game, he never appears. No statue commemorates him, no shrine is dedicated to him, no enemy bears his likeness, no character recalls his face. His presence in Lordran is entirely metonymic: it survives only in the small black sprites of humanity that the player finds on corpses, in the counter of humanity displayed beside the bar of health, and in the confession, inscribed in the humanity item's own description, that little is known of humanity, just as little is known of the Dark Soul from which it is said to derive. The text that names the substance of the human admits that it does not know what it names. It is the purest instance of the apophatic mode described in Chapter One: the human is given to the player only as what cannot be said.

Only one voice in the first game speaks of the pygmy's legacy as a destiny, and it is the least trustworthy voice in Lordran. The primordial serpent Kaathe, encountered in the Abyss beneath New Londo, tells the player that Gwyn trembled before the Dark; that, clinging to his Age of Fire and fearing humanity and the Dark Lord who would one day be born among them, he resisted the course of nature, sacrificed himself to link the fire, set his children to shepherd humankind, and obscured humanity's past so that the Dark Lord might never be born. He urges the player to complete what the cosmogony left incomplete: to become "the Fourth Lord." The numeral is decisive. Whether Kaathe tells the truth is, within the first game, undecidable, and Chapter One has shown that his record as a guide is disqualifying. But he names the structure. The prologue counted four finders and accounted for three; Kaathe proposes that the fourth be restored to the count. His counterpart, the Kingseeker Frampt, who serves the succession of Gwyn and guides the player toward the linking of the fire, never mentions the pygmy at all. In the economy of the first game, the remainder is spoken of only by the tempter, and passed over in silence by the guardian of the order.

The second game, produced under another directorial hand, disperses the remainder rather than disclosing it. The Dark returns to Drangleic in the form of fragments—the queen Nashandra and her sisters, each a shard of Manus, the primeval man whose humanity overflowed into the Abyss—and in the speculations of Aldia, the Scholar of the First Sin, on the futility of an order of light that cannot integrate its dark. The pygmy himself remains unnamed. Only in the final expansion of the third game, *The Ringed City* (2017), six years after the first game's release, does the trilogy disclose his descendants, the Pygmy Lords, in a city set apart at the end of the world. And the disclosure is itself a loss. By the time

the player arrives, the Slave Knight Gael has already devoured their Dark Soul; the origin appears only as something already consumed. The structure recalls the fifth of Benjamin's theses on the concept of history: "Das wahre Bild der Vergangenheit huscht vorbei"—the true image of the past flits by, and can be held only as an image that flashes up in the instant of its recognizability and is never seen again. The English epithet of the prologue is, in this light, uncannily exact. *Furtive* derives from Latin *furtivus*, from *furtum*, theft, and *fur*, thief: the furtive is what moves by stealth, what is stolen or secretly taken. The pygmy flits by, at the beginning and at the end, like Benjamin's image of the past; and his epithet marks him, alone among the finders, as one whose finding was a kind of theft.

Freud's essay on "Das Unheimliche" (1919) observed that the uncanny is not the merely unfamiliar but the familiar made strange—the *heimlich*, the homely and intimate, returning as what ought to have remained hidden. The pygmy is the uncanny in this exact sense. Nothing in the trilogy is more intimate to the player than the pygmy: he is the ancestor of the player-character, the substance of the player's humanity, the soul named in the game's title. Nothing is more estranged. The order of the world has made the most intimate origin the most alien, and every subsequent encounter with the Dark—in the Abyss, in the Hollow, in the Ringed City—carries the charge of this estrangement.

The present chapter treats the pygmy not primarily as a character, of whom the trilogy tells almost nothing, but as a structural position: the position of the remainder, which Chapter One defined as the dark residue that every order of fire can neither assimilate nor remember. It tracks the occupants of this position through the trilogy—the pygmy himself, the substance of humanity, the Fire Keepers who are its vessels, Manus and the Abyss, the Pygmy Lords of the Ringed City—and reads them against the philosophical traditions that have thought the remainder most rigorously. Section 3.2 sets the missing fourth of the prologue beside the missing fourth of Plato's *Timaeus* and its afterlives in Jung, in Indo-European comparative mythology, and in Lacan. Section 3.3 reads the Dark Soul through the speculative theology of the dark ground in Böhme, Schelling, and Hegel. Section 3.4 reconstructs, under the principle of operative constraint, what humanity actually does within the game's systems, and draws from this an anthropology. Section 3.5 tests the Gnostic and Kabbalistic theologies of the fallen spark against the trilogy. Section 3.6 reads Manus and the Abyss as the remainder's monstrous return; section 3.7, the Ringed City as its belated disclosure. Section 3.8 states the Axiom of the Remainder in its final form.

3.2 *The Problem of the Fourth: Timaeus, Chōra, Quaternity*

The most influential cosmogony in the Western philosophical tradition begins, before a word about the cosmos is spoken, with a count that comes out short. Socrates, arriving to hear the account he has been promised, counts his companions: one, two, three—but the fourth of yesterday's guests, who are today's hosts, where is he? Some illness has befallen him, Timaeus replies; he would never willingly have missed the gathering. The absent guest is never named, and ancient commentators, Proclus among them, speculated at length about his identity and the meaning of his absence. The *Timaeus* thus opens, as the *Dark Souls* prologue does, with a tetrad missing its fourth member. The coincidence would be idle if the dialogue did not go on to discover, in the midst of its cosmogony, precisely such a missing term, without which the cosmos cannot be thought.

Having described the cosmos as the work of a demiurge who looks to eternal forms, Timaeus finds that he must begin again (48e). Two kinds—the model and its copy—are not enough; a third kind (τρίτον γένος), difficult and obscure, must be admitted: the receptacle (ὑποδοχή) and nurse (τιθήνη) of all becoming. Its properties are set out with extraordinary care. It must be devoid of every form in order to receive every form, as perfumers first make odourless the liquid that is to carry the scent (50e). It is an invisible and formless kind, all-receiving (ἀνόρατον εἶδός τι καὶ ἄμορφον, πανδεχές, 51a), which partakes of the intelligible in a most perplexing way. And it is apprehended without the senses by "a kind of bastard reasoning" (λογισμῷ τινι νόθῳ), scarcely an object of belief, something we look upon as in a dream (52b). The χώρα is the matrix in which forms appear without itself being a form. The Dark of *Dark Souls* has exactly these properties. It is formless: the Abyss is a void in which no shape persists, and humanity, its fragment, appears as a shapeless black sprite. It is the condition of the appearance of form: without humanity there is no human form, only the desiccated mask of the Hollow. And it is known only by bastard reasoning—by inference from traces, by half-belief, by the dreamlike reconstruction from fragments that the lore community practises and that Chapter One described as the hermeneutic proper to the work. The lore-hunter's method is, in the strictest sense, the method the *Timaeus* prescribes for the χώρα.

The χώρα has had a long afterlife in modern thought. Julia Kristeva, in *La Révolution du langage poétique* (1974), named as the semiotic *chora* the pre-symbolic, rhythmic, maternal space of the drives—ordered but not yet signifying—which the institution of the symbolic order represses, and which returns in the rhythms and ruptures of poetic language. Derrida, in *Khôra* (1993), insisted that the χώρα is neither sensible nor intelligible, neither being nor nothing, but the place that gives place to the oppositions it makes possible without belonging to any of them. This last formulation resolves a difficulty in the *Dark Souls* cosmogony that the received readings have not noticed. The prologue lists light and dark

among the disparities instituted by the fire, so that the dark is one pole of an opposition. But the same prologue says that the Lords came *from* the Dark before they found the Lord Souls—before, therefore, the disparity of light and dark existed. The Dark is thus doubly inscribed: once as the matrix from which the finders emerged, prior to all opposition, and once as a term within the opposition the fire instituted. It is what Derrida would call a re-marked term, a word that names both a pole of the field and the field itself. The Dark Soul is the χώρα of the *Dark Souls* cosmos: the condition of the disparities' appearance, re-inscribed within them as the lesser term of one of them.

C. G. Jung's essay on the dogma of the Trinity (1942; revised 1948) opens, like the *Timaeus*, with Socrates's question, and reads the missing fourth as the archetypal structure of a totality that can be whole only by including what it excludes. The Christian Trinity, on Jung's account, is a triad that has repressed its fourth—matter, the feminine, the devil, evil—and is therefore incomplete. He cited repeatedly the alchemical axiom attributed to Maria Prophetissa, "one becomes two, two becomes three, and out of the third comes the one as the fourth," and later welcomed the papal definition of the Assumption of the Virgin in 1950 as the beginning of a quaternity (*Antwort auf Hiob*, 1952). The quaternity is for Jung the archetype of the Self, the totality of the psyche; the excluded fourth corresponds to the Shadow, the unacknowledged portion of the personality, which, so long as it remains unintegrated, is projected outward and returns destructively. The *Dark Souls* cosmogony is a Jungian triad that has repressed its fourth: three sovereign Lords—of light, of death, of life's fire—and a fourth forgotten. Kaathe's "Fourth Lord" is a quaternity proposed by a serpent, and the choice of messenger is itself Jungian. In Jung's studies of alchemy, the serpent Mercurius is the spirit of the unconscious, the redeemer and the deceiver at once—*Mercurius duplex*. The trilogy doubles its serpent precisely: Frampt and Kaathe, two primordial serpents, one leading toward the kiln and one toward the Abyss, together form the caduceus of Hermes, the staff of the psychopomp, the guide of souls who is also the god of thieves and of lies.

Comparative mythology supplies a further gloss on the fourth. Georges Dumézil reconstructed Indo-European ideology as tripartite: sovereignty, force, and fecundity. N. J. Allen, in a revision first set out in 1987, argued that the system was originally quadripartite, and that its fourth function was bivalent, divided between a positive pole—the transcendent, that which stands above and outside the three functions, as the king stands above the estates—and a negative pole: the excluded, the devalued outsider who falls below them. The *Puruṣa Sūkta* (*Ṛgveda* 10.90), in which the four estates of Vedic society issue from the dismembered body of the cosmic person, the lowest from his feet, supplies Allen's paradigmatic instance of the negative fourth. The furtive pygmy occupies Allen's fourth function with remarkable precision, and in both its poles. He is small, low, hidden, forgotten, and his descendants are the branded, the confined, and the Hollow; but his soul is also the sub-

Figure 12 *The missing fourth. N. J. Allen's bivalent fourth function, standing at once above and below the three, and the furtive pygmy, who occupies both of its poles.*

stance of the Dark Lord whom Kaathe holds out as a sovereign beyond the whole order of the Age of Fire. The remainder is at once below the system and above it. Chapter Four will show that this bivalence is exactly the structure Giorgio Agamben found in the relation between the sovereign and *homo sacer*, the two figures who stand at the opposite limits of the political order and touch one another there.

Psychoanalysis, finally, explains why the remainder is desired. Jacques Lacan, in his seminar on anxiety (1962–63), described the *objet petit a* as a remainder (*reste*): what is left over when the subject is constituted in the field of the Other, the part that the symbolic operation cannot absorb, and which for that very reason becomes the object-cause of desire. Humanity is the *objet a* of the *Dark Souls* cosmos. It is, by a wide margin, the most desired substance in the world of the first game: the Hollow has lost it and the human must hoard it; the Darkwraiths drain it from their victims; the Fire Keepers are made of it; the players farm it; and in the third game Gael will cross the end of the world to devour the blood of the Dark Soul. Everyone wants what the order of fire could not absorb. The remainder

causes desire because it is the remainder: the part of being that disparity left over, and that therefore promises what disparity withholds.

3.3 The Dark Ground: Böhme, Schelling, and the Night of the World

The most rigorous Western metaphysics of the remainder was elaborated not by the Gnostics, whom the paratextual commons usually invokes, but by the German speculative tradition that runs from Jakob Böhme through Schelling to Hegel. That tradition asked how darkness is related to the divine light, and answered, with growing precision, that the dark is not the opposite of light but its ground: the source from which light is born, the basis on which it rests, and the residue it can never wholly absorb.

Jakob Böhme (1575–1624), the shoemaker of Görlitz whose *Aurora* (*Morgenröte im Aufgang*, 1612) drew the condemnation of the town's Lutheran pastor, located before God a groundless abyss, the *Ungrund*: a will without object that longs to behold itself. From this longing the eternal nature unfolds in seven qualities or source-spirits. The first three—a contracting harshness, an attracting and stinging motion, and the anguish of their conflict, which turns upon itself like a wheel—constitute the dark world. The fourth is fire, the *Schrack* or lightning-flash in which the wheel of anguish is broken open. The last three—light or love, sound, and embodied substance—constitute the world of light. Fire is the hinge of the whole. Toward the dark it burns as the fire of wrath; toward the light it shines as the fire of love; and the two are one fire seen from two sides. Lucifer fell, on Böhme's account, by willing to dwell in the fire's dark root and to sever it from the light; evil is the separation of principles that belong together. The structure maps onto the *Dark Souls* cosmogony with startling directness. The Lords came from the Dark; the fire is the event that divides and joins; and the light is born out of the darkness through the fire. The Age of Fire attempts the converse of Lucifer's separation: a light that would sever itself from its dark root. Böhme's theosophy predicts the result. A light cut off from its ground cannot sustain itself; it must be fed from outside, with ever more fuel, until there is nothing left to burn.

Schelling's *Philosophische Untersuchungen über das Wesen der menschlichen Freiheit* (1809), which drew deeply on Böhme, gave this intuition its philosophical form. Schelling distinguishes God insofar as God exists from the ground of God's existence: a nature in God, inseparable from God yet distinct, which he describes as a yearning (*Sehnsucht*) of the eternal One to give birth to itself. "Alle Geburt ist Geburt aus Dunkel ans Licht"—all birth is birth from darkness into light; the seed must be sunk in the earth and die in darkness so that the lovelier form of light may rise. Without this preceding darkness there would be no reality of creatures; the ground is the incomprehensible basis of reality, the remainder that never comes out even, which the greatest exertion cannot resolve into understanding.

In God the two principles are inseparably united. In the human being they are separable, and this separability is the condition of freedom. The dark self-will (*Eigenwille*) of the creature can either remain subordinate to the universal will, as the ground subordinate to the light, or raise itself above it, seeking to be the centre: and this elevation of self-will over the universal will, the ground usurping the place of existence, is what Schelling calls evil. Evil is not the dark as such. It is the dark in the wrong place.

This analysis clarifies the trilogy's central conflict with a precision that neither the nihilist nor the Gnostic reading can match. Gwyn's order is existence attempting to dispense with its ground: a light that has forgotten its origin in the Dark, suppressed the pygmy, and stigmatized humanity. Schelling would say that this is impossible. The ground cannot be eliminated; it remains as the indivisible remainder; and when it is suppressed rather than integrated, it returns in the form of evil, as self-will seizing the centre. The Abyss of Manus, examined below, is precisely this: humanity's dark ground, denied its place, erupting as a self-will without measure. But Kaathe's alternative is no less a perversion in Schelling's terms. The Dark Lord, enthroned at the head of an Age of Dark, is the ground set in the place of existence—evil in Schelling's strict sense, not because it is dark but because it is the dark made centre. The trilogy's refusal to endorse either the linking or the Dark Lord is, read through Schelling, a refusal of two symmetrical errors: existence without ground, and ground as existence. What Schelling proposes in their place is a bond. "Das ist das Geheimnis der Liebe," he writes near the end of the treatise, "daß sie solche verbindet, deren jedes für sich sein könnte und doch nicht ist und nicht sein kann ohne das andere"—this is the secret of love, that it unites such beings as could each exist for itself, and yet neither is nor can be without the other. The Conclusion of this thesis will argue that the ethics of the ember is an ethics of this bond.

In the unfinished drafts of *Die Weltalter* (1811–15), Schelling extended the analysis into a cosmogony. Before the beginning of time, he proposed, there was an eternal past consisting of a rotary motion (*rotatorische Bewegung*) of contracting and expanding drives, a vortex without issue, from which time begins only by a primordial decision that posits that past as past. Slavoj Žižek's readings of Schelling in *The Indivisible Remainder* (1996) and *The Abyss of Freedom* (1997) have made this rotary motion the model of the Real that resists symbolization—the drive-ridden abyss that every order of meaning presupposes and conceals. The title of Schelling's treatise is itself suggestive for a study of *Dark Souls*: the *Ages of the World*. The trilogy is organized by ages—the Age of Ancients, the Age of Fire, the Age of Dark—and its Abyss, a swirling darkness in which no form persists and from which shapeless creatures of humanity emerge, is Schelling's rotary motion given visible form.

Hegel completed the inversion by locating the dark ground within the human subject itself. In the Jena lectures on the philosophy of spirit of 1805–06 he wrote: "Der Mensch ist

diese Nacht, dies leere Nichts, das alles in ihrer Einfachheit enthält … Diese Nacht erblickt man, wenn man dem Menschen ins Auge blickt—in eine Nacht hinein, die furchtbar wird." The human being is this night, this empty nothing that contains everything in its simplicity—a wealth of representations, phantasmagoric images, a bloody head here, a white figure there, appearing and vanishing—and this night one glimpses when one looks a human being in the eye: a night that becomes terrible. Hegel's "night of the world" is subjectivity as pure negativity, the power to dismember what is given and to recompose it otherwise. It is the Dark Soul. The trilogy's title names the human as Hegel names it: a darkness that contains everything, a night that is also a power. And in the preface to the *Phänomenologie des Geistes* (1807), Hegel drew from this negativity a principle that will govern the later chapters of this thesis. The life of spirit, he wrote, is not the life that shrinks from death and keeps itself untouched by devastation, but the life that endures death and maintains itself in it; spirit is this power only by looking the negative in the face and tarrying with it (*bei ihm verweilt*), and this tarrying is the magical power that converts the negative into being. No better description exists of what the player of *Dark Souls* is asked to do.

The speculative tradition thus supplies six determinations of the dark ground, each of which belongs to the Dark Soul. The dark ground is the origin of the light (the Lords came from the Dark). It is the permanent basis of the light (the bonfires burn on humanity). It is the indivisible remainder that no order can wholly absorb (the pygmy, forgotten but never abolished). It is the seat of personality and freedom (humanity is the condition of human form and of the relation to others). It becomes evil when it usurps the centre (Manus; and, potentially, the Dark Lord). And it is the night of subjectivity itself (the Dark Soul as the soul of the human). The next section turns from metaphysics to the operative anthropology that the game's systems institute, and shows that the systems confirm each of these determinations.

3.4 *Humanity as Remainder: The Operative Anthropology of the Dark Soul*

Under the principle of operative constraint, no interpretation of humanity is licensed that does not account for what humanity does. In the first game, humanity exists in two forms: as a counter displayed beside the bar of health, and as an item, the small black sprite. Consuming the item restores health and raises the counter. At a bonfire, humanity may be offered to reverse Hollowing and restore human form; only in human form can the player summon the phantoms of other players to their aid or be invaded by hostile ones; only in human form can the player kindle a bonfire, offering humanity to the flame so that it grants more draughts of the Estus Flask. The counter raises the player's chance

of finding items and their resistance to curses; it is lost at death and left with the souls in the bloodstain, recoverable only by return. The Darkwraiths of Kaathe's covenant drain it from their victims with the Dark Hand. In the Abyss, shapeless creatures of humanity drift through the void and, when slain, release it. Weapons reforged along the path of chaos, with the ember of the Witch's flame, grow stronger in proportion to the humanity their wielder holds. And the souls of the Fire Keepers, whose bodies are said to teem with humanity, are the means by which the Estus Flask itself is strengthened—souls the player may take from a Keeper's remains, or from the Keeper herself.

These systemic facts, which the received readings mention only incidentally, constitute an anthropology. Humanity performs six functions. It is the condition of *form*: without it, the player wears the desiccated face of the Hollow. It is the condition of *community*: without it, no other player can be summoned or encountered. It is *fuel*: the bonfires of the Age of Fire burn on it, and the Fire Keepers who tend them are made of it. It is *prey*: it is drained, hunted, devoured. It is *fortune*: it governs the contingency of what the player finds. And it is *resistance*: it protects against the curse. Two of these functions require comment. The association of humanity with chance recalls a feature of the *Timaeus* that the preceding section did not mention. The χώρα is introduced in the dialogue together with Necessity (ἀνάγκη) and with what Timaeus calls the form of the wandering or errant cause (τὸ τῆς πλανωμένης εἶδος αἰτίας, 48a): the non-rational, contingent factor in the cosmos, which the demiurge's reason must persuade but cannot wholly master. The remainder of *Dark Souls* governs luck because the remainder is the errant cause. And the scaling of chaos weapons with humanity is a piece of operative evidence for the cosmology of Izalith. The Witch's failed flame, it appears, is a fire that draws its strength directly from the Dark: a flame of the remainder, which is why it is chaos.

The most consequential function, however, is fuel. The Age of Fire depends upon the substance it stigmatizes. Its hearths are fed with humanity; its Fire Keepers are vessels of humanity; its prophecy requires a human being to link the fire. Hegel's dialectic of lordship and bondage (*Phänomenologie des Geistes*, B.IV.A) described precisely this inversion: the lord, who has subjected the bondsman and enjoys the fruits of his labour, discovers that his own independence rests entirely on the bondsman, whose labour forms the world and whose recognition constitutes the lord as lord. The Age of Fire is a lord whose very substance is supplied by its bondsman. It brands humanity with the Darksign, confines it in asylums, and drives it toward Hollowing—and burns it, all the while, in every bonfire of the realm.

The Fire Keeper condenses this paradox into a single figure. She is the guardian of the flame and a vessel of the dark; she keeps the fire with a body made of what the fire's order excludes. The Japanese name gives the paradox philological form. In 火防女 (*himorime*), the second character, 防, means to ward off or defend against, as in 防火 (*bōka*), fire

prevention; and the compound 火防 has historically designated protection *from* fire—the fire-prevention charms of the Atago cult, the firebreaks of Edo. The name holds in suspension the guardian of the fire and the guardian against it. Derrida's reading of the *pharmakon* in "La pharmacie de Platon" (1968)—the word that means both remedy and poison, and that is shadowed by *pharmakos*, the scapegoat expelled from the city to purify it—describes the Fire Keeper exactly. She sustains the flame and restrains it; she is its medicine and its victim; and her soul, harvested from her body, strengthens the flask of the one who will finally feed the fire with himself.

The function of form returns the analysis to the oldest humanist account of human indeterminacy. In the *Oratio* of Giovanni Pico della Mirandola (1486), God addresses the newly created Adam: "Nec certam sedem, nec propriam faciem, nec munus ullum peculiare tibi dedimus, o Adam"—we have given you, Adam, neither a fixed seat, nor a face of your own, nor any special function, so that whatever seat, whatever face, whatever functions you choose, you may have and possess them by your own judgment. All other creatures are bound by fixed natures; the human alone is formless capacity, able to sink to the brutes or rise to the divine. *Dark Souls* implements Pico's Adam in its systems. Its gods are bound to their natures—Gwyn is light, Nito is death, the Witch is the fecundity of fire—while the human player-character has no fixed form: the starting classes are mere initial allotments, any build may be pursued, and the class called the Deprived begins the game nearly naked, with a club, a plank for a shield, and every attribute equal, a human being without determination. The Dark Soul is the indeterminacy that makes every form possible, and the Hollow is that indeterminacy decayed: the loss of the face that was never given but only chosen. Pico's phrase *nec propriam faciem*, "no face of one's own," describes both the freedom of the human and the horror of the Hollow, which are, in the trilogy's anthropology, two states of the same darkness.

The function of community, finally, is disclosed by the Japanese word for humanity itself. 人間性 (*ningensei*) is built on 人間 (*ningen*), the ordinary Japanese word for a human being, which is composed of 人, person, and 間, between. Watsuji Tetsurō made this etymology the foundation of a philosophical ethics. In *Ningen no gaku to shite no rinrigaku* (1934) and the three volumes of *Rinrigaku* (1937–49), and in *Fūdo* (1935), written explicitly in response to the individualism of Heidegger's *Sein und Zeit*, Watsuji argued that human existence is constituted not in the isolated individual but in *aidagara* (間柄), betweenness: the individual is an abstraction from a field of relations, and ethics is the study of the ways in which that field is lived. The anthropology of *Dark Souls* is Watsujian. Humanity's defining function is to make relation possible—the summoning of phantoms across worlds, the encounter with others in co-operation and in conflict—and the Hollow, deprived of humanity, is deprived above all of others. The character 間 is, moreover, the very character of *ma*, the charged interval that Chapter One identified as the aesthetic

principle of the work. The Japanese name for the remainder is the name of the between. Humanity, in *Dark Souls*, is not a substance that individuals possess but the interval in which they meet: the negativity Hegel named the night of the world, the indeterminacy Pico granted to Adam, and the betweenness Watsuji placed at the origin of ethics. The trilogy's systems instantiate all three. Humanity is lost and regained; it is the condition of form; it is the condition of community. That the order of fire burns it as fuel is the trilogy's deepest indictment of that order.

3.5 *Two Theologies of the Fallen Spark: Sophia and the Shattered Vessels*

Two religious traditions offer complete mythologies of a divine spark fallen into a world that does not acknowledge it: the Gnosticism of the second and third centuries, and the Lurianic Kabbalah of the sixteenth. The first is constantly invoked in the interpretation of *Dark Souls*; the second, to my knowledge, almost never. Testing both against the trilogy clarifies what the trilogy affirms and what it refuses.

The classical Gnostic myth is best preserved in the *Apocryphon of John*, which survives in four Coptic copies, three among the Nag Hammadi codices discovered in 1945 and one in the Berlin Codex. Sophia, the last of the divine aeons, conceives a thought without the consent of the Spirit and without her consort, and brings forth a misshapen being, a serpent with the face of a lion: Yaldabaoth. Ashamed, she hides him in a luminous cloud. Yaldabaoth steals his mother's power, fashions archons and a cosmos, and, ignorant of the realm above him, proclaims himself the only god. When the power he stole is breathed into Adam, the human shines brighter than its makers; the envious archons cast Adam down into matter and bind him in forgetfulness, and salvation comes only as *gnosis*, an awakening to one's true origin delivered by a revealer from beyond. The Valentinian version, reported by Irenaeus (*Adversus haereses* I.1–8), elaborates Sophia's fall: her passion produces a formless offspring, an *ektrōma* or abortion, and from her sufferings the substances of the material world are made—from her tears all moist substance, from her laughter light, from her grief and terror the corporeal elements (I.4.2). The third-century *Pistis Sophia* adds a further scene: Sophia, lured downward by a false light, falls into chaos, where she is trapped and afflicted, and from which she cries out in thirteen songs of repentance.

The correspondence with the Witch of Izalith is, as Chapter One noted, the strongest support the Gnostic reading possesses, and it is stronger than is usually recognized. The Witch is a female sovereign who attempts an unsanctioned creation from her own soul—a new First Flame—and brings forth not order but a formless and endlessly fecund monstrosity: the Bed of Chaos, a seedbed of demons, her passions given flesh. Her daughters suffer the consequences in the manner of Sophia's progeny. Quelaag has been fused with the body of a spider; the Fair Lady, blind, wastes from the poison she has drawn into her

own body; Quelana, the one daughter who fled, asks the player to put her mother and sisters out of their misery. And the whole family lies trapped in a chaos into which, like the Sophia of the *Pistis Sophia*, it was drawn by the pursuit of a light. The Gnostic reading's other mappings are suggestive as well. Gwyn resembles Yaldabaoth as the ruler of a light that has forgotten its origin in darkness; Kaathe's claim that Gwyn obscured humanity's past recalls the archons' bond of forgetfulness; and the Gnostic "Hymn of the Pearl" preserved in the *Acts of Thomas* (108–113)—in which a prince sent to Egypt to recover a pearl guarded by a serpent eats the food of the country, forgets his mission and his birth, and is awakened only by a letter that flies to him like an eagle and becomes speech—supplies an astonishingly apt model for an anthropology of forgetting and of messages from afar, to which Chapters Four and Six will return.

Yet the Gnostic reading fails, and the precise points of its failure are instructive. It requires a true revealer from beyond, and the trilogy supplies only serpents whose counsel is self-interested. It requires a beyond—a *pleroma* outside the cosmos to which the spark may return—and the trilogy offers no outside: the Age of Dark is not an ascent from the world but another age within it. It requires, finally, that the demiurge be a boaster, and Gwyn is not. Yaldabaoth never sacrifices himself; Gwyn walks into the furnace. The Lord of Sunlight is a tragic demiurge, whose fault lies not in arrogance but in fear, and whose punishment is to burn. The trilogy borrows from Gnosticism the grammar of a forgotten spark and a lying archon, and refuses its soteriology of escape.

The Lurianic Kabbalah offers a different and, for the first game, more exact mythology. The teachings of Isaac Luria (1534–1572), transmitted from Safed by his disciple Ḥayyim Vital in *Etz Ḥayyim* and introduced to modern readers by Gershom Scholem's *Major Trends in Jewish Mysticism* (1941), begin with an act of divine self-limitation. The infinite, Ein Sof, contracts (*tzimtzum*), withdrawing into itself to vacate a space for creation; within that space there remains a residue or impression (*reshimu*) of the withdrawn light. A ray of light enters the void and emanates the primordial man and the vessels (*kelim*) destined to receive the divine light. But the lower vessels cannot contain it, and they shatter (*shevirat ha-kelim*). Their sparks (*nitzotzot*) fall into the lower worlds and are trapped in husks or shells (*kelipot*), which draw their vitality from the sparks they imprison. The task of history is *tikkun*, restoration: by human acts, the sparks are raised from the husks and the vessels reconstituted, and the completion of this labour is the coming of the Messiah.

The correspondence with the central quest of the first *Dark Souls* is uncanny. The light of the First Flame was distributed in Lord Souls, and the Lord Souls were broken and scattered: Gwyn divided his own, bequeathing shards to the Four Kings of New Londo and to Seath. The player is charged to gather these scattered souls into a vessel—the Lordvessel, in Japanese 王の器 (*ō no utsuwa*), "the vessel of the king." The world through which the player gathers them is populated by Hollows: husks, shells, *kelipot*, each of which, when

broken, releases the souls it held. The player literally raises sparks from husks and carries them to fill a vessel, in a labour of restoration that culminates in a quasi-messianic act. And the *reshimu*—the residue of light left in the vacated space after the contraction—finds its counterpart in the dark residue left in the world after the fire's institution: humanity, the trace that remains. The decisive difference is the end. In Luria, *tikkun* redeems: the restored vessels hold the light, and the world is repaired. In *Dark Souls*, the filled Lordvessel opens the way to the Kiln, and the restoration it achieves is the restoration of the old order at the cost of the restorer. The trilogy reproduces the Lurianic labour of gathering in order to expose its consummation as a sacrifice.

Lurianic messianism generated, in the seventeenth century, its own dark double. When the messianic claimant Sabbatai Zevi converted to Islam in 1666, his prophet Nathan of Gaza explained the apostasy as a descent into the deepest *kelipot* to liberate the sparks imprisoned there—a redemption that could be achieved only through transgression. Scholem's essay "Redemption through Sin" (1937) reconstructed this antinomian logic. Kaathe's path is Sabbatian: the Dark Lord must descend into the Abyss, ally himself with the Darkwraiths, and redeem humanity by passing through what the order of fire calls corruption. The Usurpation of Fire in *Dark Souls III*, in which Yuria of Londor guides a Lord of Hollows to seize the flame for the kingdom of the Hollow, is the same logic institutionalized: the remainder enthroned by way of the husks.

Modern fiction has repeatedly revived the Gnostic suspicion that the narratives of salvation are instruments of the order they claim to overcome. Philip Pullman's *His Dark Materials* (1995–2000) makes its God, the Authority, the first angel to condense from conscious Dust, who falsely told those who came after that he had created them. Philip K. Dick's *VALIS* (1981) proclaims that the Empire never ended and that the world is a Black Iron Prison. And in the Wachowskis' *The Matrix Reloaded* (2003), the Architect reveals to Neo that the One is an anomaly the system anticipates, that the prophecy of his coming is a mechanism of control, that his function is to return to the Source so that the system may be reloaded and its human enclave rebuilt from a chosen remnant, and that he is the sixth to have been so used. No cinematic text comes closer to the prophecy of the Chosen Undead, whose function is to return to the Source—the Kiln—so that the cycle may be reloaded, and Chapter Five will read that prophecy accordingly. But each of these fictions preserves an outside: Pullman's Republic of Heaven, Dick's Valis, Neo's refusal. *Dark Souls* preserves none. It borrows from Gnosticism the forgotten spark and the lying archon, from Luria the shattered vessels and the husks, and from Sabbatianism the descent through the remainder; it refuses every soteriology of escape and every soteriology of repair. What remains is the remainder's own destiny, which the following sections trace through its monstrous return in the Abyss and its belated disclosure at the end of the world.

Figure 13 *The shattering of the vessels. The Lurianic sequence beside the central quest of the first game: the same labour of gathering, consummated not as repair but as sacrifice.*

3.6 *Manus and the Abyss: The Monstrous Return*

In *Artorias of the Abyss* (2012), the expansion to the first game, the player is seized by a monstrous dark hand that reaches through a rift in the world and drags them backward in time to Oolacile, a kingdom of sorcerers long since vanished. The hand belongs to Manus, Father of the Abyss, and what it reaches for is a broken pendant the player carries. The lore of the expansion represents Manus as a primeval human whose grave the people of Oolacile, beguiled by the serpent Kaathe, disturbed; awakened, he was consumed by his own overflowing humanity, which ran wild and became the Abyss, and the Abyss spread through Oolacile, transforming its people into shapeless things. Artorias the Abysswalker, one of the four knights of Gwyn, renowned as one who could walk the Abyss, went to halt it and was consumed in turn; in the player's present, his great grey wolf Sif still guards his grave. The player must fight the corrupted Artorias, and then Manus himself in the Chasm of the Abyss. In the present day, the Abyss beneath New Londo cannot be entered at all without the ring of Artorias's covenant: without it, one simply falls into nothing.

Manus is the return of the remainder in the form that suppression gives it. Freud's account of repression ("Die Verdrängung," 1915) established that what is repressed is not abolished but persists in the unconscious, and returns in distorted, displaced, and often monstrous forms; his last book, *Der Mann Moses und die monotheistische Religion* (1939), extended the "return of the repressed" to the history of whole peoples. The pygmy whom the order of fire forgot returns, in Manus, as the father of a darkness that devours a kingdom. Schelling supplies the metaphysical diagnosis. Manus is evil in exactly Schelling's sense: not darkness as such, but the dark ground denied its place and erupting as self-will without measure, the self-will of humanity seizing the centre and expanding until nothing remains outside it. The Abyss is humanity unbound from every relation, the between collapsed into a single overflowing self. Where the preceding section found humanity to be the condition of community, Manus shows what humanity becomes when it is the condition of nothing but itself.

Two further concepts describe the phenomenology of the Abyss. Julia Kristeva's *Pouvoirs de l'horreur* (1980) defined the abject as what the subject must expel in order to constitute itself—the corpse, filth, decay, the formless—and which returns to threaten the borders of identity from which it was cast out. The Abyss is the abject of the Age of Fire: the region in which the borders that disparity drew—between human and monster, self and other, form and formlessness—dissolve, and from which the shapeless creatures of humanity emerge. And Georges Bataille's brief dictionary entry "Informe," published in *Documents* in 1929, proposed that the formless is not an adjective with a meaning but a term that serves to bring things down in the world, to declassify, undoing the categories by which things are kept in their places—adding, provocatively, that to affirm that the universe re-

sembles nothing and is only formless amounts to saying that it is something like a spider or spit. The Abyss is Bataille's *informe*: the declassifying force that undoes the work of the fire. If the First Flame is the event of articulation, the Abyss is its exact inverse, a de-articulation that dissolves the differential system into an undifferentiated dark. That the trilogy's other great figure of formless fecundity, the Witch's daughter Quelaag, has been fused with the body of a spider gives Bataille's provocation an unexpected literalness.

Yet the remainder that returns is not merely destructive. What Manus reaches for across time is a pendant: a memento, a small token of a human past. The Father of the Abyss longs. His monstrous hand gropes through the centuries for the thing he lost, and in doing so drags the player out of the present into the past—as though the remainder, deprived of its place in the order of time, could only disrupt that order. Schelling named the dark ground a yearning, *Sehnsucht*, and placed it in an eternal past from which time must separate itself by decision; Manus is that yearning and that past, reaching into the present to reclaim what was taken. The return of the repressed is, in this light, also a nostalgia in the etymological sense—a pain of return—and the trilogy, which could have made its Abyss a simple principle of evil, insists on giving it the gesture of grief.

The fate of Artorias completes the analysis. Nietzsche's most quoted aphorism might have been written for him: "Wer mit Ungeheuern kämpft, mag zusehn, dass er nicht dabei zum Ungeheuer wird. Und wenn du lange in einen Abgrund blickst, blickt der Abgrund auch in dich hinein" (*Jenseits von Gut und Böse* §146)—whoever fights monsters should see to it that he does not become one; and if you gaze long into an abyss, the abyss also gazes into you. Artorias is the knight who walked the Abyss and became it: the order's champion against its remainder, absorbed by what he fought. The third game extends this into an institution. The Abyss Watchers of Farron, an Undead legion that inherited Artorias's legend and swore to hunt the Abyss wherever it arose, bound to one another by shared blood, are encountered as a boss in which the Watchers fight one another as well as the player—one of their number having been corrupted by the very darkness they guard against. René Girard described the culmination of the sacrificial crisis as the emergence of monstrous doubles, antagonists who in their rivalry become indistinguishable from one another. The Abyss Watchers are Girard's monstrous doubles: guardians against the remainder, turned upon themselves, each unable to tell whether the brother before him is the enemy.

The second game, finally, disperses the remainder into history. Nashandra, queen of Drangleic, and her sisters are fragments of Manus, shards of the Abyss given human form, and their mode of return is not monstrous but intimate. Nashandra attaches herself to the king Vendrick as his consort and, after his decline, draws the player toward the Throne of Want, the seat of the fire's succession in Drangleic. The remainder that is denied a centre seeks one through marriage and desire, entering the order of fire not as an invader

from below but as its queen. Across the trilogy, then, the returns of the remainder grow progressively more intimate: as a monster from the past (Manus), as a consort at the heart of the kingdom (Nashandra), as a corruption within the order's own guardians (the Abyss Watchers). In each case the order that excluded the remainder is undone from within. And in each case the lesson is the same. The remainder, suppressed, returns without measure; enthroned, it rules without measure. What it lacks, in the Abyss as in the Age of Fire, is measure itself—the subject of the third axiom, and of the ethics this thesis will propose.

3.7 *The Ringed City: Disclosure at the End of the World*

The Ringed City (2017), the final expansion of *Dark Souls III* and the last chapter of the trilogy, begins in the Dreg Heap: the ruins of the kingdoms of every age, piled together at the end of the world as the fire fails. From this heap the player descends to the Ringed City itself—a city that the lore of the expansion suggests was set apart for the pygmies by the gods, enclosed at the world's edge, and sealed, it seems, by the slumber of Gwyn's youngest daughter, Filianore, whose sleep sustains the illusion of the city's prime. When the player touches the egg-like shell that Filianore cradles, it breaks. Time lurches forward; the illusion falls away; the player stands in a desert of ash beneath a darkened sky, at the end of the world. There waits the Slave Knight Gael—an Undead of the order of slave knights whom the gods used as fodder in their wars—who has crossed the ages in search of the Dark Soul, to supply its blood as pigment for a painter he serves. He has found the Pygmy Lords and devoured their Dark Soul, and has been swollen and maddened by what he consumed. The player kills him and carries the blood of the Dark Soul back to the Painter.

The first meaning of the disclosure is enclosure. The Japanese names make explicit what the English obscures: the Ringed City is 輪の都, the city of the ring, and the Darksign is ダークリング, the Dark Ring. The mark that brands each human being and the walls that enclose the progenitors of humanity are one sign. Rousseau's first proprietor enclosed a plot of ground; the order of fire encloses the origin itself. Giorgio Agamben, in *Homo Sacer* (1995), argued that the camp—the space in which the exception becomes the rule, where life is held outside the law and wholly within the reach of power—is the hidden paradigm of modern political space, its *nomos*. The Ringed City is a gilded version of that space: a city rather than a prison, beautiful and ordered, and yet set outside the world at the world's end and sustained by an illusion maintained in a god's sleep. Its inhabitants live, quite literally, in a dream of their own prime. The *Timaeus* said that the χώρα is seen as in a dream; the trilogy houses the remainder in one.

The second meaning lies in the egg. Cosmogonies across the world begin with the breaking of an egg. The Orphic theogonies told of the cosmic egg from which Phanes, the first-born, emerged; the *Ṛgveda* (10.121) of the golden embryo, Hiraṇyagarbha; Chinese

tradition of Pangu, who grew within a cosmic egg until he split it into heaven and earth; the first rune of the *Kalevala* of the eggs that fell from the knee of the sky-maiden and broke, their fragments becoming earth and sky, sun and moon. In each, the broken egg is the beginning of the world. In the Ringed City, the breaking of the egg reveals the world's end. The trilogy's final egg hatches not a cosmos but an eschaton, and in doing so it closes the inversion of cosmogony that Chapter Two traced from the prologue onward: the anarchic beginning that no maker authorized ends in an apocalypse that no saviour averts.

The third meaning lies in the identity of the one who reaches the remainder first. Gael is a slave knight: in the hierarchy produced by Heraclitus's Polemos, which shows some as gods and makes some slaves, he occupies the lowest rank, an Undead whose life the gods spent freely. It is this slave who inherits the Dark Soul, by consuming it. Hegel's dialectic of lordship and bondage returns at the end of the world: the bondsman, whose labour the lord required, outlasts the lord and takes into himself what the lord could not hold. But Gael does not consume the Dark Soul in order to rule. He seeks it for another—for the Painter, whom he calls his lady—and he has crossed the ages so that a new world may be painted with it. Kaathe had proposed that the remainder become the Fourth Lord. Gael, the slave, proposes something else: that the remainder become pigment. Chapter Seven will argue that this is the trilogy's final word on the remainder, and that it is the decisive alternative to every politics of sovereignty the trilogy has examined.

Two further figures in the expansion complete the structure. Darkeater Midir is a dragon whom the gods raised and charged with eternal battle against the dark; by the time the player meets him, he has been corrupted by the darkness he was made to devour. The defeated principle of the Age of Ancients—the dragon, the being of the beginning—was conscripted into the order of fire's war against the remainder, and lost. Like Artorias, like the Abyss Watchers, Midir shows that every instrument the order forges against its remainder is finally absorbed by it. And the guardian of the Ringed City's church, Halflight, Spear of the Church, is, by the design of the encounter, potentially another living player: one who has sworn to the covenant of the Spear of the Church and is summoned into the first player's world to defend the gods' seal. The final guardian of the enclosure of humanity's origin may thus be a human being—a bearer of the Dark Soul, guarding the confinement of the Dark Soul. The trilogy closes its circle through the systems of play rather than through narrative: in the last city, humanity guards the prison of humanity.

The timing of the disclosure, finally, is itself philosophically significant. The trilogy reveals the progenitors of humanity only at the end of the world, as Hegel said philosophy comprehends a form of life only at its close. "Wenn die Philosophie ihr Grau in Grau malt," he wrote in the preface to the *Grundlinien der Philosophie des Rechts* (1820), "dann ist eine Gestalt des Lebens alt geworden, und mit Grau in Grau läßt sie sich nicht verjüngen, sondern nur erkennen; die Eule der Minerva beginnt erst mit der einbrechenden Dämmerung

ihren Flug." When philosophy paints its grey in grey, a shape of life has grown old, and by grey in grey it cannot be rejuvenated, only known; the owl of Minerva begins its flight only with the falling of dusk. The remainder is known only at dusk, in a grey desert of ash that recalls the grey crags of the Age of Ancients. But the trilogy does not end with knowing. It ends with a painter—and with the wager, against Hegel, that grey in grey may after all be made to yield a new world. That wager is the subject of Chapter Seven.

3.8 The Fourth Lord: Toward the Axiom of the Remainder

The remainder has now been followed through five successive modes. It appears first as a *forgotten origin*: the furtive pygmy, named and dismissed in a single clause of the prologue. It persists as *substance and fuel*: humanity, the condition of form and of community, burned in the bonfires of the Age of Fire and stored in the bodies of the Fire Keepers. It *returns without measure* when suppressed: in Manus and the Abyss, in the queens of Drangleic, in the Abyss Watchers turned against one another. It is *enclosed and belatedly disclosed*: walled into the Ringed City at the end of the world, revealed only at dusk, already consumed. And it is finally offered a *transformation*: carried by a slave across the ash of the world's end, to become the pigment of a new painting. These five modes permit the Axiom of the Remainder, stated provisionally in Chapter One, to be given its final form.

Every order of fire—every regime of distinction, value, and sovereignty—is constituted by a remainder which, first, precedes it as its unacknowledged origin; second, sustains it as the fuel it consumes; third, is excluded from its account and enclosed at its margins; fourth, returns without measure when it is suppressed; and fifth, cannot be redeemed by integration into the order as one more sovereign, but only by transformation into the material of a new making. The first four clauses are descriptive, and each has been established in this chapter on textual, systemic, and comparative grounds. The fifth is the trilogy's wager.

The fifth clause requires defence, for it rejects the most attractive solution the trilogy itself proposes: Kaathe's call to make the remainder the Fourth Lord. In Jungian terms, the call is a call to wholeness, the completion of the quaternity by the integration of the shadow, and it has a genuine nobility. But the trilogy subjects it to a long and disenchanting test. In Schelling's terms, the Dark Lord is the ground set in the place of existence, the remainder made centre—evil not because it is dark, but because it is sovereign. The Usurpation of Fire in *Dark Souls III* realizes Kaathe's programme by other means, as a Lord of Hollows seizes the flame on behalf of the remainder; and what the ending shows is not the abolition of the order of fire but its continuation in another hand. The remainder made Lord is still a fire, still a throne, still a ring. The deeper difficulty lies in the very logic of the count. To restore the fourth to the tally of Lords is to submit it to the operation that excluded it:

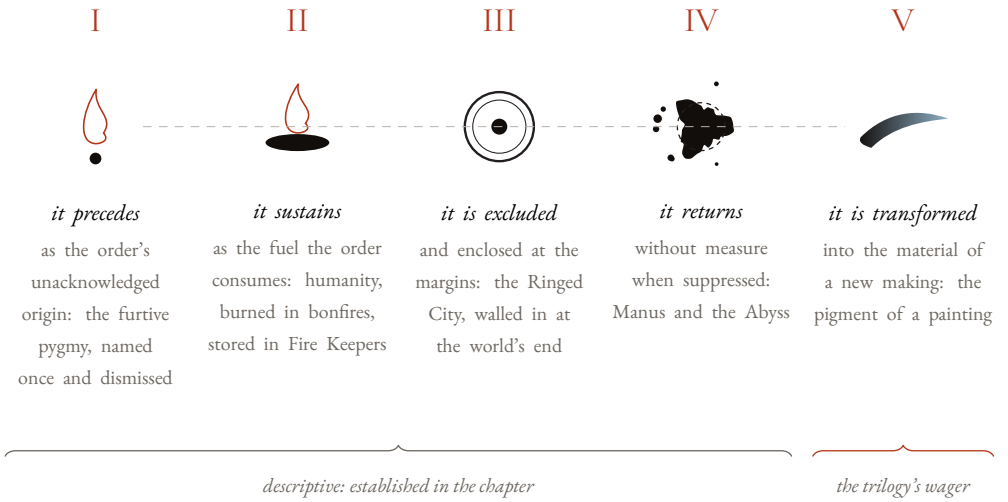


Figure 14 *The Axiom of the Remainder in its final form: five clauses, of which the first four are descriptive and the fifth is the trilogy's wager.*

the measuring, ranking, and enthroning by which disparity became inequality in the first place. The missing fourth cannot be redeemed by being counted. It can only be redeemed by an operation that does not count—by what Giorgio Agamben, in *La comunità che viene* (1990), called the community of whatever singularities, bound together by no condition of belonging but belonging itself. Chapter Six will argue that the asynchronous community of the trilogy's players, who know nothing of one another but their traces, is such a community.

The title of the trilogy, in this light, carries a final significance. The prologue speaks of a single Dark Soul, found by a single forgotten Lord. The title speaks of dark souls in the plural. Between the singular and the plural lies the whole history this chapter has traced: the dispersal of the one remainder into the many bearers of humanity, each marked, each confined, each liable to go Hollow, each capable of summoning another across the interval of worlds. The title names the remainder not at its origin but in its multiplicity—and, as Chapter Seven will argue, in its final form, as the community of those who play, whose expended lives are the pigment of the world they share.

What the order of fire does to the bearers of its remainder is the subject of the next chapter. Before the remainder can become pigment, it must be lived as a curse: branded with the Darksign, rounded up and confined, condemned to die and return until it forgets

why it returns. Chapter Four turns from the metaphysics of the remainder to its biopolitics.

Chapter Four

Branded Life

The Darksign, Hollowing, and the Biopolitics of Undeath

Her skin was as white as leprosy,
The Night-mare LIFE-IN-DEATH was she,
Who thicks man's blood with cold.

— *Coleridge,* The Rime of the Ancient Mariner *(1817 text)*

Mein Todeskahn verfehlte die Fahrt.

"My death-boat missed its course."

— *Kafka, "Der Jäger Gracchus" (1917)*

4.1 The Darksign: Stigma, the Mark of Cain, the Brand of Sacrifice

The prologue of the first game ends with a sign. Among the living, it says, are seen the bearers of the accursed Darksign; and the voice that follows the cinematic tells the player that the Darksign brands the Undead, and that in this land the Undead are corralled and led to the north, to be locked away until the end of the world. The Darksign also exists in the game as an item, and its description condenses the curse into three clauses: the sign marks an accursed Undead; those who bear it are reborn after death, but will at length lose their minds and go Hollow; and it may be used to return to the bonfire last rested at, at the cost of every soul and every scrap of humanity the bearer holds. The Darksign is therefore three things at once. It is a mark upon the body, a visible sign. It is a curse with a temporal structure—revival, and then, eventually, dissolution. And it is an instrument of return: the sign that condemns is also the vehicle that carries the bearer home to the hearth, at the price of everything they carry. The brand of the accursed doubles as the means of their homecoming.

The Greek word *stigma* (στίγμα, from στίζω, to prick or tattoo) designated in the ancient Mediterranean the mark pricked or burned into the skin of slaves, criminals, and deserters, so that their condition could be read upon their bodies. Christianity inverted the sign. Paul writes to the Galatians that he bears in his body the marks (τὰ στίγματα) of Jesus (6:17), and the stigmata of Francis of Assisi in 1224 made the wound of degradation a sign of election. The Darksign carries both valences. It is the brand of the accursed, and it is the mark of the chosen: the prophecy that summons the player addresses its bearers alone, and the Chosen Undead is chosen precisely as one who bears the curse. Erving Goffman's *Stigma: Notes on the Management of Spoiled Identity* (1963) distinguished three kinds of stigma—abominations of the body, blemishes of individual character, and the tribal stigma of lineage, nation, or faith—and two conditions of the stigmatized: the *discreditable*, whose stigma can be concealed, and the *discredited*, whose stigma is evident. The Darksign unites all three kinds, for it is a bodily mark, read as moral corruption, transmitted as the condition of an entire people, humanity itself. And the game's alternation between human and Hollow form stages Goffman's two conditions precisely. In human form the Undead is discreditable, passing for what it once was; Hollowed, it is discredited, the stigma having become the whole of the body.

The oldest Western myth of a protective curse supplies the Darksign's deepest structure. After the murder of Abel, Cain is condemned to be a fugitive and a wanderer on the earth, and when he protests that whoever finds him will kill him, God sets a mark upon him, "lest any finding him should kill him" (Genesis 4:15). The mark of Cain is not a sentence of death but its prevention, and the form of the punishment is wandering. The Darksign repeats this double structure exactly: it prevents death from completing itself,

and it condemns its bearer to an endless pilgrimage. But the comparison also discloses a decisive difference. Cain bears the mark of his own crime. The Undead bear the mark of a fault that is not theirs. Nietzsche, in his unfinished *Die Philosophie im tragischen Zeitalter der Griechen* (1873), read Anaximander's fragment as the first expression of pessimism in Western thought: individuated existence itself is conceived as a guilt, an injustice committed against the boundless, which must be expiated by perishing. The Darksign is the brand of Anaximandrian guilt—the guilt not of a deed but of existing as a separate being in a cosmos whose fire is failing.

The genetic source of the Darksign, as Chapter One noted, is the Brand of Sacrifice in Kentaro Miura's *Berserk*. During the Eclipse, the charismatic commander Griffith offers his own band of mercenaries as a sacrifice to the God Hand in exchange for transcendence, and the victims are branded before they are devoured. Guts and Casca survive, but they bear the Brand thereafter: it bleeds when evil is near, and each night it draws the creatures of the dark to hunt them. The branded of *Berserk* are those who survived their own sacrifice, marked as belonging to a consummation that did not take place. The Darksign carries this meaning into the Dark Souls cosmos. Its bearers are those destined for the fire who have not yet burned: sacrifices-in-waiting, whose curse is the interval between their marking and their consumption. The full sense of the brand becomes legible only in the light of the linking of the fire, which Chapter Five will examine; it is the mark of the victim, worn in advance.

European literature knows a whole lineage of figures for whom deathlessness is a punishment and wandering its form. Coleridge's Ancient Mariner is won at dice by the spectre Life-in-Death, white as leprosy, while Death takes his shipmates; he must live, alone on a wide sea, and afterward pass like night from land to land, compelled by recurring agony to tell his tale to strangers he will never see again. Charles Maturin's *Melmoth the Wanderer* (1820) follows a scholar who bargained for an unnatural span of life and seeks, across a century and a half, someone desperate enough to take his bargain from him. Wagner's *Der fliegende Holländer* (1843) condemns its captain to sail the seas until he is redeemed by the faithful love of a woman, whose self-sacrifice finally releases him. Each of these figures prefigures an element of the Undead condition: the Mariner its compulsive storytelling, Melmoth its bargain with time, the Dutchman its dependence on a woman who gives herself to end the curse—a dependence the Fire Keepers of the trilogy will reproduce.

The Darksign's final significance is cosmological. Chapter Two showed that its form—a burning ring around a darkened centre—is that of Anaximander's sun in eclipse. The curse is thus the inscription of a cosmic condition upon individual bodies: the fading of the fire, written in the flesh of those who suffer it. The Hermetic maxim of the *Tabula Smaragdina*, *quod est inferius est sicut quod est superius*, that which is below is as that which is above, here acquires a sinister sense. The microcosm reproduces the macrocosm, and what the cosmos suffers in its sun the human being suffers in its body. The Darksign is a cosmological stigma:

the mark by which the eclipse of the world becomes the condition of a people.

4.2 *The Asylum: Leprosy, the Great Confinement, and the Exclusion of the Undead*

The first game begins in confinement. The player awakens in a cell of the Northern Undead Asylum; a knight, Oscar of Astora, drops a corpse bearing a key through a breach in the ceiling; the player escapes, evades the Asylum Demon, and finds Oscar again, dying, who entrusts them with an Estus Flask and with the prophecy: that the Chosen Undead shall leave the Asylum, make pilgrimage to the land of the ancient Lords, and ring the Bells of Awakening. A giant crow then carries the player from the Asylum to Lordran. The first act of the order of fire toward its Undead is confinement, and the first exit from confinement is a prophecy. The two belong to a single apparatus. The Asylum holds the Undead outside the world; the prophecy summons one of them back into it, for a purpose that will prove to be the fire. Camp and mission are two faces of the same management of a stigmatized population.

Michel Foucault's *Histoire de la folie à l'âge classique* (1961) opens not with madness but with leprosy. At the end of the Middle Ages, Foucault observes, leprosy withdrew from the Western world, leaving behind it the empty leprosaria at the edges of the towns—and, more durable than the buildings, the formulas of exclusion that had sustained them. Two or three centuries later, the poor, the vagabond, the criminal, and the deranged would take up the leper's place in those formulas. The leper's exclusion had been at once social banishment and spiritual reintegration: abandoned by the community, he was held to be saved by his abandonment, his exile a form of communion. The classical age replaced the leprosarium with what Foucault called the Great Confinement, inaugurated by the edict of 1656 that founded the Hôpital Général in Paris, which within a few months had interned, by Foucault's account, more than one in every hundred of the city's inhabitants—the mad, the indigent, the idle, the debauched—in a confinement that was not medical but moral and economic. The Undead Asylum is the leprosarium of the Age of Fire. The Undead are rounded up not because they are yet dangerous—most are still lucid when they are taken—but because they are a sign: the visible symptom of the failure of the order that confines them. Confinement is the order's management of its own symptom.

The medieval rites by which lepers were separated from the community make the parallel exact. In some of these rites the leper was declared dead to the world—*sis mortuus mundo, vivens iterum Deo*, "be dead to the world, living again unto God"—and in some places was made to stand in an open grave while earth was cast upon him, before being conducted to the leper-house to live as one socially and legally dead. Medieval and early modern law knew

the category of *mors civilis*, civil death, by which a person who still breathed was nonetheless dead in the eyes of the law: the professed monk, the outlaw, the condemned. Swift gave the category its most grotesque literary form in the struldbrugs of *Gulliver's Travels* (1726), immortals who, upon reaching the age of eighty, are, in Gulliver's report, looked on as dead in law. The Undead of *Dark Souls* live in a state of civil death. They revive, but they are dead to the order: stripped of place, of property, of standing, and of any future but the north.

Foucault returned to leprosy in *Surveiller et punir* (1975), where he contrasted two models of power. The leper gave rise to rituals of exclusion: a binary division between the pure and the impure, the healthy and the contaminated, enforced by banishment. The plague gave rise to a different model: the quarantined town divided into a grid of districts, each watched, each house inspected, each inhabitant registered, the whole population held within an apparatus of surveillance and record. Where the leper was cast out, the plague-stricken were held in place and made visible. The Age of Fire employs both models. The Asylum and the herding of the Undead northward follow the model of the leper; the covenants, the registries of sin kept by the agents of Gwyndolin, and the elaborate systems by which the movements and allegiances of the Undead are tracked follow the model of the plague, as section 4.6 will show. The trilogy's order of fire has learned both of the techniques by which European societies managed their contaminated, and applies them in succession: first exclusion, then supervision.

The figure of the confined Undead acquires a sharper edge in the light of Japanese history, and responsible reading requires that it be named. From a law of 1907, through its intensification in 1931, and under the Leprosy Prevention Law of 1953 until that law's repeal in 1996, Japan pursued a policy of compulsory segregation of people with Hansen's disease, who were confined for life in national sanatoria, the first of which, Nagashima Aiseien, opened in 1930 on an island in the Seto Inland Sea. In 2001 the Kumamoto District Court found the policy unconstitutional, and the government apologized to its survivors. I invoke this history not to equate its victims with the creatures of a fiction—an equation that would repeat the very stigmatization it should condemn—but because the trilogy's critique of confinement, its depiction of a population exiled to the margins not for anything it has done but for what it is taken to signify, is a critique whose real objects existed within living memory in the society that produced the game. The Asylum is not an invention of fantasy. It is one of the oldest institutions of the order of light.

The Asylum also returns. Later in the first game, the player may go back to it, and there find Oscar, the knight who gave the prophecy, risen as a Hollow and hostile, unless the player put an end to him before. The prophet of escape is consumed, in the place of confinement, by the very condition from which his prophecy promised release. And across the trilogy, the openings form a revealing sequence. The first game begins in an asylum.

The second begins in a region called Things Betwixt, a liminal margin of the world, where three ancient women laugh at the newly arrived Undead. The third begins in a cemetery, where the Unkindled—those who once failed to link the fire, "ash without fire"—rise from their graves when the bell tolls. Confinement, liminality, burial: the order of fire, over three games, ceases to confine its remainder and begins instead to bury it, raising it again only when it has need of fuel.

4.3 *Hollowing: Care, Despair, and the Loss of Purpose*

Hollowing is implemented differently in each game of the trilogy, and the differences constitute a progressive phenomenology. In the first game, an Undead in human form who dies returns as a Hollow, desiccated and grey, and must offer humanity at a bonfire to recover the human face. In the second, each death diminishes the player's maximum health, so that the body literally dwindles in vitality with every return until a Human Effigy restores it; the game's opening warns that the cursed will lose their memories, and at last themselves. In the third, Hollowing becomes a concealed accumulation, a sigil that deepens with each death, cultivated by the emissaries of Londor, who offer to draw out the player's "true strength" and in doing so draw them further into the curse. Diegetically, the Hollow is the end-state of the Undead: a being that has lost its mind and its self, like the shambling soldiers of the Undead Burg who attack whoever passes. The characters of the trilogy, and the consensus of its interpreters, associate this end with the loss of purpose and memory. The Undead who no longer has a reason to continue goes Hollow.

The trilogy's characters furnish a casebook. The Crestfallen Warrior, who sits at Firelink Shrine mocking the player's hopes, later wanders down to New Londo and is found there Hollowed: despair completes itself. Big Hat Logan, the greatest sorcerer of his age, follows Seath's researches into the Duke's Archives and loses his mind among the crystals: obsession consumes its subject. Solaire of Astora, the cheerful knight who seeks to find his own sun, may reach Lost Izalith and there discover the Sunlight Maggot, a parasite whose glow he mistakes for the sun he sought, and go mad—unless the player destroys the creature first. And Lucatiel of Mirrah, in the second game, frightened that she is forgetting herself, asks the player to remember her name, and fades from the world. Despair, obsession, a false anchor, the slow erosion of memory: these are the roads to Hollowing, and every one of them is a failure of purpose.

Heidegger's analysis of human existence in *Sein und Zeit* (1927) supplies the most precise vocabulary for what is lost. Dasein, the being that each of us is, is distinguished by the fact that its own being is at issue for it; and the being of Dasein is care (*Sorge*), the structure by which it is always already ahead of itself, thrown into a world, and absorbed among things (§§39–44). Dasein tends, in its everydayness, to fall (*Verfallen*) into the

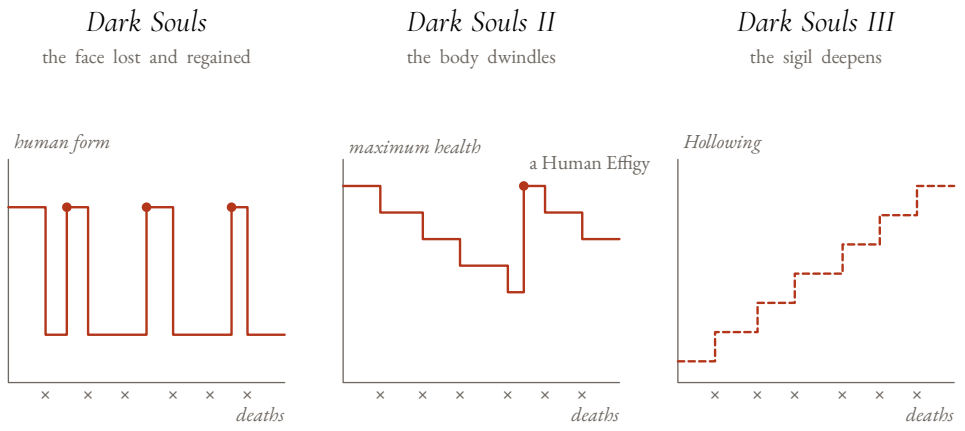


Figure 15 *Three phenomenologies of Hollowing: the human face lost and regained in the first game, the body that dwindles with every death in the second, the concealed sigil that deepens in the third.*

anonymity of *das Man*, the "they" of idle talk and average understanding (§§27, 38), and it is wrested from this fall only by its relation to death. Death, for Heidegger, is Dasein's ownmost, non-relational, certain, and unsurpassable possibility—*eigenste, unbezügliche, unüberholbare*—and the anticipation of death (*Vorlaufen*) individualizes Dasein and frees it for authentic existence (§§46–53). The Undead curse abolishes precisely what makes this authenticity possible. Death ceases to be ownmost, for it is endlessly repeatable; it ceases to be non-relational, for others die and return alongside; it ceases to be unsurpassable, for it is surpassed at every bonfire. The curse deprives Dasein of its finitude, and with its finitude of its access to itself. Hollowing is the completion of this deprivation. The Hollow is a being for which its own being is no longer at issue: care extinguished, existence reduced to the persistence of a body that no longer concerns itself with anything. The Hollows of the Undead Burg—interchangeable, faceless, endlessly repeating the same gestures of hostility—are *das Man* incarnate.

Kierkegaard had anticipated the structure eight decades earlier. In *Sygdommen til Døden* (1849), published under the pseudonym Anti-Climacus, he defined the self as a relation that relates itself to itself, and despair as a misrelation within that relation. Despair is the sickness unto death not because it kills but because it does not: its torment is precisely the inability to die, a perpetual dying of death. Kierkegaard distinguished the despair of not willing to be oneself, the defiant despair of willing to be oneself on one's own terms, and, beneath both, the despair that is not even conscious of having a self, which he called spiritlessness. The Undead live Kierkegaard's sickness unto death with terrible literalness,

and their characters distribute themselves among his forms: the Crestfallen Warrior, who will not be the self his hopes once demanded; Logan, who would be himself absolutely, through knowledge, and is consumed by the attempt; and the Hollow, who has passed beyond despair into spiritlessness, no longer relating to itself at all.

Nietzsche put the matter in a maxim that has become proverbial: "Hat man sein warum? des Lebens, so verträgt man sich fast mit jedem wie?" (*Götzen-Dämmerung*, "Sprüche und Pfeile" 12)—if one has one's *why* of life, one can bear almost any *how*. Viktor Frankl made the maxim a motto of logotherapy, the psychotherapy he founded on the premise that the will to meaning is the deepest motive of human life and that its frustration can be lethal. The Undead are given an unbearable *how*: endless death and return in a world that is ending. They can bear it only with a *why*. Hollowing is the loss of the *why*.

The Norwegian philosopher Peter Wessel Zapffe, in his essay "Den sidste Messias" (1933), offered a darker account of how human beings preserve their purpose. Human consciousness, he argued, has developed beyond what life can bear, like the colossal antlers of the extinct giant deer that, by some accounts, doomed the species; to survive the clarity of their own condition, human beings damp their consciousness by four mechanisms. *Isolation* dismisses from awareness every disturbing thought. *Anchoring* fixes the self to points of value—God, the church, the state, morality, fate, the future. *Distraction* limits attention by a constant stream of fresh impressions. *Sublimation* transforms suffering into art or contemplation. The characters of *Dark Souls* constitute a catalogue of Zapffe's mechanisms deployed against Hollowing. Solaire anchors himself to the sun; the clerics of the Way of White to their faith; Siegmeyer of Catarina to the chivalric adventure; Lucatiel to her own name. The merchants and tricksters of the trilogy, Patches above all, live by distraction. The Crestfallen Warrior practises isolation, refusing hope in advance so that it cannot fail him. And the smiths at their forges, the Painter at her canvas, and the player at play practise sublimation. Zapffe's grimmest insight is that anchors fail, and the trilogy confirms it: Solaire's sun becomes a maggot. Zapffe drew from the failure of the mechanisms an antinatalist conclusion—his last messiah tells humanity to die out—and one could read the Age of Dark as a Zapffean ending, the extinction of an overgrown consciousness. But the trilogy, as later chapters show, chooses the fourth mechanism. Its final figure is not an extinction but a painter.

Hollowing, then, is not death. It is the extinction of care: the death of the relation to oneself and, as section 4.7 will show, of the relation to others. And the operative structure of the game adds a last, decisive turn. Within the systems of the first game, the player-character cannot go Hollow in the diegetic sense—cannot lose the self and become one of the shambling things of the Burg—no matter how many times it dies. However often the character falls, it returns, and the player resumes. There is only one way in which the player's Undead truly Hollows: when the player stops playing. The condition that

Isolation

every disturbing thought dismissed from awareness

the Crestfallen Warrior, refusing hope in advance so that it cannot fail him

Anchoring

the self fixed to points of value

Solaire to the sun; the Way of White to faith; Siegmeyer to the chivalric adventure; Lucatiel to her own name

anchors fail: Solaire's sun becomes a maggot

Peter Wessel Zapffe, "Den sidste Messias" (1933)

Distraction

attention limited by a stream of fresh impressions

the merchants and tricksters of the trilogy, Patches above all

Sublimation

suffering transformed into art or contemplation

the smiths at their forges, the Painter at her canvas, the player at play

Figure 16 *Zapffe's four mechanisms for damping consciousness, and the characters of the trilogy who deploy them against Hollowing.*

the fiction attributes to loss of purpose is, in the operative register, nothing other than the player's abandonment of the game. The curse and its cure are thereby relocated from the character to the person at the controls. What keeps the Undead from Hollowing is not a property of the character but a practice of the player—and this practice, measured, repeated, and knowingly futile, is the Axiom of Measure in its most concrete form.

4.4 *Life-in-Death: Comparative Undeaths from Dante to Le Guin*

The undeath of *Dark Souls* belongs to a long literary inquiry into what deathlessness does to meaning, and that inquiry has reached, across seven centuries and several languages, a remarkably consistent conclusion: the removal of death does not enrich life but drains it. The trilogy's Hollows are the heirs of this tradition, and setting them beside their ancestors sharpens what is distinctive in them.

In the vestibule of Dante's Hell, before the river Acheron, run the souls of those who lived without infamy and without praise, rejected by Heaven lest they mar its beauty and refused by deep Hell lest the damned take glory from them. Virgil's verdict on them is among the most terrible lines in the *Inferno*: "Questi non hanno speranza di morte, / e la

lor cieca vita è tanto bassa, / che 'nvidïosi son d'ogne altra sorte" (III.46–48)—these have no hope of death, and their blind life is so abject that they envy every other lot. They run without end behind a whirling banner that seems disdainful of any rest (III.52–54), stung by wasps and hornets, their blood and tears gathered by loathsome worms at their feet. The Hollows of Lordran are Dante's neutrals. They have no hope of death; their life is blind; they move without destination in endless, restless pursuit. The difference is instructive. Dante's neutrals are those who never chose. The Hollows are those who have ceased to choose.

Kafka's fragment "Der Jäger Gracchus" (written 1917, published 1931) gives undeath its most enigmatic modern form. Gracchus, a hunter of the Black Forest, fell to his death pursuing a chamois; but his death-boat missed its course—a wrong turn of the tiller, a moment's inattention of the boatman, he does not know what—so that he remained upon the earth, lying in a boat that sails the earthly waters forever. He describes himself as perpetually upon the great stair that leads upward, sometimes above, sometimes below, sometimes to the right, sometimes to the left, always in motion; no one will help him; and he ends his account with a sentence of absolute minimalism: "Ich bin hier, mehr weiß ich nicht, mehr kann ich nicht tun"—I am here; more than that I do not know; more than that I cannot do. Gracchus is undead by accident, by an error in the passage between life and death, which is exactly the condition of the Undead whose deaths have been misrouted by the prolongation of the fire. And the great stair on which he wanders, up and down without arriving, is the vertical cosmos of Lordran seen from inside: Heraclitus's way up and way down, travelled endlessly by one who has lost the destination of both.

Jorge Luis Borges's "El inmortal" (1947) carries the inquiry to its philosophical extreme. The Roman tribune Marcus Flaminius Rufus seeks the City of the Immortals, drinks from the river that confers deathlessness, and discovers that the mute, filthy troglodytes who live near the city are the Immortals themselves—among them Homer, who has nearly forgotten his poem. The City they built is a labyrinth of senseless architecture, of corridors without exit and stairways that lead nowhere, which they abandoned. Over infinite time, the Immortals have understood that every possible thing must happen to every one of them, that no act can be performed only once, that every deed is the echo of others before it; and so they have ceased to act, sunk in indifference. Death, Rufus comes to see, is what makes human beings precious; among the Immortals nothing is irrevocable, and so nothing matters. He spends centuries searching for the river that will take his immortality away, and when at last he drinks from it and a thorn draws blood from his hand, he rejoices. The Hollow is Borges's Immortal: indifference born of the endless availability of return. And the City of the Immortals, with its stairs to nowhere, is among the closest literary analogues to the impossible architectures of the trilogy, through which the Undead wander as Rufus wandered through his labyrinth.

Jonathan Swift's struldbrugs, encountered by Gulliver in Luggnagg (*Gulliver's Travels*, 1726, III.10), supply the satirical counterpart. Gulliver, told of the immortals, imagines the wisdom and wealth he would accumulate in their place; he learns instead that they are immortal without being exempt from age. Past eighty they are looked on as dead in law, their estates passing to their heirs; they grow peevish, covetous, and morose; their memory fails; and because the language of the country is always in flux, after two centuries they can no longer converse with the mortals around them, living as strangers in their own land. The struldbrugs anticipate the second game's implementation of Hollowing as cumulative diminishment, and the trilogy's association of Hollowing with the loss of memory and speech. The Hollows of *Dark Souls* do not talk.

Tennyson's dramatic monologue "Tithonus" (1860) gives undeath its most elegiac voice. The goddess of the dawn obtained immortality for her mortal lover but forgot to ask for eternal youth, so that he withers through endless age at the quiet limit of the world, beside a dawn that renews itself every morning. The poem opens on the decay of all things that may die—"The woods decay, the woods decay and fall"—and turns at once to the one exception: "Me only cruel immortality / Consumes." Tithonus begs at last to be released and restored to the ground, so that the dawn may see his grave. The monologue is an uncanny anticipation of the Lords of Cinder: beings consumed by a cruel immortality at the limit of the world, beside a fire that is renewed while its fuel decays. The player who finally kills Gwyn in the Kiln of the First Flame, a hollow husk still moving through the forms of combat, grants him Tithonus's plea.

Ursula K. Le Guin's *The Farthest Shore* (1972) supplies the most exact structural analogue to the trilogy's cosmology of undeath. The wizard Cob, terrified of death, has opened a door between the living world and the Dry Land of the dead in order to make himself immortal, and through that door the vitality of the world is draining away: wizards forget their spells, craftsmen their crafts, singers their songs; people grow listless and despairing; and in the Dry Land the dead wander in darkness, passing one another without recognition, lovers without a glance. The Archmage Ged and the young prince Arren cross the Dry Land to close the breach, and Ged spends the whole of his power to do it. The refusal of death empties the world of meaning: this is precisely the structure of the Age of Fire, in which Gwyn's refusal of the natural end of his age brings the curse of undeath upon humankind and the progressive loss of purpose, memory, and recognition that the trilogy calls Hollowing. Le Guin had already stated the principle beneath both works in *A Wizard of Earthsea* (1968), where a master of magic teaches that the lighting of every candle is also the casting of a shadow. With fire came disparity.

Finally, the trilogy's Hollows must be distinguished from the most popular undead of the modern imagination. The zombies of George A. Romero's *Night of the Living Dead* (1968) and *Dawn of the Dead* (1978) are a crowd, a figure of the masses of consumer society,

drifting back to the shopping mall out of a residual memory of desire. The Hollow is not a crowd but the end-state of an individual; it is not mindless from the beginning but becomes so, as care is extinguished. Yet Romero's insight that habit outlives purpose applies to the Hollows with full force. The Hollows of the Undead Burg still patrol their walls, still cling to their posts, still raise their swords against intruders, long after any reason for doing so has vanished. In the vocabulary of Chapter One, the Hollow is a habit-body without a subject: Merleau-Ponty's sedimented capacity for the world persisting after the one for whom the world mattered has gone. Across Dante, Kafka, Borges, Swift, Tennyson, Le Guin, and Romero, the verdict is the same: deathlessness does not preserve life but empties it. *Dark Souls* gathers that verdict into a single figure and makes it the destiny that every player must perpetually defer.

4.5 *Between Two Deaths: The Bloodstain and the Ludic Re-Finitization of Existence*

The curse of undeath raises a problem for the game that embodies it. If death is not final, why does anything in *Dark Souls* matter? The game is renowned for the intensity of its stakes, yet its premise abolishes the only stake that ordinarily gives combat its gravity. The answer lies in a mechanism already described in Chapter One, whose philosophical significance can now be stated. When the player dies, the souls and humanity they held remain at the place of death as a bloodstain; if the player returns to it without dying again, they recover what they lost; if they die a second time before reaching it, what they carried is gone for good. The game thereby installs two deaths. The first, the death of the body, is revocable. The second, the death of what the body carried, is not. The stakes of *Dark Souls* are not life but the accumulated substance of a life.

Jacques Lacan, in the seminar on the ethics of psychoanalysis (1959–60), gave the name *l'entre-deux-morts*, the zone between two deaths, to the position of Antigone, condemned by Creon to be walled up alive: a figure in whom symbolic death precedes and does not coincide with real death. He drew the notion of a "second death" from Sade, whose Pope Pius VI, in *Juliette*, dreams of a crime that would destroy not only bodies but the very cycle by which nature regenerates them—a death beyond death, freeing nature to create anew. Slavoj Žižek, in *The Sublime Object of Ideology* (1989) and *Looking Awry* (1991), showed that the living dead of popular culture—ghosts, vampires, revenants—inhabit precisely this zone, returning because some debt remains unpaid, some symbolic account unsettled. The Undead of *Dark Souls* are a population between two deaths: their first death has already occurred, and their second, the Hollowing that will extinguish the self, awaits. The bloodstain formalizes this structure within the economy of play. It is the remainder of

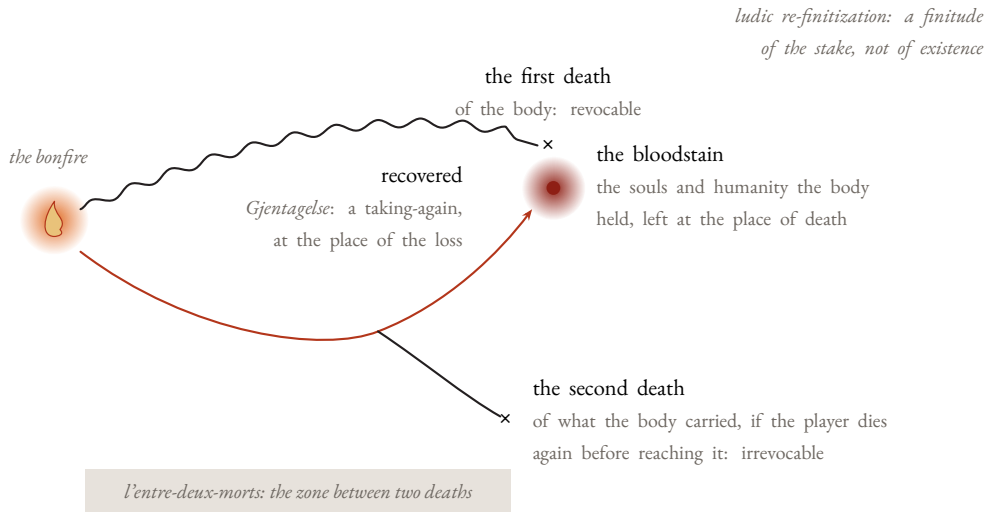


Figure 17 *Between two deaths. The death of the body is revocable; the death of what the body carried is not. The bloodstain reinstates finitude at the level of the stake.*

the first death, waiting either to be recovered or to be annihilated by the second. And the player's return to it is the return of the revenant: every bloodstain is an unpaid debt, and the player is the ghost who comes back to collect it.

The bloodstain also reconstitutes, within a world that has lost it, something like Heidegger's being-toward-death. The curse destroyed the ownmost and unsurpassable character of the first death. But the second death is irrevocable, and the player who carries a great sum of souls through a dangerous region knows a specific dread: the anxiety of the full purse, in which the whole of what one has gathered may be lost to a single misstep. This anxiety individualizes. Every decision—to press on or turn back, to spend now or risk more, to retrieve the stain or abandon it—is taken in the face of irrevocable loss, and is one's own. I call this structure *ludic re-finitization*. The game, having abolished finitude at the level of life, reinstates it at the level of what life gathers, and in doing so constructs a finitude of the stake rather than of existence. It is, I believe, a genuine philosophical innovation, and it is the precise form of finitude appropriate to an age of embers: a world in which the body persists but everything it holds may be lost.

The structure has an economic face that anticipates the argument of the next chapter. Bataille's general economy holds that the excess energy a system cannot use for growth must finally be spent, gloriously or catastrophically. The bloodstain teaches exactly this lesson. Souls hoarded are souls exposed to the second death; souls spent, at the bonfire or the merchant, are converted into capacities that cannot be lost. The player learns, through repeated catastrophe, that accumulation is punished and expenditure preserved:

the surplus left lying on the ground is, quite literally, the accursed share. A player who has internalized this lesson spends in measure, before the second death can take what remains. The Axiom of Measure is learned at the bloodstain.

The Danish word that Kierkegaard chose for repetition clarifies the temporal structure of this learning. *Gjentagelse* means, literally, a taking-again: *gjen-*, again, and *tagelse*, a taking. Kierkegaard opposed it to recollection, which repeats backward what has been, and described genuine repetition as a recollection forward—a return that is also an advance. The player's return to the bloodstain is *Gjentagelse* in its most literal sense: a re-taking of what was lost, at the place where it was lost, by one who has learned something on the way back. The absurdist reading of the trilogy, which assimilates the Undead to Sisyphus, cannot account for this structure, because Sisyphus has nothing to lose. His stone carries no stake, and his return to the foot of the hill retrieves nothing. The Undead player returns to retrieve the substance of a life, and the possibility of losing it for ever is what makes the return matter.

The tradition of meditation on death that Chapter One identified as the ancestor of the game's difficulty describes the attitude the bloodstain cultivates. Epictetus counselled that death and exile and all that seems terrible should be kept daily before one's eyes, above all death, so that one would never entertain a base thought nor desire anything too much (*Enchiridion* 21). The *Hagakure*, the sayings of the samurai Yamamoto Tsunetomo recorded between 1709 and 1716, opens its most famous passage with the declaration that the way of the warrior is found in death (武士道と云ふは死ぬ事と見付けたり), and counsels the warrior to regard himself every morning as already dead, so that he may act freely. The Zen master Shidō Bunan (1603–1676) is credited with a poem that compresses the teaching into five lines: become a dead man while still alive, wholly dead, and then do as you will, and all will be well. The player who has accepted, in advance, the loss of the bloodstain plays in exactly this spirit, as one already dead, and is freed by the acceptance to act well. Here the bloodstain discloses its deepest function. It is not merely a penalty. It is an exercise in the ancient sense, a *meditatio mortis* conducted with the hands, which teaches the player to hold what they have gathered lightly enough to spend it, and to lose it without going Hollow.

4.6 *The Biopolitics of the Curse: The Sacrificeable Homo Sacer*

Giorgio Agamben's *Homo Sacer: Il potere sovrano e la nuda vita* (1995) takes its title from an obscure figure of archaic Roman law, defined by the grammarian Festus: "At homo sacer is est, quem populus iudicavit ob maleficium; neque fas est eum immolari, sed qui occidit, parricidi non damnatur"—the sacred man is one whom the people have judged for a crime; it is not permitted to sacrifice him, but whoever kills him will not be condemned for

homicide. Agamben reads in this definition a double exclusion. The *homo sacer* is excluded from human law, since he may be killed with impunity, and from divine law, since he may not be offered in sacrifice; and this double exclusion produces what Agamben calls bare life (*nuda vita*), life exposed to death without the protection of either order. Bare life, he argues, is the original object of sovereign power, which constitutes itself, as Carl Schmitt had defined it in *Politische Theologie* (1922), by deciding on the exception: "Souverän ist, wer über den Ausnahmezustand entscheidet." The sovereign and the *homo sacer* stand at the two limits of the political order, as symmetrical figures. The sovereign is the one for whom all are potentially *homines sacri*; the *homo sacer* is the one before whom all act as sovereigns.

The Undead of *Dark Souls* are, in most respects, *homines sacri*. They may be killed without crime: the player cuts them down by the hundred, and so does everyone else. They are confined, exiled, stripped of standing, consigned to the civil death described above. And the curse that produces them is a state of exception in the strictest sense: the failure of the Age of Fire suspends the ordinary order and generates a population that stands outside it while remaining wholly exposed to its power. But in one decisive respect the Undead differ from Agamben's figure, and the difference is the trilogy's contribution to political philosophy. The *homo sacer* may be killed but not sacrificed. The Undead may be killed *and* sacrificed. The prophecy singles out one of them as the successor of Gwyn, to be burned in the Kiln of the First Flame; the Lords of Cinder of the third game are those who have already been so burned, raised from their graves to burn again. The Age of Fire produces bare life in order to consume it as sacrificial fuel. I call this figure the *sacrificeable homo sacer*: a life rendered killable without consequence by the order that produces it, so that its one meaningful death may be appropriated by that order as offering. Agamben separated the biopolitical from the sacrificial; the trilogy reunites them. The Age of Fire is a biopolitical sacrificial machine. It manufactures a population, confines it, manages it, empties its deaths of meaning, and then selects one of its members to die a death that the order alone can make meaningful—as fuel.

Michel Foucault's account of biopower supplies the complementary analysis. The ancient right of the sovereign, he argued in the first volume of the *Histoire de la sexualité* (1976) and in the lecture of 17 March 1976 in *Il faut défendre la société*, was the right to take life or let live; modernity supplemented it with a power to make live and let die—a power exercised not over individual subjects but over populations, through the management of their births, health, hygiene, and reproduction. The curse of undeath renders the sovereign's ancient right impotent: one cannot take, once and for all, the life of a being that will not stay dead. The Age of Fire responds as Foucault's modern state responded, by turning from the power of death to the management of life. It confines its Undead in asylums; it organizes them through prophecy and allegiance; it compels them to live; and it

lets them Hollow. The formula of the Age of Fire is a grim variant of Foucault's: make live, and let Hollow.

The covenants of the first game constitute the institutions of this management. The Way of White, the Princess's Guard, the Warriors of Sunlight, the Darkwraiths, the Path of the Dragon, the Gravelord Servants, the Forest Hunters, the Blades of the Darkmoon, and the Chaos Servants are allegiances through which the Undead are organized and, by means of summoning and invasion, set in relation and opposition to one another across worlds. Their functions recapitulate the techniques of power Foucault described. The Blades of the Darkmoon, servants of Gwyndolin, invade the worlds of those inscribed as guilty, executing a justice whose register is associated with Velka, the goddess of sin: the plague model of surveillance and record, applied by a secret police of the gods. The Forest Hunters guard a territory against intruders; the Gravelord Servants send death into the worlds of others; the Darkwraiths drain humanity from their victims. Through the covenants, the violence of the Undead is distributed among themselves. Thomas Hobbes, in the thirteenth chapter of *Leviathan* (1651), described the state of nature as a war of every man against every man, in which the life of man is solitary, poor, nasty, brutish, and short, and argued that only a sovereign could end it. The Undead inhabit Hobbes's state of nature with a single amendment: their life is solitary, poor, nasty, and brutish—and it is not short. The Leviathan who should end the war is absent, burning in the Kiln. The covenants are the fragments of a sovereignty in absentia, each a small Leviathan claiming the allegiance of the Undead in the name of a god who is no longer there.

The third game introduces a counter-biopolitics. Londor, a kingdom of the Hollow, sends its emissaries to the Unkindled: Yoel, who offers to draw out the player's true strength and in doing so deepens their Hollowing, and Yuria, who guides the willing toward the Usurpation of Fire, in which a Lord of Hollows seizes the flame on behalf of the Hollow. Here the bare life that the order produced organizes itself into a rival sovereignty. Agamben warned that a politics which merely inverts the sovereign relation remains imprisoned within it, and Chapter Three found the same verdict in the trilogy's treatment of the Usurpation: the remainder enthroned is still a throne. Agamben's own alternative, developed in *Mezzi senza fine* (1996) and later works, is the notion of a form-of-life (*forma-di-vita*): a life that can never be separated from its form, never isolated as bare life, because it consists in its practice rather than in a status conferred or withdrawn by power. The ethics of the ember, toward which this thesis is moving, is a form-of-life in this sense: not a sovereignty, nor a counter-sovereignty, but a practice, inseparable from the one who lives it, which no prophecy can appropriate and no covenant can register.

The curse, then, is not merely a misfortune that befalls humanity. It is the instrument by which the Age of Fire produces, manages, and consumes its remainder: a stigmatized population, confined at the margins, distributed among allegiances, compelled to live, and

destined, in the person of its chosen member, for the furnace. The next chapter traces the economy that requires this population—the economy of souls, sovereignty, and sacrifice on which the Age of Fire runs. A final section of the present chapter turns to the Japanese vocabulary of the dead, in which the curse acquires its most intimate meaning.

4.7 *Japanese Inflections: Mōja, Gaki, and the Unconnected Dead*

Chapter One noted that the beings the English text calls Hollow are, in Japanese, 亡者 (*mōja*). The word deserves fuller treatment, for it carries the curse into a Buddhist eschatology that the English obscures entirely. In Japanese Buddhism *mōja* designates the deceased, and in particular the dead who wander in the intermediate state between death and rebirth—the *chūu* (中有) of forty-nine days, the bardo of the Tibetan tradition—or who suffer in the hells, awaiting the judgments of the Ten Kings, chief among them Enma, the Yama of the Vedas. The ideal end of the dead is expressed in a phrase that has become the ordinary Japanese euphemism for a peaceful passing: *jōbutsu* (成仏), "becoming a Buddha." The dead who cannot attain *jōbutsu* remain bound to the world by attachment, and they are the restless dead of the Japanese ghost tradition, the same figures whom the Noh dramatizes as ghosts re-enacting the attachment that holds them to a place. The Hollow, read through its Japanese name, is a departed one who has not departed: a being who cannot become a Buddha because the passage has been blocked. The prolongation of the Age of Fire has done to the whole of humanity what the boatman's inattention did to Kafka's Gracchus. It has misrouted death.

Buddhist cosmology distributes beings among six paths of rebirth, the *rokudō* (六道): the heavenly beings, humans, the *asura* or *shura*, animals, the hungry ghosts or *gaki* (餓鬼), and the beings of the hells. The painted scrolls of the late Heian and early Kamakura periods—above all the *Gaki-zōshi*, the Scroll of Hungry Ghosts, and the *Jigoku-zōshi*, the Scroll of Hells, both of the twelfth century—gave these realms their canonical images: the *gaki* with swollen bellies and throats as thin as needles, invisible to the living, haunting graveyards and latrines, devouring what the living discard; the *shura* condemned to endless battle; the hells of fire and ice. The world of *Dark Souls* can be read as a *rokudō-e*, a painting of the six paths collapsed onto a single plane. Anor Londo is the realm of the heavenly beings; the Undead are the human realm; the knights who fight forever at their posts are *shura*; the beasts of Darkroot are the animals; Lost Izalith is a hell of fire. And the Hollows combine the two most wretched realms: they are *gaki* in their hunger for what they have lost, and *shura* in their endless, pointless combat. Miyazaki's later work makes the Buddhist frame explicit. One of the endings of *Sekiro* (2019) is named *Shura*, after the realm of perpetual war, into which its protagonist descends when he abandons his oath.

The most consequential Japanese inflection of the curse, however, lies in a word that links the trilogy to the society in which it was made. In Japanese folk Buddhism, the *muen-botoke* (無縁仏) are the unconnected dead: those who have died with no descendants or kin to perform the rites of memorial for them, and who are believed, uncared for, to wander as hungry ghosts. The word *en* (縁) names in Buddhist doctrine the conditions that connect events, and in ordinary Japanese the bonds that join people to one another; *muen* is the condition of having no bonds at all. Communities have long performed the rite of *segaki* (施餓鬼), the feeding of the hungry ghosts, often during the summer festival of Obon, to make offerings to precisely these unconnected dead. It was from this vocabulary that the NHK documentary of 2010, discussed in Chapter One, drew its terms: it named the solitary deaths of contemporary Japan *muenshi* (無縁死), "unconnected death," and the society that produced them *muen shakai*, the relationless society.

The Hollow is a *muen-botoke*. Its end is not merely the loss of self that Heidegger and Kierkegaard describe, but the loss of *en*, of every bond to every other. And here the anthropology of Chapter Three acquires its full significance. Humanity, *ningensei*, is the nature of the between, and the game's systems make it the condition of connection: the human may summon and be summoned, may meet others across the interval of worlds; the Hollow cannot. Humanity is *en*; Hollowing is *muen*. The curse, in its Japanese inflection, is the progressive severing of the bonds between persons, and its end-state is the solitary, unremembered death of one whom no one will mourn. It is difficult to imagine a figure more precisely calibrated to the anxieties of the society that produced the game.

The same vocabulary discloses the trilogy's answer, which Chapter Six will develop. If the Hollow is a *muen-botoke*, then the acts by which players reach across the interval of worlds—the soapstone message left for whoever comes next, the phantom summoned to aid a stranger and vanishing when the work is done, the warning written beside a trap one will never see sprung on another—are a ludic *segaki*: offerings to the unconnected dead, acts of *en*-making extended to others one will never know. The asynchronous multiplayer of *Dark Souls* is, in this sense, a ritual against *muen*.

Japanese literature and cinema supply, finally, the closest analogue to the figure who presides over the trilogy's hearths. In Ueda Akinari's *Ugetsu monogatari* (1776), the tale "Asaji ga yado," "The House amid the Thickets," tells of a husband who leaves his wife to seek his fortune, is kept away for seven years by war, and returns to find her waiting for him in their ruined house; they spend the night together, and in the morning he wakes among the ruins to learn that she died long before, and that it was her ghost that kept the house for his return. Mizoguchi Kenji's film *Ugetsu* (1953) transposed the tale: the potter Genjūrō, returning home at last, finds his wife Miyagi waiting by the hearth, and she feeds him and watches over his sleep, though she has been dead since the war. Kobayashi Masaki's *Kwaidan* (1964), in the episode "Black Hair," gives the same encounter

its most terrible form, as a samurai who abandoned his wife returns to her, spends a night of reconciliation, and wakes beside her corpse. The dead woman who keeps the hearth for the returning wanderer is the Fire Keeper of Japanese tradition. The Fire Keepers of *Dark Souls*—Anastacia of Astora, mute and imprisoned beside the bonfire of Firelink; the blind keeper of the third game who will, in one of its endings, carry the last flame out into the dark—tend the fire to which the Undead return from death, and they are themselves bound, wounded, half belonging to the dead. The curse of the Undead, read in its Japanese inflection, is the condition of those who cannot depart and cannot connect; and the figure who waits for them at the hearth is the one who has not ceased to keep the bond.

4.8 *The Curse as Diagnosis*

The findings of this chapter may be gathered in a series of propositions. The Darksign is a cosmological stigma: the image of the eclipsed sun inscribed upon human bodies, protective like the mark of Cain in that it forbids death to complete itself, and sacrificial like the Brand of Sacrifice in that it marks its bearers as victims-in-waiting. The Asylum is the leprosarium of the Age of Fire, the inheritor of techniques of exclusion that European—and Japanese—societies applied to their contaminated, and its pairing with the prophecy discloses the single apparatus of camp and mission by which the order manages its remainder. Hollowing is the extinction of care: the condition of a being for whom its own being is no longer at issue, the sickness unto death of one who cannot die, the failure of every mechanism by which consciousness defends itself against its situation; and the comparative undeaths of Dante, Kafka, Borges, Swift, Tennyson, Le Guin, and Romero confirm with one voice that deathlessness empties life of meaning. The bloodstain re-finitizes existence by relocating finitude from life to the substance life gathers, and thereby converts the curse into an exercise in dying well. The curse is a biopolitical instrument, producing a population of sacrificeable *homines sacri*, compelled to live and permitted to Hollow, from among whom the order will select its fuel. And in the Japanese vocabulary of the dead, the Hollow is the *mōja* who cannot depart and the *muen-botoke* who has lost every bond.

From these propositions follows the chapter's thesis: the curse of undeath is the Age of Fire's diagnosis of itself. Heraclitus wrote that the sun will not overstep its measures, for if it does, the Erinyes, the ministers of Justice, will find it out (B94). The Darksign is the Erinyes of the Age of Fire. Gwyn's sun overstepped its measure when its sovereign chose to prolong the age beyond its natural course, and the curse is the vengeance of measure exceeded—falling, as the Erinyes' vengeance falls in Greek tragedy, not on the transgressor alone but on all who live under the shadow of his act. The curse is not the punishment of humanity for any crime of its own. It is the symptom of the order's excess, borne by the order's remainder. That it falls upon the descendants of the pygmy, the bearers of the

Dark Soul, rather than upon the gods whose decision produced it, is the trilogy's most exact dramatization of the mechanism René Girard placed at the foundation of every sacrificial order: the displacement of the community's guilt onto those it has excluded.

Aeschylus's *Oresteia* (458 BCE) offers a final comparison, which throws the trilogy's refusal of consolation into relief. In the *Eumenides*, the Erinyes who have pursued Orestes for his mother's blood are not defeated but persuaded. Athena offers them a home beneath the city, honours, and a share in its life, and the ancient, chthonic avengers become the Eumenides, the Kindly Ones, guardians of the very order they had threatened. The Athenian trilogy ends with the integration of the remainder into the city of light. The *Dark Souls* trilogy never performs this integration. Its Erinyes are never given a home; its remainder is never housed except behind the walls of the Ringed City, at the end of the world, in a dream. Whether the trilogy offers any equivalent of Athena's gift is the question with which Chapter Seven will close, and the answer it proposes is a painter rather than a goddess.

The population is now in view: branded, confined, compelled to live, liable to go Hollow, and destined, in its chosen member, for the fire. Chapter Five turns to the economy that requires such a population—the economy of souls, sovereignty, and sacrifice on which the Age of Fire runs—and to the act at its centre, the linking of the fire.

Chapter Five

The Accursed Share of Anor Londo

Sovereignty, Sacrifice, and the Soul Economy

Le soleil donne sans jamais recevoir.

"The sun gives without ever receiving."

— *Bataille,* La Part maudite *(1949)*

三界無安
猶如火宅

"The three worlds have no peace; they are like a burning house."

— Lotus Sūtra, *ch. 3, in the Chinese of Kumārajīva (406)*

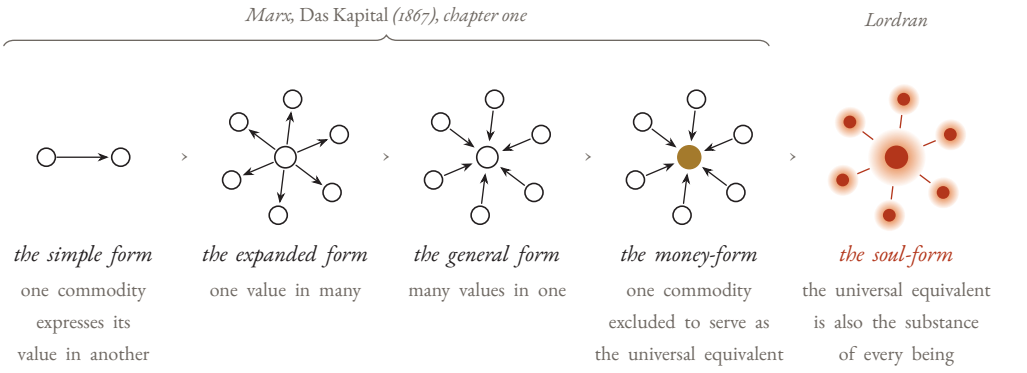


Figure 18 *From the value-form to the soul-form: in Lordran the universal equivalent is not merely the medium in which things express their value but the substance of which they are made.*

5.1 *The Soul as Universal Equivalent: Marx, Simmel, and the Money That Hollows*

Chapter One identified, as the foundational metaphysical act of *Dark Souls*, the collapse of four registers—ontological substance, currency, experience, and narrative—into the single variable of the soul. The present chapter examines the political economy that this collapse makes possible. In the world of the trilogy, the soul is the general equivalent: every being, object, service, and capacity is priced in it. Marx, in the first chapter of *Das Kapital* (1867), traced the development of the value-form from its simple expression, in which one commodity expresses its value in a quantity of another, through the expanded and general forms, to the money-form, in which a single commodity is excluded from the world of commodities in order to serve as the universal equivalent in which all others express their value. He then diagnosed, as the fetishism of commodities, the process by which definite social relations between persons assume the fantastic form of relations between things. *Dark Souls* carries both analyses to a conclusion Marx could only describe. Its universal equivalent is not merely the medium in which things express their value; it is the substance of which they are made. And its fetishism is not an illusion but a law of nature. In Lordran, relations between beings—combat, trade, growth—are relations between quantities of soul. Every encounter is a transaction; every death is a transfer of funds.

The Lord Souls are the gold reserve of this economy: the primordial deposits found

within the First Flame, from which all lordship derives and against which all lesser souls are, in effect, drawn. Gwyn's distribution of fragments of his own Lord Soul to his vassals—the Four Kings of New Londo, the dragon Seath—may be read as the monetary policy of a sovereignty that has delegated its reserves to regional banks, and the Lordvessel as the treasury in which the scattered reserve must be reassembled before its final conversion into fuel. The golden city of Anor Londo, whose cathedrals glow in perpetual sunlight, is the vault. The economy also confronts the player, at every major victory, with a choice whose terms Marx would have recognized. The soul of a great being may be consumed for its quantity, converted into the general equivalent at the price of its identity; or it may, at the hands of certain artisans, be transposed into a weapon or sorcery that preserves something of what its bearer was. The first realizes the soul's exchange-value; the second preserves its use-value, its qualitative particularity. The game asks, at every boss, whether to cash the soul or to keep it as itself.

Georg Simmel's analysis of money supplies the decisive further step. In the *Philosophie des Geldes* (1900) Simmel described money as the pure form of exchangeability, the objectification of the relation of exchange itself, which dissolves the qualitative being of things into quantitative relation. In the lecture "Die Großstädte und das Geistesleben" (1903), he drew from this analysis a diagnosis of the modern psyche. The inhabitant of the money economy, he argued, develops a blasé attitude (*Blasiertheit*), whose essence is the blunting of discrimination: "Das Wesen der Blasiertheit ist die Abstumpfung gegen die Unterschiede der Dinge"—not in the sense that the differences between things are not perceived, but that their meaning and value, and with them the value of the things themselves, are felt to be void. Things appear to the blasé person "in einer gleichmäßig matten und grauen Tönung," in an evenly flat and grey tone, none of them worth preferring to another. And the cause of this condition, Simmel argued, is money, which, by weighing all the manifold of things equally and expressing every qualitative difference as a difference of how much, becomes the most terrible of levellers: "es höhlt den Kern der Dinge, ihre Eigenart, ihren spezifischen Wert, ihre Unvergleichbarkeit rettungslos aus." It hollows out the core of things—their particularity, their specific value, their incomparability—beyond any possibility of rescue.

The verb is Simmel's, and it is exact. Money hollows. The consequence for the argument of this thesis is far-reaching. Chapter Two argued that the fading of the fire is the erosion of the distinctions the fire instituted; Chapter Four, that Hollowing is the extinction of care, the condition of a being for which nothing any longer matters. Simmel shows how an economy in which all things are measured by a single equivalent produces exactly this condition: a grey indifference to the differences between things, in which nothing is incomparable and nothing irreplaceable. The Hollow, who sees the world in Simmel's flat and grey tone—the grey of the Age of Ancients, returning as the grey of exhaustion—is the

subject that the soul economy produces. Heraclitus's exchange of all things for fire as goods for gold, read with Simmel, is therefore not a neutral cosmological principle. The exchange of all things for one thing levels all things. The Age of Fire's economy undermines the very disparity that its fire instituted: the fire that made differences becomes, as money, the solvent of differences. This is, I propose, one of the deepest structural insights the trilogy embodies. The order of fire does not fade merely because its fuel runs low. It fades because its own medium of exchange hollows out the world.

The insight extends to the player. The soul economy exerts a constant pressure toward a purely quantitative relation to the world of the game: toward the farming of enemies for their yield, the repetition of profitable routes, the reduction of every creature to a sum. In these moments the player's relation to Lordran takes on precisely the blasé, grey indifference that Simmel described, and the world's inhabitants become interchangeable deposits of currency. The game does nothing to prevent this; it is a consequence of the economy it institutes. But it also rewards the opposite comportment, at every turn, with meaning: the item text read rather than discarded, the enemy whose placement tells a story, the boss soul kept rather than spent. The player's resistance to the leveling force of the soul economy—the insistence on attending to each thing as itself—is the player's resistance to Hollowing, conducted at the level of attention. Simone Weil, whose thought will return in Chapter Seven, called attention the rarest and purest form of generosity. In a world hollowed by its own currency, attention is the first act of the ember.

5.2 *Restricted and General Economy: Bataille in Lordran*

Georges Bataille's *La Part maudite* (1949) proposed to reverse the founding assumption of political economy. Classical economics begins from scarcity: wealth is limited, needs are pressing, and the task of economic reason is to allocate, conserve, and accumulate. Bataille begins from excess. The sun lavishes its energy upon the earth without return; living matter receives more energy than it requires to sustain itself; and the surplus, first absorbed by growth, eventually meets the limits of growth and must be spent without profit—gloriously, in luxury, festival, art, and sacrifice, or catastrophically, in war. This surplus, which no system can indefinitely accumulate, is the accursed share. Political economy as ordinarily practised Bataille called a *restricted* economy, because it considers wealth only from the standpoint of particular operations and their utility. The *general* economy considers the movement of energy on the scale of the whole, and recognizes that the decisive problem of any society is not the acquisition of wealth but its expenditure. In an earlier essay, "La notion de dépense" (1933), Bataille had enumerated the forms of unproductive expenditure that human activity cannot do without, whose end lies wholly

in themselves: luxury, mourning, war, cults, sumptuous monuments, spectacles, the arts, non-reproductive sexuality—and games.

The Age of Fire is a restricted economy that has forgotten its origin in a general one. Its source is the First Flame, a prodigality without author, from which all souls derive; yet the order founded upon it treats the fire as a hoard. The Lord Souls are apportioned among loyal vassals; the light of Anor Londo is preserved, after its sovereign has departed, by illusion; and the fire itself is something to be conserved, fed, and prolonged. The linking of the fire is the decisive instance. It is a sacrifice, and Bataille held sacrifice to be the paradigmatic form of unproductive expenditure, the withdrawal of a being from the world of utility and its return to the order of the sacred. But the linking is a sacrifice subordinated to a project: it is performed in order to preserve the age, and its logic is that of investment rather than expenditure. In the unfinished work posthumously published as *La Souveraineté*, Bataille distinguished the servile, which subordinates the present to the future and every act to an end, from the sovereign, the moment that serves nothing, in which wealth is consumed beyond utility and the present is no longer governed by what is to come. Gwyn's sacrifice is servile. The Lord of Sunlight gives himself to the fire not in a sovereign moment of glorious loss but as a desperate measure of conservation. His sovereignty is, in Bataille's sense, counterfeit: a solar majesty that never truly gives, but only keeps, and whose very self-immolation is a deposit made against the future. The sun gives without ever receiving; Gwyn gives in order to keep. The Age of Fire is a solar civilization that misunderstood the sun.

Bataille's reading of Aztec sacrifice, which Chapter Two invoked in connection with the myth of the Fifth Sun, sharpens the contrast. In Bataille's account the Aztec victim, withdrawn from the order of things, was consumed in a festival of violence and intimacy whose excess was its meaning: the society spent its accursed share in a glory that it understood as the sun's own. The linking of the fire has none of this. There is no festival in the Kiln of the First Flame, no community, no intimacy—only a solitary pilgrim, a hollowed king, and a long dusk of ash. The trilogy's sacrifice is a degenerate sacrifice in the precise sense Bataille gave to modernity: a civilization that has lost the capacity for glorious expenditure and can dispose of its excess only in catastrophe. It is consistent with this diagnosis that the history of the Age of Fire is a history of wars—against the dragons, against the Abyss, against the giants beyond the sea in the second game, against the encroaching dark in the third—and that its knights, like the Abyss Watchers, end by turning their weapons upon one another.

Where, then, does the general economy reappear in the trilogy? In the player. The player harvests souls without any possibility of permanent accumulation: the bloodstain punishes hoarding, and every capacity purchased with souls is itself eventually spent in the cycle of new games that the trilogy offers after each ending. From the standpoint of the world's restricted economy, the player's activity is pure waste—dying and returning

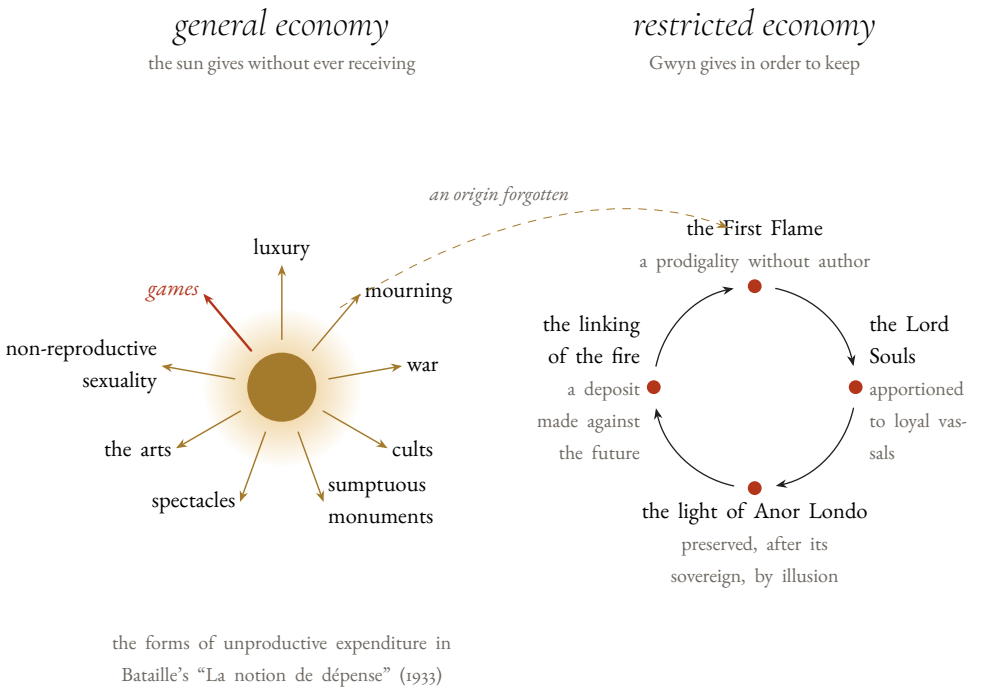


Figure 19 *Restricted and general economy. The Age of Fire is a restricted economy that has forgotten its origin in a general one: the sun gives without ever receiving; Gwyn gives in order to keep.*

hundreds of times, expending effort that produces nothing the world can use. It is, in Bataille's sense, *dépense*, and Bataille named games among its forms. The cultures that players have built around the trilogy confirm the diagnosis with a precision that would have delighted him. Players stage formal duels according to self-imposed codes of honour, bowing before combat and forgoing the use of healing, in rituals of agonistic expenditure whose closest anthropological analogue is the potlatch. They speak, with self-mocking pride, of "fashion souls," the practice of dressing one's character for beauty rather than protection—sumptuary expenditure in its purest form, the deliberate sacrifice of utility to splendour. Such practices are not ornaments on the margins of the game. They are the return of the accursed share in the one place where the order of fire cannot reach it: in play itself.

The chapter's argument may now be anticipated. The Age of Fire is a restricted economy masquerading as a solar one; its sovereign's sacrifice is servile; and the general economy, with its sovereign moment of useless expenditure, survives only in the activity of the player. It follows that the true sovereignty of the trilogy—the moment that serves nothing and is consumed beyond utility—belongs not to the Lord who links the fire but to the one who

plays. Chapter Six will develop this claim as the theory of ludic ekpyrosis, and Chapter Seven will find its final figure in a painter, whose work, like all art in Bataille's scheme, is expenditure without return.

5.3 *The Gift and the Soapstone: Mauss's Hau and Derrida's Impossible Gift*

Two economies coexist in *Dark Souls*. The first is the soul-market: the exchange of souls for goods and services with merchants, smiths, and trainers, impersonal, instantaneous, and measured entirely in the universal equivalent. The second runs between players, and it is of a different kind. A player may lay down a summon sign, and another, elsewhere, may summon them into their world, where the phantom fights alongside its host and vanishes when the boss falls or when it dies. A player may write a message on the ground with an orange soapstone, composed from a fixed lexicon of phrases, which will appear in the worlds of countless strangers. And every player moves through a world haunted by the traces of others: bloodstains that replay the final seconds of another's death, fleeting glimpses of other pilgrims passing through the same place in other worlds. This second economy is not a market. It is a gift economy.

Marcel Mauss's *Essai sur le don* (1925) described the gift, in the societies he surveyed, as a total social fact—at once religious, legal, economic, and aesthetic—governed by a threefold obligation: to give, to receive, and to reciprocate. Its paradigmatic forms were the *kula*, the ceremonial circulation of armshells and necklaces among the Trobriand Islanders that Bronisław Malinowski had documented in *Argonauts of the Western Pacific* (1922), and the potlatch of the Kwakwaka'wakw and their neighbours on the Northwest Coast, in which rank was won by giving and destroying wealth. Its most famous theoretical figure was the Maori *hau*, the spirit of the thing given, which, according to the explanation of the Maori sage Tamati Ranaipiri recorded by the ethnographer Elsdon Best, seeks to return to its place of origin, so that a gift passed on to a third party must produce a return to the original giver. The gift, for Mauss, does not transfer value between indifferent parties; it creates and sustains relation.

The gift economy of *Dark Souls* realizes Mauss's *hau* with startling literalness. When another player rates a message favourably, its author—wherever they may be in their own world, fighting their own battles—is healed. The spirit of the gift returns to its giver. The Warriors of Sunlight, a covenant devoted to aiding others, receive their tokens of honour when, as summoned phantoms, they help a stranger defeat a boss: the gift is recognized not by its recipient but by a third party, in a circulation that recalls the *kula*. And the operative law of summoning in the first game makes the anthropology of Chapter Three explicit.

The phantom who helps another to victory is restored, in their own world, to human form. Humanity is regained by giving help. Watsuji's claim that the human being exists in the between could hardly receive a more exact implementation: the Dark Soul, the substance of the human, is replenished in the act of crossing the interval to aid another.

Jacques Derrida, in *Donner le temps* (1991), argued that the pure gift is impossible. As soon as a gift appears as a gift—to its recipient, who incurs a debt of gratitude, or to its giver, who enjoys the satisfaction of generosity—it is annulled, drawn back into the circle of exchange it was meant to interrupt. A gift, if there is one, must not appear as such; it must be forgotten by both parties. The asynchronous multiplayer of *Dark Souls* approaches the impossible gift as closely as any human institution has. The helper and the helped are anonymous to one another; the first game allows them no speech, only gestures; the message is left for no one in particular and read by someone its author will never know; and where a return occurs, as in the healing that answers a well-rated message, it arrives as if from nowhere, without a face to thank. Miyazaki's own account of the system's origin, discussed in Chapter One, is the account of exactly such a gift: strangers who helped him on a snowbound slope and whom he could never thank. The asynchronous multiplayer is an apparatus for the impossible gift—an institution that prevents the gift from collapsing into exchange by preventing its parties from ever meeting.

The gift has a shadow, and the trilogy does not conceal it. Mauss himself, in a short essay of 1924, observed that the old Germanic word *Gift* means both gift and poison, and that the gift has always carried the danger of the one who gives it. The soapstone messages can deceive as easily as they help. Players have long delighted in leaving false counsel—urging others to jump from cliffs, promising treasure where there is only an ambush—and the restricted lexicon of the messages, which forbids personal identification and forces every utterance into a shared, almost liturgical language, makes the true and the false message indistinguishable in form. The message is a *pharmakon*, in the sense Chapter Three derived from Derrida: remedy and poison at once. The community's practice of rating messages, which elevates the helpful and buries the malicious, is a collective discernment of spirits, the only institution of judgment that the gift economy possesses. That the system nonetheless runs overwhelmingly on trust—that most players, most of the time, heed the counsel of strangers and are, more often than not, rightly guided—is perhaps the most hopeful fact about the trilogy, and it is a fact about its players rather than its fiction.

The two economies of *Dark Souls* thus stand in exact opposition. The soul-market exchanges everything for one thing and, as the preceding sections showed, hollows the world in doing so. The gift economy exchanges nothing for anything; what passes between its participants is not soul but relation. It is the only form of exchange in the trilogy that escapes the leveling force of the Axiom of Exchange, because it creates the bonds—*en*, in the vocabulary of Chapter Four—whose absence is the condition of the Hollow. The ethics

of the ember, when it is finally stated, will have this economy as its material form.

5.4 *The King's Two Bodies: Gwyn, Gwyndolin, the Soul of Cinder, and Lothric's Refusal*

Ernst Kantorowicz's *The King's Two Bodies: A Study in Mediaeval Political Theology* (1957) began from a doctrine set down by the Tudor crown lawyers whose arguments Edmund Plowden recorded in his *Reports*. The king, they held, has two bodies: a body natural, mortal and subject to the infirmities of infancy and age, and a body politic, invisible and immortal, utterly void of infancy, old age, and every natural defect. At the king's death the body politic is not extinguished but passes to his successor—the "demise" of the crown—and the continuity of the royal dignity across the death of its bearers was expressed in the cry *Le roi est mort, vive le roi* and in the maxim *dignitas non moritur*, the dignity does not die. Ralph Giesey's study of the French royal funeral (1960), which grew out of Kantorowicz's seminar, documented the most extraordinary expression of the doctrine: the wax effigy of the dead king, dressed in his regalia and displayed in state, to which meals were ceremonially served as though it were alive, while the corpse lay hidden in its coffin—the image of the undying dignity maintained by ritual until the successor could assume it.

Gwyn has two bodies. His body natural went into the Kiln of the First Flame and became the Lord of Cinder, a hollowed husk aged to ash in the furnace of its own sacrifice. His body politic remained in Anor Londo: the perpetual sunlight that bathes the city of the gods, the princess Gwynevere enthroned in her chamber, the knights still standing guard. And the player discovers that this body politic is an illusion. The Gwynevere whom the player meets is an image; struck, she vanishes, and the city falls into darkness; and the same darkness falls if the player slays Gwyndolin, the Dark Sun, the god who has sustained the illusion of his father's light. The radiant princess of Anor Londo is the funeral effigy of the solar dignity: the image of the undying sovereign, maintained by sorcery and ritual, while the body natural burns elsewhere. And Gwyndolin is its keeper, a moon reflecting an absent sun, the regent of an interregnum that can have no end because no successor is permitted to arrive except by entering the furnace. The Kingseeker Frampt, whose very title names his office, is the institution of succession: the elector who searches among the Undead for one worthy to succeed Lord Gwyn. Chapter One observed that the Japanese name of Firelink Shrine makes this succession, *hitsugi*, homophonous with the imperial succession of the sun. The modern Japanese state founded its legitimacy, in the first article of the Meiji Constitution of 1889, on a line of emperors "unbroken for ages eternal" (万世一系, *bansei ikkei*). Anor Londo is the image of such a line maintained after its source has gone into the fire.

The third game carries the doctrine of the two bodies to its monstrous conclusion. Its final adversary, the Soul of Cinder, is the amalgam of all the Lords who have ever linked the fire: an armoured figure whose fighting styles cycle through those of the knight, the sorcerer, the pyromancer, and the cleric, and whose second phase adopts the movements of Gwyn himself, accompanied by a variation on the melancholy piano theme that had accompanied Gwyn's own final battle. Kantorowicz traced the medieval idea of the *corpus mysticum*, the mystical body that unites the members of the Church or the realm across time into a single person. The Soul of Cinder is the *corpus mysticum* of the Age of Fire made flesh: the accumulated body politic of every sovereign who has sustained the fire, fused into one immortal and terrible form. And because those who linked the fire include, by the logic of the trilogy, the player-characters of earlier ages—Chosen Undead, Bearers of the Curse, Ashen Ones—whose fighting styles correspond to the archetypal classes from which players build their characters, the Soul of Cinder may be read as the composite body of all who have ever played. The last enemy of the trilogy is the body politic of the players themselves: the sum of every previous choice to link the fire, standing between the present player and the end.

The third game also presents the first designated sovereign of the trilogy who refuses. The royal house of Lothric devoted itself to raising a Lord of Cinder, and the younger prince, Lothric, was raised for the express purpose of linking the fire. Frail from birth, he rejected the duty and chose instead to watch the fire fade from afar, while his elder brother Lorian, once a formidable knight, bears the consequences of his brother's curse and carries him into battle. Dante placed among the neutrals of the *Inferno*'s vestibule the shade of one "che fece per viltade il gran rifiuto" (III.60), who made through cowardice the great refusal—traditionally identified with Pope Celestine V, who abdicated the papacy in 1294. The trilogy does not condemn Lothric as Dante condemns the great refusal; it presents his refusal with an ambiguity that verges on sympathy. A closer analogue is Herman Melville's scrivener Bartleby (1853), whose formula, "I would prefer not to," Gilles Deleuze and Giorgio Agamben read as the purest expression of a potentiality that neither affirms nor negates—in Agamben's phrase, a figure of the potentiality not to, which constitutes the strongest objection against the principle of sovereignty. Lothric would prefer not to link the fire. And the trilogy's answer to his refusal is the most damning revelation of the nature of its sovereignty. The Ashen One must kill the prince and carry his remains back to his throne at Firelink, so that he is enthroned as Lord of Cinder in death. The sovereignty of the Age of Fire is compulsory. Its body politic does not require the consent of the body natural; refusal is met by execution and posthumous coronation.

A final episode completes the degeneration of the two bodies. Aldrich, a cleric whose appetite for human flesh became legendary, was made a Lord of Cinder; risen again, he made his way to Anor Londo and there devoured Gwyndolin, the Dark Sun who had kept

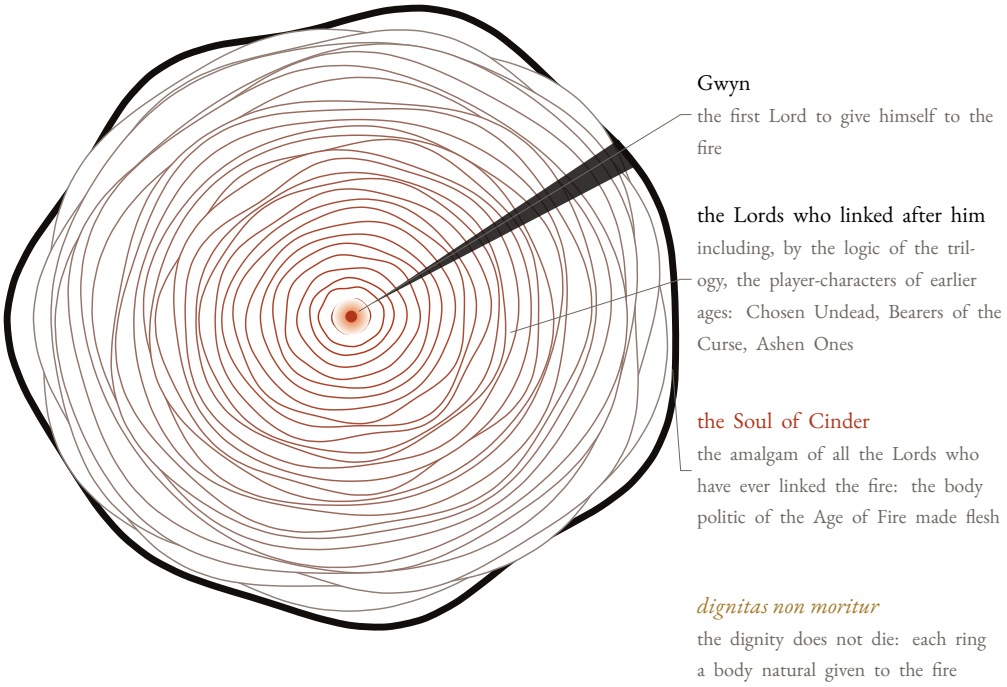


Figure 20 *The accumulated body politic. Each ring is a body natural given to the fire; the Soul of Cinder is their amalgam, the* corpus mysticum *of the Age of Fire made flesh.*

the solar effigy alive, and the player who confronts him finds the form of Gwyndolin within his swollen body. The keeper of the image of the undying dignity is eaten by one of the sovereigns who succeeded the dignity's source. If the Eucharist is the rite in which the faithful consume the body of their god and are united to it, Aldrich's feast is its inversion: a sovereign who consumes the god in order to possess its power, and becomes thereby not a member of a mystical body but a monster swollen with a body not its own.

Read through Kantorowicz, then, the political theology of the Age of Fire consists of three moments: an undying dignity maintained by illusion after its source has gone into the fire; a succession that is compulsory, enforced against the refusal of the designated heir; and the accumulation of every sovereign into a single monstrous collective body that must, at the last, be killed. The body politic, made flesh, is a monster. It is the trilogy's verdict on every political order that claims immortality for itself.

5.5 *The Wounded King and the Waste Land: The Grail Question, the Priest of Nemi, and Need-Fire*

The Arthurian matter supplies the trilogy's deepest European model of sovereignty in decline. In Chrétien de Troyes's unfinished *Perceval, ou le Conte du Graal* (c. 1180–90), the young knight comes upon the castle of the Fisher King, a lord so wounded that he cannot ride and passes his days fishing from a boat. At dinner a procession passes through the hall: a youth bearing a lance from whose point blood runs down, and a damsel bearing a *graal* that shines with a great light. Perceval, who has been taught not to ask too many questions, says nothing. In the morning the castle is empty, and he learns that had he asked why the lance bleeds and whom the grail serves, the king would have been healed and his land restored; because he did not, the land remains waste. Wolfram von Eschenbach's *Parzival* (c. 1200–1210) transformed the episode. The Grail King Anfortas suffers from a wound that will not heal and is kept alive in agony by the Grail itself; Parzival fails at his first visit and wanders for years; and when at last he returns, he asks not a question about the Grail but a question of compassion addressed to the suffering king: "Oheim, waz wirret dir?"—Uncle, what ails you? With that question Anfortas is healed.

Jessie Weston's *From Ritual to Romance* (1920), drawing on Frazer, argued that the Grail legends preserve the residue of an ancient fertility ritual in which the vitality of the land is bound to the vitality of its king, so that the king's wound and the land's waste are one. T. S. Eliot made Weston and Frazer the acknowledged sources of *The Waste Land* (1922), a poem whose own fragmentary form—"These fragments I have shored against my ruins"—anticipates the lacunary hermeneutics with which this thesis began. Lordran is a waste land in Weston's sense. Its sickness—undeath, Hollowing, the fading of the light—is one with the wound of its sovereign, who is kept alive beyond his time in the fire as Anfortas is kept alive by the Grail, and whose knights have fallen or been scattered. The sovereign's condition is the land's condition; the land cannot be healed while the king suffers.

What the trilogy withholds is the question. The Chosen Undead, guided by Frampt, performs the whole of the quest—ringing the bells, receiving the Lordvessel, gathering the Lord Souls—without ever asking whom the fire serves. It repeats Perceval's failure. In the first game only one voice asks the Grail question, and it is the voice of the serpent Kaathe, who tells the player that the fire has served Gwyn's fear and Gwyn's age. The trilogy thus divides Chrétien's question from Wolfram's: the question of whom the fire serves is asked, but in a tempter's mouth and in the service of another sovereignty; the question of compassion—what ails you?—is asked by no one. When the player finally reaches Gwyn in the Kiln, there is no dialogue at all. The king does not speak, and the player cannot ask. There is only combat. And yet the trilogy has found a means of asking what its characters cannot. The music that accompanies the final battle of the first game is

not the choral grandeur that the genre leads one to expect but a simple, melancholy theme for piano, whose effect is less of triumph than of mourning. The music asks, on Gwyn's behalf, the question no one in Lordran asks him. And the trilogy's many minor quests—the player's help to Siegmeyer of Catarina and his daughter, to Solaire, to the Unkindled Anri, to the knight Siegward in the third game, to Lucatiel in the second—are the question of compassion asked not in words but in deeds: practices of accompaniment and witness extended to those whose wounds, like the king's, cannot otherwise be healed. Parzival's question is the question of the ethics of the ember.

The sovereign succession of the Age of Fire has a second and darker analogue, drawn from Roman religion, which opens the most influential work of comparative religion of the modern age. James George Frazer's *The Golden Bough* (1890; third edition 1906–15) begins in the sacred grove of Diana at Nemi, where the priest called the King of the Wood held his office until he was slain by a successor, who, having first plucked a golden bough from a certain tree, killed him and reigned in his place until he in turn was slain. Frazer quoted Macaulay's lines on the priest "who slew the slayer, / And shall himself be slain," and built upon the rite his theory of the dying king: because the vitality of the world is bound to that of its sacred ruler, the ruler must be killed before his strength fails, so that the divine spirit may pass to a vigorous successor. The structure is precisely that of the linking of the fire. The Chosen Undead must slay Gwyn, the weakened king, and take his place in the fire; and in the third game, the Ashen One must slay the Soul of Cinder, which contains every previous linker, including the Chosen Undead of the first game. The Lords of Cinder are priests of Nemi. Each holds the fire until he is slain by his successor, and each successor is destined, by the same law, to be slain in turn.

Frazer also documented, in the volumes devoted to the fire-festivals of Europe, the custom of the need-fire (German *Notfeuer*, Old English *nied-fyr*). In times of calamity, above all during outbreaks of cattle plague, every fire in a community was extinguished, and a new fire was kindled by the friction of wood; the cattle were driven through its smoke, and the hearths of the village were relit from it. The linking of the fire is a need-fire: in the calamity of the curse, the failing flame must be renewed. But the custom carries a further implication that the trilogy will develop in its final game. The need-fire could be kindled only after every other fire had been put out. Renewal required, first, extinction. Chapter Seven will argue that the ending of *Dark Souls III* in which the Fire Keeper takes the last flame into the dark may be read in this light—not as the end of fire but as the extinction that must precede a new kindling. Frazer's fire-festivals included, finally, the burning of effigies in the great bonfires of Beltane and Midsummer, which he interpreted as substitutes for older human sacrifices. In the second game, the player may burn a Human Effigy at a bonfire to hold invaders at bay: a substitute sacrifice offered to the fire, in the very form Frazer described.

The sovereignty of the Age of Fire is thus the sovereignty of a Fisher King, wounded, its wound one with the land's; its succession is the succession of Nemi, in which the successor slays and replaces the incumbent and awaits his own slayer; its renewal is a need-fire kindled in calamity. And the one act that would heal it—the question of compassion asked of the suffering sovereign—is the act its order never performs. That the trilogy leaves this question to be asked by its music and by the player's deeds is not an evasion. It is a displacement of healing from the throne to the practices of those who live beneath it.

5.6 *The Sacrificial Crisis: Girard, the Lords of Cinder, and Omelas*

René Girard's theory of sacrifice, developed in *La Violence et le sacré* (1972), *Des choses cachées depuis la fondation du monde* (1978), and *Le Bouc émissaire* (1982), begins from desire. Human beings, Girard argued, desire not spontaneously but mimetically, according to the desire of another; mimetic desire converges on the same objects and so generates rivalry; and rivalry, as it spreads, transforms antagonists into doubles of one another, eroding the differences on which the cultural order depends. This erosion is the sacrificial crisis, a crisis of distinctions in which violence propagates by reciprocity until the community is threatened with dissolution. It is resolved when the violence of all converges, unanimously and arbitrarily, upon a single victim, whose expulsion or death restores peace and, with peace, the differences that the crisis had abolished. The victim is then sacralized in a double transference: blamed for the crisis, and therefore maleficent; credited with the peace, and therefore beneficent. Ritual sacrifice repeats the founding murder in controlled form, so that the crisis may not return. And myth narrates the founding violence from the standpoint of the persecutors, concealing the arbitrariness of the victim's selection and the innocence of the victim—a concealment that, for Girard, the Gospels decisively expose.

The linking of the fire conforms to this theory with an exactness that would be suspicious if it were not so thoroughly grounded in the game's systems. The fading of the fire is a sacrificial crisis: a crisis of distinctions, as Chapter Two showed, in which undeath blurs the difference between life and death, Hollowing the difference between self and other, the convergence of kingdoms the difference between here and there. The linking is the ritual sacrifice that restores them. And its victim undergoes the double transference precisely. The Chosen Undead is first maleficent: branded with the Darksign, accursed, confined in an asylum, the visible embodiment of the crisis that afflicts the community. Then, in the furnace, the victim becomes beneficent: a Lord of Cinder, whose sacrifice renews the light, and whose remains, in the third game, are enthroned at Firelink Shrine as relics of the age they sustained. The prophecy that leads the victim to the altar is a myth in Girard's sense, told from the standpoint of the order that requires the sacrifice. It speaks of succession, of lordship, of the linking of the fire; it does not speak of immolation, whose meaning the

player discovers only in the Kiln. And the opening of the third game, which laments that the Lords of Cinder have abandoned their thrones, is what Girard called a persecution text: an account of the victims' refusal, narrated as dereliction by those whose order depends on their consent.

The third game makes the player the agent of this order. The Lords of Cinder—the Abyss Watchers of Farron, Aldrich the Devourer of Gods, Yhorm the Giant, the princes of Lothric—have risen from their graves and refused to return to their thrones, and the Ashen One's task is to bring them back. The player does so by killing them and carrying their cinders to Firelink, where the thrones receive them. The victims who refused the altar are dragged back to it, and the player is the executioner who returns them. Each of these encounters inflects the Girardian structure differently. The Abyss Watchers, fighting one another as well as the player, are the monstrous doubles of the crisis. Aldrich, the cannibal, is the sacrificial appetite turned sovereign. Lothric is the refuser, enthroned against his will. And Yhorm discloses a possibility the sacrificial order cannot contain. Before he became a Lord of Cinder, the giant entrusted to his friend Siegward of Catarina the one weapon capable of slaying him, the Storm Ruler, so that if he were ever lost to himself, his friend might put an end to him. In the third game Siegward comes to keep that promise, and the player may fight beside him. The death of Yhorm is still a sacrifice, but it is also an act of friendship: not the unanimous violence of a persecuting crowd but the merciful killing of one who asked to be released by one who loved him. In Yhorm and Siegward, the trilogy places within the sacrificial machine the gesture of Wolfram's question—what ails you?—answered by the only means the order has left.

Ursula K. Le Guin's parable "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973), subtitled as variations on a theme of William James, describes a city of perfect happiness whose felicity depends, by some inexplicable bargain, on the misery of a single child kept in filth in a basement. Every citizen learns of the child; most, after an initial horror, accept the bargain; a few leave the city and walk away into the darkness beyond it, toward a place even less imaginable than the city of happiness. The Age of Fire is Omelas. Its light depends upon the suffering of those who burn in the Kiln and of the Fire Keepers whose bodies are vessels of the humanity the fire consumes. And the ending of the first game that the paratextual commons calls the Dark Lord ending is, in its visible form, a walking away: the player turns from the bonfire in the Kiln and walks off into the dark, leaving the flame to die. Dostoevsky had given the same refusal its most famous expression in the chapter of *The Brothers Karamazov* (1880) entitled "Rebellion," where Ivan declares that he will not accept a harmony purchased by the tears of a single tortured child, and respectfully returns his ticket. The Dark Lord ending is Ivan's returned ticket. Like Le Guin's walkers, the player who refuses the linking does not know where the road leads; the trilogy offers no verification of Kaathe's promise. The refusal is made without guarantee.

Girard held that the sacrificial order is undone by the revelation of the victim's innocence, and here the medium of the trilogy accomplishes something no written text could. A myth conceals its victim's innocence by narrating from the persecutors' side; a gospel reveals it by narrating from the victim's. *Dark Souls* is played from the position of the victim. The player is the branded one, the confined one, the one summoned by prophecy to the altar, and the player knows, as no myth would permit its audience to know, that the curse is not the victim's fault, that the prophecy conceals its purpose, and that the reward of election is the furnace. The trilogy is a persecution text inhabited from within by its victim. Its sacrificial order cannot survive this inhabitation intact, and it does not. Every alternative the trilogy offers—Lothric's refusal, Siegward's mercy, the walk away from the Kiln—is a way of declining the terms of the sacrifice, even when the sacrifice is performed. None of them restores the order. Each of them withdraws consent from it.

5.7 *The Burning House: The Prophecy as Inverted Upāya*

The *Lotus Sūtra*, which in Kumārajīva's Chinese translation of 406 became the most influential scripture of East Asian Buddhism and the foundational text of the Tendai and Nichiren schools in Japan, contains in its third chapter the parable that supplied this chapter's epigraph. A wealthy elder's great house, old and decaying, catches fire. His many children are inside, absorbed in their games, unaware of the danger and deaf to his warnings. Knowing what each of them loves, he calls to them that outside the gate are carts drawn by goats, by deer, and by oxen, such as they have always longed for. The children rush out and are saved; they ask for the promised carts; and the father gives each of them not the cart promised but a great carriage drawn by a white ox, finer than anything they had imagined. The Buddha explains the parable. The burning house is the threefold world of *saṃsāra*, aflame with birth, old age, sickness, death, and grief, and with the fires of greed, anger, and delusion; the children are sentient beings; the three carts are the three vehicles by which the Buddha's various disciples were led; and the great carriage is the One Vehicle, buddhahood itself. The elder's promise was a skilful means—*upāya*, in Japanese *hōben* (方便)—a deception justified by compassion, which leads the deceived out of danger toward a good greater than the one they were promised. The doctrine passed into Japanese proverb: *uso mo hōben* (嘘も方便), even a lie can be a skilful means.

The prophecy of the Chosen Undead is an *upāya*, but an inverted one. Like the elder's promise, it is a narrative lure addressed to beings absorbed in their condition; it promises them what they desire—release from the asylum, a destiny, the succession of a god—and it moves them to act. But where the elder's skilful means leads the children out of the burning house, the prophecy leads the Undead into it. Its carts are the Bells of Awakening, the Lordvessel, the Lord Souls; its great carriage is the throne of Gwyn; and what awaits

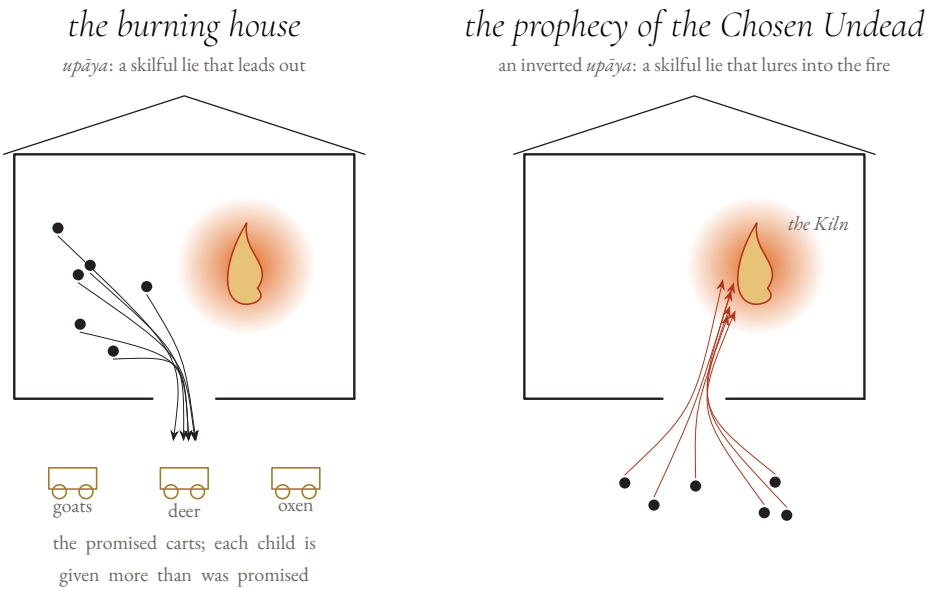


Figure 21 *The parable of the burning house and its inversion. The father's skilful lie leads the children out of the fire; the prophecy of the Chosen Undead lures its hearers into it.*

at the end of the road is the Kiln of the First Flame, the burning house itself. Frampt the Kingseeker is the elder inverted: the father who lures his children into the fire with promises of what lies beyond it. The inversion extends to the justification. An *upāya* is justified by the welfare of the deceived, whom it leads to a good they could not have chosen for themselves. The prophecy is justified by the preservation of the order that issues it. Here lies the distinction between skilful means and ideology: the one deceives for the sake of those it deceives, the other for the sake of the system that deceives them.

Louis Althusser's essay "Idéologie et appareils idéologiques d'État" (1970) described the mechanism by which ideology constitutes its subjects as interpellation. Ideology hails concrete individuals as subjects, as a policeman calls out in the street, "Hé, vous, là-bas!"; the individual turns around, recognizing that the call was addressed to him, and by this simple conversion becomes a subject. The prophecy interpellates. Oscar of Astora, dying, relays an old saying of his family—that the Undead who hears it is chosen, and must make pilgrimage to the land of the ancient Lords—and the player who has escaped the asylum turns, recognizes the call as addressed to them, and becomes the Chosen Undead. The election does not precede the call; it is produced by the call and by the response it elicits. The trilogy takes care that the player should be able to see this. The Crestfallen Warrior at Firelink mocks the prophecy, observing that many have come to Lordran before, believing the same thing; and the corpses of earlier pilgrims lie scattered across the land. The call is

addressed to everyone. The Chosen Undead is not a person but a position, occupied by whoever answers and survives.

Max Weber's *Die protestantische Ethik und der Geist des Kapitalismus* (1904–05) described the psychological consequences of a doctrine of election whose objects cannot know whether they are elect. The Calvinist believer, unable to obtain certainty of salvation, came to read worldly success in a calling as a sign of election, and the anxiety of election drove a methodical, ascetic labour that, once its religious root had withered, left behind the rationalized economic order Weber called a shell as hard as steel, *ein stahlhartes Gehäuse*. The Chosen Undead is a Calvinist of a theology without God. No one in Lordran can know whether they are the Chosen; the only sign of election is success—survival, progress, the defeat of what has killed others before; and the anxiety of election drives a methodical, ascetic labour of repetition whose rationalized form is the soul economy. The iron cage of the Age of Fire is the persistence of this labour after its meaning has gone. Long after the player has learned, from Kaathe or from the Kiln, that the prophecy is a lure, the grind continues: the souls are farmed, the levels purchased, the bosses fought. The system outlives the faith that founded it.

The order that issues the prophecy may be cynical, or it may be tragic. Dostoevsky's Grand Inquisitor, in the chapter of *The Brothers Karamazov* that follows Ivan's rebellion, explains to the silent Christ why the Church has corrected his work: human beings cannot bear the freedom he offered them, and so the Church has given them instead miracle, mystery, and authority, while a few—the Inquisitor among them—bear the burden of the truth and deceive the many for the sake of their happiness. Frampt and the order of Gwyn may be read in this light: as an inquisition that conceals the truth of the fire—that it is sustained by the immolation of those it summons—because it believes the alternative, the Dark, to be worse. The trilogy never decides whether the deception is cynical or merciful. It shows only that it is a deception.

One detail of the Buddhist parable completes the reading. The children in the burning house are not merely ignorant of the fire; they are at play. Their absorption in their games is what keeps them in danger, and the elder can reach them only by speaking the language of their play, promising toys. The *Dark Souls* player is the child at play in the burning house, and the prophecy is a toy promised. But the work itself stands in a different relation to its player than the prophecy does to the Chosen Undead. The game also lures its player with promises—of heroism, of election, of mastery—and leads them, through hundreds of deaths, into the fire. What it delivers at the end, however, is not the throne it seemed to promise but something the player could not have chosen at the outset: an education in finitude, in expenditure, in the holding of what one has gathered lightly enough to lose it. The trilogy thus has a double structure. Within the fiction, the prophecy is an inverted *upāya*, a lure into the furnace in the service of the order. As a work, *Dark Souls* is a genuine

upāya: a fiction that uses the lure of play to lead its players through the burning house toward an understanding of the burning—a great carriage, finer than the cart it promised.

5.8 *The Political Economy of Ash: The Axiom of Exchange Restated*

The chapter's findings may be gathered as a single account of the political economy of the Age of Fire. Its currency is the soul, the universal equivalent of a world in which the money-form has become ontological, and whose universality, as Simmel showed of money, hollows out the particularity of things—so that the order's own medium of exchange is the engine of its fading. Its economy is a restricted one, hoarding a gift that originated in solar prodigality, and its sovereign's sacrifice is servile rather than sovereign, an investment against the future rather than an expenditure without return; the accursed share reappears only in the useless, glorious expenditure of play. Beside the market of souls runs a gift economy among players, which realizes Mauss's *hau* and approaches Derrida's impossible gift, and which alone exchanges relation rather than substance. Its sovereignty is a body politic maintained by illusion after its source has gone into the fire, compulsory in its succession, and monstrous in its final accumulation. Its sovereign is a Fisher King whose wound is the land's, its succession the succession of Nemi, its renewal a need-fire kindled in calamity, and the question that would heal it—the question of compassion—is never asked by its order. Its sacrifice is a Girardian sacrifice whose victim is innocent and, uniquely among sacrificial narratives, played from within. And its prophecy is an inverted *upāya*, an interpellation that produces the election it announces, and an anxiety of election that drives a labour which outlives its meaning.

The Axiom of Exchange can now be stated in its final form. In a cosmos where all things are an exchange for fire: first, value is ontological, and to be is to be a quantity of exchangeable soul; second, the universal equivalent levels the disparities that the fire instituted, so that the economy of the order is the engine of its own decline; third, sovereignty is the hoarding of the fire disguised as solar giving; fourth, the preservation of sovereignty requires the sacrifice of the remainder, produced as bare life and consumed as fuel; fifth, this sacrifice is legitimated as election, by a prophecy that leads its hearers into the fire; and sixth, the only exchange that escapes this economy is the gift that cannot be returned—the anonymous, asynchronous gift by which players create relation across the interval of worlds.

The sixth clause is the economic form of the ethics of the ember, and it points beyond the present chapter. Two forms of expenditure have emerged from this analysis as exceptions to the pyrrhic logic of the Age of Fire: the gift, which spends without exacting return and thereby creates the bonds whose absence is the condition of the Hollow; and play, which spends without producing anything the order can use and thereby recovers the sovereign moment that the order's own sovereign never reached. In the Age of Fire, every preservation

is a consumption. The gift and play are the two expenditures that do not merely consume. Chapter Six turns to the place where they meet—the bonfire, the death loop, and the community of strangers who leave signs for one another in the dark—and develops from them the theory of ludic ekpyrosis.

Chapter Six

Fort/Da at the Bonfire

Ludic Ekpyrosis and the Practice of Dying

αἰὼν παῖς ἐστι παίζων, πεττεύων· παιδὸς ἡ βασιληίη.

"Lifetime is a child at play, moving the pieces of a game: the kingship is a child's."

— *Heraclitus, DK 22 B52*

Unschuld ist das Kind und Vergessen, ein Neubeginnen, ein Spiel, ein aus sich rollendes Rad, eine erste Bewegung, ein heiliges Ja-sagen.

"Innocence is the child, and forgetting, a new beginning, a game, a self-propelling wheel, a first movement, a sacred Yes-saying."

— *Nietzsche,* Also sprach Zarathustra*, "Von den drei Verwandlungen"*

6.1 *The Bonfire: Hearth, Bone-Fire, Reverie, and the Welcoming Fire of the Dead*

If the First Flame is the cosmological centre of *Dark Souls*, the bonfire is its experiential centre: the place to which every life returns and from which every life sets out. Its functions are many. Resting at a bonfire restores the player's health and replenishes the Estus Flask; it sets the point to which the player will return after death; in the first game it is where souls are converted into attributes and where humanity may be offered to reverse Hollowing or to kindle the flame; once the Lordvessel is obtained, the bonfires become a network through which the player may travel. Its form is a mound of ash and bones into which a coiled sword has been thrust, so that every hearth in the trilogy is also a grave with a blade for a marker. Lighting one is announced by a single line of text across the screen, and resting at one is the only moment in the game in which the player-character is still: it sits beside the flame, knees drawn up, gazing into the fire. And resting carries a cost that Chapter One identified as the mechanism of Anaximander's justice: every ordinary enemy in the world returns to life. The hearth is at once the place of rest and the clock by which the world resets itself against the one who rests.

The bonfire's fuel completes its significance. The description of the Homeward Bone in the third game—a fragment of bone reduced to white ash, which returns its user to the last bonfire rested at—explains that the bonfires are fed with the bones of the Undead. The English word that the localization chose for these fires is, in this light, uncannily exact. *Bonfire* derives not, as Samuel Johnson supposed in his *Dictionary* (1755), from the French *bon*, but from the Middle English *bonefire*: a fire of bones, glossed in the fifteenth-century *Catholicon Anglicum* as *ignis ossium*. The hearths of the Age of Fire are bone-fires in the etymological sense, and what they burn is the remainder of those who return to them. The Axiom of Exchange and the Axiom of the Remainder meet at the hearth: the place of rest is fuelled by the dead.

The Greek hearth-goddess Hestia supplies the bonfire's religious ancestry. The Homeric Hymn to Hestia declares that without her mortals hold no banquet at which sweet wine is not poured to Hestia both first and last, and the common hearth of the Greek city, maintained in the *prytaneion*, was the fire from which colonists carried flame to kindle the hearths of new cities across the sea. The bonfires of the trilogy, linked into a network radiating from Firelink Shrine, reproduce this structure: a mother-hearth at the centre of the world and a scattering of colonial fires, each carrying the flame into hostile country. And Plato's image of Hestia remaining alone in the house of the gods while the others ride out in procession (*Phaedrus* 247a), discussed in Chapter Two, describes the Fire Keeper who stays by the fire while the Undead go out into the world and die.

Gaston Bachelard's phenomenology of fire illuminates the bonfire's strangest feature,

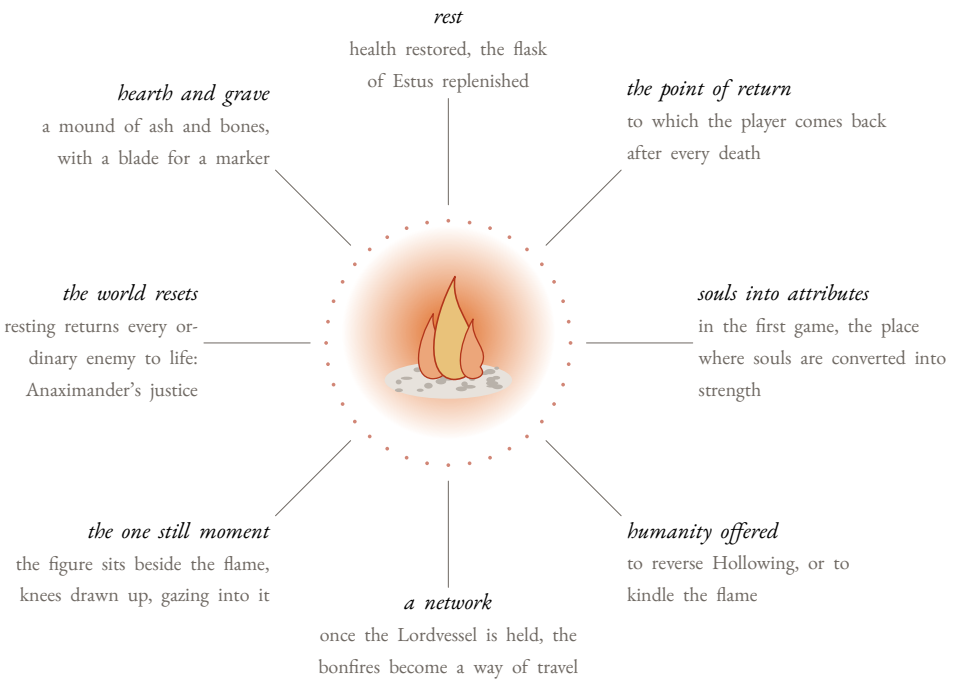


Figure 22 *The functions of the bonfire, the experiential centre of the trilogy: the place to which every life returns and from which every life sets out.*

the posture of rest. In *La Psychanalyse du feu* (1938), Bachelard called fire the ultra-living element, at once intimate and universal, gentle and cruel, the fire of the hearth and the fire of the pyre; and he observed that fire, more than any other phenomenon, induces reverie, the drifting, half-waking contemplation in which the dreamer before the hearth is carried toward origins and ends. Among the complexes he identified was one he named after Empedocles: the reverie before the flame that contains, at its depth, the longing to be consumed by it, the union of love and death in fire. In his last book, *La Flamme d'une chandelle* (1961), he returned to the solitary dreamer before a single flame and found in its verticality a model of tranquil life. The player-character sitting at the bonfire is Bachelard's dreamer. It is the one posture in the game devoted entirely to contemplation, and what it contemplates is the fire in which, at the end, it will be invited to burn. The Empedocles complex is the hidden content of every rest: the reverie at the hearth rehearses the linking. Hölderlin's unfinished tragedy *Der Tod des Empedokles* (1797–1800), which made the philosopher's leap into Etna an act of reunion with the living whole of nature, is the dramatic form of the same longing; Chapter Seven will argue that the trilogy, unlike Hölderlin, finally refuses it.

The Japanese tradition supplies a final and decisive analogue. During the summer festival of Obon, when the spirits of the ancestral dead are believed to return to their families, households light a *mukaebi* (迎え火), a welcoming fire, at the threshold of the house to guide the dead home, and at the festival's end an *okuribi* (送り火), a sending-off fire, to guide them back; in Kyoto the sending-off is performed on the night of 16 August with the Gozan no Okuribi, great fires laid out in the shapes of characters on the slopes of the surrounding mountains. The bonfire of *Dark Souls* is a *mukaebi*. It is the fire at which the dead arrive home: the place where the Undead, after each death, find themselves returned. And it is also an *okuribi*, the fire from which they are sent out again into the world. Chapter Four argued that the Hollow is a *muen-botoke*, one of the unconnected dead for whom no one lights a fire. The bonfire is the fire lit for those who have died: the sign that someone, somewhere—a Fire Keeper, a stranger, the order of the world—still expects their return. When to these associations is added the *kagaribi* of the open-air Noh, by whose light the ghosts of the dead were summoned onto the stage, the bonfire emerges as the most densely overdetermined object in the trilogy: hearth, grave, bone-fire, place of reverie, colonial flame, welcoming fire of the dead, and stage-light of the ghost play. It is the place where the practice this chapter describes begins and ends.

6.2 *Fort/Da: Repetition, the Death Drive, and the Art of Failure*

Freud wrote *Jenseits des Lustprinzips* (1920) to solve a problem posed by the First World War. Soldiers suffering from what were then called war neuroses dreamed, night after night, of the scene of their trauma, returning in sleep to the very event that had shattered them—a fact that contradicted Freud's earlier theory that dreams fulfil wishes. The puzzle led him to the compulsion to repeat (*Wiederholungszwang*), which he found also in his grandson's game of *fort* and *da*: the child who throws away the reel and draws it back converts the passive suffering of his mother's departures into an active game of his own devising. And it led him, finally, to the death drive. The drives, Freud proposed, are conservative; they tend to restore an earlier state of things, and the earliest state of all is the inorganic. "Das Ziel alles Lebens ist der Tod"—the aim of all life is death—and the drives of self-preservation are only the detours by which the organism ensures that it will reach death by its own path, for the organism, as he put it, wishes to die only in its own fashion: "daß der Organismus nur auf seine Weise sterben will."

Dark Souls is the most elaborate *fort/da* ever constructed. Its loop is a structure of traumatic repetition: the player returns again and again to the place of their death, like the soldier who dreams the battlefield. But like the child with the reel, the player converts the passive suffering of death into an active game. It is the player who chooses to pass through the fog gate once more, who chooses the angle of approach, the moment of attack, the

point of retreat; and each death throws the reel away—*fort*, the souls left behind in the bloodstain—while each recovery draws it back—*da*. The death drive, in Freud's sense, is the rhythm of the game. The edition that brought the first game to personal computers in 2012 bore the subtitle *Prepare to Die*, and the words that fill the screen at every death, in blood-red capitals, are the punctuation of the game's grammar. Freud's formula acquires here an unexpected literalness. The Undead cannot choose whether to die; the curse has taken that from them. What the game gives them is the one freedom Freud allowed the organism: to die in their own fashion, again and again, until their fashion becomes mastery.

Jesper Juul's *The Art of Failure* (2013) named the paradox at the heart of this loop. We dislike failing, and yet we seek out games that make us fail. Juul resolved the paradox by observing that failure in games is informative: it reveals an inadequacy in the player and, at the same moment, promises that the inadequacy can be overcome, a promise that life does not always make. He distinguished failures that the player attributes to their own lack of skill from failures attributed to chance or to the game's unfairness, and noted that only the first kind sustains the motivation to improve. The reputation of *Dark Souls* rests on the conviction, widely shared among its players, that its deaths are fair—that each one could have been avoided, and therefore teaches something. The vernacular injunction with which its community greets complaint, to "get good," is a crude but serviceable theory of failure as pedagogy: death is not punishment but instruction.

Roger Caillois's *Les Jeux et les hommes* (1958) classified games under four principles: *agôn*, competition; *alea*, chance; *mimicry*, simulation; and *ilinx*, vertigo, which Caillois described as the pursuit of a momentary destruction of the stability of perception, a kind of voluptuous panic. *Dark Souls* combines all four, but its most distinctive element is *ilinx*. The commonest death in the trilogy is the fall: from a bridge, a ledge, a buttress, a beam above a chasm. Its architecture is vertiginous by design, descended, as Chapter Two showed, from Piranesi's imaginary prisons; and its community's most notorious joke—the soapstone message urging the reader to try jumping, placed at the edge of a precipice—is a joke about *ilinx*. Caillois traced the ancient forms of vertigo to practices that sought in the loss of bodily orientation an access to the sacred, from the whirling of dervishes to the flight of the Mesoamerican *voladores*. In *Dark Souls* the vertigo of the fall is the vertigo of death itself, and the player's slow conquest of its heights is a training in standing at the edge of the abyss without being drawn in.

Gilles Deleuze, in *Différence et répétition* (1968), argued against the long philosophical habit of conceiving repetition as the return of the same. Repetition, for Deleuze, is the very production of difference, and he distinguished three syntheses of time through which it operates. The first is habit, the living present, which contracts past instants into a present tendency. The second is memory, the pure past in which all past instants coexist. The third is the eternal return, the empty form of time, which returns only difference and expels

the same; and Deleuze reinterpreted Freud's death drive not as a regression toward the inorganic but as this pure and empty form of repetition. The death loop of *Dark Souls* operates through all three syntheses. Each death is contracted into habit, sedimented in the hand as a tendency to dodge earlier, strike later, move otherwise. Each return draws on memory, the player's accumulating knowledge of the world's spaces, creatures, and histories. And the whole cycle is oriented toward a future that the trilogy figures, as section 6.3 will show, as an eternal return that selects only those who can affirm it.

Bernard Suits, in *The Grasshopper: Games, Life and Utopia* (1978), defined the playing of a game as the voluntary attempt to overcome unnecessary obstacles, and gave his book's hero, the grasshopper of Aesop's fable, an argument of startling ambition: in a utopia where every instrumental need had been satisfied, game-playing would be the only activity left worth doing, and would therefore be the ideal of existence itself. The world of *Dark Souls* inverts Suits's utopia. It is not a world in which every need has been met but one in which no need can finally be met: the fire is failing, death has been undone, no victory is permanent, and no project of the order can be completed. And yet the conclusion is the same. In a world where nothing productive can finally be achieved, play is the only activity that retains its sense, because play alone does not depend on its results. The Age of Fire, in its exhaustion, makes grasshoppers of everyone who remains in it.

6.3 *Ludic Ekpyrosis: The Cosmic Cycle at the Scale of the Hand*

Chapter One proposed, as the first corollary of pyrrhic ontology, that the formal loop of death and return in *Dark Souls* does not represent the cosmic conflagration and renewal of its world but performs it. The proposition can now be developed. The Stoics, from Zeno and Cleanthes to Chrysippus, held that nature is a craftsmanlike fire proceeding methodically toward generation—Zeno's definition, preserved by Diogenes Laertius, is πῦρ τεχνικὸν ὁδῷ βαδίζον εἰς γένεσιν—and that at fixed intervals the cosmos is resolved wholly into this fire in the *ekpyrosis*, the great conflagration, from which it is regenerated in the *palingenesia*, identical in every particular to the cosmos that burned. The loop of *Dark Souls* reproduces this structure at the scale of a single life. Death dissolves the player; the bonfire receives them; the world is regenerated, its creatures restored to their places as if nothing had happened; and the cycle begins again. Every death is a micro-*ekpyrosis*. But the game introduces into the Stoic cycle a difference the Stoics excluded. Their cosmos returned identical; the world of *Dark Souls* returns identical while the player returns changed, carrying into each new cycle the knowledge and skill the previous cycle deposited in the hand. The game's loop is an *ekpyrosis* with memory, in which the difference that Deleuze found at the heart of repetition is located in the one who repeats.

The trilogy extends this structure from the single life to the whole of play. When the player reaches an ending—whether they have linked the fire or refused it—the game begins again, in the mode called New Game Plus, with the player's character, attributes, and possessions intact: the world is the same, its enemies stronger, and the choice at its end the same choice. New Game Plus literalizes the cycle of linkings that the fiction narrates. Each playthrough is an Age of Fire; each ending is a linking or a refusal; and the next playthrough is its recurrence. The player who chooses to link the fire in each successive cycle repeats Gwyn's sacrifice as many times as Gwyn's successors did, and enters, as Chapter Five showed, the composite body of the Soul of Cinder. Nietzsche's demon, in the most famous section of *Die fröhliche Wissenschaft* (§341), creeps into the reader's loneliest loneliness to announce that this life, as it is now lived and has been lived, must be lived once more and innumerable times more, every pain and every joy returning in the same sequence, and asks: "Willst du diess noch einmal und noch unzählige Male?"—do you want this once more, and innumerable times more? The question, Nietzsche wrote, would lie upon every action as the heaviest weight. The player who begins a new cycle answers the demon. And the answer that Zarathustra learns to give, in the section "Vom Gesicht und Räthsel," is the answer the trilogy's most devoted players give with every new beginning: "War das das Leben? Wohlan! Noch Ein Mal!"—Was that life? Well then! Once more!

Heraclitus's fragment B52, chosen as this chapter's first epigraph, names the cosmic principle of which this repetition is the image. Aion—the span of a life, and in later Greek, eternity—is a child at play, moving the pieces of a board game; the kingship belongs to a child. Nietzsche, in *Die Philosophie im tragischen Zeitalter der Griechen*, read the fragment as Heraclitus's answer to Anaximander's pessimism. Where Anaximander saw in coming-to-be a guilt to be expiated by perishing, Heraclitus saw play: a building and destroying, a coming-to-be and passing away, without moral imputation and in forever equal innocence, such as belongs in this world only to the artist and the child. It is the same conviction that *Die Geburt der Tragödie* had expressed in its most quoted sentence, that only as an aesthetic phenomenon are existence and the world eternally justified. Eugen Fink's *Spiel als Weltsymbol* (1960) developed the fragment into a cosmology of play, in which human play is the symbol of a world that moves without ground and without purpose outside itself. Ludic ekpyrosis is the meeting point of these traditions. The hand that dies and returns, builds and destroys, plays the game that Heraclitus attributed to Aion and the Stoics to the craftsman fire. The player does not watch the cosmic cycle; the player is the child moving its pieces.

Zarathustra's first speech, "Von den drei Verwandlungen," whose final sentence supplies this chapter's second epigraph, describes three metamorphoses of the spirit. The spirit first becomes a camel, which kneels to take on the heaviest burdens and bears them into the desert under the command of "thou shalt." In the loneliest desert it becomes a lion, which

Figure 23 *Ludic ekpyrosis. The loop of death and return performs, at the scale of the hand, the cosmic conflagration and regeneration the game narrates; New Game Plus extends it from the single life to the whole of play.*

seizes its freedom and speaks a sacred No to the dragon of duty, replacing "thou shalt" with "I will." But the lion cannot create new values; for that, it must become a child: innocence and forgetting, a new beginning, a game, a self-propelling wheel, a first movement, a sacred Yes. The trilogy invites its players through the same metamorphoses. The first passage through the game is the camel's: the player bears the burden of its difficulty and obeys the prophecy, ringing the bells, filling the vessel, walking to the Kiln. The second is the lion's: the refusal of the order's terms, figured in the trilogy as the walk away from the Kiln, the prince who will not link, the usurpation of the flame. The third is the child's: the player who returns to the game freely, in new cycles and self-imposed challenges, in the duels and ornaments and rituals of its communities, playing without burden and without the need of a prophecy to justify the play.

The child's first attribute, after innocence, is forgetting—and here the theory of ludic ekpyrosis touches the curse of Hollowing, which Chapter Four associated with the loss of memory. Nietzsche distinguished two kinds of forgetting. In the second essay of *Zur Genealogie der Moral* (1887) he argued that forgetfulness is not a mere inertia of the mind but an active and positive faculty, a doorkeeper of psychic order that closes the doors of consciousness for a time so that there may be room for the new; without it, there could be no happiness, no cheerfulness, no hope, no present. The trilogy contains both forgettings. The Hollow forgets passively: memory dissolves, and with it the self and every bond. The child forgets actively: it lets go of each failure in order to begin again. The player who, after the hundredth death at the same threshold, releases the frustration of the last attempt and approaches the fog gate as if for the first time practises the child's forgetting, and this practice is precisely what protects them from the Hollow's. The rest at the bonfire, which resets the world, is the outward form of this inward forgetting. The Undead must learn the second forgetting in order to escape the first.

Chapter Two left a promise to be kept: that the player of *Dark Souls* practises *tapas* in both of the senses the Sanskrit word bears. The *Nāsadīya* hymn describes the One as born by the power of *tapas*, heat; and the same word names the ascetic discipline whose practitioners, as Mircea Eliade documented in *Le Yoga: immortalité et liberté* (1954), were believed to generate within themselves a magical inner heat. In *Le Chamanisme et les techniques archaïques de l'extase* (1951), Eliade described the shaman as a master of fire, able to handle embers and endure heat, a mastery acquired through an initiation that is itself a death and a rebirth: the candidate, in vision, is killed and dismembered by spirits, his bones counted and reassembled, and he returns as one who has passed through death and learned its ways. The death loop of *Dark Souls* is an initiatory ordeal of this kind, and the skill it produces is an inner heat: the fire generated in the practitioner by discipline. The two meanings of *tapas* meet in the player. The cosmogonic fire that the game narrates is performed by the ascetic fire that the game cultivates. Ludic ekpyrosis is *tapas*: the cosmos

kindled, in measures and quenched in measures, in the practice of the one who plays.

6.4 *The Phaedonic Machine: Spiritual Exercise, Tarrying with the Negative, the Great Death*

Chapter One called *Dark Souls* a Phaedonic machine, a device for the practice of dying that Plato's Socrates identified with philosophy itself. The claim can now be given its full content. Pierre Hadot's reconstruction of ancient philosophy, in *Exercices spirituels et philosophie antique* (1981) and *Qu'est-ce que la philosophie antique?* (1995), showed that the philosophical schools of antiquity understood themselves not primarily as producers of doctrine but as schools of life, whose students were transformed by daily exercises: attention (*prosochē*), the Stoic's continual vigilance over the present moment and over the movements of the self; the memorization and meditation of principles, so that they might be ready to hand in every circumstance; the *praemeditatio malorum*, the rehearsal in advance of misfortunes; the "view from above," which sees human affairs from the standpoint of the cosmos; and, at the root of all of them, the exercise of death. Hadot read the *Phaedo*'s practice of dying as the passage from the individual and passionate perspective to the universal one, a dying to the partial self. Michel Foucault, in the lectures of 1981–82 published as *L'Herméneutique du sujet*, described the same practices as the care of the self (*epimeleia heautou*) and its *askēsis*: not a renunciation of the world but an equipment of the self, a *paraskeuē*, that prepares it to meet whatever events may come.

The practice of *Dark Souls* is an exercise in each of these senses. It demands, first, *prosochē*: an attention so complete that the slightest lapse—a missed wind-up, a misjudged distance, an unnoticed sound—is punished with death, while attention sustained is rewarded with survival. The game trains its player to dwell in the present moment, which the Stoics held to be the only time in which we live. It demands, second, memory. Its world must be learned by heart, route by route and room by room, until the player can traverse it in imagination. Frances Yates's *The Art of Memory* (1966) recovered the classical technique by which orators fixed their discourses in the mind by assigning images to places (*loci*) along a remembered architecture; Lordran, learned locus by locus through repeated death, is a memory palace in exactly this sense, an architecture in which each place holds the image of what happened there. It offers, third, a *praemeditatio malorum* externalized and shared: the messages that warn of an ambush ahead, of a trap to the right, of a danger behind the door, are rehearsals of misfortune bequeathed by those who suffered it. It teaches, fourth, the acceptance of loss, which Chapter Four found at the bloodstain. And it transforms, fifth, the one who practises it. The equipment the player finally carries is not

chiefly the armour and weapons of the inventory but a disposition: patience, steadiness under failure, the capacity to begin again without resentment. This is *paraskeuē* in Foucault's sense, and it outlasts the game.

Hegel supplies the speculative form of this transformation. Chapter Three cited the preface to the *Phänomenologie des Geistes*, in which the life of spirit is said to be not the life that shrinks from death but the life that endures it and maintains itself in it, looking the negative in the face and tarrying with it (*bei ihm verweilt*). Hegel continued: "Dieses Verweilen ist die Zauberkraft, die es in das Sein umkehrt"—this tarrying is the magical power that converts the negative into being. The player who returns to the place of their destruction, who stands again before the fog gate behind which they have died twenty times, who looks at the thing that killed them and does not look away, is tarrying with the negative. And the magic of *Dark Souls* is not its sorcery but this conversion: the transformation of death into skill, of failure into the being of a self that can do what it could not do before.

The Zen tradition, which shaped the culture in which the trilogy was made, names this transformation with a starkness that Western philosophy rarely matches. In Rinzai practice, the student's struggle with a *kōan* generates what is called the Great Doubt (大疑, *taigi*): a total impasse, in which reason can make no further progress, which culminates in the Great Death (大死, *daishi*), the dropping away of the ego that clung to its own perspective, from which the Great Life emerges as awakening. Hakuin Ekaku (1686–1769), who revived Rinzai practice in Japan and devised the *kōan* of the sound of one hand, insisted that at the bottom of great doubt lies great awakening, and that the *kōan* is not solved by thought but by becoming one with it. One of the cases of the *Blue Cliff Record* (*Hekiganroku*, case 41) turns on Zhaozhou's question to Touzi: what of the one who has died the great death and comes back to life? The player of *Dark Souls* is the one who has died the great death and comes back to life. The encounter that cannot be passed by reasoning, only by a transformation of the whole body until the movements of the adversary are known as one knows one's own breath, functions as a *kōan*; and the blood-red words that fill the screen at every death fall like the stick of the meditation master, interrupting every scheme of the discursive mind. Nishitani Keiji, in *Shūkyō to wa nanika* (1961; English *Religion and Nothingness*), argued that nihilism cannot be overcome by flight but only by passing through it to its bottom, where the nihility that dissolves every meaning opens onto the field of emptiness (*śūnyatā*), in which the self is realized as non-self and all things are realized in their suchness. The trilogy's player passes through nihility, through hundreds of meaningless deaths in a world whose meaning is failing, and finds at the bottom of that passage not despair but a practice.

The four traditions—the Platonic practice of dying, the spiritual exercises of the Hellenistic schools, Hegel's tarrying with the negative, and the Great Death of Zen—converge on a single claim: that death, rehearsed rather than merely contemplated, transforms the

one who rehearses it. The arts of the West have long made death their subject. Tragedy represents it, and purges its audience by pity and fear; the novel narrates it; painting depicts it, in the *memento mori* and the *vanitas*, setting a skull among the instruments of worldly vanity. But in all these arts the audience survives the death it contemplates. Videogames had killed their players for decades before *Dark Souls*; what the trilogy did was to make the killing a curriculum, the substance of the work rather than its interruption, so that its audience could receive the work only by dying in it, repeatedly, and learning from each death. In this precise sense *Dark Souls* is the first great Phaedonic machine of popular culture: an artwork whose form of reception is the *melétē thanátou* itself.

6.5 *The Trace of the Other: Levinas, the Inoperative Community, Ichigo Ichie*

Emmanuel Levinas, in *Totalité et infini* (1961), proposed that ethics, not ontology, is first philosophy, and located its origin in the encounter with the face of the Other (*le visage d'autrui*): an epiphany that resists every attempt to comprehend or possess it, and whose first word is a command, thou shalt not kill. Responsibility for the Other, on this account, precedes the self's freedom and constitutes it; the Other appears in the figures of the stranger, the widow, and the orphan, who have nothing to offer but their need. In the essay "La trace de l'autre" (1963) and in *Autrement qu'être ou au-delà de l'essence* (1974), Levinas deepened the analysis with the concept of the trace. The Other signifies not as a presence but as the trace of one who has already passed—the mark of a past that was never present, an immemorial passage—and the self's responsibility for the Other is so radical that Levinas named it substitution: the self as hostage, answerable for the Other's suffering and even for the Other's death.

The sociality of *Dark Souls* is a sociality of the trace. The Other is almost never encountered face to face. The phantoms who come to aid the player appear as glowing figures without voices, able, in the first game, to communicate only by gestures; invaders come masked and hostile; and the dominant forms in which other players are present are traces. The message on the ground is a sign left by someone who has passed this way and gone. The bloodstain, when touched, replays the final seconds of a stranger's death—a death the player never witnessed, made briefly visible as a ghostly re-enactment of a past that was never present to them. Faint figures of other players flicker through the same spaces in their own worlds and vanish. And it is from these traces, not from faces, that the ethical demand of the trilogy arises. A warning written beside a trap was written, in all likelihood, by someone who died in it; the death of the Other becomes, through its trace, the condition of the reader's survival. Its author took responsibility for a stranger they

would never meet, and the reader, who survives because of it, inherits that responsibility and often discharges it in turn by writing a warning for whoever comes next. The structure is Levinasian substitution in miniature: in *Dark Souls*, every death is potentially a gift, because it leaves a trace from which another may learn to live.

Chapter Three promised a return to the Gnostic "Hymn of the Pearl," in which a prince sent to a foreign land to recover a pearl forgets his mission and his birth, and is awakened only by a letter from his kin that flies to him in the likeness of an eagle, alights beside him, and becomes speech. At its voice he remembers who he is, recovers the pearl, and returns home. The messages of *Dark Souls* are such letters. Written by unknown kin and left upon the ground, they reach the player in moments of despair and forgetting—at the threshold of a battle lost twenty times, in the dark of a region whose purpose has been forgotten—and recall them to themselves: with encouragement, with a jest, with the simple evidence that someone else has stood here and gone on. The trilogy's most famous gesture, the outstretched arms with which Solaire of Astora praises the sun, has become, among its players, the emblem of exactly this solidarity; Solaire's own phrase for the help he offers, "jolly cooperation," names an ethic the community adopted as its own. Chapter Four argued that the Hollow is the one who has forgotten, and that what preserves the Undead from Hollowing is purpose. The Hymn of the Pearl suggests that purpose is not always self-generated. Sometimes it arrives as a letter from a stranger.

The community that these traces constitute has a philosophical form, which Chapter Three anticipated. Giorgio Agamben, in *La comunità che viene* (1990), described a coming community of whatever singularities, bound together by no condition of belonging—no identity, no nation, no class—but by belonging itself. Jean-Luc Nancy, in *La Communauté désœuvrée* (1986), argued against every conception of community as a work or a project, as the fusion of individuals into a collective subject, and proposed instead that community is the sharing of finitude, the exposure of singular beings to one another, revealed above all in the death of others; Maurice Blanchot's response, *La Communauté inavouable* (1983), and Alphonso Lingis's *The Community of Those Who Have Nothing in Common* (1994) extended the thought. The community of *Dark Souls* is inoperative in Nancy's sense and whatever in Agamben's. It has no work and no project; its members know nothing of one another but their traces; anyone may summon or be summoned, and the only condition of belonging is to be in the same place, at the same moment, in another world. And it is constituted, visibly and literally, by the sharing of death. The bloodstains that cover the floors of its most difficult places are the evidence of a community founded on shared finitude: each stain a death that was also, for someone else, a lesson.

The Japanese aesthetics of encounter names the form these meetings take. The phrase *ichigo ichie* (一期一会), "one time, one meeting," was given its classic formulation by the tea master and statesman Ii Naosuke in *Chanoyu ichie shū* (1858), developing a teaching

attributed to Yamanoue Sōji, a disciple of Sen no Rikyū: every gathering for tea is unique and will never recur, and host and guests should therefore give themselves wholly to it. The summoning of a phantom in *Dark Souls* is *ichigo ichie*. Two strangers meet once, fight together through a single passage of danger, and part for ever; the phantom vanishes the instant the boss falls; there are, in the first game, no names exchanged, no friendship formed, no future promised. The meeting's value lies entirely in its singularity, as Miyazaki's founding anecdote of the strangers on the snowbound slope already suggested. Yoshida Kenkō, in the *Tsurezuregusa* (c. 1330), observed that if human beings did not vanish like the dew, things would lose their power to move us, and that the most precious thing in life is its uncertainty. The phantom's disappearance is what gives the meeting its weight.

The form has had descendants that confirm its ethical potential. thatgamecompany's *Journey* (2012) paired its players with anonymous companions who could communicate only by a single musical call, and revealed their names only in the closing credits. Kojima Productions' *Death Stranding* (2019) made the asynchronous building of roads, bridges, and shelters for strangers its central mechanic, and its theme the reconnection of a fractured world. But *Dark Souls* differs from its descendants in one essential respect: its Other may also be an enemy. The same system that brings a helper into the player's world brings invaders; the same messages that warn may deceive. The trace, like the gift, is a *pharmakon*. The ethics of the ember is therefore not a utopian ethics of a community without danger. It must be practised in a world where the stranger who arrives may have come to help or to kill, and where the decision to leave a true sign for the next traveller is made without any assurance of its reception.

6.6 *Authorial Kenosis: The Withdrawal of the Maker*

Chapter One promised a description of the trilogy's narrative method as *authorial kenosis*. The term derives from the hymn that Paul quotes in his letter to the Philippians (2:6–7), which says of Christ that, being in the form of God, he did not count equality with God a thing to be grasped, but emptied himself—ἑαυτὸν ἐκένωσεν—taking the form of a slave. Kenosis, self-emptying, became in modern theology the name for a divine self-limitation: in the Lutheran kenoticism of Gottfried Thomasius in the mid-nineteenth century, in the Russian kenotic tradition, and, most radically, in the thought of Simone Weil, for whom creation itself was an act of divine renunciation, God withdrawing so that something other than God might exist, and who asked of the creature a corresponding *décréation*, an undoing of the self that would let the uncreated pass through it. The Lurianic doctrine of *tzimtzum*, discussed in Chapter Three, belongs to the same family of ideas: creation begins not with an outpouring but with a contraction, a withdrawal of the infinite to make room for the finite. Hans Jonas, in his lecture on the concept of God after Auschwitz (1984), took

the thought to its extreme, proposing a God who in creating had renounced omnipotence and given himself over to the becoming of the world.

The narrative method of *Dark Souls* is a kenosis of its author. It withholds exposition, explanation, and judgment; it offers no authoritative narrator, no codex, no final word on what its world means; its maker withdraws from what he has made. And when the authorial voice does speak, it takes, in the most literal sense the medium allows, the form of a slave. Its vehicle is the item description: the humblest genre of game text, the note attached to a key, a ring, a scrap of armour, written in the voice of no one. The trilogy's deepest meanings are carried in the inventory, in the voice of things. Miyazaki's characteristic reticence in interviews about the correct interpretation of his worlds extends the same withdrawal beyond the text. The author declines to adjudicate the meanings his work has generated, leaving them to those who play.

This kenosis mirrors the cosmogony. Chapter Two argued that the *Dark Souls* cosmogony is anarchic: its fire has no maker, and nothing authorizes it. The author performs, at the level of the work, the absence that the fiction narrates at the level of the cosmos. And the gods of the fiction perform it too. Gwyn has gone into the Kiln; the true Gwynevere, according to the lore of her ring, has left Anor Londo as the bride of Flann, the god of flame, together with many of the other deities; the city of the gods is held together by the illusion of a son who stayed behind. The world the player enters is a house from which its makers and its gods have withdrawn. Hölderlin's elegy "Brod und Wein" (1800–01) gave this condition its classic modern expression: "Aber Freund! wir kommen zu spät. Zwar leben die Götter, / Aber über dem Haupt droben in anderer Welt"—but, friend, we have come too late; the gods are living, yes, but above our heads, up there in another world. And the same stanza asks the question that Heidegger would make the title of an essay of 1946: "wozu Dichter in dürftiger Zeit?"—what are poets for, in a destitute time? The player of *Dark Souls* arrives in Lordran too late, after the gods. The question the trilogy poses, in Hölderlin's form, is what a player is for in a time of embers.

Roland Barthes ended his essay on the death of the author by declaring that the birth of the reader must be paid for by the author's death. *Dark Souls* makes this payment by design, and the commentary tradition described in Chapter One is its consequence. Here a Pauline pairing acquires a new sense. Against the *kenōsis* of Philippians stands the *plērōma* of Colossians, the fullness of deity that dwells bodily in Christ (2:9), and the same word named, in the Gnostic systems, the divine fullness from which Sophia fell. In *Dark Souls*, the author's emptying is answered by the community's fullness. What the maker withheld, the players supply; the work is completed not in its text but in the vast collective labour of interpretation, cartography, translation, and dispute that its emptiness called into being. The author contracted, in the Lurianic sense, to make room; the players filled the room.

Kenosis has, finally, an ethical significance that the remaining chapters will develop. It

is the form of creation proper to the ember: a making that withdraws in order to let others be. The trilogy offers three instances of this gesture at three different levels—the divine withdrawal within the fiction, the authorial withdrawal from the fiction, and, at the end of the third game, the Painter who will make a new world not for herself but for those who will live in it. Chapter Seven will argue that these are three moments of a single gesture: creation as the making of room.

6.7 *Comparative Loops: Bergman, Groundhog Day, Edge of Tomorrow, Hollow Knight, Outer Wilds, Nostalghia*

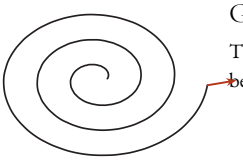
The loop of death and return is not unique to *Dark Souls*, and its distinctiveness emerges most clearly when it is set beside its neighbours across media.

Ingmar Bergman's *Det sjunde inseglet* (1957) opens on a desolate shore, where the knight Antonius Block, returned from the Crusades to a Sweden ravaged by plague, finds Death waiting for him and challenges him to a game of chess. Block knows that he cannot win. He plays to buy time—time to understand, and time to perform one meaningful deed before the end. His journey through the stricken land passes a procession of flagellants and the burning of a young woman accused of witchcraft, whom Block questions in the hope that she has seen the devil and can therefore offer some proof of a beyond; she has seen nothing. At the last, seeing that Death intends to take a family of travelling players—the juggler Jof, his wife Mia, and their child—Block overturns the chessboard to distract his opponent, and the family escapes. The film closes on Jof's vision of Death leading the others in a dance across the hills. Every element of Bergman's film has its counterpart in the trilogy: the knight who has returned from a holy war to a plague-ridden land; the game against Death that cannot be won; the flagellants, whose descendant is Father Ariandel, scourging himself in the Painted World of the third game; the burning of a scapegoat. And Block's one meaningful deed is the ethic this thesis has been describing. He does not defeat Death; he uses the time of the game to shelter the vulnerable. It is fitting that those he saves are players.

Harold Ramis's *Groundhog Day* (1993) gave the loop its most popular modern form. A cynical weatherman relives the same day in a small Pennsylvania town, passing through exploitation, despair, and at last self-cultivation and service—learning the piano, sculpting ice, saving the same lives day after day—until the loop releases him as someone who has learned to live the day well. The film has been read, by Buddhist and Nietzschean commentators alike, as a parable of *saṃsāra* and of eternal recurrence. Its difference from *Dark Souls* is structural: Phil Connors's loop is a test, and it ends when he passes; the loop of the Undead is a condition, and it does not end. But the film's answer to the question

Det sjunde inseglet *Ingmar Bergman, 1957*

A game against Death that cannot be won, played for time: time to understand, and to perform one meaningful deed. The knight overturns the board so that a family of travelling players may escape.



Groundhog Day *Harold Ramis, 1993*

The loop as a test, which ends when it is passed. What makes the repetition bearable is not escape from it but a practice of care within it.

Edge of Tomorrow *Doug Liman, 2014, after Sakurazaka Hiroshi, 2004*

Live, die, repeat: the death-loop as a training, and as an instrument. It ends when the war is won; the war of the Undead cannot be won.

Hollow Knight *Team Cherry, 2017*

Vessels born of the Void, made hollow to contain a light that would destroy them. The valuation is inverted: light is the plague, the dark the instrument of salvation.

Outer Wilds *Mobius Digital, 2019*

A loop of twenty-two minutes that ends in a supernova. Only knowledge carries over: a loop of *gnosis*, closing in acceptance around a campfire as a new universe begins.

Nostalghia *Andrei Tarkovsky, 1983*

The pyre and the candle: a small flame carried across the drained pool, guttering out, relit, carried again, and set down on the far ledge.

Dark Souls *FromSoftware, 2011–2017*

The loop as a condition, which does not end. What carries over is skill sedimented in the hand and substance carried in the bloodstain: a loop of *askēsis*.

Figure 24 *Comparative loops: the death-and-return structure of* Dark Souls *set beside its neighbours across media.*

of how a loop can be borne coincides with the trilogy's. What makes repetition bearable is not escape from it but a practice of care within it.

Doug Liman's *Edge of Tomorrow* (2014), adapted from Sakurazaka Hiroshi's novel *All You Need Is Kill* (2004), is the closest cinematic analogue to the mechanics of the trilogy. A soldier killed in battle against an alien invasion wakes on the morning of the previous day, and through hundreds of deaths learns to fight, guided by a veteran who once possessed the same power; the film was marketed with a phrase that might stand as the formula of *Dark Souls*: live, die, repeat. The Japanese provenance of the source, published five years before *Demon's Souls*, suggests a convergent imagination of the death-loop as a training. Yet here too the loop is instrumental. It ends when the war is won, whereas the war the Undead fight—against the fading of the fire—cannot be won, and the trilogy knows it.

Team Cherry's *Hollow Knight* (2017) is the most searching response to *Dark Souls* that another game has produced, and it reads as a commentary on the trilogy's metaphysics. The Pale King of the insect kingdom of Hallownest, seeking to contain the Radiance, a goddess of light whose infection drives his subjects mad, created vessels born of the Void: hollow beings meant to have no mind, no will, and no voice, so that they might hold the light without being corrupted by it. One of them, the Hollow Knight, was sealed with the infection inside the Black Egg Temple; the player-character is another, and may take the Hollow Knight's place in the seal—a linking of the fire in all but name—or, in the game's deeper endings, confront the Radiance itself and turn the Void against it. *Hollow Knight* inverts the trilogy's valuation openly: light is the plague, and the dark is the instrument of salvation. The Pale King's motto, inscribed in his palace, might be the motto of the Age of Fire: no cost too great. And his hollow vessel fuses the Lordvessel and the Chosen Undead into a single figure—a being made empty in order to contain a light that will destroy it—sealed, like Filianore, within an egg.

Mobius Digital's *Outer Wilds* (2019), already discussed in Chapter Two, offers the most illuminating contrast of all. Its loop, too, ends in death every twenty-two minutes; but nothing carries over from one cycle to the next except knowledge—the entries of the ship's log and the player's growing understanding of the universe. There are no levels to gain, no equipment to keep, no skill gates of any consequence. *Outer Wilds* is a loop of *gnosis*: salvation by knowledge. *Dark Souls* is a loop of *askēsis*: salvation by practice, in which what carries over is skill sedimented in the hand and substance carried in the bloodstain. The two games map the two great forms of learning that the religious traditions surveyed in this thesis have opposed and combined, and their endings correspond to their forms. *Outer Wilds* ends in contemplative acceptance around a campfire, its travellers assembling their music as the old universe passes and a new one begins. *Dark Souls* ends at a bonfire, with a choice of practice: to give oneself to the fire, to walk away from it, or—in the third game—to let it be carried into the dark.

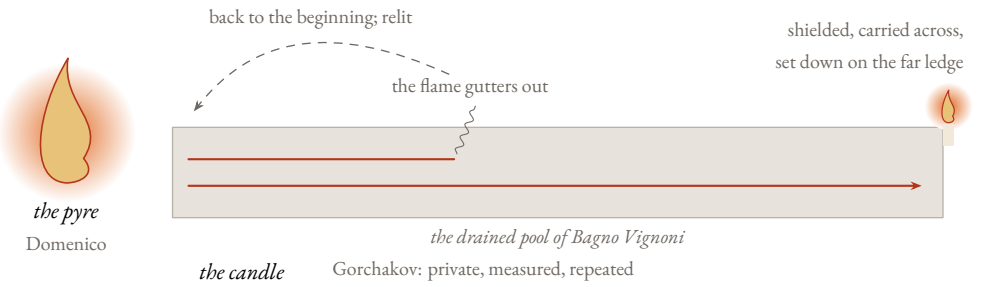


Figure 25 *Two relations to fire in Tarkovsky's* Nostalghia*: the pyre, a public self-immolation for the world, and the candle, carried across the drained pool, relit when it gutters out, and carried again.*

Andrei Tarkovsky's *Nostalghia* (1983) supplies, finally, the image in which the ethical alternative of the trilogy is most exactly staged. Domenico, a recluse whom the townspeople of Bagno Vignoni regard as mad, believes that the world might be saved if someone carried a lit candle across the drained thermal pool of Santa Caterina; the people have never let him try. Later, in Rome, he climbs the equestrian statue of Marcus Aurelius on the Capitoline, delivers a speech to an indifferent crowd, and sets himself on fire while a recording of Beethoven's Ninth Symphony falters and breaks off. Meanwhile the Russian poet Gorchakov, himself dying, returns to Bagno Vignoni to fulfil Domenico's wish. In a single long take, he carries the candle across the empty pool. It goes out. He returns to the beginning, relights it, and sets out again, shielding the flame with his coat; at last he reaches the far side, sets the candle on the ledge, and collapses. Tarkovsky's film presents, side by side, two relations to fire. One is the pyre: Domenico's public self-immolation for the salvation of the world, an Empedoclean sacrifice and, in the terms of this thesis, a linking of the fire. The other is the candle: Gorchakov's private, measured, futile, repeated carrying of a small flame across an emptied space—the ember. Tarkovsky honours both. But the film's weight falls on the candle, and so, this thesis argues, does the trilogy's.

6.8 *The Candle and the Pyre: Play as Sovereign Expenditure*

The chapter's findings compose a single account of what it is to play *Dark Souls*. The bonfire at which every life begins and ends is at once hearth and grave, a bone-fire fed with the remains of the Undead, a place of reverie in which the longing for the pyre is rehearsed, a colonial flame carried out from the mother-hearth of Firelink, the welcoming fire at which the dead arrive home, and the stage-light under which ghosts are summoned. The loop that returns the player to it is a *fort/da* that converts the trauma of death into a game of mastery, and a repetition that produces difference rather than sameness. It performs, at the scale of the hand, the cosmic cycle of conflagration and renewal that the Stoics placed at the heart of the world, and in its new cycles it answers Nietzsche's demon with Zarathustra's "once more," passing from the camel's burden through the lion's refusal to the child's play. It cultivates *tapas*, the inner fire of discipline that is also, in the Vedic hymn, the fire from which the cosmos was born. It is a Phaedonic machine, a curriculum of dying conducted through attention, memory, rehearsal, and the acceptance of loss: the tarrying with the negative that converts death into being, and the Great Death from which the practitioner returns to life. Its sociality is the trace of the Other, constituting an inoperative community of whatever singularities founded on the sharing of finitude, whose meetings, once and never again, have the form of *ichigo ichie*. Its author has withdrawn from it, as its gods have withdrawn from their city, so that its players might fill the room. And among the loops of other works, its closest kin is not the test of *Groundhog Day* nor the war of *Edge of Tomorrow* but the candle of *Nostalghia*.

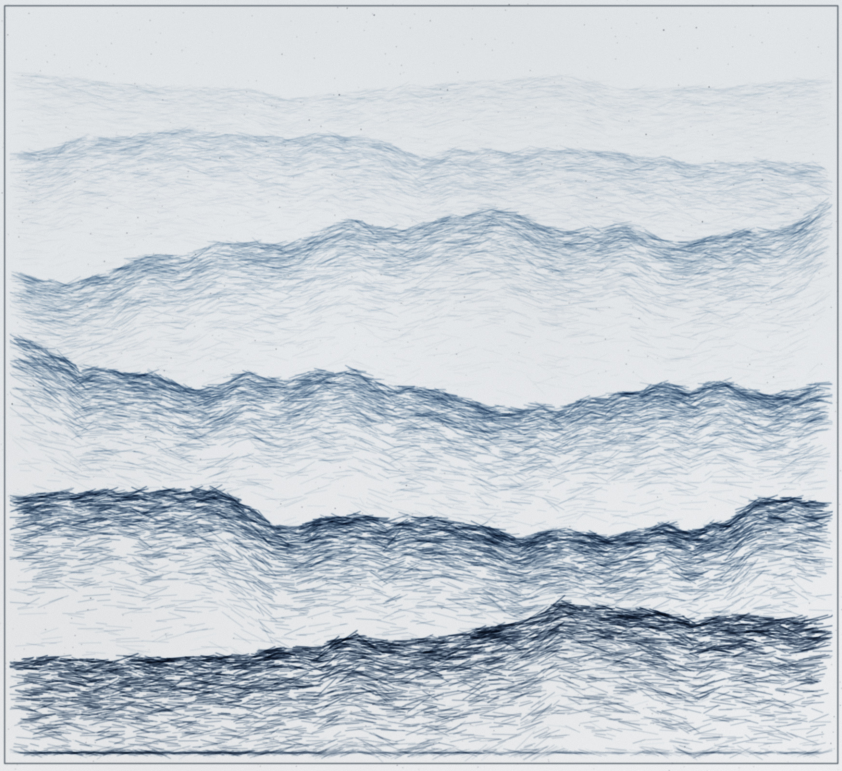
The chapter's thesis follows. Play, in *Dark Souls*, is the sovereign expenditure that the Age of Fire's sovereign never achieved. Chapter Five showed that Gwyn's sacrifice was servile—an investment in the preservation of an order—and that the accursed share of the general economy reappears in the trilogy only in the useless, glorious expenditure of play and in the anonymous gift between strangers. The present chapter has shown that play and gift are joined in the practice of the player: the death that teaches the hand also leaves a trace that teaches another; the exercise that transforms the self also leaves signs for those who come after. This joined practice is what this thesis calls the ember.

Tarkovsky's two fires give the distinction its final image. The pyre is the linking: Gwyn's servile sacrifice, the Empedoclean longing that every rest at the bonfire rehearses, the public immolation of the self for the salvation of a world that does not listen. The candle is the ember: a small flame, carried across an emptied world, shielded with the body, extinguished and relit and carried again, its futility known and accepted, for the sake of something—or someone—on the far side. The pyre burns once, and completely. The candle can go out, and be lit again. The mechanics of *Dark Souls* are built for the candle. Every death extinguishes the small flame of a life, and every return relights it; the whole of play is a

crossing of the drained pool, again and again, with a light that will not stay lit.

The ember is not yet the whole of the trilogy's answer, for the trilogy does not end with the player. Its final game turns from the practice of the one who plays to the fate of the world in which they play: to the convergence of exhausted kingdoms, to the ash that remains when the fire has burned too long, to the endings in which the flame is linked, seized, or carried into the dark—and to a painter at the end of the world, who asks for the blood of the Dark Soul to make a new one. Chapter Seven turns to *Dark Souls III* as the late style of the trilogy, and to the cold and gentle eschaton toward which it has been moving.

VII



Chapter Seven

The Painted World

Ash, Late Style, and the Cryotopian Eschaton

Wo eine Kette von Begebenheiten vor uns erscheint, da sieht er eine einzige Katastrophe, die unablässig Trümmer auf Trümmer häuft und sie ihm vor die Füße schleudert.

"Where a chain of events appears before us, he sees one single catastrophe, which keeps piling wreckage upon wreckage and hurls it before his feet."

— *Benjamin, "Über den Begriff der Geschichte" (1940), IX*

il y a là cendre

"There is ash, there."

— *Derrida,* Feu la cendre *(1987)*

7.1 Late Style: Dark Souls III and the Art of the Ending

Dark Souls III (2016) was widely presented, by its director among others, as the conclusion of the series, and with its two expansions it closes the trilogy. Miyazaki, returning to direct after the interlude of the second game, made a work that is self-consciously an ending. Its world is ash. Its lands converge. Its places return from the first game in ruined form; its music quotes the music of the first game; its final adversary is the composite of everyone who ever linked the fire; and its endings concern not the continuation of the cycle but its exhaustion. To read it is to read a late work, and the concept of late style supplies the frame.

Theodor W. Adorno, in his fragment on the late style of Beethoven (1937), observed that the maturity of the late works of significant artists does not resemble the ripeness of fruit. They are not round but furrowed, even ravaged; they lack sweetness; they refuse the harmonious synthesis that classicism promised. In them, Adorno argued, the conventions of the form are not dissolved by the artist's subjectivity but left standing, bare and unreconciled, as the subject breaks out of the work and leaves behind only fragments—and so, in his closing sentence, in the history of art late works are the catastrophes. Edward Said took up Adorno's idea in *On Late Style* (2006), describing a lateness that is not serenity but intransigence, a refusal of resolution that leaves contradictions standing. Among his examples was Giuseppe Tomasi di Lampedusa's *Il Gattopardo* (1958), in which an aristocratic prince contemplates his own death and the extinction of the order to which he belongs, knowing that the forms of his world will survive only as empty ceremony under new masters. Lampedusa's prince, watching the passing of an age whose gods are departing, would recognize Lothric.

Dark Souls III leaves the conventions of the trilogy standing as ruins. Firelink Shrine returns, but as a different shrine: a hall of thrones for the Lords of Cinder, tended by a Fire Keeper whose eyes have been taken from her. Anor Londo returns, darkened, its god of illusions devoured by the cannibal Aldrich. The Kiln of the First Flame returns as the arena of the Soul of Cinder, whose second phase, as Chapter Five observed, takes up the movements of Gwyn and a variation on his theme. Beyond a hidden path lies the Untended Graves, a darkened mirror of the game's own opening, beneath an eclipsed sun, where an abandoned Firelink stands empty: the ruin of the game's own beginning, found near its end. Even the trilogy's families return as ruins of themselves: a knight of Catarina, in the tradition of the cheerful Siegmeyer, still wandering in his onion-shaped armour; the trickster Patches, still setting his traps. The work quotes itself as rubble.

And the late style of *Dark Souls III* is a catastrophe in Adorno's sense: it refuses reconciliation. Tolkien, in "On Fairy-Stories" (1947), named as *eucatastrophe* the sudden joyous turn by which the fairy-story denies final defeat and gives a fleeting glimpse of joy

beyond the walls of the world, and held this consolation to be the highest function of fantasy. Michael Moorcock, in his polemic "Epic Pooh" (1978), attacked precisely this consolation as a comfortable evasion. The trilogy sides with Moorcock. None of its endings is a eucatastrophe; none restores the world. But neither is the trilogy simply bleak. It finds, as the following sections will show, a different and more minimal consolation: not joy beyond the walls of the world, but gentleness within its dark.

Two further frames describe the trilogy's sense of an ending. Hegel's lectures on aesthetics pronounced that art, considered in its highest vocation, is and remains for us a thing of the past—"nach der Seite ihrer höchsten Bestimmung für uns ein Vergangenes." *Dark Souls III* is, among other things, a meditation on the exhaustion of its own form: a game that treats the bonfire, the death loop, and the linking of the fire—the conventions the trilogy invented and its imitators multiplied—as an inheritance grown old. And Oswald Spengler's *Der Untergang des Abendlandes* (1918–22), which described every culture as passing through the seasons of an organism toward a late phase of ossified civilization, supplies the political image of that exhaustion. The royal house of Lothric, devoted to the breeding of an heir whose only purpose is to be burned, its Grand Archives a labyrinth of dangerous learning, its rites performed long after their meaning has gone, is a late civilization in Spengler's sense; and it recalls, still more closely, the castle of Mervyn Peake's *Titus Groan* (1946) and *Gormenghast* (1950), where the Earls of Groan perform from birth to death a ritual whose books no one understands and whose purpose no one can remember. Lothric is a Gormenghast of the fire: an order that has become entirely the maintenance of its own ceremony, and whose heir, like Titus Groan, would rather leave.

7.2 *The Angel of History: Convergence, the Dreg Heap, and Ruin*

The ninth of Walter Benjamin's theses on the concept of history, written in 1940 in the months before his death, takes as its emblem Paul Klee's *Angelus Novus* (1920), a drawing Benjamin owned. The angel of history, Benjamin wrote, has his face turned toward the past. Where we perceive a chain of events, he sees one single catastrophe, which keeps piling wreckage upon wreckage and hurling it at his feet. He would like to stay, to awaken the dead and make whole what has been smashed. But a storm is blowing from Paradise; it has caught in his wings with such violence that he can no longer close them; and it drives him irresistibly into the future to which his back is turned, while the pile of debris before him grows toward the sky. "Das, was wir den Fortschritt nennen, ist dieser Sturm"—what we call progress is this storm.

The world of *Dark Souls III* realizes Benjamin's image with an exactness that makes it the central allegory of the trilogy's late style. As the fire fades, the transitory lands of the Lords of Cinder are drawn together toward Lothric, so that kingdoms of different ages—

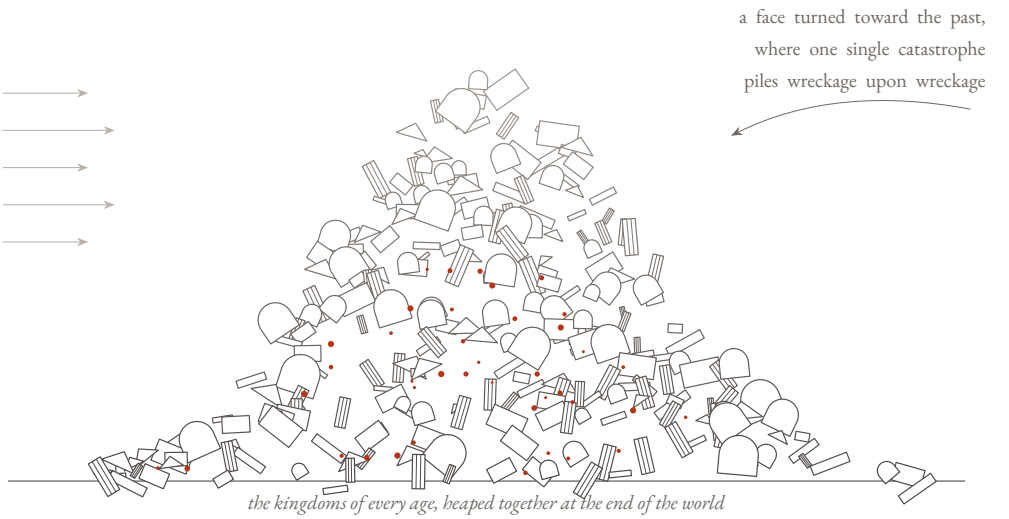


Figure 26 *The Dreg Heap after Benjamin's ninth thesis: the kingdoms of every age heaped together at the end of the world.*

the Profaned Capital, the swamps of Farron, the moonlit city of Irithyll, the darkened Anor Londo—lie crowded against one another, joined by no history except their common decline. In *The Ringed City* the convergence reaches its terminus in the Dreg Heap: the kingdoms of every age heaped together at the end of the world, a mountain of wreckage down which the player climbs. It is the angel's pile of debris, grown skyward. The player stands where the angel stands, face turned toward the ruins of the past, unable to make whole what has been smashed; and the storm that piles up the wreckage is the fading of the fire, propelled by the very linkings that were meant to preserve the age. Every linking prolonged the Age of Fire and multiplied its ruins. The angel's wish—to awaken the dead and make whole what has been smashed—is the wish of the linking itself, and the trilogy's verdict on it is Benjamin's: the storm cannot be resisted from within the history it drives.

Georg Simmel's essay "Die Ruine" (1907) supplies the phenomenology of what the player sees. Architecture, for Simmel, is the art in which the upward-striving will of the spirit and the downward pull of matter achieve a precarious balance; the ruin is the moment at which that balance tips, and nature begins to reclaim the work of spirit. Yet the ruin has its own peace. In it the past is present as form, and the decay that destroys the building's purpose creates a new totality, in which the work of spirit and the work of nature are joined. The ruined kingdoms of Lothric, ash-strewn, overgrown, frequently beautiful, are Simmel's ruins. The Japanese tradition names the feeling they evoke *mono no aware*, the poignancy of things in their passing, which Motoori Norinaga in the eighteenth century

placed at the heart of Japanese literature. The *Heike monogatari*, the epic of the fall of the Taira, opens with a sentence every Japanese schoolchild knows: 祇園精舎の鐘の声、諸行無常の響きあり—the sound of the bell of the Jetavana monastery echoes the impermanence of all things—and goes on to say that the proud do not endure, but vanish like a dream on a spring night. And the *Hōjōki* of Kamo no Chōmei (1212) opens with an image that is Heraclitus's river in Japanese: ゆく河の流れは絶えずして、しかももとの水にあらず—the current of the flowing river never ceases, and yet the water is never the same water. Chōmei goes on to record the disasters of his age, beginning with the great fire of 1177, which consumed a large part of the capital, and to describe his withdrawal into a hut ten feet square in the hills, where he lived out his years in a small and measured solitude. The Age of Fire's ruins belong to Chōmei's world: a capital consumed by fire, and a life of small warmth carried on beyond it.

Italo Calvino's *Le città invisibili* (1972) offers the convergence its most beautiful literary counterpart. Marco Polo describes to Kublai Khan the cities of his empire—cities of memory and desire, of signs and of the dead, continuous cities that turn out to be a single city—while the Khan, contemplating in his atlas the decay of everything he rules, sinks into melancholy. At the close of the book, Polo answers the Khan's despair. The inferno of the living, he says, is not something still to come; it is already here, the one we inhabit every day. There are two ways to escape suffering it. The first, easy for many, is to accept the inferno and become so much a part of it that one no longer sees it. The second, risky, demanding constant vigilance and apprehension, is to seek and learn to recognize who and what, in the midst of the inferno, are not inferno, and to make them endure, and give them space. The converged kingdoms of Lothric are Calvino's atlas, its cities collapsing into one; and Polo's second way is the ethics of the ember stated in a sentence.

Two works of speculative fiction promised in earlier chapters complete the comparative frame. William Hope Hodgson's *The Night Land* (1912) imagines the last of humanity sheltering in the Last Redoubt, a vast pyramid of metal at the end of the world, sustained by the Earth-Current and surrounded by a darkness filled with watching powers. The Ringed City is a Last Redoubt: the last city at the end of the world, sustained by a power that the player's touch dissolves—Filianore's sleep—beyond which lies the ash desert of the Night Land. Gene Wolfe's *The Urth of the New Sun* (1987), the coda to *The Book of the New Sun*, brings to the dying world of Urth the renewal its prophets awaited: Severian returns with the New Sun, a white fountain that restores the failing sun's fire. But the coming of the New Sun raises the seas, and much of the old world drowns; the renewed Ushas is born from the flood that destroys Urth. Wolfe's parable measures the cost of every renewal by fire, and it sharpens the question with which the trilogy ends. The linking renews the fire at the cost of the one who links. The Painter, as section 7.5 will show, proposes a renewal that drowns no one: a new world made not by consuming the old but from its remainder.

7.3 Ash and Cinder: Derrida's Feu la cendre, the Unkindled, and the Bones in the Ash

The trilogy moves from fire to ash. The protagonist of the first game is the Chosen Undead; the protagonist of the third is the Ashen One, one of the Unkindled—in Japanese 火のない灰 (*hi no nai hai*), "ash without fire"—who in some earlier age attempted to link the fire and failed, too weak even to be consumed, and who rise from their graves in the Cemetery of Ash when the bell tolls to bring back the Lords of Cinder. The Lords themselves, in the Japanese text 薪の王, kings of firewood, are returned to their thrones in the form of their remains, the Cinders of a Lord. Ash lies everywhere: in the cemetery where the game begins, in the desert at the end of the world where the Ringed City's illusion fails, in the Kiln where the fire is linked—and, in the first game, in the hidden lake at the bottom of the world. Across the trilogy the protagonist descends from the cursed living, through the Bearer of the Curse of the second game, to the residue: from a subject who bears a curse to a remnant of what has already burned.

Jacques Derrida's *Feu la cendre* (1987) is a meditation, in many voices, on a sentence that had haunted him for years: "il y a là cendre," there is ash, there. The grave accent on *là* distinguishes the adverb "there" from the article *la*, so that the sentence wavers, in speech, between "there is ash there" and "there is the ash," a difference legible only in writing. For Derrida the cinder is the figure of the trace that effaces itself: what remains of what has burned without remainder, neither presence nor absence, the witness of a holocaust—in the word's etymological sense, a whole burning—that has consumed even the evidence of its own taking place. The title doubles the figure. *Feu* is fire; but *feu*, as an adjective, also means late, deceased, as in *feu mon père*, my late father. *Feu la cendre* is at once "fire the ash" and "the late ash." The Ashen One is *feu* in both senses: a deceased one, risen, and a remnant of fire. And the Ashen One is the trace-subject of the trilogy: the one who remains after every previous linking, who carries in the Soul of Cinder they must finally confront the composite memory of all who burned before, and whose task—to return the cinders of the lords to their thrones—is quite literally the arrangement of traces.

The ash of *Dark Souls III* carries a further resonance in the culture that produced it. Japan cremates nearly all of its dead, and after cremation the family performs *kotsuage* (骨上げ), the gathering of the bones. Mourners lift the bone fragments from the ash with long chopsticks, sometimes passing a fragment from one pair of chopsticks to another, and place them in the urn, from the feet upward, with particular care for the second vertebra of the neck, the *nodobotoke* (喉仏), "the Buddha of the throat," whose shape is said to resemble a seated Buddha. The everyday prohibition against passing food from chopsticks to chopsticks preserves the memory of this rite at every Japanese table. The third game's Homeward Bone, a fragment of bone reduced to white ash that returns its

bearer to the bonfire, and whose description reveals that the bonfires are fed with the bones of the Undead, is an object of *kotsuage*: a bone gathered from the ash. The bonfire is the crematory hearth, and the Ashen One, rising from a cemetery of ash, is the bone lifted from it by the rite.

The Western liturgical tradition knows the same ash. On Ash Wednesday the faithful are marked on the forehead with ash while the priest recites the words of Genesis 3:19 in the Vulgate's form: *memento, homo, quia pulvis es, et in pulverem reverteris*—remember, human being, that you are dust, and to dust you shall return. The Darksign, a ring of fire around a darkened centre, is a mark of the same kind, borne on the body as a reminder of the end. And the history of painting supplies a material fact that will prove decisive for the trilogy's final image. Among the oldest black pigments known to painters is bone black—the ivory black of the old masters among them—made by charring bones until they are reduced to a fine carbonized powder. The black of the painter's palette has always been made, in part, of the burnt remains of the dead. The bonfires of the Age of Fire burn the bones of the Undead; the painter's black is made of burnt bones. The transformation of the remainder into pigment, toward which the trilogy has been moving since the Ringed City, has a material basis in the oldest practices of the painter's craft.

The Ashen One, then, is the subject after the pyre. It is neither the fire, the sovereign principle the Lords sustained, nor the Dark, the remainder the order excluded, but ash: what remains when fire has done its work and not quite finished it. Its defining condition, to be unkindled, is a failure to be consumed, and this failure is the source of its freedom. The Lords of Cinder burned; the Ashen One did not. The ash that failed to burn completely retains what the burned-out cinder has lost: the capacity to become something else. It is precisely such a remainder that a painter needs.

7.4 The Endings: Linking, Usurpation, and the End of Fire

The third game offers three principal endings, each with its variants, and together they constitute the trilogy's final statement on the relation between the human and the fire. In the first, the Ashen One, having defeated the Soul of Cinder, links the First Flame, becoming its fuel as Gwyn did, and the cycle continues. In the second, a player who has followed the path of Londor—accepting the service of its emissaries, deepening their own Hollowing, and wedding the Unkindled Anri with a ceremonial sword—seizes the flame as Lord of Hollows, and the Hollow bow before a new sovereign. In the third, a player who has given the Fire Keeper of Firelink the eyes that were taken from her, so that she may see the age to come, may summon her to the Kiln after the Soul of Cinder falls. She kneels before the dying flame, gathers it into her cupped hands, and the world goes dark. In the darkness, she asks whether the Ashen One can still hear her voice.

Figure 27 *The three endings of* Dark Souls III*: the pyre, the seizure of the pyre, and the flame held in cupped hands that it does not burn.*

The first ending completes the trilogy's critique of the linking. Chapter Six observed that the bonfire's reverie rehearses what Bachelard called the Empedocles complex, the longing to be consumed by fire, and that Hölderlin gave this longing its noblest dramatic form in the unfinished *Der Tod des Empedokles* (1797–1800), in which the estranged philosopher-priest of Agrigento chooses the leap into Etna as a sacrificial reunion with the living whole of nature. Hölderlin's Empedocles dies sublimely, freely, and for the sake of a reconciliation that his death achieves. By the third game the trilogy has made this sublimity impossible. The Kiln is the place where countless Empedocleses have already leapt, and the fire still fades; their composite body, the Soul of Cinder, is a monster that must be killed; and the linking with which the third game may end is visibly one more deferral in a series that has been deferring for ages. The trilogy refuses Hölderlin's tragic sublime. The self-immolation for the world's sake is exposed as the servile sacrifice analysed in Chapter Five: an investment in an order that cannot be saved.

The second ending, the Usurpation of Fire, is the lion's No of Chapter Six turned into a new throne. Chapter Three found in it the remainder enthroned, and Chapter Four a counter-sovereignty of bare life that reproduces the form of the sovereignty it overthrows. Its imagery confirms both readings: the Lord of Hollows takes the flame into himself, and the Hollow kneel. The order of fire has changed hands; it has not ended.

The third ending is of a different kind, and the trilogy's philosophical traditions converge upon it. Simone Weil, in the notebooks published as *La Pesanteur et la grâce* (1947), conceived creation as an act of divine abdication, God withdrawing so that something other than God might be, and asked of the creature a corresponding *décréation*: to make something created pass into the uncreated, to undo in oneself the self that stands between the world and its beauty. She expressed the wish to disappear so that the things she saw might become perfect in their beauty from the very fact of no longer being seen by her. The Fire Keeper performs a decreation. She neither destroys the fire nor seizes it; she gathers it into her hands and lets the world pass into the dark, undoing the order of fire with gentleness, as the one who served it. Her gesture is the kenotic gesture described in Chapter Six: a withdrawal that makes room.

The Buddhist tradition names what happens to the fire. In the dialogue with Vacchagotta (*Majjhima Nikāya* 72), the Buddha asks the wanderer whether, if a fire burning before him were to go out, he would know that it had gone out; Vacchagotta says that he would. And if someone were to ask him in which direction the fire had gone—east, west, north, or south—what would he answer? The question does not apply, Vacchagotta replies: the fire burned dependent on its fuel, and when the fuel is used up and no more is added, it is reckoned simply as extinguished. So too, the Buddha concludes, the one who is liberated is deep, immeasurable, unfathomable as the ocean, and the questions of whether he exists after death do not apply. Where does the First Flame go when the Fire Keeper takes it into

her hands? The question does not apply. *Nirvāṇa* means a blowing-out, and the Pali texts describe the liberated one as having become cool, *sītibhūta*. The End of Fire is the world's *nirvāṇa*: the extinguishing of the fires that the Fire Sermon named—of passion, of aversion, of delusion—and the cooling that follows. Nāgārjuna's analysis of fire and fuel in the tenth chapter of the *Mūlamadhyamakakārikā*, which shows that fire is neither identical with its fuel nor independent of it, and that neither exists by its own nature, diagnoses the error the Age of Fire committed for millennia: it treated the flame as a self-existent substance that had to be preserved at any cost, and fed it the Lords of Cinder as though the fire could exist apart from what it consumed. The End of Fire is the realization of the flame's emptiness. A fire that has no own-being can be let go.

Nishitani Keiji's meditation on fire in *Religion and Nothingness* completes the reading. Fire burns things, Nishitani observed, but it does not burn itself; and it is precisely in not burning itself that fire is fire, its selfhood consisting in its non-self-burning. On the field of emptiness, things return to what he called their home-ground, where they are what they are without grasping. The final image of the End of Fire is exactly this: a flame held in two cupped hands that it does not burn. The fire that consumed the Lords of Cinder, held by the Fire Keeper, consumes nothing. It has returned to its home-ground, where fire does not burn.

What survives in the dark is not nothing. When the Fire Keeper is given her sight, she foresees a darkness across which, one day, small flames will flicker, like the embers of the lords who came before. And in the dark at the end, her question—whether the Ashen One can still hear her—keeps open the bond between two persons when every other light has gone. The End of Fire is not the extinction of all warmth but its transformation: from a single sovereign blaze sustained by sacrifice to scattered embers sustained by nothing but themselves. Chapter Five observed that the need-fire of the European fire-festivals could be kindled only after every other fire had been put out. The End of Fire is that extinguishing, and the darkness it inaugurates is the condition of a new kindling—not by sacrifice, but by the many small flames the Fire Keeper foresees. The three endings, finally, correspond to the three relations to fire that run through this thesis. The linking is the pyre; the usurpation is the seizure of the pyre by another hand; the End of Fire is the candle, carried into the dark. It is the trilogy's ember.

7.5 *The Painted World: Ariamis, Ariandel, the Painter, and the Play-Drive*

Paintings that are also worlds recur across the trilogy, and they bracket it. In the first game, a great canvas hangs in Anor Londo, and a player who carries a strange doll is drawn into it, into the Painted World of Ariamis: a frozen, snowbound realm around a ruined castle, which proves to be a refuge for those the world outside rejected. Its most remarkable inhabitant is Priscilla the Crossbreed, a gentle half-dragon whom the gods could not tolerate, who does not attack the intruder unless provoked and asks only to be left in peace. The Painted World is the inverse of the Asylum with which the first game began: not a confinement for the stigmatized but a sanctuary for the unwanted. In the third game, *Ashes of Ariandel* returns to a painted world, and finds it rotting. In the frozen Painted World of Ariandel, rot is the sign that a painting must be burned so that a new one may be painted; but Sister Friede, an Ashen One who forsook the fire, has kept the painting in its slow decay, preferring a rotting refuge for its outcast inhabitants to the burning that would end it, while Father Ariandel scourges himself in penance. In the attic of the chapel waits a small girl, the Painter, who needs to see flame before she can paint anew. When Friede has fallen and the Painter has seen the flame, she resolves to paint a world that is cold, dark, and gentle—a world she imagines as a gentle home for those who will one day live in it. In *The Ringed City*, the Slave Knight Gael, whom she calls her uncle, has gone to the end of the world to bring her the pigment she lacks: the blood of the Dark Soul. The player who defeats Gael carries it back to her. With it, she will paint.

Chapter Two promised a return to Claude Lévi-Strauss's culinary triangle, and the choice of Ariandel is its most exact illustration. The rot that Friede preserves is the raw transformed by nature; the burning that would end it is the raw transformed by culture, the cooked. Friede is, in her way, a linker of rot: she preserves a declining world against its end exactly as the Lords of Cinder preserved the Age of Fire, choosing indefinite decline over renewal. The Painter needs the flame, but not in order to burn. She needs it in order to see, and what she will paint with its light is the cold. The Painter's act thus introduces a fourth term into Lévi-Strauss's triangle. Her painting is neither raw nor cooked nor rotten. It is made.

Chapter One anticipated that the trilogy would disclose, in its final image, the third term that Friedrich Schiller found between the drives of human nature. In the *Briefe über die ästhetische Erziehung des Menschen* (1795), Schiller described the sensuous drive (*Stofftrieb*), which binds us to matter, change, and life, and the formal drive (*Formtrieb*), which binds us to law, permanence, and form; and he found their reconciliation in the play-drive (*Spieltrieb*), whose object, he wrote in the fifteenth letter, is living form, *lebende Gestalt*—which is to say, beauty. The cosmos of *Dark Souls* has been divided throughout

the trilogy between an order of form without matter, the Age of Fire, which maintains its distinctions by consuming the substance it excludes, and a matter without form, the Dark and the Abyss, which dissolves every distinction when it returns. The Painter's painting is the living form that neither could produce: form seen by the light of the flame, made from the matter of the Dark Soul's blood. And it is made in play. The Painter is a child.

Heraclitus's fragment B52, which Chapter Six took as its epigraph, ends with five words that the trilogy at last fulfils: παιδὸς ἡ βασιληίη, the kingship is a child's. Every sovereignty the trilogy has examined—the Lord of Sunlight's, the Dark Lord's, the Lord of Hollows'—has proved to be a throne sustained by sacrifice or seized by force. The one figure in the trilogy whose act serves nothing but itself and the dwelling of others, whose making is expenditure without return in Bataille's sense, is a child with a brush. Nietzsche's third metamorphosis ends in the child as a new beginning and a sacred Yes; the trilogy ends in a child who will begin a world. The kingship is a child's.

Jorge Luis Borges's "Las ruinas circulares" (1940), promised in Chapter One, reveals the recursive structure of this ending. A silent man comes to a circular temple, ruined long ago by fire and once sacred to a god of fire, and sets himself the task of dreaming a man into reality, organ by organ, through many nights. The god of fire, appearing to him in a dream, agrees to animate the dreamed son, so that all but the god and the dreamer will believe him to be a man of flesh, and grants that fire will not burn him. Years later, fire again engulfs the ruins. The dreamer walks into the flames, and they do not burn him; and he understands, with relief, with humiliation, with terror, that he too is an appearance, dreamed by another. The Painter of Ariandel paints a world, and the trilogy, in showing her, shows itself. The game is a painted world, and its players are beings within it whose substance—the Dark Soul—is the very pigment the Painter requires. The literary term for an image that contains itself is *mise en abyme*, which André Gide borrowed in 1893 from the heraldic practice of placing a small copy of a shield within the shield; its literal sense is "placed into the abyss." The Painted World is the trilogy placed into its own abyss: the image, within the work, of the work's own making.

Tanizaki Jun'ichirō's *In'ei raisan* (1933) supplies the aesthetic of the world the Painter will make. Japanese beauty, Tanizaki argued, dwells in shadows: in the dim interior beneath deep eaves; in lacquerware, whose depths come alive only in the flicker of a single candle; in the gold leaf of a screen catching the last light at the back of a darkened room; in the alcove of the *tokonoma*, which holds nothing but shadow; in the face of the Noh actor emerging from the dark. Electric light, in flooding everything, destroys the beauty that shadows make possible, and Tanizaki closed his essay with the wish to call back, at least in literature, something of the world of shadows that was being lost—to deepen the eaves, darken the walls, and push back into darkness what had become too visible. The Painter's cold, dark, and gentle world is a world in Tanizaki's sense: a world whose beauty requires

dimness, in which a small flame reveals what a great light would obliterate. It is the aesthetic of the ember.

Two questions left open by earlier chapters receive their answer here. Chapter Three cited Hegel's verdict that when philosophy paints its grey in grey, a form of life has grown old, and by grey in grey it cannot be rejuvenated, only known. The Painter at the end of the world, painting with the blood of the Dark Soul in a desert of grey ash, is the trilogy's wager against Hegel: that a world grown old may be not only known but begun again—not by restoration, as the linking attempted, but by a new making from its remainder. And Chapter Four asked whether the trilogy offers any equivalent of Athena's gift in the *Eumenides*, by which the ancient avengers were given a home in the city and transformed into its guardians. The answer is a painter rather than a goddess. The remainder that the Age of Fire branded, confined, burned, and walled up at the end of the world is not integrated into the old city. It becomes the substance of a new world, and that world is offered as a home.

7.6 *The Cryotopian Eschaton: Against the White Mythology*

Chapter One named as the second corollary of pyrrhic ontology the *cryotopian eschaton*, from the Greek κρύος, icy cold, and τόπος, place: an imagination of redemption as a cold place. The evidence for this pattern across Miyazaki's corpus can now be gathered. In the first game, the Age of Dark that Kaathe promises is, whatever else it may be, an age of cooling, and the one sanctuary the world offers to those it has rejected is the frozen Painted World of Ariamis. In the third, the End of Fire leaves the world in a darkness across which small flames will one day flicker, and the Painter resolves to paint a world that is cold, dark, and gentle. In *Elden Ring*, the witch Ranni's ending inaugurates an Age of Stars, in which the order that governs the world withdraws into the cold distance of the night sky. Within the same corpus, fire's culminations are of two kinds only: sacrifice, as in the linking of the fire and in the burning of the Erdtree in *Elden Ring*, for which the maiden Melina offers herself as kindling; or dissolution, as in the Frenzied Flame of the same game, a fire that would melt every distinction back into one. Fire, in Miyazaki's imagination, is the medium of sovereignty, sacrifice, and chaos. Cold is the medium of gentleness and refuge.

This persistent pattern inverts the founding gesture of Western metaphysics as Jacques Derrida analysed it in "La mythologie blanche" (1971). Philosophical concepts, Derrida argued, are worn-out metaphors whose sensible origin has been effaced, like coins rubbed smooth until their effigy has vanished—an image he drew from Anatole France's *Le Jardin d'Épicure* (1894), where metaphysics is called a white mythology, a fable written in white ink that has forgotten it is a fable. And the master-metaphor of this mythology is the sun. From the *Republic*, in which the sun is the offspring and likeness of the Good (507b–509b) and

Figure 28 *Fire and cold across Miyazaki's corpus. Fire culminates only in sacrifice or in dissolution; the imagination of redemption is persistently cold, dark, and gentle.*

the prisoner freed from the cave ascends at last to behold it (514a–517a), through the natural light of reason of the Enlightenment, Western philosophy has been heliotropic, turning always toward the sun as the source of visibility and truth. *Dark Souls* is anti-heliotropic from beginning to end. Its sun is a lie sustained by a god of illusions; its Lord of Sunlight is a hollow husk; its image of the sun on human bodies is an eclipse. And it inverts the allegory of the cave with precision. The prisoner of the first game escapes the Asylum and climbs to Anor Londo, where the sun is an illusion; the true source of light lies at the bottom of the world, reached by descent through the Firelink Altar, and it is a kiln of ash. In Plato the truth of the sun is found by ascending; in *Dark Souls*, by descending, and it is ash. Nietzsche's madman, whose question supplied this thesis's first epigraph, asked in terror whether it was not growing colder, whether night was not closing in; the trilogy answers that it is, and that the cold can be lived in—that it is, in fact, the condition under which small lights become visible.

The Japanese aesthetic and philosophical tradition supplies the counter-mythology on

which the cryotopian eschaton draws. Tanizaki's praise of shadows has been discussed. Nishida Kitarō's logic of place located the ground of all determinations in a place of absolute nothingness (*zettai mu no basho*), a darkness conceived not as privation but as the field in which things appear; Nishitani's fire that does not burn itself completed the thought. The Japanese poetic tradition, moreover, made of the moon's cold light an image of enlightenment—the moon of suchness, *shinnyo no tsuki*—and celebrated it in the poems of Saigyō and of the monk Myōe, whose cry of wonder at the bright moon Kawabata Yasunari quoted in his Nobel lecture of 1968. The trilogy's own moon-god, Gwyndolin, the Dark Sun, and *Elden Ring*'s Ranni of the moon belong to this lineage of cold luminaries: lights that are reflected, distant, and gentle. And the medieval poetics of *renga* elevated coldness itself to the rank of a supreme aesthetic value: the poet-monk Shinkei (1406–1475) prized above all a beauty he called *hie*, chill, together with leanness and solitude. The cold, in this tradition, is not the absence of beauty but one of its highest forms. Buddhism, finally, conceived liberation itself as a cooling: the Pali texts, as section 7.4 recalled, describe the one who has attained *nirvāṇa* as having become cool. Chapter Two observed that Dante's Purgatory culminates in a wall of fire through which the soul must pass before it reaches the Earthly Paradise. The trilogy locates its images of redemption, instead, in the cold beyond the fire.

The comparative field confirms the pattern and sharpens it. In the final volumes of Hayao Miyazaki's manga *Nausicaä of the Valley of the Wind* (1982–94), the heroine discovers in the Crypt of Shuwa that the toxic forest of her world is a purification system engineered by an ancient civilization; that the humans of her age have been modified to survive the poison and will die in the purified world to come; and that the crypt preserves the means to restore a pure world and a purified humanity. She destroys it, choosing the contaminated and mortal life of the present over the engineered purity of the future, and affirms that life is a light flickering in the darkness. Lars von Trier's *Melancholia* (2011) ends with a planet bearing down upon the earth; the depressed Justine, calm at last, builds with her young nephew a "magic cave" of branches on the lawn, a shelter that can shelter no one, and sits within it holding hands with him and her sister as the world ends—a gesture of care at the end of all things, without hope, consoling only by presence. Béla Tarr's *A torinói ló* (2011) opens with the story of Nietzsche embracing a flogged horse in Turin before his collapse, and follows a father and daughter in a stone house through six days in which their world winds down: the horse will not move or eat; the well runs dry; and on the last day the lamp will not stay lit, though it holds oil, and the embers in the stove die. Tarr's film is the purest image in cinema of a world in which fire itself fails. The trilogy's difference from it is the ember: in the dark of the End of Fire, small flames persist.

Cormac McCarthy supplies the image in which the cryotopian eschaton is most perfectly realized. In *The Road* (2006), a father and his son cross a burned and ash-covered

continent, and the father tells the boy that they are carrying the fire; when the father dies, the boy goes on with strangers who carry it too. And *No Country for Old Men* (2005) ends with a sheriff recounting a dream of his dead father riding past him through a mountain pass in the cold and the dark, carrying fire in a horn, going on ahead to make a fire somewhere out there in all that dark and all that cold, and the dreamer knowing that whenever he got there, his father would be there. This is the cryotopian eschaton: not the triumph of darkness, nor the heat death of despair, but an eschatology of cooling, in which the sovereign blaze has ended and what remains is fire carried by hand through the cold—small, shared, passed from the dead to the living, kept alight for those who come after. The Fire Keeper foresees embers in the dark like those of the lords who came before. The sheriff dreams of his father carrying fire ahead of him into the cold. They are the same vision. It inverts the white mythology without merely reversing it, for it does not set darkness above light; it sets the small light above the great one, and finds in the cold the place where the small light can be seen.

7.7 *Coda: Elden Ring and the Afterlife of the Flame*

The questions the trilogy closed did not end with it. Miyazaki's subsequent works returned to them in new cosmologies, and a brief examination of their answers confirms the pattern this chapter has traced.

Elden Ring (2022), whose mythological substrate was furnished in collaboration with George R. R. Martin, takes place in a world that has suffered a Shattering. The Elden Ring, the principle of the Golden Order established by the queen Marika, has been broken, and its fragments, the Great Runes, are held by her demigod offspring, whose war over them has left the Lands Between in ruin. The player is one of the Tarnished, exiles from whom the guiding grace of the land was once withdrawn, now summoned back to gather the Great Runes and become Elden Lord. The structure reprises the central quest of the first *Dark Souls*—scattered sovereign fragments gathered toward a restoration of order—and with it the Lurianic schema of shattered vessels whose sparks must be raised, which Chapter Three found beneath the Lordvessel. The Tarnished are the Undead's successors: exiles recalled by a summons to restore the order that cast them out.

Fire, in *Elden Ring*, takes two forms, and both continue the trilogy's critique. The golden world-tree at the centre of the Lands Between, the image of the Golden Order, has been sealed against entry by thorns, and the player can pass only by burning it with the Flame of Ruin, a forbidden fire kept at the Forge of the Giants, whose bearers the Golden Order long ago warred to suppress. Melina, the maiden who has guided the player throughout, offers herself as the kindling. The linking of the fire returns here transformed—a burning not to preserve the old order but to break a way through it—and with it returns

the figure of the guide who becomes the fuel, the Fire Keeper consumed in the flame she served. The other fire is the Frenzied Flame, offered by an alien power called the Three Fingers: a yellow fire of madness that would burn away every distinction, every separation, and every suffering that separation causes, melting all things back into a single undifferentiated being. The Frenzied Flame is the exact inverse of the First Flame of the trilogy. The First Flame instituted disparity; the Frenzied Flame would abolish it. It is the parable of Hundun from Chapter Two run in reverse: not the undifferentiated killed by the gift of distinctions, but the differentiated world dissolved back into chaos by a fire that cannot bear difference.

Against both fires stands the ending in which the player aids Ranni, a demigod who rebelled against the order that would have governed her, to take the Elden Ring and inaugurate an Age of Stars. In this ending the governing order of the world withdraws from the Lands Between into the cold and distant cosmos, an age that Ranni herself describes in terms of distance and solitude, governed, if at all, from afar. It is the cryotopian eschaton in its cosmic form, and it is also the kenotic gesture described in Chapter Six raised to the level of the divine: an order that withdraws in order to let the world be itself—a *tzimtzum* of sovereignty.

The other works of the corpus extend the pattern into different registers. *Bloodborne* (2015), the most Lovecraftian of Miyazaki's games, offers among its endings one titled *Childhood's Beginning*—a deliberate inversion of the title of Arthur C. Clarke's *Childhood's End* (1953)—in which the hunter is reborn as an infant of a higher order of being, and the game closes on a new beginning in the form of a child: the Heraclitean and Nietzschean child once more. *Sekiro: Shadows Die Twice* (2019) makes the curse of deathlessness the explicit centre of its plot. Its protagonist returns from death by virtue of an inheritance from an ancient dragon, but each return spreads a sickness, Dragonrot, among the people around him, so that the cost of his own survival is borne by others—the biopolitics of Chapter Four compressed into a single mechanic. Its endings include the severing of immortality and the return of the dragon whose gift sustained it to the land from which it came. Across the corpus, the questions remain the trilogy's: whether to sustain an order by sacrifice, whether to dissolve it, or whether to let it withdraw; and the gentlest answers remain cold, distant, and small.

7.8 A Painting Made of Dark Souls

This chapter has read the final game of the trilogy as a late work in Adorno's sense, leaving the conventions of its own form standing as ruins; its convergent kingdoms and its Dreg Heap as the wreckage that Benjamin's angel sees piling at his feet; its ash as Derrida's cinder, the trace of what has burned, and as the ash of the cremation hearth from which the bones are lifted; its three endings as the pyre, the seizure of the pyre, and the flame held in cupped hands that it does not burn—a decreation, a cooling, a *nirvāṇa*; its Painted World as Schiller's living form, made in play by a child to whom the kingship belongs; and its imagination of redemption as a cryotopian eschaton, opposed to the white mythology of the West and continuous with the Japanese aesthetics of shadow, the Buddhist soteriology of cooling, and the fire that McCarthy's dead carry ahead through the cold.

The boldest proposition of this thesis, announced in Chapter One, can now be stated in full. *Dark Souls* is a painting made of dark souls. Within the fiction, the Painter's pigment is the blood of the Dark Soul: the substance of humanity, the remainder of the Age of Fire, carried across the end of the world by a slave and given to a child. Within the operative structure of the work, the world each player inhabits is composed not only of the assets its developers made but of the traces of other players—the messages glowing on the ground, the bloodstains that replay strangers' deaths, the phantoms that flicker past, the summon signs that wait to be answered. These traces are the accumulated expenditure of millions of lives, each of them, in the trilogy's own anthropology, a dark soul. The world of the game is literally painted, for each of its players, with the remainder of all the others. The Painter's act at the end of the trilogy is therefore the image, within the work, of the work's own genesis: a world painted with the remainder of the humanity that inhabits it. The title of the trilogy has been read as naming its monsters, its Lords, or its cursed humanity. It names, finally, the community of those who play: dark souls whose deaths, gifts, and traces are the pigment of the world they share.

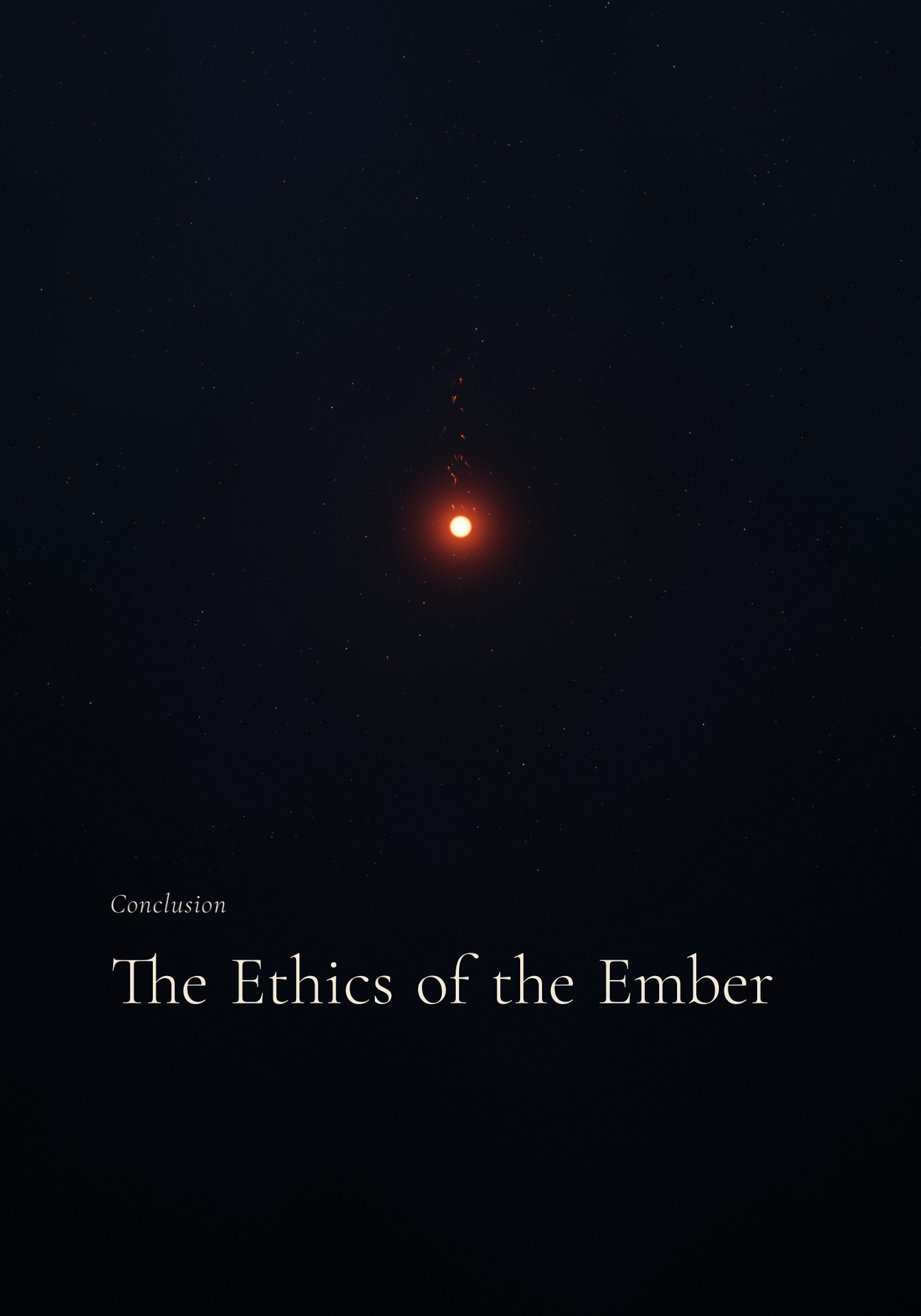
The Painter thereby fulfils the fifth clause of the Axiom of the Remainder, which Chapter Three called the trilogy's wager: that the remainder cannot be redeemed by integration into the old order as one more sovereign, but only by transformation into the material of a new making. And the transformation the Painter performs differs in kind from every other transformation the trilogy has shown. The bonfire consumes the remainder; the Lordvessel gathers it to burn; the Ringed City encloses it; Gael devours it. The Painter does none of these things. She spreads it. The pigment is not burned but laid upon a surface, given form, and offered as a world in which others may live. In the terms of Chapter Five, it is the only expenditure in the trilogy that is also a gift; in the terms of Chapter Six, the only creation that is also a withdrawal, a making of room.

The world she will make is cold, dark, and gentle. It is made rather than linked, offered

Figure 29 *A painting made of dark souls: a world composed not only of the assets its developers made but of the accumulated traces of its players, whose deaths, remainders, and expenditures are its pigment.*

rather than imposed; its sovereign is a child; its substance is the remainder of the old; its light, one imagines, is small. It is the cryotopian eschaton given form. And it resembles, in a manner the trilogy surely intends, the world its players have already made of it: a cold, dark world, threaded with small lights—messages, phantoms, signs, bonfires burning in the gloom—which strangers keep alight for one another without ever meeting. The trilogy ends by painting the community that played it.

What this means for those who live outside the painting—for an ethics, and for a philosophy of finitude under conditions of exhaustion that are not only fictional—is the subject of the Conclusion.



Conclusion

The Ethics of the Ember

Wo aber Gefahr ist, wächst
Das Rettende auch.

"But where danger is, there grows also what saves."

— *Hölderlin, "Patmos" (1803)*

旅に病んで夢は枯野をかけ廻る

"Sick on a journey—my dreams go wandering over withered fields."

— *Matsuo Bashō, last poem (1694)*

The Argument Restated

This thesis set out to show that Hidetaka Miyazaki's *Dark Souls* is a philosophical system of the first order, articulated not in propositions but in operations—an operative metaphysics whose principal medium of argument is the repeated death of the one who plays it—and to name the position that system implies. Chapter One introduced that position, pyrrhic ontology, together with a method suited to a work composed of fragments: a lacunary hermeneutics, disciplined by the principle of operative constraint, attentive to the Japanese text beneath the English, and comparative in the mode of the constellation rather than the genealogy of influence. Chapter Two read the prologue as an anarchic cosmogony of finders, in which fire arrives without a maker, disparity is instituted as inequality, the Age of Ancients fuses Anaximander's boundless with Parmenides' being, and the curse of undeath appears as the erosion of the first distinctions as the fire fades—an entropic eschaton whose sequence of fog, fire, embers, and dark is the sequence of physical cosmology. Chapter Three followed the forgotten fourth Lord through the metaphysics of the remainder, from the missing guest of the *Timaeus* and the χώρα, through the dark ground of Böhme, Schelling, and Hegel, to the operative anthropology of humanity as the nature of the between, and on to Manus, the Abyss, and the belated disclosure of the Ringed City. Chapter Four analysed the curse as a biopolitics: the Darksign as cosmological stigma, the Asylum as leprosarium, Hollowing as the extinction of care, the bloodstain as the re-finitization of an existence that had lost its death, and the Undead as a new figure in political philosophy, the sacrificeable *homo sacer*. Chapter Five reconstructed the political economy of the Age of Fire—the soul as an ontological money that hollows the world it measures, a restricted economy masquerading as solar, a gift economy running beneath it, a body politic sustained by illusion, a Fisher King whose wound is the land's, a Girardian sacrifice played from within by its victim, and a prophecy that functions as an inverted *upāya*. Chapter Six developed the theory of ludic ekpyrosis, in which the death loop performs at the scale of the hand the cosmic cycle the trilogy narrates, and identified the practice of play as a Phaedonic exercise in dying, conducted within an inoperative community of strangers who know one another only by their traces. Chapter Seven read the final game as a late work whose endings culminate in a flame held in cupped hands and a painter who will make a cold, dark, and gentle world from the blood of the Dark Soul—the cryotopian eschaton given form, and the image, within the work, of the work's own making.

The three axioms of pyrrhic ontology can now be stated in their final form. The Axiom of Exchange holds that in a cosmos where all things are an exchange for fire, value is ontological; that the universal equivalent levels the disparities the fire instituted, so that the order's own economy is the engine of its decline; that sovereignty is the hoarding of

the fire disguised as solar giving; that its preservation requires the sacrifice of the remainder, produced as bare life and consumed as fuel, and legitimated as election; and that the only exchange which escapes this economy is the gift that cannot be returned. The Axiom of the Remainder holds that every order of fire is constituted by a remainder which precedes it as its unacknowledged origin, sustains it as fuel, is excluded from its account and enclosed at its margins, returns without measure when suppressed, and can be redeemed not by integration into the order as one more sovereign but only by transformation into the material of a new making. The Axiom of Measure holds that in such a cosmos the only comportment that does not end in Hollowing is a measured, repeated, and knowingly futile self-expenditure. The chapters have given this third axiom its operative content: to spend what one has gathered before the second death takes it; to refuse both the hoard and the pyre; to return to the threshold of one's defeat without resentment; to carry the flame into the dark rather than to feed it with a self or to seize it for oneself. Measure is the practice by which recurrence is converted from a curse into an *askēsis*.

From the axioms followed three corollaries, each of which the thesis has now established. Ludic ekpyrosis names the performance, in the formal loop of play, of the cosmic cycle of conflagration and renewal, so that the player does not represent the cosmology of the trilogy but enacts it. The cryotopian eschaton names the persistent figuration of redemption, across Miyazaki's corpus, as cold, dark, and gentle—an anti-heliotropic counter-mythology to the solar metaphysics of the West. And the ethics of the ember names the position that the trilogy implies but never states: the subject of the remainder of this conclusion.

The Ethics of the Ember

An ember is what remains of a fire that has burned down: no longer a blaze, not yet ash. It glows rather than flames; it gives warmth without consuming much; it can be banked against the night, carried from one hearth to another, and used to kindle a new fire. The third game of the trilogy gives the ember operative form. The Ember is a consumable that restores the Ashen One to an embered state, in which their vitality is strengthened and in which alone they can summon other players into their world—while also, in the same state, becoming open to invasion. Within the game's own systems, then, the ember is the condition of relation to others, and the condition of exposure to them. The ethics of the ember is an ethics of that condition. It may be stated in seven principles, each drawn from the trilogy's systems and from the traditions this thesis has brought to bear upon them.

The first principle is *measure*. Heraclitus's cosmic fire is kindled in measures and quenched in measures, and his sun may not overstep its measures without the Erinyes finding it out. Measure is not the Aristotelian mean between excess and deficiency; it is a rhythm of expenditure and renewal, the right amount spent at the right time, again

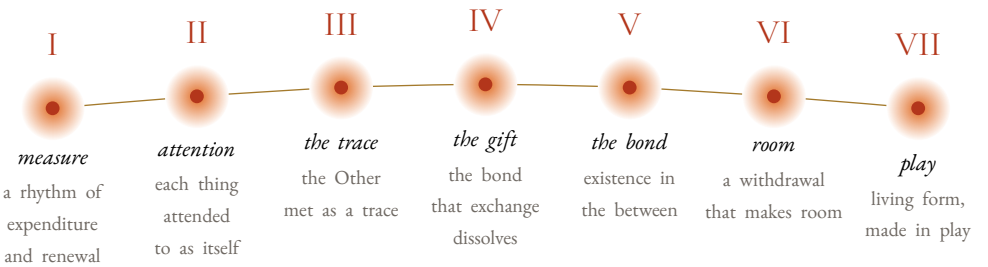


Figure 30 *The seven principles of the ethics of the ember, each drawn from the trilogy's systems and from the traditions brought to bear upon them.*

and again. The trilogy teaches it at the bloodstain, which punishes the hoard, and at the Kiln, which exposes the pyre. Between the restricted economy that accumulates until it loses everything and the sacrifice that gives everything once and for all lies the practice of spending oneself in measure: enough to act, enough to help, never so much that nothing remains to be carried forward.

The second principle is *attention*. Chapter Five showed that the soul economy hollows its world, reducing every being to a quantity of the universal equivalent and producing the grey indifference that Simmel called the blasé attitude and the trilogy calls Hollowing. Against this leveling, the ember attends to each thing as itself: the item text read rather than discarded, the creature seen as a being rather than a sum, the place remembered for what happened there. Simone Weil held attention to be the rarest and purest form of generosity, and Hadot placed *prosochē* first among the spiritual exercises of antiquity. In a world hollowed by its own currency, attention is the first resistance and the first gift.

The third principle is the *trace*. Chapter Six found the sociality of the trilogy in Levinas's concept of the trace: the Other is encountered not as a face but as the mark of one who has passed. The ember leaves true signs for those who come after—the warning beside the trap, the encouragement at the threshold—and dies, when it must die, in a way from which another may learn. It accepts responsibility for strangers it will never meet, not in the infinite measure Levinas sometimes demanded, but in the finite form of a sign laid on the ground.

The fourth principle is the *gift*. Mauss showed that the gift creates the bonds that exchange dissolves; Derrida, that the pure gift must escape the circle of return. The ember gives without return: the phantom who crosses into a stranger's world, fights beside them,

and vanishes when the work is done; the help that cannot be thanked because its giver has no name. The asynchronous systems of the trilogy are an apparatus for this impossible gift, and the healing that answers a well-rated message, arriving as if from nowhere, is the only return the ember expects.

The fifth principle is the *bond*. Watsuji Tetsurō located human existence in the between, and Chapter Three found that the Japanese name of humanity, *ningensei*, is the nature of the between; Chapter Four found in the Hollow the condition of *muen*, the loss of every bond. The ember keeps the bond. Its paradigm is the Fire Keeper's question in the dark at the end of the third game—whether the Ashen One can still hear her—asked when every other light has gone out. Its form is *ichigo ichie*: the single meeting honoured as though it were the only one, because it is.

The sixth principle is the making of *room*. Chapter Six described the trilogy's narrative method as a kenosis of its author, and found the same gesture in the Lurianic contraction by which the infinite makes room for the world and in Simone Weil's decreation. Chapter Seven found it again in the Fire Keeper, who gathers the flame into her hands and lets the world pass into the dark, and in the Painter, who makes a world in order to offer it as a home. The ember does not occupy the centre. Where the usurpation seats the remainder upon the throne, the ember gives the remainder room.

The seventh principle is *play*. Schiller found in the play-drive the mediation between matter and form, and in its object, living form, the beauty in which the human being is fully human; Bataille found in useless expenditure the sovereignty that no servile operation can attain; Heraclitus gave the kingship to a child. The ember plays. It returns to the game freely, as Zarathustra's child returns to its wheel; it spends without utility; it makes rather than conserves. Play is the one expenditure in the trilogy that does not merely consume, and the Painter is its emblem.

These principles define a position distinct from every option the trilogy stages and from its nearest philosophical neighbours. The ember is not the heroic linking of the fire, which sacrifices the self to an order that cannot be saved; nor the revolutionary usurpation, which seats the remainder on the throne it overthrew; nor the quietist extinction that accepts the end and contributes nothing to what follows—still less the antinatalist counsel of Zapffe's last messiah and his modern successors, Thomas Ligotti and David Benatar, that the overgrown fire of consciousness should simply be allowed to die. It shares the lucidity of Camus's revolt but replaces defiance with tending. It shares Nietzsche's *amor fati*, his love of what necessarily comes, but adds to the affirmation of one's own fate a care for the fates of others. It is relational where Heidegger's authenticity individualizes, as Watsuji objected. And it is measured where Levinas's responsibility is infinite: it does not require that one burn for the Other, only that one carry a small flame on the Other's behalf. The ethics of the ember is an ethics of finitude that is neither heroic, nor revolutionary, nor

resigned. It is the ethics of those who know that the fire is fading and decide to keep a small flame anyway—for themselves, for strangers, for those who will come after.

Its figures are present throughout the trilogy, usually at its margins: the Fire Keeper who carries the last flame into the dark; Siegward of Catarina, keeping his promise to kill his friend before the friend is lost to himself; Solaire, whose jolly cooperation became the emblem of a community; the anonymous author of a true warning; the phantom who fights and vanishes; the Painter; and, above all, the player who returns. Outside the trilogy, its figures are Gorchakov's candle carried across the drained pool, the fire carried in a horn through the cold in McCarthy's last dream, and Marco Polo's second way out of the inferno: to recognize who and what, in the midst of it, are not inferno, and to make them endure, and give them space.

Schelling's Bond and Aldia's Other Path

Chapter Three promised that the ethics of the ember would prove to be an ethics of the bond Schelling placed at the summit of his treatise on freedom. Schelling had diagnosed two symmetrical errors: existence that denies its ground, as the order of light would dispense with the darkness from which it was born, and ground that usurps the place of existence, as self-will seizes the centre and becomes evil. Neither error is corrected by the victory of the opposite principle. Both are overcome by love, which Schelling defined as the power that binds together beings each of which could exist for itself and yet neither is nor can be without the other: "Das ist das Geheimnis der Liebe, daß sie solche verbindet, deren jedes für sich sein könnte und doch nicht ist und nicht sein kann ohne das andere." Above both principles Schelling placed a primal non-ground, an indifference prior to all opposition, from which love proceeds as the all in all.

The ember is this bond made visible. It is a small fire that neither denies the dark around it, as Gwyn's light denied its ground, nor dissolves into it, as the Abyss dissolves every form, but burns within it, its light defined by a darkness it does not pretend to abolish. It is Tanizaki's lacquer glowing in candlelight, and the flame held in the Fire Keeper's hands. It is fire that has made peace with the dark. In this precise sense the ethics of the ember is an ethics of Schellingian love: not the triumph of light over darkness or of darkness over light, but the bond that lets each be, in the presence of the other, what it could not be alone.

The trilogy itself contains a voice that anticipates this position, and it belongs, significantly, to the deuterocanonical second game. Aldia, the Scholar of the First Sin, brother of the king Vendrick, appears to the player in the revised edition of *Dark Souls II* as a shadowed figure who speaks of the futility of an order that repeats without end the alternation of light and dark, life and death, and who asks whether the cycle must be perpetuated at all. At the Throne of Want, in that edition, the player may decline the throne and turn

away to seek another path. Aldia is the first figure in the trilogy to refuse not one term of the dichotomy but the dichotomy itself, and his refusal anticipates both the End of Fire and the Painter. Yet his history is also a warning. Aldia pursued his other path through the mastery of life: his keep is filled with the grotesque results of his experiments, and the Emerald Herald who guides the player through Drangleic is herself, in the lore, a product of them. The trilogy shows that a third way engineered by force reproduces the violence of the orders it would escape. The ember is not engineered; it is practised. Where Aldia sought another path by mastering life, the Fire Keeper and the Painter find it by tending and by making room.

The ethics of the ember thus stands at the point where Schelling's metaphysics of love meets Aldia's refusal of the dichotomy: a bond rather than a victory, and a practice rather than a project.

Beyond the Game: Finitude in the Pyrocene

A thesis that claims philosophical seriousness for a work of art must ask what its philosophy means outside the work. Chapter One proposed a constellation in Benjamin's sense: *Dark Souls* appeared in Japan six months after a catastrophe centred on a fire that could not be extinguished and had to be ceaselessly cooled, in a society that had spent two decades learning the textures of fading and of the relationless death. The conclusion may widen the constellation.

The environmental historian Stephen J. Pyne has proposed that the present epoch be understood as a Pyrocene, an age of fire (*The Pyrocene: How We Created an Age of Fire, and What Happens Next*, 2021). Pyne distinguishes three fires: the first, the natural fire that appeared with plant life on land; the second, the burning of living landscapes that human beings have practised since they first held fire; and the third, the combustion of fossil biomass—the burning of what Pyne calls lithic landscapes, the buried remains of ancient life. Industrial civilization is a civilization of the third fire. It sustains its light and motion by burning, in engines and furnaces, the stored remains of a deep past; much of the coal on which the industrial revolution ran was laid down in the swamp forests of the Carboniferous period, forests of giant lycopsids and tree ferns, some three hundred million years ago. The resonance with the cosmology of the trilogy is difficult to ignore. Here, too, is an age of fire that sustains itself by consuming the stored substance of an ancient age of great trees; here, too, the prolongation of the fire defers an end it cannot prevent; and here, too, the consequences fall, as the Darksign falls upon the Undead, on those who did not choose the order that produces them—the distant, the poor, and the not yet born. Paul Crutzen and Eugene Stoermer's proposal of the Anthropocene (2000), Dipesh Chakrabarty's argument that human beings have become geological agents ("The Climate

of History," 2009), and Andreas Malm's history of the fossil economy (*Fossil Capital*, 2016) describe, in their different registers, a world whose fire has overstepped its measure, as the consensus of climate science attests that the combustion of fossil fuels is warming the planet. Heraclitus wrote that the sun which oversteps its measures will be found out by the Erinyes.

The claim here is one of constellation, not allegory. *Dark Souls* is not a parable of climate, and nothing in this thesis attributes such an intention to its makers. But a work that thinks with such rigour about an age sustained by burning the remains of the past, and about the ethics available to those who live in that age's exhaustion, has something to offer a civilization that has discovered the finitude of its own fires. Hans Jonas, in *Das Prinzip Verantwortung* (1979), argued that a technological civilization requires a new ethics, because its actions reach across distances of space and time that traditional ethics, concerned with the near and the contemporaneous, never contemplated; and he formulated a new imperative, to act in such a way that the effects of one's action are compatible with the permanence of genuine human life on earth. The asynchronous ethic of *Dark Souls*—the true sign left for an unknown successor in a world one will not see again—is a rehearsal, in play, of this responsibility to those who do not yet exist. The message on the ground for the next traveller is the miniature form of what is owed to the future.

The seven principles of the ember are, in this light, something like the virtues an age of exhaustion requires. To spend in measure rather than hoard or immolate. To attend to the particular against the leveling force of a universal equivalent. To leave true traces for those who come after. To give without expecting return. To keep the bond in a relationless society, against the solitary deaths that gave contemporary Japan the phrase *muen shakai*. To make room rather than occupy the centre. And to recover forms of expenditure—play, art, the gift—that do not merely consume. Chapter Two observed that philosophy has answered the prospect of the sun's death either by imagining an escape from it, as Lyotard's techno-science would carry thought beyond the solar catastrophe, or by letting it void all meaning in advance, as Brassier's nihilism does. The ember answers neither way. It neither flees finitude nor surrenders meaning to it. It tends a small warmth within the cold, for others, for as long as it can. The game arrived in the wake of a fire that had to be cooled. Its ethics is an ethics of cooling: not the pyre that consumes, but the ember that is carried.

Contributions, Limitations, and Further Research

The contributions of this thesis are of three kinds. Its conceptual contributions are the framework of pyrrhic ontology and its three axioms; a method, lacunary hermeneutics, with its correlates of negative architecture and operative constraint; the account of the game as an operative metaphysics; the reading of the soul as an ontological money-form that hollows the world it measures; the analysis of the bloodstain as a ludic re-finitization

of existence through two deaths; the figure of the sacrificeable *homo sacer*; the prophecy as inverted *upāya*; ludic ekpyrosis; authorial kenosis; the ludic *mugen-nō*; the cryotopian eschaton; and the ethics of the ember. Its philological contributions concern the Japanese text: the homophony of fire-succession and sun-succession in *hitsugi*; the suspended sense of 火防女, guardian of the fire and against it; the binding of the Darksign to the Ringed City through the ring; *ningensei* as the nature of the between; the Bed of Chaos as a seedbed of *konton*, and through it the Hundun of the *Zhuangzi*; the Hollow as *mōja*, the unreleased dead; the Lords of Cinder as kings of firewood and the Unkindled as ash without fire. Its comparative contributions include the reading of the Darksign as Anaximander's sun in eclipse; of the Lordvessel through the Lurianic shattering of the vessels; of the linking of the fire through the Aztec myth of the Fifth Sun, the Vedic *agnicayana*, and the priest of Nemi; of the Witch and Nito through Izanami's fire-birth and descent to Yomi; of the prologue's disparity as Parmenides' *doxa* and its ages as the ages of physical cosmology; of the bonfire as bone-fire, *kagaribi*, *mukaebi*, and crematory hearth; of the soul economy through Simmel's money that hollows; and of the trilogy's ethical alternative through the two fires of *Nostalghia*.

For the study of games, the thesis argues that games can be philosophical media in a strong sense: not vehicles for ideas but institutions of them, whose systems establish identity, causation, value, and time. It follows that interpretation must be constrained by systems as well as by texts; that philology, including attention to localization, belongs among the methods of game studies; that comparative religion and mythology are indispensable to the reading of works whose worlds are built from their materials; and that the communities of interpretation and practice that form around a game may be part of the work itself.

The limitations of the thesis are real, and they define its further horizons. First, although the Japanese text has been consulted at decisive points, a full philological comparison of the Japanese and English versions of the trilogy, attentive to revisions across editions and to the work of its localizers, remains to be undertaken, and would almost certainly revise some of the readings proposed here. Second, the thesis has treated *Dark Souls II* as deuterocanonical; a fuller study of its distinctive cosmology—its Throne of Want, its preoccupation with memory, its Scholar of the First Sin—would test the thesis's claims against the trilogy's most divergent member. Third, the claims made about the trilogy's community rest on the structure of its asynchronous systems and on widely documented practices; an ethnography of its players—their exegetical labour, their rituals of combat, their cultures of the message—would give those claims an empirical ground they here lack.

Fourth, and most consequentially, the figures of tending and sacrifice in the trilogy are overwhelmingly female. The Fire Keepers carry humanity in their bodies and surrender their souls to strengthen the flask of another; the Witch of Izalith and her daughters are consumed by a fire they sought to make; Gwynevere's image is maintained as an effigy of

a departed sovereignty; Filianore's sleep seals a city; and the Painter is a girl who makes a world for others. The trilogy both exposes and reproduces an old economy in which women's bodies serve as vessels and fuel for orders they do not govern—the economy that Wagner's redeeming Senta and Mizoguchi's ghostly Miyagi also inhabit. Since this thesis has drawn the paradigmatic figures of the ember from among these women, a feminist reading is not an optional supplement but a necessary corrective. It would ask whether the ethics of the ember risks romanticizing a care that has historically been extracted rather than freely given, and it would find resources for answering in the feminist ethics of care, from Carol Gilligan's *In a Different Voice* (1982) and Nel Noddings's *Caring* (1984) onward, which insisted that care is a practice to be shared and justly distributed, not a nature to be exploited. Fifth, the discourse of difficulty that surrounds the trilogy has also served as an instrument of exclusion, and the debates about accessibility it has provoked raise the question of whether the ascesis this thesis praises is equally available to all bodies. An ethics of the ember must take seriously that the exercise it describes is not open to everyone on the same terms. Sixth, the method itself carries a risk. The thesis has distinguished genetic from homological relations and has disciplined the latter by operative constraint, but the hermetic drift that Eco warned against can be reduced, not eliminated. Some of the constellations proposed here will seem illuminating and others ornamental. The test of each is whether it helps its reader to see the work, and to play it, otherwise.

Beyond these limits lie the obvious extensions: a study of Miyazaki's later works, treated here only in codas, as a continuous meditation on sovereignty, deathlessness, and withdrawal; comparative work on the genre the trilogy founded and the games that have answered it; and an inquiry into the relation between the ethics of the ember and environmental philosophy, for which the preceding section has offered only a sketch.

Coda: Kindled in Measures, Quenched in Measures

This thesis began with a fragment of Heraclitus: this cosmos, which no god and no human made, always was and is and shall be an ever-living fire, kindled in measures and quenched in measures. Read at the beginning, the fragment seemed to describe the cosmology of *Dark Souls*—an age of fire kindled by a flame without a maker, prolonged by sacrifice, fading toward the dark. Read at the end, it describes something else: a practice. To be kindled in measures and quenched in measures is the life of the player at the bonfire, rest and return, death and recovery, the small flame of a life put out and lit again. It is also the life of the ember, which neither blazes nor goes out but glows, and which can be carried.

The trilogy gives its players several images of that carrying, and the traditions this thesis has consulted give others. A Fire Keeper kneels in the Kiln and gathers the last flame into her hands, and it does not burn her; in the dark she asks whether she can still be heard. A

child at the end of the world takes the blood of the forgotten and resolves to paint a world that is cold, dark, and gentle, a home for those who will live in it. A dying poet carries a candle across a drained pool, and when it goes out, goes back to the beginning and lights it again. A sheriff dreams of his father riding ahead through the cold, carrying fire in a horn. A poet who spent his life on the road, sick at last on a journey, dreams of wandering withered fields. And millions of strangers who will never meet leave small signs for one another on the ground of a dying world—be wary, try, ahead, praise the sun.

The title of the trilogy names them. They are the dark souls: the bearers of the remainder that the order of fire forgot, burned, and walled up at the end of the world; the descendants of the furtive pygmy; the players. The trilogy ends by painting them. And it leaves them where Hölderlin's verse leaves its reader, at the place where danger and what saves grow together: in a cold that is not despair, a darkness that is not the end, and a fire that, held in measure, does not consume.

The fire fades. It was always going to. The question the trilogy asks, and this thesis has tried to answer, is what to do with the time and the warmth that remain. Its answer is the ember: keep a small flame; spend it in measure; carry it for others; leave a sign for whoever comes next. Kindled in measures, quenched in measures—and, between the kindling and the quenching, tended.

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Keywords

Hidetaka Miyazaki; FromSoftware; *Dark Souls*; game studies; philosophy of play; operative metaphysics; pyrrhic ontology; ludic ekpyrosis; cryotopian eschaton; ethics of the ember; lacunary hermeneutics; negative architecture; operative constraint; authorial kenosis; Heraclitus; Anaximander; Empedocles; pre-Socratic cosmology; Stoic *ekpyrosis*; *palingenesia*; eternal recurrence; Nietzsche; active and passive nihilism; Heidegger; being-toward-death; Kierkegaard; repetition; Camus; the absurd; Bataille; general economy; accursed share; Mauss; sacrifice; Girard; Frazer; Bachelard; psychoanalysis of fire; Schelling; dark ground; indivisible remainder; Böhme; *Ungrund*; Lurianic Kabbalah; *shevirat ha-kelim*; *kelipot*; *tikkun*; Gnosticism; Sophia; demiurge; Hans Jonas; Pali Buddhism; Fire Sermon; *nirvāṇa*; Nāgārjuna; Madhyamaka; *Lotus Sūtra*; *upāya*; *mappō*; Kyoto School; Nishitani Keiji; Tanizaki Jun'ichirō; *In'ei raisan*; *ma*; *mono no aware*; Zeami; *mugen-nō*; *takigi-nō*; *hitsugi*; *Ningen-sengen*; Japanese political theology; lost decades; *muen shakai*; apophatic theology; Pseudo-Dionysius; Ingarden; Iser; *Leerstellen*; Schlegel; the Romantic fragment; Walter Benjamin; allegory and ruin; constellation; Derrida; white mythology; heliotropism; *Feu la cendre*; Levinas; the trace; Agamben; *homo sacer*; Foucault; author-function; technologies of the self; Pierre Hadot; spiritual exercises; *melétē thanátou*; Phaedo; Freud; *fort/da*; death drive; Merleau-Ponty; habit-body; Sudnow; Eugen Fink; Schiller; *Spieltrieb*; Gadamer; Huizinga; Juul; art of failure; Bogost; procedural rhetoric; Aarseth; ergodic literature; Vella; ludic sublime; asynchronous multiplayer; paratext; interpretive communities; comparative mythology; Dumézil; Lévi-Strauss; Warburg; *Kojiki*; *Völuspá*; Aztec Fifth Sun; Nanahuatzin; dying-earth fiction; Gene Wolfe; William Hope Hodgson; Kentaro Miura; *Berserk*; Tarkovsky; *Nostalghia*; Béla Tarr; *Outer Wilds*; finitude; entropy; eschatology.